

2013



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>
Feb 4, 2013, 6:27:01 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

[confidential: this information is not to be shared without permission of the sender]

Brothers,

I've added you all to a new Google Group email group. It doesn't change much. It ensures that when you email the group (through the address th...@googlegroups.com) you will be emailing the most current list for the Partnership. It also avoids the clutter of the long list of names on the top of our emails. Let me know if this does something funky to your emails. Also let me know if you haven't received an email from me for a few weeks!

JK

1.Additions (94 elders in 38 presbyteries)

TE Ian Hard (Iowa)

TE Worth Carson (South Florida)

RE Andre Fowlkes (SE Alabama)

RE Bruce Terrell (Metro New York)

2. Updates:

1. Nominating Committee: 13 Partnership members on committee. Note vacancies listed below

2. Review of Presbytery Records: 9 Partnership members on committee. Lots of vacancies to fill. This committee will have to battle the ongoing attempt to shift denominational orthodoxy by review/judicial action rather than overture. Bless you brothers!

3. Overtures Committee: 6 Partnership members. Likely many of you haven't signed up for CofC assignments yet. It'd be great to work with you brothers here. Due to a shift in our rules all business must run through Overtures. The significance of this super committee to the work of the Assembly has only increased.

4. The intinction measure has been defeated somewhere around 900-450 against adoption (so far).

3.To Do

1. Volunteer for committee work in Presbyteries where there are vacancies on either Nominating or RPR (Please correct this list if I'm in error!). These are Partnership Presbyteries where we could fill vacancies:

Ascension (NC, RPR)

Central Indiana (NC)

Gulf Stream (NC, RPR)

Ohio Valley (RPR)

South Florida (RPR)

SE Alabama (NC, RPR)
Warrior (NC, RPR)

2. If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC. Hope you'll consider that work; it's how we steer the ship.

3. Expansion: if you know like-minded men in the presbyteries below, please consider reaching out to them about the National Partnership. It's helpful for us to be able to coordinate across more presbyteries

Catawba Valley
Central Carolina
Central Georgia
Covenant
Eastern Carolina
Eastern Pennsylvania
Fellowship
Great Lakes
Gulf Coast
Heartland
Heritage
Mississippi Valley
Nashville
New Jersey
New River
New York State
North Florida
Northern California
Illiana
Northern new Eng
NW Georgia
Pacific
Philadelphia
Philadelphia MW
Piedmont Triad
Platte Valley
Providence
South Texas
SE Louisiana
S. New England
SW Florida
Westminster
Wisconsin

4.What's Next

1.Committee nominations. Every able man should be willing. I've talked to a number of men in our denomination who have recommended the following in order of importance: 1. Nominating Committee 2. Review of Presbytery Records 3. Overtures Committee of Commissioners. You can conceivably stand for all

three of these if you really want that Presbyter of the year award, but my recommendation is to do both 1 and 3 if they are available to you. This is how we help to steer the ship.

2. Resourcing in advance of committee meetings. I intend for us to share our opinions on issues and candidates in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

3. Discussion of overtures to the 41st GA as they come available. As soon as these overtures are received by the denominational offices and accessible I will make them available to this list for discussion.

National Partnership Note

3 views

Skip to first unread message



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Feb 11, 2013, 12:49:11 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

1. Additions (97 elders in 38 presbyteries)

TE Bob Flayhart (Evangel)

TE Steve Jeantet (Southwest Florida)

2. Updates:

1. Nominating Committee: 16 Partnership members on committee. Note vacancies listed below

2. Review of Presbytery Records: 9 Partnership members on committee. Lots of vacancies to fill. This committee will have to battle the ongoing attempt to shift denominational orthodoxy by review/judicial action rather than overtur.

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Ohio Valley (RPR)

South Florida (RPR)

SE Alabama (NC, RPR)

Warrior (NC, RPR)

2. If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC. Hope you'll consider that work; it's how we steer the ship.

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Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Carolina

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland
Heritage
Mississippi Valley
Nashville
New Jersey
New River
New York State
North Florida
Northern California
Illiana
Northern new Eng
NW Georgia
Pacific
Philadelphia
Philadelphia MW
Piedmont Triad
Platte Valley
Providence
South Texas
SE Louisiana
S. New England
Westminster
Wisconsin

4.What's Next

1.Committee nominations. If your presbytery is still electing members to the Special committees (esp. Nominating and Review of Presbytery Records) please consider serving there. We also need to begin filling the spots available for Overtures. It may be more difficult for you to find spots on the Overtures committee because there is a greater understanding of the importance of that committee among the typical presbyter.

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4. Resourcing is always welcome. Whether you would like feedback concerning an proposed overture or you would like to propose a conversation for everyone's mutual benefit please let me know and I'll start the post on the Partnership website.

5. Resources

Over on the Partnership website (thenationalpartnership.com) we have a number of profitable discussions proposed including:

Confession and Catholicity – how to hold to our standards with an eye toward the broader church

Overture 1 – revision of the Assembly's order of business to ensure that the most critical work is finished by the greatest representation of the Assembly body.

Presbytery Health – In my presbytery (Ohio) we are considering a massive revision to the way we do business. I'm going to post the proposed changes (drawn from discussion within this Partnership) that our presbytery will soon debate. It may be instructive for you if you are in a presbytery, like ours, where we struggle to operate as a church for our TEs.

National Partnership Note

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Feb 18, 2013, 9:08:57 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

The Partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'col116')

1.Additions (99 elders in 40 presbyteries)

TE Kevin Twit (Nashville)

TE Shane Gibson (SE Louisiana)

2. Updates:

1. Nominating Committee: 16 Partnership members. Note vacancies listed below

2. Review of Presbytery Records: 10 Partnership members. Lots of vacancies to fill. This committee will have to battle the ongoing attempt to shift denominational orthodoxy by review/judicial action rather than overture.

3. Overtures Committee: 8 Partnership members. It'd be great to work with you brothers here. Due to a shift in our rules all business must run through Overtures. The significance of this super committee to the work of the Assembly has only increased.

3.To Do

1. Volunteer for committee work in Presbyteries where there are vacancies on either Nominating or RPR (Please correct this list if I'm in error!). Even though the deadline for nominations is here you can still serve on one of these committees by receiving permission from your presbytery preceding the meeting (nominations committee meets March 16). In other words, with permission from your presbytery, you can be a committee "walk-on" if your presbytery has a vacancy. These are Partnership Presbyteries where we could fill vacancies:

Ascension (NC, RPR)

Gulf Stream (NC, RPR)

Ohio Valley (RPR)

South Florida (RPR)

SE Alabama (NC, RPR)

Warrior (NC, RPR)

2. If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC. Hope you'll consider that work; it's how we steer the ship.

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Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Carolina

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland

Heritage

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey

New River

New York State

North Florida

Northern California

Illiana

Northern new Eng

NW Georgia

Pacific

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Philadelphia MW

Piedmont Triad

Platte Valley

Providence

South Texas

S. New England

Westminster

Wisconsin

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6. Google Groups Instructions

Google groups manages our group emails.

1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

National Partnership Note

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 4, 2013, 2:22:54 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

The Partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'col116')

Interesting article on William Evans' blog about how conservative presbyterianism has 'lost its mojo'. Item 3 in his rationale I think is particularly pertinent for us as we increasingly wrestle with pursuing orthodoxy in the PCA:

"While on this larger topic of religious authority, there are also the problems of how the confessions of the church are to be utilized and what can reasonably be expected of them. Some in the conservative Presbyterian orbit have responded to differences within the Reformed community and to the doctrinal diversity of broader evangelicalism by trumpeting the Reformed confessions of the sixteenth and seventeenth century as the solution to what ails us. But the problems here are significant. First, such a strategy of confessional positivism is, at the end of the day, little more than a bald appeal to external authority, and to a fallible one at that. This is an odd move for people ostensibly committed to sola scriptura! Second, the Reformed confessions themselves need to be interpreted. The assumption that the confessions give us some sort of trans-historical Archimedean point of reference from which to understand Scripture simply does not obtain—the Reformed confessions are human documents and products of their time. While these documents are splendid and wonderful resources for the church (and I've spent a good deal of time in recent years trying to acquaint Reformed believers with the richness of this tradition), wooden "confessionalism" is not the answer to anything."

(read the rest of item 3 in his article here: <http://theecclesiacalvinist.wordpress.com/2013/02/21/how-conservative-presbyterianism-lost-its-mojo/>)

1.Additions (103 elders in 41 presbyteries)

TE Erik Bonkovsky (James River)

TE Geoff Bradford (Eastern Carolina)

TE Walt Coppersmith (Ascension)

TE Glenn Hoburg (Potomac)

2. Updates:

1. Nominating Committee: 16 Partnership members. Note vacancies listed below

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3.To Do

1. If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC. Hope you'll consider that work; it's how we steer the ship.

2. Partnership Expansion: if you know like-minded men in the presbyteries below, please consider reaching out to them about the National Partnership. It's helpful for us to be able to coordinate across more presbyteries

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Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland

Heritage

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey

New River

New York State

North Florida

Northern California

Illiana

Northern new Eng

NW Georgia

Pacific

Philadelphia

Philadelphia MW

Piedmont Triad

Platte Valley

Providence

South Texas

S. New England

Westminster

Wisconsin

4.What's Next

1.Committee of Commissioners. If your presbytery is still electing members to the Special committees (esp. Nominating and Review of Presbytery Records) please consider serving there. We also need to begin filling the spots available for Overtures. It may be more difficult for you to find spots on the Overtures committee because there is a greater understanding of the importance of that committee among the typical presbyter.

2.Resourcing in advance of committee meetings. I intend for us to share our opinions on issues in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

3.Discussion of overtures to the 41st GA will begin soon. We're coming up on the deadline for overtures requiring BCO amendment, so discussions on the discussion page should start fairly soon; I'll let you know.

4. Resourcing is always welcome. Whether you would like feedback concerning an proposed overture or you would like to propose a conversation for everyone's mutual benefit please let me know and I'll start the post on the Partnership website.

5. Resources

Over on the Partnership website (thenationalpartnership.com) we have a number of profitable discussions proposed including:

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Presbytery Health – In my presbytery (Ohio) we are considering a massive revision to the way we do business. I'm going to post the proposed changes (drawn from discussion within this Partnership) that our presbytery

will soon debate. It may be instructive for you if you are in a presbytery, like ours, where we struggle to operate as a church for our TEs.

Attached is a quick and handy [Roberts Rules chart](#) for understanding the process of making/passing procedural motions et al. Enjoy!

6. Google Groups Instructions

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1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

Overtures discussions are open

2 views



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

Mar 5, 2013, 10:03:33 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Fathers and Brothers,

If you've seen the fantastic movie The Jerk I feel a bit like Navin running with White Pages in hand yelling "the new phone book's here, the new phone book's here!" because, men, the overtures (so far) are here and some of you are already eager to start the discussions on some of them (I'll be very interested in your perspectives on #8 in particular). I have created discussion pages on the Partnership website

(<http://thenationalpartnership.com> password: col116) for each of the overtures and will continue to do so as overtures make their way to Atlanta. Here's how I anticipate us working together to resource one another:

1. You join the discussion on overtures over on the partnership website – adding your comments
2. You subscribe to the discussions you're interested in and receive emails when a comment is added to that discussion. You respond where helpful.

3. At the end of may/beginning of June I'll distribute a handy reference summarizing our majority opinions on the matter from the website discussions and recommendations
I hope this will be an helpful avenue for developing our views, serving one another and the denomination.

Blessings,

JK

Off Topic: Lead Pastor Search

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 8, 2013, 4:47:28 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

I hope you'll indulge the occasional pastoral search email. I think the NP has an opportunity to provide search committees with exceedingly qualified candidates for leadership positions in the PCA. So I'm forwarding Jack Howell's email to the group, per his request. Peace,

JK

From: Jack Howell <ja...@trinitynorfolk.com>

Brothers,

I was approached by the Search Committee at New Life Glenside to help network their senior pastor opening among like-minded men. Attached you will find a job description as well as information about NLG. It's a wonderful church with a tremendous heritage and exciting, ambitious on-going ministry. If you know of men who would find their culture attractive and might be interested in exploring the position, encourage them to contact Ms. Piper Lowell (piper....@gmail.com) on their search committee. When you read the list of men who have served as the senior minister at NLG, you can see why men attracted to the National Partnership might be interested in building upon their labors. Thanks very much,

Jack Howell

An important note and update

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 11, 2013, 12:47:20 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Brothers:

I just had an hour-long conversation with a member of the Siouxlands Presbytery who had been given one of our Partnership emails by a concerned person. I would expect for the Partnership to become very public information soon, possibly not from the person I spoke to but others. I'm not at all surprised that word got out. Trying to act as one body politically was bound to become public. But I still expect to maintain the confidentiality of our discussions. Let me say a couple of things about this:

1. Confidentiality exists in this group because our conversations are not public. We want to know who we're talking to. And we want reasonable assurance that our words are being read charitably and in context.
2. When sharing information about the Partnership to others you are not permitted to share these emails (note the confidentiality statement above). You may characterize what we're trying to do but I prefer for people to become members before they're privy to the conversations of others, conversations that are assumed to be held in confidence. So if you're reaching out to someone about joining us, do not simply send them our email.
3. The person I spoke to on the phone said they didn't feel bound by our confidentiality agreement because they were not the original receiver of the information. This means that someone receiving this email didn't feel bound either and sent it to him. I would just ask that you observe our right to a private conversation and that you would honor my intent – and the intent of others – to speak privately.
4. I have changed the password for the Partnership website and will not be sharing it in future emails. Please note the password below.

The Partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220') - NOTE THE NEW PASSWORD

1.Additions (108 elders in 43 presbyteries)

TE Will Tabor (SE Louisiana)

TE Ray Cortese (Central Florida)

TE Sean Roberts (Philadelphia)

TE Russell Silverglate (Gulfstream)

TE Rick Searle (Evangel)

TE John Pennylegion (Missouri)

TE Brandon Lauranzon (Central Florida)

2. Updates:

1. Nominating Committee: 17 Partnership members.
2. Review of Presbytery Records: 10 Partnership members. Lots of vacancies to fill. This committee will have to battle the ongoing attempt to shift denominational orthodoxy by review/judicial action rather than overture.
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3.To Do

1. If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC. Hope you'll consider that work; it's how we steer the ship. Please note: *like-mindedness is critical for what we're trying to accomplish*. If you have any doubt that your recommendation is a great fit please wait until you are more certain. We are willing to expand only as quickly as due diligence allows us.

2. Partnership Expansion: if you know like-minded men in the presbyteries below, please consider reaching out to them about the National Partnership. It's helpful for us to be able to coordinate across more presbyteries

Catawba Valley

Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland

Heritage

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey

New River

New York State

North Florida

Northern California

Illiana

Northern new Eng

NW Georgia

Pacific

Philadelphia MW

Piedmont Triad

Platte Valley

Providence

S. New England

Westminster

Wisconsin

4.What's Next

1.Committee of Commissioners. We need to fill the spots available for Overtures. It may be more difficult for you to find spots on the Overtures committee because there is a greater understanding of the importance of that committee among the typical presbyter.

2.Resourcing in advance of committee meetings. I intend for us to share our opinions on issues in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

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National Partnership Confidential Conversations - continued!

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 13, 2013, 4:30:16 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Received a phone call (again) from our brother in the Siouxlands Presbytery that notified me of confidential emails received. As it turns out he did not receive one of our confidential emails but simply an email *about* the National Partnership. Wanted to let you know that there has not been a breach in confidentiality as far as I know and that the brothers in this Partnership have honored our desire to listen to one another charitably and in confidence. I continue to be so thankful to work with you in our common goal of a healthy and mission-minded denomination. Please do be in prayer for this weekend's Nominating Committee meeting. Sixteen Partnership members are serving on committee and we want to work efficiently and effectively while maintaining love for those with whom we may disagree. Pray, if you would, that God would not only be honored by the result of deliberations but by the love we display for the brethren.

Warmly, with great appreciation for all of you,

JK

Quick note on GA work

2 views



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

Mar 19, 2013, 7:52:45 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

I'm including a link to the Aquila Report's story about last weekend's Nominating Committee meeting. What you read here is the impact that the National Partnership had in electing a very qualified slate of nominees for, in this case, the SJC. You'll also read in the tone of the piece the surprise that we were able to depose three TE who were up for renomination. This was an important move but is only the first step. We've now made it possible to alter the composition of the court *this year* in a way more representative of our denomination's center.

When you became members of the Partnership, one of the expectations you were given was the willingness to be involved in the work of the General Assembly. So this is my appeal: we must be present, we must share our views not only internally but also among those who are not Partnership men. If you are willing to marshal support on the floor of GA with a couple of non-partnership friends we can hold the line. We have to be organized and ready to vote, particularly at times like this – when the committee nominations are considered. We will need your help to uphold the Nominating Committee work. So forego the beers with friends if you must, we'll pick a pub and all of you can join us after. Please make every attempt to be at GA and participate. End of appeal. Thanks for listening and for partnering with us.

<http://theaquilareport.com/pca-nominating-committee-votes-to-replace-all-three-teaching-elder-seeking-reelection-to-the-sjc/>

JK

National Partnership Note

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 18, 2013, 2:34:44 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

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1.Additions (111 elders in 45 presbyteries)

TE Troy Albee (Southern New England)

TE Dan McDonald (Eastern Canada)

TE Ed Sirya (Metro New York)

2. Updates:

1. Nominating Committee: Very encouraging result from the Nominating Committee meeting this last weekend. With a significant group of NP members on committee we nominated a great slate of candidates for

the assembly, including the SJC nominees Greg Thompson, Will Barker, Ray Cannata, EJ Nusbaum, John Pickering and John Bise. We were very glad for the result.

2. Review of Presbytery Records: 10 Partnership members. Lots of vacancies to fill. This committee will have to battle the ongoing attempt to shift denominational orthodoxy by review/judicial action rather than overture.

3. Overtures Committee: 10 Partnership members. It'd be great to work with you brothers here. Due to a shift in our rules all business must run through Overtures. The significance of this super committee to the work of the Assembly has only increased.

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1. If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC. Hope you'll consider that work; it's how we steer the ship.

2. Mike Khandjian would like to extend an invitation to everyone on our Partnership list to a dinner on Wednesday night of GA week (the official docket shows an ice cream social). Mike has been active in drawing many of you men into fellowship around the idea of being more active in leading our denomination. Obviously the Partnership has engaged more in the logistics side of things, but fellowship and visioning is important. I'm including Mike's invitation below:

On Wednesday night of GA week, there will be a gathering at a local restaurant.

Dinner will be served for a nominal fee, and we will hear from several from this and one other fellowship, two growing groups committed to the denomination's future.

Ray Cortese will share what he envisions for the PCA. Shayne Wheeler and Ray Cannata will offer some thoughts. Bruce O'Neil will speak to how presbyteries can change.

James Kessler will discuss the National Partnership and Charles McGowan, one of our 'Grandfathers' will speak to the Founders' vision and their encouragement of what we are doing. Kevin Twit will lead in song, and Scotty Smith will lead in a season of repentance and prayer. The room holds 125 and we already are nearly 1/3 full with

nearly 4 months remaining. Contact Mike Khandjian @ mi...@chapelgate.org if you are interested in attending.

2. Partnership Expansion: if you know like-minded men in the presbyteries below, please consider reaching out to them about the National Partnership. It's helpful for us to be able to coordinate across more presbyteries. [Please note: *like-mindedness is critical for what we're trying to accomplish*. If you have any doubt that your recommendation is a great fit please wait until you are more certain. We are willing to expand only as quickly as due diligence allows us.]

Catawba Valley
Central Carolina
Central Georgia
Covenant
Eastern Pennsylvania
Fellowship
Great Lakes
Gulf Coast
Heartland
Heritage
Mississippi Valley
New Jersey
New River
New York State
North Florida
Northern California
Illiana
Northern new Eng
NW Georgia
Pacific
Philadelphia MW
Piedmont Triad
Platte Valley
Providence
Westminster
Wisconsin

4.What's Next

1. Committee of Commissioners. We need to fill the spots available for Overtures. It may be more difficult for you to find spots on the Overtures committee because there is a greater understanding of the importance of that committee among the typical presbyter.

2. Resourcing in advance of committee meetings. I intend for us to share our opinions on issues in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

3. Discussion of overtures to the 41st GA has begun. Join the discussion!

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DISCUSSION OF 2013 GA OVERTURES IS ACTIVE. Please do resource the rest of us with your perspective on this year's slate of overtures.

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Presbytery Health – In my presbytery (Ohio) we are considering a massive revision to the way we do business. I've heard some of you would like to push for the same in your own presbyteries. Obviously our presbyteries functioning more like churches for our Teaching Elders would be a blessing to the church at large. Posted on the 'resources' page are the Ohio Bylaw proposed changes (drawn from discussion within this Partnership) that our presbytery will soon debate. Others of you may contribute your own plans for reform in your presbyteries for the good of the group. Perhaps we can encourage one another in this task.

6. Google Groups Instructions

Google groups manages our group emails.

1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

A note on retaining the character of the NP

1 view

Skip to first unread message



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 20, 2013, 7:40:14 AM

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□

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

<http://theaquilareport.com/national-partnership-a-new-group-in-the-pca/>

The Aquila Report has picked up on our existence, which is not a problem. It was never our intent to exist as a secret society. In fact, I would prefer for the information to be disseminated now rather than right before the Assembly so that suspicions the minority might have about our aims can be dealt with now, rather than provoking prejudices (a secret faction!) that could derail our business at the Assembly. But I want to give you a couple of thoughts on where we go from here, in no particular order:

1. Membership in the Partnership will remain invitation only. This is going to be a problem for some people. That's ok. We want to protect the integrity of what we're trying to do. We're like-minded and we want to stay that way in order to remain organized and effective in polity. I, and you perhaps, will get plenty of emails asking about membership. You are free to direct them to me if you aren't certain that they fit. At any rate we all may have additional awkward conversations.
2. Other than extending the Partnership into Presbyteries where we aren't represented, there isn't a dire need to increase membership. We have already reached critical mass and I believe the effect of the Partnership will certainly be felt at the Assembly. So just be wise in extending invitations.
3. I'm very grateful that anything we've said or done has been beyond reproach. There is nothing to fear from the Aquila Report or anyone else that is suspicious of what we're doing. Frankly, the danger may come from insecurity – being worried about the perspective of some that feel we're being *too political*. God has providentially ordered the composition of our denomination – we are in the majority. We care for the minority, we bear with them, but we shouldn't shy away from exercising order as the majority. That's what we're trying to do.
4. If, at any time, you wish to no longer be identified with the National Partnership please do let me know. I will harbor no resentment; I understand that increased attention may present issues for some of you in your presbyteries or even on your sessions. I'm sorry that I cannot allow non-listed persons to be a part of our conversation; I need to allow everyone to know the partners in our dialogue so you must be willing to be publicly identified with us in order to fully participate. But, again, I am more than willing to delist you.
5. We will move on the same as we have. Increased scrutiny will require us to attend to love for our neighbor and our opponents, which is good for us.

Thank you for standing together and for your hard work on behalf of the Kingdom,
JK

From NP member Omar Ortiz

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 20, 2013, 8:57:52 AM

:



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Message from NP member Omar Ortiz

I had a thought last night. Would it be beneficial for an article to be written and published in byFaith (or some other well known PCA outlet, perhaps even the Aquila report would publish it as a rebuttal) that gives a fuller picture of the SJC vote. Here are a few items that occurred to me

1. EJ got the highest number of votes of ANY nomination (something which is very important to consider)
2. D. Aquila and F. Greco were numbers 3 and 4 in the ballots, so it is unfair to characterize the vote as "removing all three teaching elders" that was done by the votes, not the NP.
3. Our desire was not to disenfranchise REs who wish to serve, and we only had three RE nominations for three spots.
4. Greco was moved to the number three spot and a substitute motion was made.
5. Thompson was already in the number 1 spot when two substitutions were attempted.

I am not sure if this is going to help or hurt the cause. my thought is that by a wider group of people knowing the whole story it will help the vote at GA. But it could also be seen as a tit-for-tat - which could paint the partnership in a negative light.

Thoughts?

Omar

A couple of things

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 22, 2013, 3:11:05 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Several of you have asked how I'm doing in light of the articles posted on The Aquila Report and their reception in the social media world. I am fine, thanks for asking. I hesitated to write this email because I didn't want to overreact to some negative press. But I thought I'd respond to at least a couple of things internally:

1. I do not believe us to be creating a schism or advocating one in the PCA. To confer with one another is a perfectly reasonable thing. To resource one another with the means to be more efficiently involved seems like a noble cause to me.

2. Though I do not have an appetite for a "they do it too!" sort of defense, we certainly could make that case. We are not breaking the mold here in the Partnership. But we are effective, which might be part of the problem for others.
3. I have asked to speak directly with each opponent as a way to resolve any concerns about the way the Partnership started and my role in it. None of these men has taken me up on this offer. Even TE Webb, who declined my request for a private conversation in favor of an open letter.
4. I did respond to Webb privately because he asked me questions publicly, though I suppose that response may become public. I would have preferred a phone call.
5. I will not be responding publicly to these letters for a number of reasons but one reason in particular is that I do not believe I have the right to speak for you. This partnership continues to have a decentralized leadership structure. We are friends and friends of friends, not a political party. So I will refuse these requests unless you all plead with me to speak on the issue; even then I suppose I would prefer to speak to my own involvement, not yours.
6. You are all certainly free to respond as you see fit, though I would ask that you represent only your own views and that you do your best not to be inflamed by some of the rhetoric out there. More easily said than done, sure.
7. You are also free to reveal that you are a member of this Partnership. I will not be revealing our roster.
8. Interestingly the tone of inquisition reinforces the need for confidentiality. The louder and more cutting the objection, the more I feel we are caring for one another by deliberating in confidence.
9. I intend to continue working in the same way we have before. We will enfold new men interested in resourcing one another and preparing for Assembly work. We will seek to be effective on committees and on the floor. I see no reason to change this.
10. While I intend to follow the same path I will of course listen to correction. One of you in particular has been challenging me gently on how we speak internally. I'm very open to change where appropriate!
11. I want you to know that I am open to hearing from you on anything at all. If I have anxiety about all of this it is for you – I don't want you to be hassled for your desire to be more involved and effective for the good of the Church.

Thank you for your partnership. Thank you for your kind words and counsel. I am indebted!

For the King,

JK

National Partnership NOTE

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 25, 2013, 7:42:27 AM

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□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

The Partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

1.Additions (114 elders in 45 presbyteries)

TE Ray Cannata (SE Louisiana)

TE Bob Sawyer (S. New England)

TE David Goneau (Philadelphia)

2. Updates:

1. Review of Presbytery Records: 8 NP guys on this committee. Lots of vacancies to fill. This committee will have to battle the ongoing attempt to shift denominational orthodoxy by review/judicial action rather than overture. Here is the list of presbyteries where we have NP representation but may have a vacant spot on the RPR. Check with your stated clerk of presbytery (and please correct me if I'm wrong!):

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Blue Ridge

Chicago Metro

Gulf Stream

James River

Nashville

Ohio Valley

Philadelphia

Rocky Mountain

Siouxlands

Southern New England

Warrior

2. Overtures Committee: 10 NP guys are currently on this committee. If you're looking to be maximize your involvement in the work of the Assembly this is where your time will be well spent. It'd be great to work with you brothers here. Due to a shift in our rules all business must run through Overtures. The significance of this super committee to the work of the Assembly has only increased.

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Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland

Heritage

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey

New River

New York State

North Florida

Northern California

Illiana

Northern new Eng

NW Georgia

Pacific

Philadelphia MW

Piedmont Triad

Platte Valley

Providence

Westminster

Wisconsin

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4. Resourcing is always welcome. Whether you would like feedback concerning an proposed overture or you would like to propose a conversation for everyone's mutual benefit please let me know and I'll start the post on the Partnership website.

5. I will be checking on the availability of space at GA for additional seminars during the equipping sessions. I would love to have some of you willing to serve the assembly by sharing your ministry experience in a seminar. Will let you know what I hear about this.

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Over on the Partnership website (thenationalpartnership.com) we have a number of profitable discussions proposed including:

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On Responding to Dominic Aquila, Don Clements et al.

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 26, 2013, 3:24:51 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Let me respond once more internally to the things being said on blogs and highlighted by Dominic Aquila, Don Clements, Douglas Vos and Rachel Miller (The Aquila Report).

- Some of you may not know, and I think that perhaps many readers do not know, that the Aquila Report is Aquila, Clements, Vos and Miller. I do not want to overstate opposition to the National Partnership. We are, by contrast, a collection of more than 115 elders in the denomination seeking to encourage and resource one another for the good of our churches. It is a good cause.

- If you are going to respond, and I wouldn't dissuade you from doing that if you feel you must, I would ask that we respond in a way true to our organization: Person-to-person conversations in the following order of preference
 - 1. In person/on phone,
 - 2. Email,
 - 3. Private Message,
 - 4. Semi-public response (comments on blogs, FB, etc.) as a last resort
- If you are responding it may be helpful to remember some of the following points regarding why the NP exists and what we do:
 - Many men lack the awareness of how polity at both the Presbytery and Assembly level are to be utilized by Elders.
 - Many feel unprepared to act regarding particular issues of debate
 - Many do not feel they can openly discuss issues of controversy in an environment of brotherly love and charity
 - The Partnership began as a one-to-one invitation friend to friend. We did this to avoid the appearance of gross politicking (creating a political party, etc.). We have grown this way from the beginning.
 - The NP has focused on raising awareness for the uninvolved about the various ways a man can serve at the assembly level. We have posted resources about what to expect when working on committees and how to pursue health in your presbytery.
 - The NP contributes to the aims of our denomination's strategic plan (Thanks Josh Moon for this thought)
 - Our plan aspired to more "seats at the table" for our younger men (thus the NP's organization and drive toward committee work)
 - Our plan called for "safe places" where we could sharpen our orthodoxy and learn from one another without being published and subsequently attacked for our conversations (thus the NP's confidentiality agreement)
 - If someone were to disagree about safe places/confidentiality I would only point them to these public and accusatory articles which have been written without seeking to understand, first, the truth of said accusations. Again, I have not been contacted even once by any these writers. The National Partnership exists, in part to provide an arena for real discussion that does not devolve into polarizing public arguments
 - The NP reflects a great deal of diversity of opinion. We have intinctionists, anti-intinctionists, confessionalists of all stripes, Northerners and Southerners. We disagree on many things.
 - No one in the NP is told how to vote, all are encouraged to participate in the process of resourcing one another about particular overtures and other denominational business
 - The National Partnership is not secret. Members are free to reveal their connection to the Partnership and they are even free to characterize our conversations, they just can't violate our expectations of privacy by reproducing our roster or our conversations for others.
- Here is why I will not respond publicly
 - Any public response will likely be drawn into the fray by Aquila, Clements and Miller. They intend, it seems, to highlight any story available that opposes the work of the NP. I would guess that your response will be linked to in social media and either criticized by Aquila, Clements, Miller or lionized by your own friends, getting you nowhere. Dominic Aquila will link to it and you will be forced into the same back and forth we see right now.
 - Any public response will result in a tide of men wishing to join us. It will have the effect of saying publicly: "If you're with us, join us." I would call that a more polarizing move that could create a party spirit in the denomination. Our identity is grass roots and person-to-

person. We are not a political party; we are a group of men seeking to be more efficient, knowledgeable, and wise in our roles as presbyters.

- Any public statement on behalf of all of us indicates a level of organization out of accord with our goals. It may also suggest a degree of uniformity and coercion – we speak for you and we tell you how to vote. We need to reject this.
- I am personally speaking with the writers of the articles promoted by Dominic Aquila and will attempt to do so in every case of public backlash against the NP as I am able. My first such conversation was today and was very productive. I have another planned for tomorrow.

Finally: my greatest concern about the negative blogging we've seen this last week is the degree to which men are willing to engage in one-way conversation. The other person is by necessity diminished in these conversations. To me this is not just an ethical code violated but a *grievous dishonor*. Loving our enemies/opponents has to involve representing their character and beliefs charitably. Inquiries about the NP by one of these bloggers or Dominic Aquila, Don Clements or Rachel Miller would not only have served the public trust but would have dignified me and you by giving us a chance to *define ourselves*. Let's not fall into the same soup by failing to pray for our opponents and represent them truthfully in every forum.

Thank you all, again, for listening

JK

reflections of a battle weary pastor

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



Jason Dorsey
<jason@redeemindy.org>

unread,

Mar 26, 2013, 4:25:17 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

James and National Partnership brothers-in-Christ,

Let me share my perspective as one who writes from the "backwaters" of Indianapolis, who doesn't read the Aquila report, who did not attend Covenant Seminary and who, as a child of the Pacific Northwest took a very long roundabout road to becoming a Presbyterian minister.

The needs of my own heart - with its own "unreached people groups" and darkness - demands front-line battle. I have no desire to politically fence with my brothers in Christ in the PCA with who I share a common confession.

Moreover, the pressing needs of my growing congregation - the sins, the sicknesses, the spiritual warfare, the pastoral duties of counseling, disciple-making, evangelism, prayer and preaching, leadership formation, etc. require my wholehearted zeal and focused vision.

Then, on top of needs of "keeping watch" on my own heart and the providing spiritual food for my congregation (not to mention my own family, my dear wife and children), I have the screaming, aching needs of the City I love - Indianapolis - before me. I hear the cries of young men without fathers. I see the pressing needs in our public schools and other public institutions. I see growing spiritual darkness. And, at the same time, I see the wind of the Holy Spirit moving.

This is my work. This is my calling.

In no way do I want to belittle the intramural jousting that happens. I just don't understand it.

But what I do appreciate *very much* about this partnership is that it is a forum where important conversations and important issues are brought to my attention before GA, it is a place where good discussion and even debate can happen.

Up to a few months ago - in all my last 15 years as an ordained minister in the PCA, I didn't have a forum to be part of a discussion or really even "listen in". There may have been one out there; but I did not know of it nor was I invited.

So I'm thankful for the Partnership.

And I'm thankful that my calling that I share with you men is to be a minister of the gospel for the glory of Jesus Christ to the place and people where I have been called.

Grace, Jason Dorsey

National Partnership NOTE

3 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Apr 1, 2013, 7:14:59 AM

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□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

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TE Brian Dennert (Chicago Metro)

TE David Salyer (Platte Valley)

2. Updates:

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Gulf Stream

James River

Metro NY

Nashville

Northern Illinois

Philadelphia

Platte Valley

Rocky Mountain

Southern New England

RPR orientation: A friend provided this primer on RPR, the process for nomination and the nature of the commitment:

Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment in late May - and the PCA pays the expenses. This year, the GA Committee on Review of Presbytery Records convenes at 1 pm on Wednesday May 29 and is scheduled to adjourn by noon on Saturday. (But the last two years adjourned by noon on Friday). Most RPR members fly into ATL on Wed morning, spend two nights at the Hampton Inn near the PCA offices about an hour NE of ATL, and catch a flight out of ATL late Friday afternoon or evening. The PCA provides the hotel rooms and reimburses other travel expenses (airfare, ground transportation, meals, etc.).

After a Presbytery elects its RPR rep (or, if a Presbytery's Rules allow, after the Moderator appoints him) the Presbytery Clerk notifies the PCA Admin Office in Lawrenceville of the name of the RPR Rep. RPR members usually serve three-year terms (like the GA Nominating Committee). And a Presbytery's slot alternates between RE and TE (though Presbytery is free to sub one for the other if needed). Nothing prohibits a Presbytery from appointing a different man each year, if they need to. Better that option than no rep.

Work before the Meeting - Each Presbytery files three sets of their 2012 minutes with the PCA prior to April 19. At some point before the RPR meeting, the PCA Clerk's office sends each RPR member a set from two Presbyteries, which they will review and make notations about, prior to the May meeting. At the meeting, these minutes and the RPR member's comments will be reviewed by second readers. Any RPR members that are appointed late will often not review minutes beforehand. So, much of Wednesday is spent in doing "First Reads." Furthermore, if an RPR rep can

only come to Atlanta early Thursday morning, and stay one night, he would still likely be there for the most important or most controversial votes.

Overtures Committee: 10 NP guys are currently on this committee. If you're looking to be maximize your involvement in the work of the Assembly this is where your time will be well spent. It'd be great to work with you brothers here. Due to a shift in our rules all business must run through Overtures. The significance of this super committee to the work of the Assembly has only increased.

3.To Do

If you are serving on a permanent cmte, special cmte, or Committee of Commissioners at the GA could you check our list on the Partnership website to make sure you are correctly included? Let me know of any changes/additions.

If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC. Hope you'll consider that work.

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Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland

Heritage

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey
New River
New York State
North Florida
Northern California
Illiana
Northern new Eng
NW Georgia
Pacific
Philadelphia MW
Piedmont Triad
Providence
Westminster
Wisconsin

4.What's Next

1. Attendance at GA. All of the work we've done to inform and resource one another rests on our willingness to attend GA and be a part of the polity process. Not only that but bringing a Ruling Elder this year could help the voting on the floor to be more representative of the denomination as a whole. Please do consider it. There may also be some helpful seminars for you to attend together. I've found that to be true a time or two in the past. Good chance for ministry dreaming, etc.

2.Committee of Commissioners. We need to fill the spots available for Overtures. It may be more difficult for you to find spots on the Overtures committee because there is a greater understanding of the importance of that committee among the typical presbyter.

3.Resourcing in advance of committee meetings. I intend for us to share our opinions on issues in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

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National Partnership NOTE

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Apr 9, 2013, 9:31:22 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

For the next several weeks I think the newest information you will receive from the Partnership would be updates in our roll and the encouragement to visit the website and explore the discussions on overtures. I hope you will all make the trip to Greenville this year; involvement at the Assembly level is critical – and bring a Ruling Elder with you while you're at it. The next big milestone may be a summary document (similar to the one David Coffin prepares every year) summarizing the wisdom of our group's discussions on overtures. I am thinking late May for this. Still below is an exhortation to fill out any RPR openings and to let me know if you are serving on any committees. I would like to keep an accurate roll on the website so I appreciate your help on that. Lastly I'm certain that we will gather unofficially for a beer one particular night of the Assembly. No smoky room politicking, just a chance to see one another face to face and compare seersuckers. Thanks everyone for your participation and willingness to grab the rope. Hope your service in the Lord is sweet in addition to be exhausting, trying, etc. etc.

Best,

JK

The Partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

1.Additions (119 elders in 46 presbyteries)

RE Brent Stutzman (Chicago Metro)

TE Geoff Ziegler (Chicago Metro)

TE Jason Little (Chicago Metro)

RE Damon Cinaglia (Heritage)

2. Updates:

Review of Presbytery Records: 9 NP guys on this committee. Some vacancies to fill. This committee will have to battle the ongoing attempt to shift denominational orthodoxy by review/judicial action rather than overture. Here is the list of presbyteries where we have NP representation but may have a vacant spot on the RPR. Check with your stated clerk of presbytery (and please correct me if I'm wrong!):

Gulf Stream

James River

Metro NY

Nashville

Northern Illinois

Philadelphia

Platte Valley

Rocky Mountain

Southern New England

RPR orientation: A friend provided this primer on RPR, the process for nomination and the nature of the commitment:

Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment in late May - and the PCA pays the expenses. This year, the GA Committee on Review of Presbytery Records convenes at 1 pm on Wednesday May 29 and is scheduled to adjourn by noon on Saturday. (But the last two years adjourned by noon on Friday). Most RPR members fly into ATL on Wed morning, spend two nights at the Hampton Inn near the PCA offices about an hour NE of ATL, and catch a flight out of ATL late Friday afternoon or evening. The PCA provides the hotel rooms and reimburses other travel expenses (airfare, ground transportation, meals, etc.).

After a Presbytery elects its RPR rep (or, if a Presbytery's Rules allow, after the Moderator appoints him) the Presbytery Clerk notifies the PCA Admin Office in Lawrenceville of the name of the RPR Rep. RPR members usually serve three-year terms (like the GA Nominating Committee). And a Presbytery's slot alternates between RE and TE (though Presbytery is free to sub one for the other if needed). Nothing prohibits a Presbytery from appointing a different man each year, if they need to. Better that option than no rep.

Work before the Meeting - Each Presbytery files three sets of their 2012 minutes with the PCA prior to April 19. At some point before the RPR meeting, the PCA Clerk's office sends each RPR member a set from two Presbyteries, which they will review and make notations about, prior to the May meeting. At the meeting, these minutes and the RPR member's comments will be reviewed by second readers. Any RPR members that are appointed late will often not review minutes beforehand. So, much of Wednesday is spent in doing "First Reads." Furthermore, if an RPR rep can only come to Atlanta early Thursday morning, and stay one night, he would still likely be there for the most important or most controversial votes.

Overtures Committee: 13 NP guys are currently on this committee. If you're looking to maximize your involvement in the work of the Assembly this is where your time will be well spent. Due to a shift in our rules all business must run through Overtures. The significance of this super committee to the work of the Assembly has only increased.

3.To Do

If you are serving on a permanent cmte, special cmte, or Committee of Commissioners at the GA could you check our list on the Partnership website to make sure you are correctly included? Let me know of any changes/additions.

If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures to the General Assembly must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC.

Please share your perspectives on overtures on our discussion page. Resourcing one another really is the greatest benefit of the NP. Several of you have weighed in; thank you!

Partnership Expansion: if you have like-minded friends in the presbyteries below, where we have no Partnership members, please consider reaching out to them about the National Partnership. It's helpful for us to be able to coordinate across more presbyteries.

Catawba Valley

Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey

New River

New York State

North Florida

Northern California

Illiana

Northern new Eng

NW Georgia

Pacific

Philadelphia MW

Piedmont Triad

Providence

Westminster

Wisconsin

4.What's Next

1. Attendance at GA. All of the work we've done to inform and resource one another rests on our willingness to attend GA and be a part of the polity process. Not only that but bringing a Ruling Elder this year could help the voting on the floor to be more representative of the denomination as a whole. Please do consider it. There may also be some helpful seminars for you to attend together. I've found that to be true a time or two in the past. Good chance for ministry dreaming, etc.

2. Committee of Commissioners. We need to fill the spots available for Overtures. It may be more difficult for you to find spots on the Overtures committee because there is a greater understanding of the importance of that committee among the typical presbyter.

3. Resourcing in advance of committee meetings. I intend for us to share our opinions on issues in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

4. Discussion of overtures to the 41st GA has begun. Join the discussion!

5. Resourcing is always welcome. Whether you would like feedback concerning an proposed overture or you would like to propose a conversation for everyone's mutual benefit please let me know and I'll start the post on the Partnership website.

6. I will be checking on the availability of space at GA for additional seminars during the equipping sessions. I would love to have some of you willing to serve the assembly by sharing your ministry experience in a seminar. Will let you know what I hear about this.

5. Resources

Over on the [Partnership website](#) we have a number of profitable discussions proposed including:

DISCUSSION OF 2013 GA OVERTURES IS ACTIVE. Please do resource the rest of us with your perspective on this year's slate of overtures.

Presbytery Health – In my presbytery (Ohio) we are considering a massive revision to the way we do business. I've heard some of you would like to push for the same in your own presbyteries. Obviously our presbyteries functioning more like churches for our Teaching Elders would be a blessing to the church at large. Posted on the 'resources' page are the Ohio Bylaw proposed changes (drawn from discussion within this Partnership) that our presbytery will soon debate. Others of you may contribute your own plans for reform in your presbyteries for the good of the group. Perhaps we can encourage one another in this task.

6. Google Groups Instructions

Google groups manages our group emails.

1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole. Your email to the entire group must have this address in the 'To' field rather than the 'CC' field.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

National Partnership NOTE

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Apr 23, 2013, 8:10:40 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Hello all,

Seeing great communication on committee assignments and glad to see so many of you jumping on overtures where available. I'll have a private single-malt tasting for you OC guys at the Hilton! I'm also trying to get a read on other strategically important CoC assignments and I'll get that info to you ASAP. One other update of note, RE Sam Duncan – the NP representative from Seersucker Presbytery - has provided us with his suggestion for an overture to refine the BCO language regarding the diaconate issue. He gives two options, one he calls moderate/conservative and one he calls progressive. As we have such a diversity of opinions in the Partnership I'm loving the chance for us to charitably interact. I've placed it on the website for your perusal. Two months to GA so jump on those overture discussions. I'll look to get a summary of our discussions in your hand for advice during the Assembly toward the end of May/first week of June.

Best,

JK

The Partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

1.Additions (121 elders in 47 presbyteries)

TE Glenn McDowell (Philadelphia)

RE Scott Winchester (Heritage)

TE Michael Novak (South Texas)

TE John Gullett (Central Florida)

2. Updates:

Overtures Committee: 18 NP guys are currently on this committee. If you're looking to maximize your involvement in the work of the Assembly this is where your time will be well spent. Due to a shift in our rules all BCO-related business must run through Overtures. The significance of this super committee to the work of the Assembly has only increased.

Picked up a representative of South Texas presbytery, pushing our presbyteries to 47.

3.To Do

-If you are serving on a permanent cmte, special cmte, or Committee of Commissioners at the GA could you check our list on the Partnership website to make sure you are correctly included? Let me know of any changes/additions.

-If a position on the Overtures Committee of Commissioners is open for you in your presbytery, volunteer. Our denomination's polity vests much influence in the work of this committee – all overtures requiring BCO amendment must pass through it. The shorthand: the work of 1000 delegates in the past is now done by 80 or so on the OC.

-Please share your perspectives on overtures on our discussion page. Resourcing one another really is the greatest benefit of the NP. Several of you have weighed in; thank you! I intend for us to share our opinions on issues in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

-Attendance at GA. All of the work we've done to inform and resource one another rests on our willingness to attend GA and be a part of the polity process. Not only that but bringing a Ruling Elder this year could help the voting on the floor to be more representative of the denomination as a whole. Please do consider it. There may also be some helpful seminars for you to attend together. I've found that to be true a time or two in the past. Good chance for ministry dreaming, etc.

-Committee of Commissioners. We need to fill the spots available for Overtures. It may be more difficult for you to find spots on the Overtures committee because there is a greater understanding of the importance of that committee among the typical presbyter.

-Resourcing is always welcome. Whether you would like feedback concerning an proposed overture or you would like to propose a conversation for everyone's mutual benefit please let me know and I'll start the post on the Partnership website.

-Partnership Expansion: if you have like-minded friends in the presbyteries below, where we have no Partnership members, please consider reaching out to them about the National Partnership. It's helpful for us to be able to coordinate across more presbyteries.

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Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Heartland
Mississippi Valley
New Jersey
New River
New York State
North Florida
Northern California
Illiana
Northern new Eng
NW Georgia
Pacific
Philadelphia MW
Piedmont Triad
Providence
Westminster
Wisconsin

4. Resources

DISCUSSION OF 2013 GA OVERTURES IS ACTIVE. Please do resource the rest of us with your perspective on this year's slate of overtures.

Robert's Rules primer – a handy chart for committee work

Serving on a Committee of the General Assembly – a short introduction from RE EJ Nusbaum

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2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

Additional options for Committee of Commissioner assignments

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Apr 25, 2013, 10:26:48 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Some have asked if there are other areas of involvement beyond the Overtures committee. I'm still gathering opinions but two that seem to be highlighted repeatedly are the Interchurch relations and Administrative committees. IRC is a focus of those that would like to restrict our fraternal relations with other reformed denominations. The Admin committee of commissioners is what you might expect – there are factions that would like to level whatever real or perceived power the Admin committee possesses and the CoC is one forum where that battle seems to be fought on occasion. At the very least understanding how our denomination's Admin committee works is helpful for any presbyter. I hope you'll consider these options, men as you meet with your presbyteries one last time before the Assembly (you may be able to contact your stated clerk and be placed on these committees without much effort if an opening exists. Worth a try). I'll update you on other hotspots as I hear about them. Thanks so much for your participation in the process.

JK

National Partnership Note

1 view

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James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

May 8, 2013, 11:10:55 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Hello all,

In addition to the normal update I wanted to give you a heads up on front-burner issues.

1. The resolution of the Peter Leithart matter. For those of you unaware, TE Leithart – member of Pacific Northwest Presbytery – has been accused of views placing him outside the boundaries of orthodoxy in our denomination. A complaint brought against him was heard, dismissed by presbytery, the presbytery was directed to conduct a trial, he was tried by his presbytery and exonerated. Then an appeal was filed to the Standing Judicial Commission wherein most recently the SJC found that the presbytery did not err in exonerating TE Leithart. There was significant anger in some circles – one could read this blog entry for a taste: <http://greenbaggins.wordpress.com/2013/04/02/the-leithart-verdict/> (the writer of this blog was a prosecution expert witness in the presbytery trial), Dominic Aquila has published multiple articles related to the issue with a significant anti-leithart slant (<http://theaquilareport.com/?s=leithart>) . If you want to see the trial documents in their entirety you can go here: <https://www.dropbox.com/sh/kpzd4mjnptyipkm/ApHiA1kiZ9> . This will be the talk of the Assembly and I suspect you will hear from it in four ways:
 1. Review of Presbytery records will be deciding whether the PNW Presbytery's response to an inquiry regarding the holding of Paedocommunion views is acceptable. While we have a long (30+ year) record of Paedocommunionists in the PCA (though they may not practice Paedocommunion, they may hold the view) there has been a recent push to declare these views untenable for Teaching Elders in the PCA. I suspect that a great many in our denomination erroneously view Paedocommunion and Federal Vision to be nearly synonymous.
 2. The Nominating Committee will bring an encouraging (to me!) slate of nominees to the floor. With some frustration over the SJC's exoneration of PNW Presbytery, the stakes will be seen as uniquely high. To some a vote for jurists like Dominic Aquila to retain his seat on the SJC will be a vote for saving orthodoxy from activist judges. The floor vote on Nominations will be critically important and a non-beer hour for those of us that visit the pub during GA.
 3. Overture 19 from Illiana presbytery (I would call Illiana very conservative) asks the Assembly to order the SJC to retry the Leithart case. My information is that this overture is out-of-

order and will probably be ruled by the CCB as in conflict with the constitution. Expect a minority report from the CCB expressing that this overture is in order. Fun times with polity! It should be noted that more typical objections/appeals have not yet been filed in the case; the overture from Illiana is an unusual (and perhaps unconstitutional) way to get another bite at the apple.

4. Three presbyteries have filed an overture asking the SJC to take original jurisdiction from Pacific Northwest Presbytery in the Leithart case. Here's Dominic Aquila's article about the overtures: <http://theaquilareport.com/three-pca-presbyteries-overture-ga-to-assume-original-jurisdiction-over-te-leithart/> . Our book of order allows for a minority of presbyteries to ask that the jurisdiction of one presbytery over a case in the bounds be assumed by a greater court. This is a drastic action in our polity, being a grass-roots denomination (power vested in the presbyteries, sessions and congregations first). What we would be saying is that Pacific Northwest has shown itself either incapable or unwilling to exercise proper discipline over those in their care. The burden of proof here is high.
2. SJC Nominations. The current slate of nominees approved by the Nominating committee includes TE/s Greg Thompson, Ray Cannata, and Will Barker. The RE/s include E.J. Nusbaum, John Bise and John Pickering. These are all well-qualified men, to me and to the Nominating Committee. The greatest heat here revolves around the fact that this slate removed TE Dominic Aquila, former moderator of the assembly and publisher of the Aquila Report. Because RE EJ Nusbaum (also a former moderator of the General Assembly) was approved (and received the most votes of any candidate, either TE or RE) and is a member of Rocky Mountain Presbytery, Dominic was ineligible for the TE spot, though he received significant support in balloting. The rules state that only one man may represent a presbytery on the court. There will be several attempts to have Dominic Aquila re-elected to the court and Nusbaum either defeated or ruled ineligible by Aquila's election.

Those points may leave your head spinning. I laughed writing this. Realize that there is far more that can and will be said in weeks ahead about both issues; complications abound and those who understand process will be pushing every button. My hope is only to have you informed so that you may fully participate in debate and vote your conscience. Please do continue to share your views on overtures – we have added more to the website.

Many of you have asked for other CoC assignments that could be helpful if Overtures is filled. The two I've heard most: Administrative Committee and Interchurch Relations Committee. One more word: encourage your friends in your presbyteries to attend this year's assembly. Registrations appear to be higher than normal. We should certainly be mindful of the need to include RE/s and bring them along. The first year I attended Assembly with an RE was a sweet time of shared vision and mission.

Thanks all of you for staying informed and pulling the rope together. Hope your ministry, and your hope in the gospel, is strong.

Christ is King,

JK

National Partnership NOTE

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

May 29, 2013, 8:04:35 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Hello all, Partnership Note below, but before that with 3 weeks until the opening of the 41st General Assembly I'd like to ask all of you for two favors:

1. Please review the overture discussions on the NP website. Even if you won't be attending the assembly for some reason we would do well to have your thoughts.
2. Review and interact with our latest discussion topic, the pertinent issues heading into this assembly. To better prepare yourself and others for Assembly work is a primary aim of the Partnership. I would love to see us sharpen our thinking. Thank you!

Christ is King,
JK

The Partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

1.Additions (125 elders in 48 presbyteries)

TE Nate Conrad (Chicago Metro)

TE Chad Smith (Westminster)

TE Campbell Silman (SE Louisiana)

2. Updates:

Overtures 20-22 have been referred to the SJC (rather than the Overtures committee); the overtures seek to force the SJC to assume original jurisdiction away from the Pacific Northwest Presbytery in order to retry TE Leithart

Overture 23 (ordering a trial of TE Myers in Missouri Presbytery after the original complainant left the presbytery rendering the trial out of order) has been added to the website discussion page.

3.To Do

-If you are serving on a Committee of Commissioners at GA could you check our list on the Partnership website to make sure you are correctly included? Let me know of any changes/additions.

-Please share your perspectives on overtures on our discussion page. Resourcing one another really is the greatest benefit of the NP. Several of you have weighed in; thank you! I intend for us to share our opinions on issues in confidence. This group exists to be a help so you'll hear from me (and others) regarding recommended courses of action. These are only given for the benefit of discussion and unity where helpful.

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-Resourcing is always welcome. Whether you would like feedback concerning an proposed overture or you would like to propose a conversation for everyone's mutual benefit please let me know and I'll start the post on the Partnership website.

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Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship
Great Lakes
Gulf Coast
Mississippi Valley
New Jersey
New River
New York State
North Florida
Northern California
Illiana
Northern new Eng
NW Georgia
Pacific
Philadelphia MW
Piedmont Triad
Providence
Wisconsin

4. New Resources

DISCUSSION OF 2013 GA OVERTURES IS ACTIVE. Please do resource the rest of us with your perspective on this year's slate of overtures.

GA Primer 1 – efficient use of the Review of Presbytery Records report – TE Cal Boroughs

Robert's Rules primer – a handy chart for committee work

Serving on a Committee of the General Assembly – a short introduction from RE EJ Nusbaum

5. Google Groups Instructions

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2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

Pre-Assembly week details; action needed

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 10, 2013, 7:52:06 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

I hope to have some resources available to you by the end of the week:

1. **Critical docket items** – that is, when not to be getting a beer
2. **Summary document** stating the consensus on Overtures from the website (note also that we will send out a summary of the Overtures Committee conversation after it meets during General Assembly included any recommended actions. As always you're free to disagree!)

If you can add any wisdom to our discussions on the website regarding Overtures [before Wednesday COB](#) I would be very thankful. Particularly your views on 7, 8, 16, 17, 19, 23. Thank you!

JK

Overture 17 feedback

1 view

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refandrev
<refandrev@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 13, 2013, 11:26:36 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers, Overture 17 is an academic exercise about the ability for us to amend the WCOF. Its author T David Gordon, chose an area that is as non-controversial as possible, having even investigated the historical differences between Reformed denominations, so as NOT to choose language that adds anything more (ie. tithing). This overture is one of the few things that generated little discussion at Presbytery, but a few chuckles in the process. It should be taken at face value. -- Walt

On Jun 12, 2013 11:18 PM, "James Kessler" <JKes...@npc-dublin.org> wrote:

Brothers,

Those of us on the Overtures committee have had a lively discussion about Ascension Presbytery's proposed amendment to the confession. On the surface the alteration seems minor but concern is there that this addition paves the way for undue encroachment via the Regulative Principle. Others feel that we gain something by opening the door to the amendment of the confession through this addition. I would be very glad if we could hear from those of you with wisdom to add to the discussion. Thank you men!

JK

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To post to this group, send email to Th...@googlegroups.com.

For more options, visit https://groups.google.com/groups/opt_out.

--

Walt Coppersmith

Executive Pastor

Insider Movement Report

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



mbates
<mbates@v7pc.org>

unread,

Jun 13, 2013, 12:04:51 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

It would be easy to ignore this report because it does not directly affect most of our ministries. However, I do think it could affect some ministries more than you realize, especially if you are laboring in an area that is post-Christendom.

While this may not be the intent, the Majority Report's treatment of Acts 15 seems to speak against many forms of biblical contextualization. I realize some ministering to Muslims (and many other contexts) have abused the concept of contextualization, but it is still an important concept that affects biblical ministry. The issues of culture, identity, and contextualization are very important discussions for those living in post-Christendom. This report therefore is not only about ministry to Muslims, but ministry to people in your city. I believe the Minority Report is clearer on this issue.

2. The Majority Report, while it says many good things, is in such technical theological language that most lay people will not be able to understand it. The Minority Report is much more readable and deals with certain important realities.

3. The Majority Report does not take into consideration important realities such as this: in Egypt, no matter what your theological or religious beliefs may be, you are registered at birth as either a Muslim or Christian. There are no other options and this "identity" can never be changed. It is illegal, and therefore impossible, for a person who is registered Muslim to change his identity to Christian. What are we asking those who convert to Christianity to do? That is a very critical issue that is addressed in the Minority Report that is not addressed by the Majority Report. It is also a very practical issue in many ministries. How do we want people to relate to the culture where they live and are born when they come to faith in Christ? Are we advocating withdrawal or engagement?

Overall, the Majority Report is good, but lacking. I think the Minority Report fills in the gaps and is an important addition.

Mark Bates
Senior Pastor
Village Seven Presbyterian Church

Comparison of the Louisiana (Steve Wilkins) and Pacific Northwest (Peter Leithart) cases

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



larry.c.hoop
<larry.c.hoop@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 13, 2013, 5:00:48 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

In response to one of our number who expressed the concern to me that the SJC's case involving Louisiana Presbytery and Steve Wilkins might be suggested as a parallel to some of the actions being suggested regarding the Leithart (and Meyers) cases, I have prepared a paper comparing the the SJC involvement with Louisiana and Pacific Northwest on these matters (sorry - I didn't do the same for MO - maybe I'll have time to do that addendum). I have attached the resulting paper which demonstrates the substantial differences between the two. I hope it will prove helpful.

In Him,

Larry Hoop

Paper:

A COMPARISON OF SJC 2007-14 WITH SJC 2012-5 I have received the following inquiry regarding the Leithart case: "I am looking at SJC 2007-14 - The Louisiana Presbytery case. What are the differences in the reasoning of the SJC between the Louisiana case and the Pacific Northwest case?" SJC 2007-14 is a very complicated case. Here's the background: • On April 9, 2005, Louisiana Presbytery received a preliminary study report from its own study committee on Federal Vision/Auburn Avenue Theology, and in particular the teachings of TE Steve Wilkins. The preliminary report was received and adopted by Presbytery and a study committee was appointed to examine TE Wilkins concerning his teachings. Wilkins was exonerated. • In January 2006, Central Carolina Presbytery sent a memorial to GA (as per BCO 40-5) arguing that TE Wilkins exoneration was improper and asking the SJC to assume original jurisdiction over the case, or, failing that, to cite Louisiana Presbytery to appear under BCO 40-5 "to show what [it] has done or failed to do in the case in question" regarding TE Wilkins. The SJC opted for the latter and designated this SJC 2006-2. • The SJC ruled that Louisiana could not demonstrate that their examination of TE Wilkins complied with the standard set for investigation of allegations made in BCO 31-2 ("due diligence and great discretion"). They directed presbytery to reexamine TE Wilkins and gave guidelines as to how that examination was to be conducted. • Louisiana Presbytery conducted the investigation, and exonerated TE Wilkins a second time in January 2007. On February 15, RE James Jones filed a complaint with Presbytery regarding its exoneration of TE Wilkins. At its April meeting, Presbytery denied the complaint. RE Jones filed a complaint with the SJC in May. This was designated SJC 2007-8. • This complaint was sustained. The SJC directed that an indictment be drawn against Louisiana Presbytery for its failure to find a "strong presumption of guilt" against TE Wilkins and indict him. This was designated SJC 2007-14 (yes, we're finally there). The citation and indictment was drawn (two counts: failure to properly address the differences between TE Wilkins and the Standards, and failure to indict him) in early January 2008; letter in January, Louisiana met to plead (not guilty to the first count, guilty to the second); and at the end of the month, Auburn Avenue Church and TE Wilkins left the PCA. The trial against Louisiana Presbytery was held in March 2008 and the SJC dismissed the first count of the indictment and admonished presbytery as censure for the second. • Note these salient features of this case: (1) It was against Louisiana Presbytery for a failure to indict Wilkins (i.e., "failure to act"). (2) Because of this failure to indict, and his leaving the denomination, no trial of TE Wilkins was ever held. This is a key point. Compare with the background to SJC 2012-5: • Following the adoption of the Federal Vision Study Paper in 2007, TE Leithart wrote to the Stated Clerk of the Pacific Northwest Presbytery in order to lay out his views on specific subjects contained in the 9 Declarations of that paper. In response to a request from Leithart and TE Stellmon, Presbytery appointed a Study Committee to examine Leithart's fitness to continue as a PCA Teaching Elder in light of his response. On October, 2008, the Study Committee filed its report recommending that Leithart's views be judged to be not out of accord with the fundamentals of our system of doctrine. A Minority Report was also filed, recommending that Leithart's views be found out of accord with the fundamentals of the system of doctrine. Presbytery adopted the Committee Report. • Later in October of the same year, a Complaint was filed with Presbytery alleging that Presbytery erred by not finding that Leithart's views were out of accord with the Standards and by finding that Leithart's views were not out of accord with the Standards (a subtle distinction). There were also two other specifications. In April 2009, Presbytery, acting on the recommendation of its Judicial Commission, denied the complaint. In May 2009, TE Bordwine and others filed complaint with the SJC by rejecting the Minority Report, which contained ample evidence that the

differences between Leithart's views and the Standards are fundamental, and in affirming that Leithart's differences are not out of accord with the Standards. This was designated SJC 2009-6. • In March 2010, the Complaint was sustained. The SJC reasoned that without the completion of judicial process, Presbytery could not declare that these teachings are not out of accord with our system of doctrine; further, views of Leithart touching fundamentals of the system of doctrine set out in the Record suggested a strong presumption of guilt on matters that could that could properly be the subject of judicial process. Presbytery was directed to counsel Leithart "that the views set forth above constitute error that is injurious to peace and purity of the church and offer him pastoral advice on how he might recant and make reparations for those views or, if he is unwilling or unable in conscience to do so, that he is free to take timely steps toward affiliation with some other branch of the visible church that is consistent with his views." Should he fail to recant or affiliate elsewhere, Presbytery was directed , in effect, to draw an indictment against him. It should be noted that, despite the obvious differences in the two decisions, and the attending circumstances (e.g., Wilkins leaving the PCA), Cases 2009-6 and 2007-14 end at roughly parallel points: judgment has been rendered against each presbytery for exonerating a member; no indictment has been filed; no trial has been held. • At the Pacific Northwest Presbytery meeting in October, TE Leithart reported he had not changed his views nor was he requesting to transfer his credentials out of the PCA. At that point Presbytery initiated process against him. The trial was held in June 2011, and Leithart was found not guilty of all the charges against him. This judgment was adopted by Presbytery at its October meeting. • Complaint against this action was filed with the Presbytery in November 2011. This complaint was denied in April 2012. RE Hedman then filed complaint with the SJC in May. This was designated SJC 2012-5. The complaint was denied by the SJC in March 2013. It should be noted that Presbytery had acted in this matter by holding an extensive trial (as opposed to Louisiana), and that no clear error of fact or judgment was demonstrated by the Complainant.

Overture 17

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 12, 2013, 10:18:23 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Those of us on the Overtures committee have had a lively discussion about Ascension Presbytery's proposed amendment to the confession. On the surface the alteration seems minor but concern is there that this addition paves the way for undue encroachment via the Regulative Principle. Others feel that we gain something by opening the door to the amendment of the confession through this addition. I would be very glad if we could hear from those of you with wisdom to add to the discussion. Thank you men!

JK



kevinjtwit

<kevinjtwit@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 13, 2013, 1:59:08 PM

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□

to thenp@googlegroups.com

But Gordon is a strict regulative guy and so my concerns as to the precedent this sets are still there. We don't need it if you are not a strict rp guy.

Sent from my iPhone



David Goneau

<dgoneau@newlifeglenside.com>

unread,

Jun 13, 2013, 4:22:33 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

I'm not sure I fully understand why it's necessary to amend the WCoF on this particular issue. It seems to me that Scripture, being our highest authority, already speaks relatively clearly on the issue of supporting the work of the church financially. Is it to establish precedent that may allow for more controversial amendments in the future? My skeptical bent thinks this may be an attempt to more narrowly define theological positions that were, for whatever reason, not addressed by the Westminster Divines. I would appreciate any feedback that may help clarify the argument for me.

David Goneau

Pre-Assembly Partnership Notes

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 16, 2013, 6:50:18 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Brothers,

I'd like to orient you a little to Assembly week and provide a couple of details.

1. At the close of Overtures Committee business (probably Tuesday afternoon) I will prepare a summary of our actions and advice from our guys on the OC. Of course as always you are free to vote however you choose we just want to do our best to resource anyone looking for further information.

2. Docket: There are some moments where you are going to need to be present to vote rather than strolling the exhibitions or grabbing a beer. I would outline the most crucial areas of the docket this way (all times approximate)
 1. Wednesday, 1.30pm – **Review of Presbytery Records report** (there are 4 minority reports seeking to retry SJC cases or constrain further our brothers who hold to Paedocommunion but respectfully do not practice Paedocommunion, as they have for more than 2 decades in our denomination). Most of the NP Guys on RPR voted in the majority in each of those cases. I am personally opposed to each of those minority reports.
 2. Thursday, 10.25am – **SJC report**.
 3. Thursday, 11.10am – **Constitutional Business** – another attempted bite at the TE Leithart SJC case. I expect the minority report to be ruled out of order
 4. Thursday 11.30am – **Nominating Committee** – there will be attempts to overturn the committee's recommendations, as there are every year. This is of particular interest to me and 13 other NP members as we served on this committee and were very happy with the candidates believing them very qualified, but good brothers can disagree here.
 5. Thursday 3.30pm – **Overtures Committee**

So then, I would plan to be very available from Wednesday early afternoon and particularly the Thursday morning hours. Keep an eye out for those reports on the docket.

3.

Use of the National Partnership Website. Brothers, I would like to ask that you not access the Partnership website publicly (that means in committee, on the floor, in the halls), not because we have anything to hide but because we want to be mindful of being perceived as participating in the Assembly with a 'party spirit'. Though I believe we've proceeded honorably I would like to care enough for those opposed to or fearful of the NP to exercise restraint where reasonable.

4.

Emails during the Assembly will be useful but will be moderated to ensure that we do not overload everyone's email boxes. If you wish to have an email spread to the entire group you can let me know. So if you 'reply' to NP emails or send an email to th...@googlegroups.com your email will go directly to me and I can attempt to answer any questions you might have or post your email to the whole group if you prefer.

5.

I will be participating in a Thursday Morning seminar with **George Robertson** and **Mike Ross**. It should draw nearly dozens as it happens opposite the Duncan/Mohler seminar on inerrancy. Of course if you've already settled the matter of inerrancy and have already picked up your free stuff and spoken to the guy in the exhibit hall about Jews for Jesus we would love for you join us. The title of the seminar is 'loving communication' which is not a fantastic title but will have fantastic

content from some great speakers. I will also speak. And there will be an opportunity to ask questions about how we interact with one another both publicly and privately in an information age. My specific focus will regard the price we pay in the process of brotherly love if we believe the Gospel.

6.

Me and some other Partnership guys will look to grab a beer Thursday night after everything and you are invited to join us. I will send out an email letting you know when and where.

7.

Additions (131 elders in 48 presbyteries)

TE Pat Hickman (Central Indiana)

RE Bill Thomas (North Texas)

RE Paul Neighbors (Siouxlands)

TE Mike Tilley (Central Florida)

TE Scott Sauls (Nashville)

TE Jim Lovelady (Philadelphia)

One final note:

I hope you won't mind if I reflect for a moment on a couple of things I'm trying to tell myself as we enter a contentious but also God-honoring week of work and worship.

This Assembly will neither save nor condemn the PCA, contrary to what you may have heard. I don't pretend that we are here to save the denomination or prevent it from decay. We are here to do the Lord's work and to love one another. I'm not sure what sorts of frustrations we will encounter in committee, on the floor, on the internet, whatever; but I do know that we can't take ourselves too seriously and that we are privileged to deliberate and craft together as men called.

It has to be enough for me, and perhaps for you too, to adorn our profession with honor and dignity this week, to love one another well, to believe the Gospel more than before we came. It has to be more important to us to be men than to be right. I'm preaching to myself, but I thought you might be interested in overhearing. Pulling the rope with you brothers has been a joy for me this past year; I've met so many new brothers and have been encouraged at different times by several of you. To lead the National Partnership has been hard and good work, and hilarious if you saw the state of my closets – both figurative and literal. You are my friends most of all and I'm thankful for that. Have a great week.

Christ is King,

JK

Google Groups Instructions

Google groups manages our group emails.

1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole. Your email to the entire group must have this address in the 'To' field rather than the 'CC' field.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

Another Docket Item

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



e.j.nusbaum.b7ci
<e.j.nusbaum.b7ci@statefarm.com>

unread,

Jun 16, 2013, 8:53:30 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers:

May I suggest another "don't miss" item will be the IM study committee report. It will be first thing Thursday AM. You received a good email from Mark Bates explaining why it is critical to combine the minority report with the majority report.

Looking forward to seeing you soon!

In Him!

EJ



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 16, 2013, 9:45:53 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

From: <Bates>, Mark Bates <mba...@v7pc.org>
Reply-To: "TheNP+...@googlegroups.com" <TheNP+...@googlegroups.com>
Date: Sunday, June 16, 2013 10:42 PM
To: "TheNP+...@googlegroups.com" <TheNP+...@googlegroups.com>
Cc: "Th...@googlegroups.com" <Th...@googlegroups.com>
Subject: Re: Another Docket Item

Also, I heard that Alfred Poirier speaking against the Minority Report. If someone has that, could you please send it to me. I would like to see what the arguments are against it.

Thanks,

Mark

Mark Bates
Senior Pastor
Village Seven Presbyterian Church

To TNP: Response to The Gospel Coalition's Statement on the abuse/cover-up allegations in SGM

1 view

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Mike Sloan
<mikeasloan@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 14, 2013, 9:43:54 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

My Dear Brothers

I wanted to bring up an important story that is not getting the attention it deserves in our Reformed circles. I don't know if you have heard yet about the alleged child sexual abuse and cover-up case involving C.J. Mahaney and Sovereign Grace Ministries. After their initial silence, the very influential groups, Together for the Gospel and The Gospel Coalition, have now publicly supported their friend C.J. Mahaney with written statements on their respective websites. They include many distressing inaccuracies and damaging statements to any victims of child sexual abuse. I wanted to bring them to your attention and ask you to educate yourself about the situation for the good of our churches and our children. This is a critical issue in our time as sexual abuse is an epidemic in our culture and tragically few churches take appropriate steps to protect those who cannot protect themselves.

I have attached a document in which I respond to these disturbing statements by The Gospel Coalition and Together for the Gospel for your consideration. I would also encourage you to please read [the lawsuit](#) for yourself. I believe what is going on is very wrong. This case is parallel to the Penn State case and cover-up in the number of witnesses and types of charges. The difference is these are our Reformed evangelical brothers and almost no one with influence is speaking out. I know you men care about speaking up for the truth and protecting the vulnerable because this is the heart of the God we serve. I would love to hear from any of you about this. Looking forward to seeing some of you soon at GA.

Grace and Peace,

Mike Sloan

mikea...@gmail.com

[678-524-5595](tel:678-524-5595)

□

Thoughts on TGC_T4G Statements Re SGM Scandal.docx



Jedidiah Slaboda

<jedidiah@secondcitychurch.org>

unread,

Jun 14, 2013, 10:37:20 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Thanks for sharing, Mike. I have been troubled by this as well. Organizations centered around authoritative or celebrity figures are often too proud to admit failure or sin until it is impossible to deny it any longer. We have all seen men deny adultery until the evidence piles up for similar reasons--pride.

One resource for churches is the training program by Stewards of Children, Darkness to Light. Look it up and sign up your staff and children's workers to attend. Announce it in the church, let would be abusers know that you know it can happen (and is happening) in any church and that we are called to vigilantly steward all children from abuse.

http://www.d2l.org/site/c.4dIClJOkgcISE/b.6243681/k.86C/Child_Sexual_Abuse_Prevention_Training.htm

Resolution on Child Sexual Abuse

1 view

Skip to first unread message



Mike Sloan

<mikeasloan@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 17, 2013, 7:38:57 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

I am planning on bringing this personal resolution on child sexual abuse. I have attached it for your consideration. I would really appreciate your support on this as your conscience dictates. It should come under new business on Wednesday morning. It needs a 2/3 majority to pass. My prayer is that it will encourage many churches to more actively pursue protecting children as the love of Jesus would have us do.

Mike

Personal Resolution on Child Sexual Abuse

Proposed to the 41st General Assembly in Greenville, South Carolina

By TE Mike Sloan, Georgia Foothills Presbytery

WHEREAS our Lord Jesus demonstrated his righteous anger at his disciples, rebuking those who would do anything to prevent covenant children from coming unto him, saying “to such belongs the Kingdom of God” (Mark 10:14); and

WHEREAS the Lord Jesus, who possesses all power and authority in heaven and on earth, taught and demonstrated in his humiliation, that power is rightly exercised to serve others, protect the weak, and speak for the oppressed (Mark 10:42-45, Exodus 22:21-24, Deuteronomy 10:17-19, Proverbs 31:1-9); and

WHEREAS a silent epidemic of child abuse exists in our culture wherein 1 in 4 girls and 1 in 6 boys are sexually abused before their eighteenth birthday (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2006), including girls and boys who attend PCA churches, with 95% of victims being violated by someone they know and trust (Darkness2Light.org); and

WHEREAS child sexual abuse thrives in an environment that discourages open communication about the abuse and also thrives with both the calculated sin of abusers and by the inaction of church leaders who are nonetheless complicit in the abuse and culpable before the Lord; and

WHEREAS the law mandates all pastors, church employees and volunteers to report child abuse to civil authorities, and biblical due diligence requires churches to train its workers and volunteers to protect children by screening workers and volunteers, by strictly limiting one adult one child situations, and by maintaining a child protection policy informed by wise resources now widely available; and

WHEREAS the silence of the church, by not speaking out against this sin, or not supporting the courageous victims who disclose abuse, or not proactively taking the steps to prevent abuse, is a fundamental failure of servant leadership in such a time as this, and drives people away from the Gospel of Jesus Christ; and

WHEREAS some Reformed and evangelical organizations, fellowships of ministers, and well-known leaders have lately come under the closest moral and legal scrutiny, many facing criminal and/or civil litigation for neglect in reporting probable criminal activity against children and harboring and protecting probable sexual perpetrators against children; and

WHEREAS some of our church officers and members, have established close relational ties with some of these Reformed and evangelical organizations, fellowships of ministers, and/or well-known leaders, some with little or no knowledge of these circumstances, and some despite knowledge of these circumstances, casting doubt in the eyes of many on the stance of the PCA toward child sexual abuse and our moral resolve to uproot it; THEREFORE, be it

RESOLVED that we plead with all pastors and church officers to lead their churches to study, implement, and maintain child protection policies pertaining to our moral and legal obligations in loving our covenant children and protecting their rightful interests as God's image-bearers and heirs of the Covenant of Grace from the devastating actions of abusers in the church; and be it further

RESOLVED that we pledge our commitment to work and fully cooperate with duly appointed God-ordained government officials in exposing and bringing to justice all probable perpetrators, who morally and criminally harm the children placed in our trust, and not in any perceivable way display reluctance in fully cooperating with lawful authorities by attempting to handle the issue internally by subjecting either the supposed victim or alleged criminal perpetrator to private "church discipline" or relational "restoration" apart from the fulfillment of our mandated reporting duties to God-ordained government authorities; and be it further

RESOLVED that we strongly urge our permanent committees and agencies, church officers, and members, to exercise a high level of discernment in our affiliations, whether official or unofficial, with any Reformed and/or evangelical organization, fellowship of ministers, and/or well-known leader who does not take an active posture toward rooting out child sexual abuse in the church; and be it further

RESOLVED that we exhort all pastors and church officers to use their power for the protection of the vulnerable, by any and all godly means, including speaking boldly about the horrors of child sexual abuse

in our time, urging anyone with knowledge of these sins to “take no part in the unfruitful works of darkness, but instead expose them.” (Ephesians 5:11), and by supporting victims who are easily intimidated, and often suffer in silence, without the clear support of those in positions of power; and be it finally

RESOLVED that the 41st General Assembly urge all members of the PCA to renew our allegiance to our Lord Jesus to love our covenant children as he loves our covenant children, for to such belongs the Kingdom of God (Mark 10:14).

GA: Beer tonight, 8.30pm at The Trappe Door

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 17, 2013, 2:55:30 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Completely informal beer gathering tonight. We don't have a room but we have a restaurant. Come buy a beer and some food. For those of us that have interacted through the NP who still don't know the faces behind the names, this might be fun. No Agenda, no speeches or slogans. Just beer and great food. I recommend the McChouffe and the homemade Apple Sausage. Come hang out if you like. No big deal if you can't.

JK

No beer tonight!

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 17, 2013, 4:32:37 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Overtures has been reconvened for this evening, so no-go on beer night!
JK

GA: BEER ON

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 17, 2013, 7:50:02 PM

to thenp@googlegroups.com

Barley's on West Washington, 9pm.

Revised Personal Resolution on Child Sexual Abuse

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



Mike Sloan
<mikeasloan@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 18, 2013, 8:19:22 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Please see the attached revision of the Personal Resolution on Child Sexual Abuse. Brothers, I would certainly appreciate your support for this resolution on Wednesday in the morning or hopefully shortly after lunch at the latest (It will come under new business). The man who trained me in abuse prevention has told me that he knows of a case right now in the PCA where the church is presently seeking to deal with the situation by not reporting the abuse to the authorities. Brothers, let's speak boldly and clearly on this matter.

Regards
Mike

Personal Resolution on Child Sexual Abuse

Proposed to the 41st General Assembly in Greenville, South Carolina

By TE Mike Sloan, Georgia Foothills Presbytery

WHEREAS our Lord Jesus demonstrated his righteous anger at his disciples, rebuking those who would do anything to prevent covenant children from coming unto him, saying "to such belongs the Kingdom of God" (Mark 10:14); and

WHEREAS the Lord Jesus, who possesses all power and authority in heaven and on earth, taught and demonstrated in his humiliation, that power is rightly exercised to serve others, protect the weak, and speak for the oppressed (Mark 10:42-45, Exodus 22:21-24, Deuteronomy 10:17-19, Proverbs 31:1-9); and

WHEREAS a silent epidemic of child abuse exists in our culture wherein 1 in 4 girls and 1 in 6 boys are sexually abused before their eighteenth birthday (Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2006), including girls and boys who attend PCA churches, with 95% of victims being violated by someone they know and trust (Darkness2Light.org); and

WHEREAS child sexual abuse thrives in an environment that discourages open communication about the abuse and also thrives with both the calculated sin of abusers and by the inaction of church leaders who are nonetheless complicit in the abuse and culpable before the Lord; and

WHEREAS the law in almost all states mandates pastors, and even in some states volunteers, to report child abuse to civil authorities within 24 hours, and biblical due diligence requires churches to train its workers and volunteers to protect children by screening workers and volunteers, by strictly limiting one adult one child situations, and by maintaining a child protection policy informed by wise resources now widely available; and

WHEREAS the silence of the church, by not speaking out against this sin, or not supporting the courageous victims who disclose abuse, or not proactively taking the steps to prevent abuse, is a fundamental failure of servant leadership in such a time as this, and drives people away from the Gospel of Jesus Christ; and

WHEREAS many of our members have close relational ties with some Reformed and evangelical organizations, fellowships of ministers, and well-known leaders who have lately come under the closest moral and legal scrutiny, some facing criminal and/or civil litigation for neglect in reporting alleged criminal activity against children and harboring and protecting alleged sexual perpetrators against children, casting doubt in the eyes of some on the stance of the PCA toward child sexual abuse and our moral resolve to uproot it; THEREFORE, be it

RESOLVED that we plead with all pastors and church officers to take an active stance toward rooting out child sexual abuse in the church by leading their churches to study, implement, and maintain child protection policies pertaining to our moral and legal obligations in loving our covenant children and protecting their rightful interests as God's image-bearers and heirs of the Covenant of Grace from the devastating actions of abusers in the church; and be it further

RESOLVED that we pledge our commitment to work and fully cooperate with duly appointed God-ordained government officials in exposing and bringing to justice all probable perpetrators, who morally and criminally harm the children placed in our trust, and not in any perceivable way display reluctance in fully cooperating with lawful authorities by attempting to handle the issue internally by subjecting either the supposed victim or alleged criminal perpetrator to private “church discipline” or relational “restoration” apart from the fulfillment of our mandated reporting duties to God-ordained government authorities; and be it further

RESOLVED that we exhort all pastors and church officers to use their power for the protection of the vulnerable, by any and all godly means, including speaking boldly about the horrors of child sexual abuse in our time, urging anyone with knowledge of these sins to “take no part in the unfruitful works of darkness, but instead expose them.” (Ephesians 5:11), and by supporting victims who are easily intimidated, and often suffer in silence, without the clear support of those in positions of power; and be it finally

RESOLVED that the 41st General Assembly urge all members of the PCA to renew our allegiance to our Lord Jesus to love our covenant children as he loves our covenant children, for to such belongs the Kingdom of God (Mark 10:14).

GA: Stay put tonight for the opening session

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 18, 2013, 4:01:09 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Ordinarily the opening of the General Assembly proceeds *pro forma* with a moderator election and the adoption of the docket. Tonight the Administrative Committee has been notified that there will be amendments to the docket seeking to expand the footprint of the TE Leithart case over the span of the assembly rather than dealing with the matter in a condensed fashion. In my opinion this would in no way serve the body (only protracting a conflict for the sake of making a point) so I thought I would let you know that it may be important for you to be present to vote on the matter. If I had other plans for post Assembly worship tonight (like the Reformed Communion dinner, etc.) I would delay them in order to be present and ready to vote.

Thanks men,

JK

GA: Sloan's personal resolution

1 view

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James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2013, 9:39:28 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

For those of you interested in hearing/acting on Mike Sloan's personal resolution (dealing with sexual abuse in the church), you will want to get to the hall ASAP.

JK

GA: Today's Note

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2013, 10:56:03 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

I want to bring you a couple of important notes for today's Assembly:

1:30 – RPR report. There will be four minority reports (2 dealing with Paedocommunion exceptions and 2 dealing with already-decided SJC cases). You probably have strong feelings one way or another (personally I will be opposing all four reports); if you would like to vote on these we would encourage you to get back from lunch on time for this report. As it is an order of the day it will not occur at any other time. See you then.

Vacancies on the SJC: TE Greg Thompson had to withdraw from nomination to the SJC and TE Brian Lee had to resign from the class of 2015. Due to this there will be two additional nominees (in addition to the typical multiple floor nominations we will deal with). I appreciate your forbearance when I give you my own hope for those spots. I will give you what I see as the most qualified options for those vacancies after the final floor nominees are received today. As always I would welcome your thoughts either personally or to share with the rest of the group. As I mentioned before the assembly you will want to be present for the Nominating committee report due tomorrow morning, 10:25am.

Thanks brothers!

JK

GA: votes are close, join us.

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2013, 2:30:51 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

The last vote from RPR was a difference of 30 votes. If you are present and unsure about the significance of your voting, it appears the assembly is divided and your participation would be significant. See you soon!

JK

GA: Today's assembly note

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 20, 2013, 9:20:11 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Brothers:

Now – completion of RPR report. Critical for you to be here

11:30am – ORDER OF THE DAY. Nominating Committee Report. Please be here for this. Please do not be late. There is a critical procedural move at the beginning of this report (11:30am) of which I am in favor and hope you will be supportive too. The procedural motion will allow the assembly to at least hear the Nominating Committee candidate (E.J. Nusbaum) instead of having him eliminated as a candidate by a floor nomination of Dr. Dominic Aquila. We can only have one nominee from each presbytery on the SJC, we can only have Aquila or Nusbaum, both of whom have been General Assembly Moderators but I am heavily in favor of E.J. I hope you'll forgive this strong opinion. I want to give you my thoughts on the other candidates and welcome your response either privately or to the group as a whole:

Admin Committee:

TE Steve Jeantet, Southwest Florida (my friend Timothy LeCroy is also nominated and both are very qualified, but we may want to ensure that we are united on this matter so that we do not split the vote)

Committee on Constitutional Business:

TE Larry Hoop

Alternate – Steve Dowling

MTW – TE Larry Doughan

SJC

Class of 2015 – TE Cal Boroughs

Class of 2017 – TE Ray Cannata

Class of 2017 – RE E.J. Nusbaum

TEC

RE Bill Cranford

Following the NC report – Ad Interim Committee on Insider movements – you have read TE Mark Bates' argument for adding the minority report to the majority report. Perhaps Mark will restate his support in a note I will send later. Please be informed on the minority report so you can vote accordingly.

More to come, undoubtedly. Christ is King!

JK

GA: 130 start!

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 20, 2013, 12:18:13 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Need you back for the next session's business, 1:30 sharp for this important procedural discussion and vote.

JK

4:20

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 20, 2013, 2:59:52 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Special order. Overtures 19&23. Have to be there.

GA: reconvene at 9p

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 20, 2013, 6:03:03 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Men,

We will be reconvening around 9p (when worship ends). Significant items we will take action on:

1. Mike's resolution (it will be moved procedurally to have the item moved up in the docket) regarding sexual sin in the church. It was gutted in committee.
2. Overture 8: the item requiring the reporting of differences. This appeared to be a step away from good faith subscription and a step toward stricter subscription. That may be an oversimplification but there will be a minority report coming from those unhappy with the committee work. I will vote against that minority report, believing that this is a solution in search of a problem.

See you then!



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 20, 2013, 6:40:08 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Begin forwarded message:

From: "Bates, Mark" <mba...@v7pc.org>

Date: June 20, 2013, 7:33:23 PM EDT

To: <TheNP+...@googlegroups.com>

Subject: Re: GA: reconvene at 9p

Reply-To: <TheNP+...@googlegroups.com>

Insider report may come back tonight with the section on Allah a deleted

What I think about the resolution on child sexual abuse

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



Mike Sloan
<mikeasloan@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 20, 2013, 7:07:04 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

After much soul searching, I am convinced it would be better for victims if we vote down the watered down statement tonight. I would appreciate any of you who are led to speak. There will hopefully be a procedural motion to allow me to speak even though I was in overtures, since I am the original author of the resolution.

My speech is below if you want to read my reasons for opposing this now.

I appreciate you all

Mike

Mike Sloan, TE, Georgia Foothills Presbytery. I actually plan to vote against the Resolution on Child Sexual Abuse as amended by the overtures committee, which may surprise you since I wrote and brought the original resolution. After careful thought, and in light of my experience listening to victims of abuse, and Christian experts on child sexual abuse, I believe this statement will do more harm than good. This shortened statement will not communicate to victims that we stand with you without hesitation, or that we plan to diligently challenge the environment of silence surrounding this issue in our churches, or that we will challenge all of

our churches to take the loving and bold actions needed to prevent child sexual abuse. Here are three reasons for my opposition:

1. First, I think one of the main sentiments that led to this current weaker statement is our concern about potentially making ourselves vulnerable, especially in regard to lawsuits in our churches. First of all, churches now who are not reporting child sexual abuse *are* vulnerable to lawsuits. A more robust statement that actually called churches into compliance with mandated reporting laws would help protect them from lawsuits. But brothers, I hope you have noticed that this is exactly the type of thinking that has led to a silent epidemic of child sexual abuse in our time. Our instinct is to protect ourselves and those in positions of power instead of the weak. My dear brothers, if we are putting concern for our *potential* vulnerability over the present and real vulnerability of children, it seems our priorities are out of line with Scripture. I believe if a lawsuit is what it takes to bring repentance to a church who has been sheltering child sexual abuse and so that it begins to protect the weak, then so be it.
2. Second, a glaring omission of this statement is any urgent call to follow mandated reporting laws. If we would simply listen to experts in this area, and the countless victims, then we would hear that there is today, right now, in countless churches, including PCA churches, a widespread failure to report abuse to authorities. I know of several situations in the PCA happening right now. Our PCA brothers who are not following mandated reporting laws need a loving rebuke. This resolution is not a loving rebuke. This statement essentially affirms the status quo. We must stand up and declare unequivocally that this is unacceptable for churches who profess deep love for the Lord Jesus. Affirming this statement would inadvertently encourage the code of silence that many churches have adopted. It is great to *say* we encourage one another to protect children by any and all means, but it rings hollow if we fail to challenge churches to **report** child sexual abuse. Brothers, if we will not affirm that the love of Jesus requires us to bring such heinous crimes to the attention of the civil authorities, then there is no point in making a statement at all.
3. Third, the point of any resolution is to make a strong exhortation, for such a time as this. A resolution is more of a *timely* statement than a *timeless* statement. Of course it must have timeless elements in it. However, if it is not timely and prophetic, there is no point in making a statement. This reads more like an obligatory statement than a prophetic statement. This will be heard as.....too little.....and too late. If we start to listen to our brothers and sisters who have been harmed, if we start to listen to experts in this area, many of whom are found in our own denomination, I believe we could pass a robust and prophetic statement that would affirm victims and give churches real pause if they are not reporting child sexual abuse. I'm afraid if we pass this statement we will convince ourselves we have handled this issue, and we will believe that there is nothing else to be said. My brothers, there is much more to be said in defense of children.

In summary brothers, I am urging you to vote against the resolution *today*. I believe this resolution puts children at greater risk for child sexual abuse, because it contains no language urging our churches to work with civil authorities, or fulfill their mandated reporting duties. Without those explicit encouragements, the resolution implicitly encourages churches to handle the crime of child sexual abuse

internally, with devastating effects for our children. Victims of abuse will hear this and it will hurt them, because we are not strongly standing with them on the main issue that could have stopped their abusers and rescued them.

GA: starting now

2 views

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 20, 2013, 7:49:34 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Come to the floor



Jason Polk
<jasonandlizpolk@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 22, 2013, 2:07:33 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

James, and fellow NP brothers,

As one of our number who was unable to attend GA this year, I want to thank each of you for your faithfulness in participating in our denomination's committees and assembly. There were various issues that came up this year on which I have my particular perspectives, but regardless of how any particular vote went, or whether you and I agree or disagree on how it should have turned out, I am deeply blessed to know that you brothers represented our denomination well and also represented me and the many other PCA brothers who are serving several continents away from Greenville (in my case, the beautiful land of coffee-- Ethiopia).

James, your well-stated final email encouraged my heart. As you all take some well-deserved 1am rest after your full week of procedural motions, committee reports, and the like-- I am waking up to a sunny Addis Ababa morning and smiling as I see in my mind's eye Jeff Kerr stepping up to that microphone, or Mike Sloan speaking courageously about a profoundly important issue that deeply affects my own personal story as well as the many vulnerable and at-risk children our team works with daily. I see your thoughtful reading and consideration of a 200-page majority and minority Insider Movement report which may have less direct application to your own ministries, but significantly affects the way I minister to my 10-year old friend, Tsefedin, who "runs" on crutches to embrace the followers of Jesus who are helping make his crippled feet straight again.

So, thank you brothers. One sadness that comes with our family's particular place of calling is that I am not able to join you all at GA or other important gatherings as often as I would like. But rest assured that I will be there in 2014, and fully expecting some firm handshakes, warm hugs, and a well-deserved beer after a long business meeting. I look forward to continuing this journey together as we labor with Christ's strength to see God's Kingdom advance and to make our denomination a place of gracious discourse as we share life and ministry together.

Blessings to each of you as you return to your families, and your specific congregations and places of ministry-- and thank you for blessing me this week.

Jason

--

Pastor Jason Polk
Ethiopia ACT Project

GA: Final note

2 views

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 21, 2013, 10:25:47 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

I wanted to write and tell you two things:

First, you don't want to read any more Partnership Notes and I don't want to write them. The next time you hear from me will probably be a few months from now.

Second I find myself full of thanksgiving. It would be easy to believe it to stem from the feeling that *we won*. But that would be wrong not only because it isn't true of me but also because it isn't true of us. There was plenty of "winning" in terms of votes and procedural motions and the mussels in roquefort broth and McChouffe's at the Trappe Door, but that isn't what I mean. We didn't win; the kingdom won – and not because Jesus is a member of the National Partnership (unless one of you invited him but I haven't heard anything). The kingdom won because Bobby Griffith was passionate and because Jeff Kerr didn't fear the microphone. The kingdom won because Scott Winchester came to the Overtures Committee without a suit on and business proceeded nonetheless and because Dan Wykoff almost stayed awake the entire time we debated the third substitute to a procedural motion regarding independent clause use in Appendix K.

The kingdom won because immediate bonds were formed between men in Greenville simply because they shared the presence of the Spirit and union with Christ. They won because connecting your faces with your names on the convention floor felt like meeting an old friend and because none of you felt weird that I kept

looking at your name tags. And because none of you made fun of me – to my face – about my West Wing-esque brisk walk everywhere and because I did – I tell you I really did – at one point yell out "We're at microphone FOUR!" outside the convention center like it was the most important thing that could be said. Like the building might be on fire. Like the only escape was microphone FOUR.

The kingdom won because I read Fred Greko's nomination form – a man I sought to oppose by floor nominee - and loved the story of his life. And it won because I had several chances to repent with men about whom I said stupid things and I even took one or two of them. The kingdom won because at the end of the day I could shake David Coffin's hand and thank him for helping me understand complicated things and because – God help me – I do love Joey Pipa and that mustache because he's an old southern dog who still knows how to wrangle an assembly, and because his sins are so, so familiar to mine.

The kingdom won too because one man stood in the courage of Jesus and rebuked us and him from the floor of the General Assembly and said that we must suffer the little children; that a resurrection demands first the grave for every one of us, even our sense of decorum, even our sense of prerogative. It demands that we storm the gates full of fire sometimes and that we may have to dash ourselves against those gates in the process. But Jesus is always with us and there is nothing lost between the last breath and the first.

There are no enemies for those who are in Christ, and though there is plenty of losing everywhere there are no true defeats in the end. May you rest in your labors, brothers. Thank you.

JK

From: bobby griffith <bg...@yahoo.com>
Date: June 23, 2013, 1:41:17 PM EDT
To: <TheNP+...@googlegroups.com>
Subject: Re: GA: Final note
Reply-To: <TheNP+...@googlegroups.com>

Brothers,

Thank you for your service to God's kingdom in the PCA - every day and last week at our General Assembly.

Though Mike Sloan's resolution was not adopted, I will seek to introduce something similar for my presbytery (North Texas) to adopt and send to all our member churches. I am going to send drafts to child advocate attorneys and make sure the language will be prophetic and specific to my regional context. I urge some of you to try and do the same.

I would also like to see four or five presbyteries (or more) offer overtures regarding protecting our children to the 42nd General Assembly. I think if we have more than one, even if the subsequent ones read (answer in reference to Overture One) it will send a strong message to

those who are watching the PCA and to those who may be hesitant to "speak to legal issues" or so-called "social justice" issues. It would be a nice homage to Mike's hard work if someone could time it where Overture One next year is something like Mike's resolution.

It was an honor to sit with many of you at Microphone Four this year. I am grateful for all of you and for this partnership.

Blessings,
Bobby

Rev. Bobby G. Griffith, Jr.
City Presbyterian Church - OKC

Insider movement criticism response from Mark Bates

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 28, 2013, 12:24:22 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

With a flurry of critical articles being written and posted by The Aquila Report, Mark Bates (NP) - who supported the minority report - answers those criticisms on his blog.

JK

<http://6000ft.blogspot.com/2013/06/the-pca-insider-movement-study-committee.html?m=1>

National Partnership Note

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jul 29, 2013, 3:10:48 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

1. **Additions** (140 elders in 48 presbyteries)

TE Richard Schwartz (Nashville)

TE Scott Crosby (Nashville)

TE Phil Kruis (Southwest)

TE Mike Tilley (Central Florida)

TE Matthew Armstrong (Metro Atlanta)

TE Rich Good (Potomac)

TE Clay Holland (Houston Metro)

TE Jim Richter (Westminster)

TE Jack Ewing (Suncoast)

2. Notes

I would propose these NP goals for the following 'season' (before GA 2014):

1. continue to dutifully serve on presbytery and assembly committees, fill vacant seats where possible
2. Support a healthy denominational dialogue - NP members speaking in GA seminars on topics beneficial to the Church
3. Help to pass comprehensive guidance/advice on dealing with sexual abuse in the church via multiple presbytery overtures
4. Resist presbytery-by-presbytery attempts to redefine/constrict orthodoxy in the PCA as they arise (similar to opposition to intinction measures last year)

I would be glad to hear from you about these goals or others you would propose. Thanks for your help in thinking this through.

TE Mike Sloan will be providing guidance to this group about the best way to move forward for those of us interested in pursuing the matter of sexual abuse in the church. You should expect an update from Mike in the next couple of days.

GA seminars: One way the NP can benefit our denomination is by starting helpful resourcing conversations at GA through the seminar hours. **Please suggest any seminars that you would love to hear at GA and we'll see if anyone on this list is up for it.** I would appreciate that week taking on more of a continuing education opportunity. We will always have a fair amount of work to do at the assembly but wouldn't it be nice to also benefit from the collective wisdom in our denomination? I'll start a conversation on the website regarding possible topics and speakers. Here's what I've proposed to the folks in Atlanta so far (speakers for these topics have been approached, though if any of you are interested in joining a panel discussion from one of the topics below please let me know!):

1. Paper to pulpit: The sermon drafting process.
2. Presbytery Health: we have some guys in the NP that have pursued very helpful reforms in their presbyteries. I would love to resource other pastors that long for a better life together for their presbyteries.
3. How to establish appropriate guidelines for dealing with sexual abuse in your church.
4. Staffing: Sharpening your Assistant and Associate Pastors for greater ministry impact.
5. The Pastor and Writer: cultivating your writing gifts to benefit both your local and the greater Church.

3. **Calendar**: for those of you new to our list or new to PCA polity, this is the typical lineup of those items throughout the year requiring NP action,

Fall/Winter: Overtures from previous GA up for vote at the presbytery level. GA seminars are scheduled and openings filled.

March: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April: Review of Presbytery Records committee meets in Atlanta

May: Deadline for proposed BCO amendments. The NP starts discussions on all overtures set for GA

June: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be with us at GA.

Google Groups Instructions

Google groups manages our group emails.

1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole. Your email to the entire group must have this address in the 'To' field rather than the 'CC' field.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

FW: Update for the NP on Child Sexual Abuse Statement

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Aug 6, 2013, 7:42:13 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

An update from Mike Sloan

From: "mikea...@gmail.com" <mikea...@gmail.com>

Date: Monday, August 5, 2013 8:37 PM

To: james kessler <jkes...@npc-dublin.org>

Subject: Update for the NP on Child Sexual Abuse Statement

James,

Below is the email for the NP on the child sexual abuse statement. Let me know what you think and then one of us can send it on.

Thanks
Mike

Dear Brothers,

Thank you for all of your encouragement during and since GA regarding the statement on child sexual abuse. I wanted to update all of you on what will hopefully happen between now and next GA. I am organizing a meeting with several PCA experts on child sexual abuse, including some survivors, which I hope will meet by the end of the year. The goal of this meeting will be to produce a robust statement more in line with the original statement I brought, not the weakened version that came out of the overtures committee. We will also plan to produce a detailed rationale for the statement to give more education about the dynamics of abuse and thus the need for a more robust statement. We will also address potential objections. In the meeting we also plan to spend time planning strategically about how to encourage and educate churches in this area so we can follow through with action not just words.

I am hoping there will be many men willing to take the statement coming out of this meeting to their presbyteries who will send it up to the GA as an overture. This will accomplish two things. First, any presbyteries who pass it will be sending the same consensus statement. It would be a nightmare if overtures received several different statements and was charged with merging them somehow. Second, if the same consensus statement is sent up by multiple presbyteries, it will send a message to overtures that our denomination wants a strong statement, and that we should think carefully before we cut things out.

Two other quick notes:

First, as much as many of us want a statement from GA, remember you do not have to wait for the General Assembly to pass a statement for your presbytery to act. I would encourage you all to work toward that end. I would advise waiting until we have the consensus statement by the end of the year to see if you would like to use it for your presbytery's statement regardless of what GA in Houston decides.

Second, some of you have let me know you are willing to advocate for the consensus statement as an overture to the GA from your presbytery. If you are willing, but have not communicated that to me, please let me know soon so I can communicate well with you as this develops.

Please feel free to call me with any questions or concerns about this [678-524-5595](tel:678-524-5595)). Thanks so much.

Your Servant,

Mike Sloan

praying for you brothers

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Sep 8, 2013, 8:42:29 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Men,

I am praying for those of you bringing the Word this morning. May you be passionate, confident in Christ, aware of your own great mercy received. I pray that we run into the breach this morning, brothers, with the only tools we've been given.

Christ is King,

JK

Resources for Credentialing

1 view

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erik
<erik@citychurchrva.com>

unread,

Oct 14, 2013, 3:17:07 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers:

I wanted to reach out because I desire to benefit from the collective wisdom of the National Partnership. Our Presbytery (James River) is poised to multiply into two Presbyteries and we've used this time to reframe some of the structures and culture of our Presbytery. I will serve as part of the new Leadership Development Committee in the Presbytery to nurture and credential men called to ministry. As part of our work I'd like to help recast the exams we use for licensure and ordination. I wonder if there are good examples from other Presbyteries that share the vision of the National Partnership. Could you direct me to any resources that you are aware of and that you have used in your local contexts?

I am grateful for your partnership in the gospel,

Erik Bonkovsky
Pastor

City Church of Richmond

National Partnership Note

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Oct 29, 2013, 4:46:52 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

1. Additions (140 elders in 48 presbyteries)

None. Here are presbyteries where we do not yet have Partnership members:

Catawba Valley

Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Great Lakes

Gulf Coast

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey

New River

New York State

North Florida

Northern California

Illiana

Northern new Eng

NW Georgia

Pacific

Philadelphia MW

Piedmont Triad

Providence

Wisconsin

If you have like-minded friends in those presbyteries that you would like to invite please let me know.

2. News

TE Mike Sloan, who offered a personal resolution on the issue of child sexual abuse in the church at Greenville's General Assembly, will be meeting with other denominational leaders in December to craft a consensus statement for this year's Overtures Committee. If any of you are willing to speak for the consensus statement by offering the same statement as an overture on the floor of your presbyteries, please contact mike (mikea...@gmail.com). It will be easier to pass an overture in tact through the OC if several presbyteries offer a version as similar as possible to the others. Here's a link to Mike's interview about child sexual abuse in the church with ByFaith (<http://byfaithonline.com/key-questions-about-child-sexual-abuse-in-the-church/>).

The SJC is currently considering the three re-trial overtures (Calvary, Gulf Coast, MS Valley) regarding the TE Leithart trial before PNW Presbytery. The Oct 17-18 meeting recessed and reconvenes Nov 4 for a likely decision. The deeper question appears to be less about Leithart himself and more about whether BCO 34-1 applies in this particular case (34-1. *Process against a minister shall be entered before the Presbytery of which he is a member. However, if the Presbytery refuses to act in doctrinal cases or cases of public scandal and two other Presbyteries request the General Assembly to assume original jurisdiction (to first receive and initially hear and determine), the General Assembly shall do so.*) that is, did PNW "refuse to act". Some in the blogosphere have maintained that they (and many other, in their words) pastors and churches will depart the PCA if the SJC refuses these appeals.

In light of the interest in the Leithart case and disagreement about the SJC's review process among some in our denomination NP member Sean Lucas and his session crafted the language of overture 1 (<http://theaquilareport.com/grace-presbytery-overtures-the-pca-ga-to-amend-bco-15-5-to-vote-on-sjc-decisions/>). While I'm not yet sure where I fall on the subject it's worth thinking through. I've created space on the website here (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-1-voting-on-sjc-decisions/>) and Sean has answered a few questions about the overture's intent and effect. Please feel free to interact.

3. Calendar:

Fall/Winter: Overtures from previous GA up for vote at the presbytery level. GA seminars are scheduled and openings filled.

March 22: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April 18: Overtures requiring CCB opinion

May 28-31: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. The NP starts discussions on all overtures set for GA this month.

June: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA. We'll try for an informal beer/pizza meeting during the week.

Google Groups Instructions

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1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole. Your email to the entire group must have this address in the 'To' field rather than the 'CC' field.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

National Partnership NOTE

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Dec 7, 2013, 8:24:51 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

1. **Additions** (141 elders in 50 presbyteries)

TE Daniel Millward (Great Lakes)

Here are presbyteries where we do not yet have Partnership members:

Catawba Valley

Central Carolina

Central Georgia

Covenant

Eastern Pennsylvania

Fellowship

Gulf Coast

Mississippi Valley

New Jersey

New River

New York State

North Florida

Northern California

Illiana

Northern new Eng

NW Georgia

Pacific

Piedmont Triad

Providence

Wisconsin

If you have like-minded friends in those presbyteries that you would like to invite please let me know.

2. News

The SJC denied (15-1-1) three overtures seeking an appeal regarding the disposition of the Leithart case (that the Pacific Northwest Presbytery did not err in acquitting Leithart). This is a link to the

decision:<http://byfaithonline.com/wp-content/uploads/2013/11/2013-SJC-Answer-to-Overtures-20-21-22-w-votes-and-Concurrence.pdf> . The action by the SJC was predictably unpopular in the blogosphere among those threatening to leave the denomination.

TE Cannata, Larson, Hoop and Gwennap have commented on TE Sean Lucas' post on the NP website regarding Overture 3. My own read is that we will need some sort of additional language regarding the SJC's review process, but that we haven't yet seen that language. Check out the conversation here: (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-1-voting-on-sjc-decisions/>). Please feel free to interact.

3. Action Items

It's time to think about committee assignments and committee of commissioners for the General Assembly.

Nominating Committee: This committee is tasked with filling the committees of our denomination with qualified men. The committee meeting is March 22nd in Atlanta and your travel/lodging expenses are reimbursed by the denomination. The work of this committee might really be the most efficient way to contribute to the work of helping to lead our denomination. Those who sit on the NC will have to deliberate together and work through the biographies of men submitted by their presbyteries. This is a critical committee. Below are the presbyteries where we have Partnership members and there are either vacancies or the term of the seated presbyter is expiring. Each presbytery rotates RE/TE every three year term. However your presbytery may nominate based on availability (RE/TE). If you are in one of these presbyteries please consider joining in the work of this committee:

Central Indiana (RE)

Chesapeake (TE)

Evangel (TE)

Gulf Stream (RE)

Iowa (RE)

Metro Atlanta (RE)

North Texas (RE)

Northern Illinois (RE)

Philadelphia (TE)

Pittsburgh (TE)

Platte Valley (TE)

Potomac (TE)

Siouxlands (TE)

South Florida (TE)

Southeast Louisiana (RE)

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Suncoast (FL) (TE)

Review of Presbytery Records: Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment May 28-31 - and the PCA pays the expenses. This committee reviews the minutes presbyteries submit to the General Assembly to ensure the minutes of presbytery are in order – that is, there are no strange deviations, exceptions recorded that strike at the vitals of our system, etc. What sounds perhaps mild-mannered has become a battleground for theological axe-grinding. While there are many who seek to serve on this committee for less litigious reasons, there are others who see RPR as an opportunity to move the lines of orthodoxy in the PCA. It is always necessary to have wise and qualified men serving in this committee to ensure that our denomination is accurately represented in these discussions. The rules regarding the RE/TE alternating slots are similar to the NC. If there is not a qualified man of a particular office willing to serve your presbytery may appoint one representative of the other office. Below is a list of NP presbyteries where there is a vacancy.

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Suncoast (FL) (RE)

GA Committee of Commissioners:

I've heard nothing yet about any particular committees that require special attention outside of they typical: Overtures, Admin, Inter-church Relations. I would love to see you men taking the opportunity to serve – anywhere really! - but in particular those committees can be volatile and influential in the work of our denomination.

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June: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA. We'll try for an informal beer/pizza meeting during the week.

Google Groups Instructions

Google groups manages our group emails.

1. *Emailing* this address (th...@googlegroups.com) will communicate with the group as a whole. Your email to the entire group must have this address in the 'To' field rather than the 'CC' field.
2. *Replying* to a group email (from th...@googlegroups.com) will only be sent to me (James Kessler) as the group originator/moderator but will be sent to the whole group if that is your intent.

2014

Prayer request for Dan Adamson

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jan 2, 2014, 11:06:03 AM

:

□

□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

From NP TE Dan Adamson:

"Guys. We are on vacation in Kentucky and my 14 year old starting acting really weird. Out of it, not herself, confused. We waited a few days but called our doctor. She said to go to ER for tests. We are really scared please pray. It's really hard."

Please do pray brothers.

JK

Question about New Covenant Theology

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



mbates

<mbates@v7pc.org>

unread,

Jan 8, 2014, 1:42:41 PM

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□

□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

I have some men in my officer training class who are into New Covenant Theology. They are well read on the topic. I will be covering Covenant Theology in a couple of weeks and would like to offer a

critique of some of the main points. However, I haven't read much on New Covenant Theology and I am not going to read Kingdom through Covenant. Does anyone know of a good critique of New Covenant Theology?

One of my challenges is, in the class I have a few men who are really into this, but many men who have no knowledge of it. So, I need to teach in such a way that is helpful to those who have a great deal of knowledge and to the novice as well.

Thanks for your help.

Mark Bates
Senior Pastor

National Partnership Note

1 view

Skip to first unread message



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>
unread,
Jan 9, 2014, 12:34:33 PM

:
□
□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'gal220')

Overture 2 is worth a look. Link to the overture discussion page is below.

TE Jason Dorsey has submitted a paper for us to review and offer feedback. It is an important and helpful proposal, I hope we can help him perfect it. (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/the-order-of-widows-1-timothy/>)

Time to sign up for committee work, everyone.

1. **Additions** (141 elders in 52 presbyteries)

None

Here are presbyteries where we do not yet have Partnership members:

Catawba Valley
Central Carolina

Central Georgia
Covenant
Eastern Pennsylvania
Fellowship
Gulf Coast
Mississippi Valley
New Jersey
New River
New York State
North Florida
Northern California
Illiana
Northern new Eng
NW Georgia
Pacific
Piedmont Triad
Wisconsin

If you have like-minded friends in those presbyteries that you would like to invite please let me know.

2. News

Westminster Presbytery has overtured the 42nd GA to reaffirm a denominational stance regarding homosexuality/same-sex marriage. The page dealing with this Overture (Overture 2) is up on the Partnership website (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-2-concerning-same-sex-marriage/>). Feel free to interact.

TE Cannata, Larson, Hoop and Gwennap have commented on TE Sean Lucas' post on the NP website regarding Overture 3. Check out the conversation here: (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-1-voting-on-sjc-decisions/>). Please feel free to interact.

3. Action Items

It's time to think about committee assignments and committee of commissioners for the General Assembly.

Nominating Committee: This committee is tasked with filling the committees of our denomination with qualified men. The committee meeting is March 22nd in Atlanta and your travel/lodging expenses are reimbursed by the denomination. The work of this committee might really be the most efficient way to contribute to the work of helping to lead our denomination. Those who sit on the NC will have to deliberate together and work through the biographies of men submitted by their presbyteries. This is a critical committee. Below are the presbyteries where we have Partnership members and there are either vacancies or the term of the seated presbyter is expiring. Each presbytery rotates RE/TE every three year term. However your presbytery may nominate based on availability (RE/TE). If you are in one of these presbyteries please consider joining in the work of this committee:

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4. Action items:

Interact with overture items 2 and 3 on the Partnership website

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Consider the Overtures Committee, Administrative Committee, or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work

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New website password

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jan 13, 2014, 11:22:04 AM

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□

□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Time for an update to our website password:

Old: gal220

New: ps2211

Thanks!

JK

Partnership NOTE

1 view

Skip to first unread message



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jan 25, 2014, 7:01:39 PM

⋮
□
□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

There's a lot of news in this NOTE; please take the time to review.

-Sign up for committee work, everyone. Please let me know what committees you'll be serving so I can update our website.

-Mike Sloan has included a note appealing for support on Overture 6 (Child Protection in the PCA) below.

1. **Additions** (140 elders in 52 presbyteries)

Here are presbyteries where we do not yet have Partnership members:

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Fellowship
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NW Georgia
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If you have like-minded friends in those presbyteries that you would like to invite please let me know.

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There are currently 16 NP members serving on the Nominating Committee and 8 NP members serving on RPR

We have also begun a discussion on the website on Overture 6 (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-6-child-protection-in-the-pca-georgia-foothills-presbytery/>)

An appeal from Mike Sloan regarding Overture 6:

“Brothers,

I wanted to update you on where things stand. We had a productive meeting in December with some PCA experts on child protection and came up with a robust statement that I think will have a good chance to pass. My presbytery Georgia Foothills passed it unanimously last Saturday (it is now officially Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills on “Child Protection in the PCA”, available on the General Assembly website). Now we are working to get other presbyteries to send a simple overture to General Assembly urging that they pass the statement from Georgia Foothills. This approach will allow us to get broad presbytery support without sending up ten slightly different statements. What you can do in your presbytery is head up an effort to pass this supporting overture: orchestrate bringing to the floor, speak for it, and find others who will also speak for it. I have some supporting documentation and arguments I would be happy to share with you that are helpful to understand why this matters in the PCA. Also I will put up some rationale on the TNP discussion board under this overture. I also have some simple straight-forward language you could use for the overture:

'WHEREAS Georgia Foothills Presbytery has sent an overture to the 42nd General Assembly calling on the General Assembly to speak to the issue of child sexual abuse (Overture 6: “Child Protection in the PCA”); and

WHEREAS _____ Presbytery believes that child sexual abuse is an issue to which the General Assembly should speak; and

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THEREFORE, be it RESOLVED that _____ Presbytery urges the 42nd General Assembly to answer in the affirmative Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills Presbytery on child sexual abuse.'

I have already reached out to many of you about this and I am so encouraged by your willingness to speak up on behalf of the little ones Jesus loves. Please pray for this. Two presbyteries are considering a supporting overture today!"

3. Action Items

Nominating Committee: This committee is tasked with filling the committees of our denomination with qualified men. The committee meeting is March 22nd in Atlanta and your travel/lodging expenses are reimbursed by the denomination. The work of this committee might really be the most efficient way to contribute to the work of helping to lead our denomination. Those who sit on the NC will have to deliberate together and work through the biographies of men submitted by their presbyteries. This is a critical committee. Below are the presbyteries where we have Partnership members and there are either vacancies or the term of the seated presbyter is expiring. Each presbytery rotates RE/TE every three year term. However your presbytery may nominate based on availability (RE/TE). If you are in one of these presbyteries please consider joining in the work of this committee:

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Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website
Sign up for the NC or RPR (or get someone to volunteer in your place)
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Consider sponsoring an overture affirming overture 6

5. Calendar:

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National Partnership NOTE

1 view

Skip to first unread message



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Feb 4, 2014, 8:06:11 AM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

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Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

-Sign up for committee work, everyone. Please let me know what committees you'll be serving so I can update our website.

-Mike Sloan has included a note appealing for support on Overture 6 (Child Protection in the PCA) below.

-Overture 9 from Southwest Presbytery proposes a major change to the relationship of the SJC to the General Assembly via the Committee on Constitutional Business

1. **Additions** (143 elders in 53 presbyteries)

TE Brian Ferry (Ohio Valley)

TE Michael Craddock (Ohio Valley)

2. **News**

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan

TE Justin Woodall

TE Walt Coppersmith

Admin

TE James Kessler

TE Matthew Armstrong

Presbyteries passing an overture in support of Overture 6: (2)

Metro Atlanta

The Ohio

Westminster Presbytery has overtured the 42nd GA a second time to reaffirm a denominational stance regarding homosexuality/same-sex marriage in stronger language than Overture 2 (also from Westminster Presbytery). The page dealing with this Overture (Overture 2) is up on the Partnership website (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-2-concerning-same-sex-marriage/>). You can read about overture 5 here (<http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2014/01/Overture-5-Westminster-our-present-need.pdf>) Feel free to interact.

Overture 9 is the latest overture seeking to revise the relationship of the SJC to the General Assembly (joining overtures 3 and 8). You can read the text of the overture and join the discussion here (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/new-blog/2014/2/4/nca6ppzyk8nc4zt7gh8acw3kxnacwq>)

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TE Tim LeCroy (Admin)

TE Jon Price (MNA)

TE David Richter (MNA)

RE Richard Dolan (CCB)

TE Josh Anderson (CCB)

TE Bryan Chapell (SJC)

TE George Robertson (SJC)

Their nominations will be debated among many others at the Nominating Committee meeting in Atlanta. Please be in prayer for that discussion.

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4. Action items:

Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website

Sign up for the NC or RPR (or get someone to volunteer in your place)

Consider the Overtures Committee, Administrative Committee, or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work

Consider sponsoring an overture affirming overture 6

5. Calendar:

Winter presbytery meetings: committee nominations, GA committees of commissioners filled

March 22: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

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National Partnership NOTE

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Feb 18, 2014, 7:07:53 AM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com



[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

-Overture 3 from Grace Presbytery, which seeks to allow for greater review of SJC decisions, has been affirmed by overtures from two other presbyteries (Southwest and Nashville). Unfortunately these proposed revisions appear to many to plunge us back into Assembly bickering, and will encourage greater politicizing of decisions in the blogosphere and elsewhere.

-Men are needed for the Overtures Committee. I have 7 so far noted below. Please let us know if you have jumped on the OC.

-Please let me know what committees you'll be serving so I can update our website; the current list is below – let me know where there are corrections to be made

-There is still time for your presbytery to pass an affirmation of Overture 6 regarding sexual abuse in the church. The form for doing so is included in this email

1. Additions (144 elders in 54 presbyteries)

TE Ben Lyon (Tidewater)

2. News

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan

TE Justin Woodall

TE Walt Coppersmith

TE Mark Bates

TE Jim Richter

TE Ben Lyon

TE Michael Craddock

Admin

TE James Kessler

TE Matthew Armstrong

Interchurch Relations

TE Walter Henegar

Presbyteries passing an overture in support of Overture 6: (6)

Heritage

Metro Atlanta

Nashville

North Texas

The Ohio

Southwest Florida

Westminster Presbytery's Overture has overtured the 42nd GA a second time to reaffirm a denominational stance regarding homosexuality/same-sex marriage in more temperate language than Overture 2 (also from Westminster Presbytery). However both overtures include the language from our denomination's original statement on homosexuality – **a statement that includes a call to prohibit homosexuals from teaching in schools**. The page dealing with this Overture (Overture 2) is up on the Partnership website (<http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-2-concerning-same-sex-marriage/>). You can read about overture 5 here (<http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2014/01/Overture-5-Westminster-our-present-need.pdf>) Feel free to interact.

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TE Josh Anderson (CCB)
TE Bryan Chapell (SJC)
TE George Robertson (SJC)
RE Bruce Terrell (SJC)

Their nominations will be debated among many others at the Nominating Committee meeting in Atlanta. Please be in prayer for that discussion.

An appeal from Mike Sloan regarding Overture 6:

"Brothers,

I wanted to update you on where things stand. We had a productive meeting in December with some PCA experts on child protection and came up with a robust statement that I think will have a good chance to pass. My presbytery Georgia Foothills passed it unanimously last Saturday (it is now officially Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills on "Child Protection in the PCA", available on the General Assembly website). Now we are working to get other presbyteries to send a simple overture to General Assembly urging that they pass the statement from Georgia Foothills. This approach will allow us to get broad presbytery support without sending up ten slightly different statements. What you can do in your presbytery is head up an effort to pass this supporting overture: orchestrate bringing to the floor, speak for it, and find others who will also speak for it. I have some supporting documentation and arguments I would be happy to share with you that are helpful to understand why this matters in the PCA. Also I will put up some rationale on the TNP discussion board under this overture. I also have some simple straight-forward language you could use for the overture: 'WHEREAS Georgia Foothills Presbytery has sent an overture to the 42nd General Assembly calling on the General Assembly to speak to the issue of child sexual abuse (Overture 6: "Child Protection in the PCA"); and

WHEREAS _____ Presbytery believes that child sexual abuse is an issue to which the General Assembly should speak; and

WHEREAS _____ Presbytery endorses the substance of Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills Presbytery on child sexual abuse;
THEREFORE, be it RESOLVED that _____ Presbytery urges the 42nd General Assembly to answer in the affirmative Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills Presbytery on child sexual abuse.'

Review of Presbytery Records: Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment May 28-31 - and the PCA pays the expenses. This committee reviews the minutes presbyteries submit to the General Assembly to ensure the minutes of presbytery are in order – that is, there are no strange deviations, exceptions recorded that strike at the vitals of our system, etc. What sounds perhaps mild-mannered has become a battleground for theological axe-grinding. While there are many who seek to serve on this committee for less litigious reasons, there are others who see RPR as an opportunity to move the lines of orthodoxy in the PCA. It is always necessary to have wise and qualified men serving in this committee to ensure that our denomination is accurately represented in these discussions. The rules regarding the RE/TE alternating slots are similar to the NC. If there is not a qualified man of a particular office willing to serve your presbytery may appoint one representative of the other office. Below is a list of NP presbyteries where there is a vacancy.

Central Indiana (TE)
Chesapeake (RE)
Evangel (RE)
Gulf Stream (TE)
Illiana (TE)
Iowa (TE)
North Texas (TE)
Northern California (TE)
Northern Illinois (TE)
Philadelphia (RE)
Pittsburgh (RE)
Platte Valley (RE)
Potomac (RE)
South Florida (RE)
Southwest (TE)
Suncoast (FL) (RE)

4. Action items:

Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website

Sign up for the Overtures Committee

If not overtures, serve in the Administrative Committee or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work

Consider moving an overture in your presbytery affirming overture 6

5. Calendar:

Winter presbytery meetings: committee nominations, GA committees of commissioners filled

March 22: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April 18: Overtures requiring BCO amendment are due

May 28-31: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. The NP starts discussions on all overtures set for GA this month.

June 16-20: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA. We'll try for an informal beer/pizza meeting during the week.

Partnership NOTE

1 view

Skip to first unread message



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 3, 2014, 12:56:14 PM

:

□

□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

-Overture 3 from Grace Presbytery, which seeks to allow for greater review of SJC decisions, has been affirmed by overtures from five other presbyteries. This is going to be *the* primary issue debated in Houston. Unfortunately these proposed revisions appear to many to plunge us back into Assembly bickering on judicial cases, and will encourage greater politicizing of decisions in the blogosphere and elsewhere.

-Men are needed for the Overtures Committee. I have 7 so far noted below. Please let us know if you have jumped on the OC.

-Please let me know what committees you'll be serving so I can update our website; the current list is below – let me know where there are corrections to be made

-There is still time for your presbytery to pass an affirmation of Overture 6 regarding sexual abuse in the church. The form for doing so is included in this email

The following is a message from Mike Khandjian, NP member and organizer of The Fellowship Dinner. His group was created completely independent of ours but with a high degree of overlap. Where his group is invested in

fellowship and visioning we are more engaged in logistics. Both groups are necessary and helpful! He wanted to extend an invitation to those of you on this list:

"I can't begin to tell you how cool this evening will be. Kevin Twit will lead us in some song, but he will be accompanied by the worship band from Redeemer Sugarland, the church Bradley Wright pastors in the Houston area. They too will lead in some song and the music will flow as we gather and eat - it will be

a bash. As to the dinner, DON'T ASSUME YOU ARE ON THE GUEST LIST!!! I make no assumptions as to who is coming, unless contacted. As it stands, we are over 1/3 full for the evening, which is way ahead of where we were last year at this time. The word is out and it has to be a first-come, first-seated dinner. What is this Dinner? - I guess the best way to put it is that it is an evening - a couple hours - where we rehearse the Gospel to ourselves and celebrate who we were always intended to be as a denomination, and are. Ultimately, though politics matter in the whole matter of change, it will be a gathering community of people who are determined to protect the sweeter things of the Faith - in how we present ourselves, how we love one another and how we love the world God created to be good, that makes every aspect of our involvement worthwhile. "

1. **Additions** (144 elders in 54 presbyteries)

2. **News**

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan

TE Justin Woodall

TE Walt Coppersmith

TE Mark Bates

TE Jim Richter

TE Ben Lyon

TE Michael Craddock

TE Jedidiah Slaboda

Admin

TE James Kessler

TE Matthew Armstrong

Interchurch Relations

TE Walter Henegar

Presbyteries passing an overture in support of Overture 6: (7)

Heritage

Metro Atlanta

Nashville

North Texas

The Ohio

Providence

Southwest Florida

There are currently **17 NP members serving on the Nominating Committee and 8 NP members serving on RPR**

Here is a list of NP members who have been nominated for permanent or special committees:

TE Tim LeCroy (Admin)

TE Jon Price (MNA)

TE David Richter (MNA)

TE Dave Schutter (MNA)

RE Richard Dolan (CCB)

TE Josh Anderson (CCB)

TE Bryan Chapell (SJC)

TE George Robertson (SJC)

RE Bruce Terrell (SJC)

TE Steve Jeantet (Admin)

RE Brad Bradley (Admin)

Their nominations will be debated among many others at the Nominating Committee meeting in Atlanta. Please be in prayer for that discussion.

An appeal from Mike Sloan regarding Overture 6:

“Brothers,

I wanted to update you on where things stand. We had a productive meeting in December with some PCA experts on child protection and came up with a robust statement that I think will have a good chance to pass. My presbytery Georgia Foothills passed it unanimously last Saturday (it is now officially Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills on “Child Protection in the PCA”, available on the General Assembly website). Now we are working to get other presbyteries to send a simple overture to General Assembly urging that they pass the statement from Georgia Foothills. This approach will allow us to get broad presbytery support without sending up ten slightly different statements. What you can do in your presbytery is head up an effort to pass this supporting overture: orchestrate bringing to the floor, speak for it, and find others who will also speak for it. I have some supporting documentation and arguments I would be happy to share with you that are helpful to understand why this matters in the PCA. Also I will put up some rationale on the TNP discussion board under this overture. I also have some simple straight-forward language you could use for the overture:

'WHEREAS Georgia Foothills Presbytery has sent an overture to the 42nd General Assembly calling on the General Assembly to speak to the issue of child sexual abuse (Overture 6: “Child Protection in the PCA”); and

WHEREAS _____ Presbytery believes that child sexual abuse is an issue to which the General Assembly should speak; and

WHEREAS _____ Presbytery endorses the substance of Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills Presbytery on child sexual abuse;

THEREFORE, be it RESOLVED that _____ Presbytery urges the 42nd General Assembly to answer in the affirmative Overture 6 from Georgia Foothills Presbytery on child sexual abuse.'

Review of Presbytery Records: Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment May 28-31 - and the PCA pays the expenses. This committee reviews the minutes presbyteries submit to the General Assembly to ensure the minutes of presbytery are in order – that is, there are no strange deviations, exceptions recorded that strike at the vitals of our system, etc. What sounds perhaps mild-mannered has become a battleground for theological axe-grinding. While there are many who seek to serve on this committee for less litigious reasons, there are others who see RPR as an opportunity to move the lines of orthodoxy in the PCA. It is always necessary to have wise and qualified men serving in this committee to ensure that our denomination is accurately represented in these discussions. The rules regarding the RE/TE alternating slots are similar to the NC. If there is not a qualified man of a particular office willing to serve your presbytery may appoint one representative of the other office. Below is a list of NP presbyteries where there is a vacancy.

Central Indiana (TE)

Chesapeake (RE)

Evangel (RE)

Gulf Stream (TE)

Illiana (TE)

North Texas (TE)

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Northern Illinois (TE)

Philadelphia (RE)

Pittsburgh (RE)

Platte Valley (RE)

Potomac (RE)

South Florida (RE)

Southwest (TE)

Suncoast (FL) (RE)

4. Action items:

- Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website
- Sign up for the Overtures Committee
- If not overtures, serve in the Administrative Committee or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work
- Consider moving to affirm overture 6 in your presbytery

5. Calendar:

March 22: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April 18: Overtures requiring BCO amendment are due

May 28-31: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. The NP starts discussions on all overtures set for GA this month.

June 16-20: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA. We'll try for an informal beer/pizza meeting during the week.

National Partnership NOTE

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Mar 26, 2014, 8:56:40 AM

:

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

-Overture 3 from Grace Presbytery, which seeks to allow for greater review of SJC decisions, has been affirmed by overtures from five other presbyteries. This is going to be *the* primary issue debated in Houston. Unfortunately these proposed revisions appear to many to plunge us back into Assembly bickering on judicial cases, and will encourage greater politicizing of decisions in the blogosphere and elsewhere.

-Men are needed for the Overtures Committee. I have 10 so far noted below. Please let us know if you have jumped on the OC.

-Please let me know what committees you'll be serving so I can update our website; the current list is below – let me know where there are corrections to be made

The following is a message from Mike Khandjian, NP member and organizer of The Fellowship Dinner. His group was created completely independent of ours but with a high degree of overlap. Where his group is invested in fellowship and visioning we are more engaged in logistics. Both groups are necessary and helpful! He wanted to extend an invitation to those of you on this list:

"I can't begin to tell you how cool this evening will be. Kevin Twit will lead us in some song, but he will be accompanied by the worship band from Redeemer Sugarland, the church Bradley Wright pastors in the Houston area. They too will lead in some song and the music will flow as we gather and eat - it will be a bash. As to the dinner, DON'T ASSUME YOU ARE ON THE GUEST LIST!!! I make no assumptions as to who is coming, unless contacted. As it stands, we are over 1/3 full for the evening, which is way ahead of where we were last year at this time. The word is out and it has to be a first-come, first-seated dinner. What is this Dinner? - I guess the best way to put it is that it is an evening - a couple hours - where we rehearse the Gospel to ourselves and celebrate who we were always intended to be as a denomination, and are. Ultimately, though politics matter in the whole matter of change, it will be a gathering community of people who are determined to protect the sweeter things of the Faith - in how we present ourselves, how we love one another and how we love the world God created to be good, that makes every aspect of our involvement worthwhile. " You can contact Mike about the Fellowship Dinner at mi...@chapelgate.org

1. **Additions** (149 elders in 54 presbyteries)

TE Iron Kim (South Coast)

TE Jonathan Winfree (Southwest Florida)

TE Drew Bennett (Southwest Florida)

TE Nate Walker (Pacific Northwest)

2. **News**

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan

TE Justin Woodall

TE Walt Coppersmith

TE Mark Bates

TE Jim Richter
TE Ben Lyon
TE Michael Craddock
TE Jedidiah Slaboda
TE Dan MacDonald
TE Eric Costa

Admin

TE James Kessler
TE Matthew Armstrong

Interchurch Relations

TE Walter Henegar
TE Kyle Hackmann

Presbyteries passing an overture in support of Overture 6: (8)

Heritage
Iowa
Metro Atlanta
Nashville
North Texas
The Ohio
Providence
Southwest Florida

The Nominating Committee met this last weekend in Atlanta. Many of us on this email list were present and helped in the discussions/debates. Here are the NP guys nominated for permanent committee/commission:

TE Tim LeCroy (Admin) - *Alternate*
TE Dave Schutter (MNA) - *Alternate*
RE Richard Dolan (CCB)
TE Josh Anderson (CCB) - *Alternate*
TE Bryan Chapell (SJC)
TE George Robertson (SJC)
RE Bruce Terrell (SJC)
RE Brad Bradley (Admin)
TE Jim Richter (MTW) - *Alternate*
TE Bruce O'Neil (IRC)
TE Bryan Counts (RUM)

Review of Presbytery Records: Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment May 28-31 - and the PCA pays the expenses. This committee reviews the minutes presbyteries submit to the General Assembly to ensure the minutes of presbytery are in order – that is, there are no strange deviations, exceptions recorded that strike at the vitals of our system, etc. What sounds perhaps mild-mannered has become a battleground for theological axe-grinding. While there are many who seek to serve on this committee for less litigious reasons, there are others who see RPR as an opportunity to move the lines of orthodoxy in the PCA. It is always necessary to have wise and qualified men serving in this committee to ensure that our denomination is accurately represented in these discussions. The rules regarding the RE/TE alternating slots are similar to the NC. If there is not a qualified man of a particular office

willing to serve your presbytery may appoint one representative of the other office. Below is a list of NP presbyteries where there is a vacancy.

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Pittsburgh (RE)

Platte Valley (RE)

Potomac (RE)

South Florida (RE)

Southwest (TE)

Suncoast (FL) (RE)

There are currently **8 NP members serving on RPR**

4. Action items:

- Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website
- Sign up for the Overtures Committee
- If not overtures, serve in the Administrative Committee or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work

5. Calendar:

April 18: Overtures requiring BCO amendment are due

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Partnership NOTE

1 view

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James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Apr 15, 2014, 5:36:55 AM

:

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

NOTE: A gentle push here... I see 19 men serving on CoC. With over 150 in the partnership we should be doing a bit better than that; remember that part of what we ask is that you be willing to jump into committee work unless providentially hindered (or blacklisted!). Please let me know if I haven't recorded your name.

-Overture 3 from Grace Presbytery, which seeks to allow for greater review of SJC decisions, has been affirmed by overtures from five other presbyteries. This is going to be *the* primary issue debated in Houston. Unfortunately these proposed revisions appear to many to plunge us back into Assembly bickering on judicial cases, and will encourage greater politicizing of decisions in the blogosphere and elsewhere.

-Men are needed for the Overtures Committee. I have **13** so far noted below. Please let us know if you have jumped on the OC.

-Please let me know what committees you'll be serving so I can update our website; the current list is below – let me know where there are corrections to be made

-If you feel we should be discussing an overture not currently on a discussion page on the website please let me know. I've tried to create discussion for the overtures likely to cause debate.

The following is a message from Mike Khandjian, NP member and organizer of The Fellowship Dinner. His group was created completely independent of ours but with a high degree of overlap. Where his group is invested in fellowship and visioning we are more engaged in logistics. Both groups are necessary and helpful! He wanted to extend an invitation to those of you on this list:

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1. **Additions** (154 elders in 54 presbyteries)

TE Wes Neel (Chicago Metro)

TE Don Aldin (Georgia Foothills)

TE Blake Altman (North Texas)

TE Tim Weldon (Gulfstream)

TE Joel Kavanaugh (Westminster)

2. **News**

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan
TE Justin Woodall
TE Walt Coppersmith
TE Mark Bates
TE Jim Richter
TE Ben Lyon
TE Michael Craddock
TE Jedidiah Slaboda
TE Dan MacDonald
TE Eric Costa
TE Will Reinmuth
TE Kevin Twit
TE Ian Hard

Admin

TE James Kessler
TE Matthew Armstrong

Interchurch Relations

TE Walter Henegar
TE Kyle Hackmann
TE Jason Polk

MNA

TE Drew Bennett

Covenant Seminary

TE Jonathan Winfree

Presbyteries passing an overture in support of Overture 6: (15)

Heritage
Iowa
Metro Atlanta
Nashville
North Texas
The Ohio
Providence
Southwest Florida
Georgia Foothills
Eastern Canada
Western Canada
Chicago Metro

Houston Metro
Eastern Pennsylvania
Tennessee Valley

Review of Presbytery Records: Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment May 28-30 - and the PCA pays the expenses. This committee reviews the minutes presbyteries submit to the General Assembly to ensure the minutes of presbytery are in order – that is, there are no strange deviations, exceptions recorded that strike at the vitals of our system, etc. What sounds perhaps mild-mannered has become a battleground for theological axe-grinding. While there are many who seek to serve on this committee for less litigious reasons, there are others who see RPR as an opportunity to move the lines of orthodoxy in the PCA. It is always necessary to have wise and qualified men serving in this committee to ensure that our denomination is accurately represented in these discussions. The rules regarding the RE/TE alternating slots are similar to the NC. If there is not a qualified man of a particular office willing to serve your presbytery may appoint one representative of the other office. Below is a list of NP presbyteries where there is a vacancy.

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Gulf Stream (TE)
Illiana (TE)
North Texas (TE)
Northern California (TE)
Northern Illinois (TE)
Philadelphia (RE)
Pittsburgh (RE)
Platte Valley (RE)
Potomac (RE)
South Florida (RE)
Southwest (TE)
Suncoast (FL) (RE)

There are currently **8 NP members serving on RPR**

4. Action items:

- Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website
- Sign up for the Overtures Committee
- If not overtures, serve in the Administrative Committee or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work

5. Calendar:

April 18: Overtures requiring BCO amendment are due

May 28-30: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. The NP starts discussions on all overtures set for GA this month.

June 16-20: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA. We'll try for an informal beer/pizza meeting during the week.

National Partnership NOTE

1 view

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James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

May 6, 2014, 7:25:03 AM

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□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

NOTE: A gentle push here... I see 27 men serving on CoC. With over 150 in the partnership we should be doing a bit better than that; remember that part of what we ask is that you be willing to jump into committee work unless providentially hindered (or blacklisted!). Please let me know if I haven't recorded your name. The Overtures Committee accepts last-minute additions (if your presbytery appoints via an admin committee you can be added as late as your arrival at GA)

Sixteen "Grandfathers" of our denomination, present at the birth of the PCA, signed a letter encouraging the next generations to "lead from the center". I found it to be encouraging and perhaps you will too: <http://byfaithonline.com/founders-to-the-next-generation/> . As you might expect there was a response from those who consider the center to be too far left: <http://theaquilareport.com/a-tale-of-two-letters/> . Just keeping you in the loop here.

-Overture 3 from Grace Presbytery, which seeks to allow for greater review of SJC decisions, has been affirmed by overtures from several other presbyteries. This is going to be *the* primary issue debated in Houston. Unfortunately these proposed revisions appear to many to plunge us back into Assembly bickering on judicial cases, and will encourage greater politicizing of decisions in the blogosphere and elsewhere.

-Men are needed for the Overtures Committee. I have **16** so far noted below. Please let us know if you have jumped on the OC.

-Please let me know what committees you'll be serving so I can update our website; the current list is below – let me know where there are corrections to be made

-If you feel we should be discussing an overture not currently on a discussion page on the website please let me know. I've tried to create discussion for the overtures likely to cause debate.

Please add your thoughts to the discussions on the primary matters of debate on Overtures this year through the website. As NP men on the Overtures Committee begin to prepare for GA it would be helpful for them to read your thoughts. I hope you'll take a few minutes to comment.

1. **Additions** (154 elders in 54 presbyteries)

2. **Updates**

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan
TE Justin Woodall
TE Walt Coppersmith
TE Mark Bates
TE Jim Richter
TE Ben Lyon
TE Michael Craddock
TE Jedidiah Slaboda
TE Dan MacDonald
TE Eric Costa
TE Will Reinmuth
TE Kevin Twit
TE Ian Hard
TE Mike Sloan
RE Richard Dolan
TE Geoff Ziegler

Admin

TE James Kessler
TE Matthew Armstrong
TE Erik Bonkovsky
TE Jon Price

Interchurch Relations

TE Walter Henegar
TE Kyle Hackmann
TE Jason Polk
TE Larry Hoop

MNA

TE Drew Bennett

Covenant Seminary

TE Jonathan Winfree

Covenant College

TE Nate Walker

Presbyteries passing an overture in support of Overture 6: (22)

Heritage

Iowa

Metro Atlanta

Nashville

North Texas

The Ohio

Providence

Southwest Florida

Georgia Foothills

Eastern Canada

Western Canada

Chicago Metro

Houston Metro

Eastern Pennsylvania

Tennessee Valley

James River

Missouri

Savannah River

Rocky Mountain

Southern New England

Blue Ridge

Gulf Stream

There are currently **10 NP members serving on RPR**

4. **Action items:**

- Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website
- Sign up for the Overtures Committee
- If not overtures, serve in the Administrative Committee or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work. If none of those are open serve somewhere! The denomination is healthier with greater participation.

5. **Calendar:**

May 28-30: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. The NP starts discussions on all overtures set for GA this month.

June 16-20: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA. We'll try for an informal beer/pizza meeting during the week.

Partnership NOTE (and new website password)

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
 <JKessler@npc-dublin.org>
 unread,
 May 12, 2014, 1:57:52 PM

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 ☐

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

NOTE THE NEW WEBSITE PASSWORD - rev223

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

-

Please add your voice to the discussion on the website concerning the overtures speaking to same-sex marriage and the proposed SJC changes. Your input will help sharpen the views of NP members who are serving on the OC. This link will take you to the discussion on the SJC: <https://james-kessler.squarespace.com/overture-1-voting-on-sjc-decisions/2013/10/29/overture-1-and-sean-lucas-comments#comments-52702ab1e4b08363c17a3128>

NOTE: A gentle push... I see 36 men serving on CoC. With over 150 in the partnership we could be doing a bit better than that; remember that part of what we ask is that you be willing to jump into committee work unless providentially hindered (or blacklisted!). Please let me know if I haven't recorded your name. The Overtures Committee accepts last-minute additions (if your presbytery appoints via an admin committee you can be added as late as your arrival at GA)

-Overture 3 from Grace Presbytery, which seeks to allow for greater review of SJC decisions, has been affirmed by overtures from several other presbyteries. This is going to be *the* primary issue debated in Houston. Unfortunately these proposed revisions appear to many to plunge us back into Assembly bickering on judicial cases, and will encourage greater politicizing of decisions in the blogosphere and elsewhere.

-Men are needed for the Overtures Committee. I have **18** so far noted below. Please let us know if you have jumped on the OC.

1. **Additions** (154 elders in 54 presbyteries)

2. **News**

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan
 TE Justin Woodall
 TE Walt Coppersmith
 TE Mark Bates
 TE Jim Richter
 TE Ben Lyon

TE Michael Craddock
TE Jedidiah Slaboda
TE Dan MacDonald
TE Eric Costa
TE Will Reinmuth
TE Kevin Twit
TE Ian Hard
TE Mike Sloan
RE Richard Dolan
TE Geoff Ziegler
TE Tim LeCroy
RE Bill Thomas

Admin

TE James Kessler
TE Matthew Armstrong
TE Erik Bonkovsky
TE Jon Price

Interchurch Relations

TE Walter Henegar
TE Kyle Hackmann
TE Jason Polk
TE Larry Hoop

MNA

TE Drew Bennett

MTW

TE Jeff Schneider
TE Charles Godwin

Covenant Seminary

TE Jonathan Winfree
TE Luke Evans

Covenant College

TE Nate Walker
TE Erik McDaniel

CE/P

TE David Wallover

Ridge Haven

TE Daniel Gilchrist
TE Wes Neel

RUM

TE Jason Little

TE Charles Garland

Presbyteries passing an [overture in support of Overture 6](#): (23)

There are currently **10 NP members serving on RPR**

4. Action items:

- Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website
- Sign up for the Overtures Committee
- If not overtures, serve in the Administrative Committee or Interchurch Relations Committee for your Assembly work. If those are full, serve somewhere! The denomination is best served with more participation.

5. Calendar:

May 28-30: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. The NP starts discussions on all overtures set for GA this month.

June 16-20: Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA. We'll try for an informal beer/pizza meeting during the week.

Overture from Pittsburgh Presbytery

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



jon

<jon@covcommunity.org>

unread,

May 14, 2014, 9:34:05 AM

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□

to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

My Session presented an Overture to Presbytery in January that received a unanimous vote. It was delivered to the Clerk prior to the deadline, but somehow was never forwarded to the CCB. We've been told that it has been forwarded to the CCB, and will be added as an Assembly addition (pending their approval). While it's not as important of an overture as some that we'll be considering, I'd like to get it in front of the Partnership for you to be aware of, and interact with any questions you might have regarding it.

The Overture asks that BCO 18-7 be amended regarding removal of candidates and interns. We are proposing that the reasons (and any action taken by a Session or Presbytery) for removal be reported in the minutes of Presbytery. It seems to us that we are not caring well for our candidates and interns by not having this stipulation. We've often noticed that men are removed 'just because,' and then later find out that there was some contention or lack of care by a pastor or Session, but by that time there's no way for the Presbytery to intervene. We've also noticed, (and unfortunately been involved in a situation before my time at Covenant Community) where questionable actions by an intern were cause for his removal, but not reported to Presbytery, only for those issues to show themselves later and in 'greater' sin. Had the Presbytery known of these issues, perhaps greater care would have been given to help these men confront their sin, and find freedom in Christ.

Anyway, I wanted to pass this along to you men so that you may prayerfully consider it for this summer's GA. Also, if you have any questions or concerns, please feel free to pass them along.

Blessings,

Jon Price

Pastor

Covenant Community Church

OVERTURE FROM PITTSBURGH PRESBYTERY "Amend BCO 18-7 Regarding Removal of Candidates and Interns" Whereas every intern is required to be a candidate for ministry (BCO 19-8), and; Whereas with respect to the candidate "his preparatory training for the ministry he is under the oversight of the Presbytery. It shall be the duty of the Presbytery to show a kindly and sympathetic interest in him" [BCO 18-4, emphasis added]; and Whereas "The intern should be closely supervised by the Presbytery throughout this trial period." [BCO 19-7, emphasis added]; and Whereas "For the development of his Christian character, for the service he can render, and for his more effective training, the candidate, when entering on his theological studies, should be authorized and encouraged by the Presbytery to conduct public worship, to expound the Scriptures to the people, and to engage in other forms of Christian work. These forms of service should be rendered under the direction of Presbytery" [SCO 18-5]; and Whereas this relationship between the candidate and Presbytery does not change when they

become an intern, "Presbyteries should require interns to devote themselves diligently to the trial of their gifts; and no one should be ordained to the work of the ministry of the Word until he has demonstrated the ability both to edify and to rule in the Church." (BCO 19-12]; and Whereas the candidate or intern can have his status removed. "A candidate shall, at his request, be allowed to withdraw from the care of the Presbytery. The Presbytery may also, for sufficient reasons, remove the name of the candidate from its roll of candidates; but in such a case it shall report its actions and the reasons therefor to the candidate and to the Session of his church." [BCO 18-7]; and Whereas the Presbytery is required to give sufficient reasons for the candidate's removal to the candidate and to the Session of his church [BCO 18-7]; and Whereas Sessions will, at their discretion, request the removal of candidates from the care of the Presbytery; and Whereas the Session of his church is not required to give sufficient reasons or make a report to Presbytery of its actions; and Whereas there is no requirement for the candidate to give sufficient reasons to the Presbytery for his withdraw from the care of the Presbytery; and Whereas we are doing a disservice to these men under our care by allowing them, or their Sessions, to request to be withdrawn from the care of the Presbytery without reporting sufficient reasons and actions, thereby not giving the Presbytery the opportunity to "show a kindly and sympathetic interest in him" [BCO 18-4] before the relationship is severed. Therefore be it resolved that the 42nd General Assembly of the Presbyterian Church in America amend BCO 18-7 by adding "or at the request of his Session,... But in such a case sufficient reasons [and any actions taken] must be reported to the Presbytery." Also, "In all cases of a removal or withdrawal of a candidate, the sufficient reason for the action shall be recorded in the minutes of Presbytery." The new 18-7 would thus read [new wording underlined]: "The Presbytery may, upon application of the candidate, give a certificate of dismissal to another Presbytery. The candidate may be allowed to retain membership in his home church upon the request of his Session and the approval of both Presbyteries involved. A candidate shall, at his request or at the request of his Session, be allowed to withdraw from the care of the Presbytery, by reporting sufficient reasons to the Presbytery. But in such a case sufficient reasons (and any actions taken) must be reported to the Presbytery. The Presbytery may also, for sufficient reasons, remove the name of the candidate from its roll of candidates; but in such a case it shall report its actions and the reasons therefore to the candidate and to the Session of his church. In all cases of a removal or withdrawal of a candidate, the sufficient reason for the action shall be recorded in the minutes of Presbytery." Adopted by Pittsburgh Presbytery at its stated meeting, January 25, 2014. Stated Clerk

1 view

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James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

May 20, 2014, 7:02:04 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

In an effort to ensure that everyone participating in the National Partnership feels no undue pressure I want to extend the offer to de-list from us if you would like; if your conscience pushes you toward non-participation you should feel free to be removed. I have been very thankful for all of your participation in the Partnership – it has been encouraging for me and helpful for my growth as a presbyter (and a pastor!). As we head into General Assembly you'll receive quite a few updates and exhortations to be present for votes, etc. It would be natural to hang on to membership in the NP because all of us want to "know what people are up to." But the NP is a working group and we would hope/expect that you'll participate in the process rather than sit on the sidelines. You should feel no frustration from me or others if you decide it isn't for you. Just let me know and I'll try to change our roster as quickly as possible. Again, whatever your decision, I'm grateful for your participation so far!

For the rest of you: let's get ready for Houston.

JK

Partnership NOTE

1 view

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James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 2, 2014, 7:38:48 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Please add your voice to the discussion on the website concerning the overtures speaking to same-sex marriage and the proposed SJC changes. Your input will help sharpen the views of NP members who are serving on the OC.

This link will take you to the discussion on the SJC: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-1-voting-on-sjc-decisions/>

TE Mark Bates has provided an FAQ regarding the Insider Movement's minority report. This will be a fairly contentious debate again this year. This may prove helpful for you: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/insider-movements/>

NOTE: The **Overtures Committee** accepts last-minute additions (if your presbytery appoints via an admin committee you can be added as late as your arrival at GA). The OC committee does not list anyone from the following:

Blue Ridge
Central Florida
South Florida
Warrior

-Overture 3 from Grace Presbytery, which seeks to allow for greater review of SJC decisions, has been affirmed by overtures from several other presbyteries. This is going to be *the* primary issue debated in Houston. Unfortunately these proposed revisions appear to many to plunge us back into Assembly bickering on judicial cases, and will encourage greater politicizing of decisions in the blogosphere and elsewhere.

-Men are needed for the Overtures Committee. I have **20** so far noted below. Please let us know if you have jumped on the OC.

1. Additions (154 elders in 54 presbyteries)

TE Will Tabor (SE Louisiana)

TE Grant Lowe (Tennessee Valley)

2. News

Thanks to those who attended RPR this year. From what I heard the meeting proceeded without much craziness. That's always a good thing and only happens when we are all willing to participate.

GA Committee of Commissioners: Here are the current names of NP on the Committee of Commissioners (please update me)

Overtures

TE Peter Rowan

TE Justin Woodall

TE Walt Coppersmith

TE Mark Bates

TE Jim Richter

TE Ben Lyon

TE Michael Craddock

TE Jedidiah Slaboda

TE Dan MacDonald

TE Eric Costa

TE Will Reinmuth

TE Kevin Twit

TE Ian Hard

TE Mike Sloan
RE Richard Dolan
TE Geoff Ziegler
TE Tim LeCroy
RE Bill Thomas
RE Paul Neighbors
RE Sam Duncan

Admin

TE James Kessler
TE Matthew Armstrong
TE Erik Bonkovsky
TE Jon Price

Interchurch Relations

TE Walter Henegar
TE Kyle Hackmann
TE Jason Polk
TE Larry Hoop

MNA

TE Drew Bennett

MTW

TE Jeff Schneider
TE Charles Godwin
TE Todd Crusey

Covenant Seminary

TE Jonathan Winfree
TE Luke Evans

Covenant College

TE Nate Walker
TE Erik McDaniel

CE/P

TE David Wallover

PCA-f

TE Blake Altman

Ridge Haven

TE Daniel Gilchrist
TE Wes Neel

RUM

TE Jason Little

TE Charles Garland

Presbyteries passing an [overture in support of Overture 6](#): (23)

4. Action items:

- Interact with overture items 2, 3, and 6 on the Partnership website
- Sign up for the Overtures Committee if your Presbytery still has a vacancy

5. Calendar:

[June 16-20](#): Houston in the Summer! Being a member of the NP presumes that you'll be in attendance at GA.

GA floor noms - vacant RE slots

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



joel

<joel@mosaicsilverspring.org>

unread,

Jun 13, 2014, 7:19:44 AM

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□

to thenp@googlegroups.com

Friends,

As we head to Houston next week, I wanted to highlight an opportunity for RE nominations. Currently, there are 4 **open** committee alternate slots (no candidate was put forward by the Nominating Committee):

- Admin Committee

- MNA
- Interchurch Relations
- Theological Examining

The alternate attends the scheduled meetings over the next year, fills in if quorum is needed or if a member cannot serve their term out, gains valuable experience, and gains consideration the following year for a permanent slot (BCO 14-1).

I have attached the Floor Nomination form together with the Committee qualification descriptions for the open slots. **Floor nominations are due on the floor clerk's desk by Wednesday, 6/18 @ 5pm.**

If you have any questions at all about how to get this done, I'm glad to walk you through it.

Please take a minute and consider if you have a Ruling Elder in your Presbytery that would be a good fit for one of these positions.

Warm regards,

Joel

Joel St. Clair
Pastor

General Assembly Note #1

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 17, 2014, 5:42:19 PM

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□



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

This evening the Assembly begins with the first worship service and the election of a moderator. I wanted to give you an overview of this week's work. I will send it in multiple emails for ease of navigation:

- I. 42nd Assembly Introduction – primary issues (now)
- II. Study Committee on Insider Movements (later tonight)
- III. The overtures committee review (Wednesday morning)
- IV. Nominations to permanent committee (Wednesday evening)

As I have said before, I will do my best to provide resources for your preparation – including my own perspectives – but I want to emphasize once again that participation in the National Partnership does not imply your conformity to the opinions expressed. What I'm going for is unity – in truth and charity. Certainly the opinions expressed here would be far less helpful had I not received from you all much feedback and help. Thank you!

Overview

The primary issues

The SJC's current system allows for the commission to process a case without waiting for the Assembly to either uphold or strike down their decisions. This year there are a handful of motions seeking to allow for decisions of the SJC to be reviewed but the Assembly before they are finalized. The Overtures committee recommended that all the SJC motions be answered in the negative. While there was much debate the decision was not narrow – they failed by a 4-1 margin in committee. Next they will come to the floor where the Assembly can debate the motion to answer the SJC overtures in the negative but they cannot offer amendments. This means either the assembly will affirm the motion to answer the overtures in the negative (i.e. 'no to SJC changes') or they will deny the motion to answer in the negative, committing the matter to the next Overtures committee at the general assembly in 2015.

Overtures 2 and 5 sought to make a denominational statement in regards to the issue of homosexuality and the sanctity of marriage. The makers of the overture want the denomination to go on record against the encroachment of religious liberty by groups advocating for homosexual rights (in view: Christians denying their services to homosexual couples on religious grounds then being prosecuted) and to reaffirm the biblical

doctrine of marriage over and against the current cultural trend. The debate in the Overtures committee was very passionate and more divided than any other debate. On one side were those who thought the motions unhelpful pastorally in contexts where churches are seeking to engage the culture more delicately. On the other side were those who feel anxiety about the increasing harassment Christians receive in trying to live out Biblical commitments. Both sides want the Church of Jesus Christ to speak pastorally and truthfully to the issue but disagree as to whether an overture to the general assembly resulting in a public statement is the best forum. Ultimately after much debate and reconsidering the question the overtures were answered in the negative – a good result in my view. There will be a minority report to answer in the affirmative with some amendments. This means that on the floor of the assembly the minority report can be substituted for the majority report by a majority of the commissioners voting. I expect this debate to be fevered on the floor.

The Study Committee on Insider Movements is docketed for discussion tomorrow afternoon. The question before the Assembly will be this: 1. Accept only the Majority report (deny minority report) 2. Accept both the Majority and Minority report (treating them as companion work of the study committee). It is my hope that the Minority report will be accepted. If you are looking to understand more about the minority report here are some links I found to be helpful:

Dr. Greg Perry: <http://gregoryperry.wordpress.com/2014/06/08/in-praise-of-the-minority-report-on-so-called-insider-movements/>

Dr. Nelson Jennings (in debate with David Garner): <http://www.reformation21.org/articles/jennings-and-garner-debate-the-insider-movement.php>

Seminars

I want to recommend two seminars to you. Unfortunately they are occurring simultaneously, **Wednesday morning - 8am**. They are both strategically important – the relationships on multi staff churches have great potential to multiply ministry and empower movements; the transformation of presbytery culture is a crucial step toward greater impact in church planting, mercy ministry and community transformation. The men leading these seminars are great teachers. I hope you'll make time for one of them:

Shaping the Relationship between Senior, Associate, and Assistant Pastors

Seminar Speakers:

George Robertson, Pastor, First Presbyterian, Augusta, GA

Adam S. Tisdale, Sr. Pastor, North Hills Church (PCA) Meridianville, AL

Erik McDaniel, Assistant Pastor, Faith Presbyterian Church Anniston, AL

"Too frequently the relationship between the Senior, Associate, and Assistant pastors on church staff creates unnecessary frustration and confusion. This seminar will address common difficulties and suggest ways to make greater use of the different Pastoral staff roles for the greater kingdom ministry of your church."

Leading Presbytery Renewal and Cultural Transformation

Seminar Speakers:

Ray Cortese, TE, Seven Rivers Presbyterian Church

Bruce O'Neil, TE, Evangelical Presbyterian, Annapolis

Jason Dorsey, TE, Redeemer Presbyterian, Indianapolis Too frequently the relationship between the Senior, Associate, and

Assistant pastors on church staff creates unnecessary frustration and confusion. This seminar will discuss the process of moving presbyter-ies toward being an inward-facing "court of care" for pastors and an outward-facing church-planting movement following the experiences of the Central Florida, Chesapeake, and Central Indiana Presbyteries.

A point of personal privilege

A good friend reminded me of a helpful truth a couple of weeks ago: we must constantly fight against the tendency to reduce the personhood of those with whom we disagree to a proposition easily dismissed. More simply: your opponents are more than the propositions they affirm. We have to fight to hear each other in these heated debates. I tell you I am not good at this. I am impatient and weary of anyone's voice but my own after a few minutes. I pray that you and I will fight the good fight to love Jesus well in these conversations. May we be alternately frustrated, relieved, pensive, winsome, annoyed even, but never disgusted with one another. When we throw away our voting cards on Friday; when we beat our swords back into plowshares we will continue to drink from the same fountain and we will continue to plead the same blood. A pleading much louder and sharper than our disagreements. I know you know all of this but it does my heart good to say them out loud again. I want to excel at being a churchman this week. I believe that means I must excel as a worshiper too. Thank you as always for joining in the hard work of loving the brethren well and leading this small part of the Kingdom. Many many blessings to you.

Warmly,

JK

If you have a question during the assembly

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 18, 2014, 11:17:08 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

I will be seated at microphone 8

[614.302.1570](tel:614.302.1570)

JK

NP: Wednesday outlook

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 18, 2014, 11:43:23 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

1.30pm – RPR report

2.30pm – Report on Insider Movement Study Committee

7.30pm - Worship

Report on the Insider Movement:

It is my sincere hope that we will approve the reception of both reports. The Majority report includes the desire to *not receive* the minority report. The Minority report, on the other hand, views its place as a helpful companion to the majority report. I think of it this way: the Majority report (though it has some content that is not optimal to my reading) provides a very broad canopy under which a biblical application of IM principles may function healthily. The Minority report provides further clarification to that point: I.e. How the majority report can function in real ministry contexts. I agree with the Minority report that both reports need one another. If you have not read the minority report FAQ I have attached it again. Here also are a couple of items for further reading:

<http://gregoryperry.wordpress.com/2014/06/08/in-praise-of-the-minority-report-on-so-called-insider-movements/>

<http://www.reformation21.org/articles/jennings-and-garner-debate-the-insider-movement.php>

Discussion thread at the General Assembly

Feel free to follow along, post questions, etc. and I (or someone else) will do our best to answer you:

<http://thenationalpartnership.com/the-42nd-general-assembly-discussion/>

JK

PCA Study Committee for Insider Movements

Minority Report 2014 FAQs

Prelude

As an aid to Commissioners to the 2014 General Assembly of the PCA regarding the Study Committee on Insider Movements, the authors of the 2014 Minority Report entitled, “Realities on the Ground, An Additional Perspective,” present the following FAQs.

Question: Why did you submit a Minority Report to the 2014 General Assembly?

Answer: While the Committee Report (CR) provides vital theological foundations and helpful

boundaries for doing mission (through the Affirmations and Denials) which we support, we believe it's important for those doing mission among Muslims to receive information concerning certain on-the-ground realities, along with some associated biblical considerations. We hope and pray that the additional perspective in this 37 page report will provide practical help to PCA churches, assisting them in their broad sowing of the message of God's saving power through his Son and the building of his church throughout Muslim nations, "...that your ways may be known on earth, your salvation among all nations" (Psalm 67:2, NIV).

Question: What is the relationship between MR 2014 and the Minority Report submitted during the General Assembly of 2013?

Answer: MR 2014 has new authorship and thus we consider it as a total replacement for Minority Report 2013.

Question: What is the significance of MR 2014's recommendations to the 2014 General Assembly?

Answer: Our recommendations mirror those of the CR with the exception that we separately recommend that the 2014 General Assembly, "make available and recommend for study" both the CR and MR 2014 to its presbyteries, churches and missions committees. Treating the papers separately allows commissioners to discuss and vote for each paper on its own merit. A General Assembly action to "make available and recommend for study" does not imply agreement with every word or idea expressed in a paper. We are not requesting, "adoption" of these reports, but that the Assembly send the papers to presbyteries, churches and missions committees for study.

Question: Tell us some of your convictions on matters related to Insider Movement missiology.

- 1☐ We hold to the Scriptures as our only authoritative guide to engaging in mission.
- 2☐ We believe that both Scripture and our confession encourage believers to apply scriptural principles to the realities of everyday life, wherever they live.
- 3☐ We believe that Christ ordinarily intends that his people will follow him in the context of their family, birth community, and vocation.
- 4☐ In recognition of the comprehensive claims of Christ on the lives of his people we hold that identity in Christ is wholly controlling in the life of the believer; we do not advocate or support voluntary, indefinite retention of Islamic religious identity by MBBs.
- 5☐ We hold that disciplers of MBBs should not encourage a disciple to remain within Islamic religious institutions.

- 6□ We hold that every believer is a member of the church of Jesus Christ, and we believe in the central importance of every believer to be part of a local expression of church.
- 7□ We hold by faith that Muslims are people made in the image of God, and that through Christ alone, people from Muslim majority countries will be among those represented before the throne of God (Rev. 7:9-10).

(Note: In Minority Report 2014, references are provided for the above points to specific Affirmations and Denials from the Majority Report.)

Question: What is the outline of the Minority Report?

Answer: After providing introductory context to this report, we describe five realities faced by believers living in Muslim societies and treat four considerations that undergird and inform our approach to mission in the midst of these realities. A list of questions for use by missions committees with their missions partners is also included. An outline of our major topics follows.

Part One: Realities on the Ground Facing Muslim Background Believers (MBBs)

- 8□ Reality #1: It is Important that MBBs Live Biblically within Muslim Societies.
- 9□ Reality #2: MBBs Can Live Biblically within Muslim Societies.
- 10□ Reality #3: National Churches within Muslim Societies Do Not Always Accept MBBs.
- 11□ Reality #4: Living within Muslim Societies Requires MBBs to be Vigilant to Avoid Syncretism.
- 12□ Reality #5: Growing in Christ within Muslim Societies Holds Significant Challenges for MBBs.

Part Two: Biblical Considerations for Facing Realities on the Ground.

- 13□ Consideration A: Every Culture has “Good” and Evil Aspects.
- 14□ Consideration B: We Must Not Add Requirements to the Gospel: Principles from the Jerusalem Council of Acts 15.
- 15□ Consideration C: We are Called to Live in the World But Not of the World: 1 Corinthians 7:17-24 and its Context.
- 16□ Consideration D: We Must Not Participate with Demons in False Worship: A Warning from 1 Corinthians 10:19-20.

Schedule change

2 views

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 18, 2014, 2:04:55 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Insider movement report starting now

GA: Thursday outlook

3 views

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2014, 8:29:30 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Today's notable events:

10am Nominations Committee (This is an 'order of the day' and will happen no earlier or later than 10)

1.30pm Overtures Committee – I'm guessing here. Overtures is docketed for 3.30p but I imagine we will get through the preceding business before lunch.

Nomination Advice (Thanks much to Joel St. Clair who did the work of pulling together all the information below; the recommendations are mine – as always you are encouraged to vote your conscience!)

NOTE: all of the uncontested nominations will be moved in an Omnibus motion. This will be followed by the contested nominations.

(c) = Nominations Committee Recommendation

ADMIN COMMITTEE

Class of 2018

-

TE - David Silvernail (c) vs. **Rod Mays***

Rationale: While David has a ton of experience on the AC committee already – having chaired the committee in the past – it is difficult for me to ignore the work Rod has done in the past with a large organization like RUF. I would like to see his experience in a denominational agency with mission impact added to the mix of qualified men on the committee

Alternate

-

TE - **Tim LeCroy*** (c) vs. Steve Jeantet vs. Kenneth Pierce

Rationale: Both Steve and Tim are NP guys, both are very competent men. It was difficult for me to point in one direction here in particular because Steve has done a lot of great work for the Admin committee – and I trust he will continue to do so whether or not he is on committee. But one factor sways me: I want more small-church pastors and church-planters involved in the Administrative committee. I think we will need to learn how to meet the needs of a church that is becoming more dispersed and plant-driven. LeCroy was also the committee's recommendation. Know that if Steve does not win the spot I will be supporting him heavily next year as his gifts would be valued on the AC.

-

RE - ***Todd Carlisle** vs. Barry Sheets vs. H.Scott Winchester

Rationale: Scott participates with us on the NP (one of our small group of RE guys) which means a lot to me. But I can't ignore Carlisle's imminent qualifications. The guy has done great work in Evangel Presbytery and on staff at Briarwood. It is a tough call here but the number of people I spoke to who are impressed by Todd's work and experience swayed me in his direction. I think we can't go wrong with either of those two guys.

COMMITTEE ON CONSTITUTIONAL BUSINESS

Alternate

-

TE - ***Josh Anderson** (c) vs. Mark Rowden

Rationale: If you know Josh you know he's made for this committee. Served multiple years on RPR, helped write reports for the committee, understands the interplay between the two committees very well. He's impressive in his knowledge of the BCO, etc. When I've asked his help in understanding a particular action I've been impressed by his competence. He's also a younger guy and I continue to desire that sort of representation on the committees.

COMMITTEE ON INTERCHURCH RELATIONS

Alternate

-

TE - Richard Phillips (c) vs. ***Richard Lints**

-

RE - Paul Bush vs. ***Paul Richardson** (c)

Rationale: This has more to do with the candidates' view of our relationship to other reformed denominations. Lints and Richardson seem far more open to strong fraternal ties than Bush and certainly Phillips (who has stated his personal mission to cut our denomination out of the NAE et al.). I'm not there yet; I think there's value in continued ties.

COMMITTEE ON MISSION NORTH AMERICA

Alternate

-

RE - ***Paul Adams Sr** vs William Hill

Rationale: Paul Adams comes on high recommendation from MNA

COMMITTEE ON MISSION TO WORLD

Alternate

-

TE – ***Richard Wiman** (c) vs. Roland Barnes

Rationale: Wiman was the committee's nominee and eminently qualified

BOARD OF DIRECTORS OF RIDGE HAVEN

Class of 2019

-

TE ***Roger Newell** vs. Richard Smith

Rationale: Simply that Newell was our committee's recommendation. When there is not much separating the candidates we try to trust the committee.

SJC

Class of 2018

-

TE ***George Robertson** (c) vs. Paul Fowler

Rationale: Robertson is well-qualified and was the committee nominee

TEC

Class of 2017

-

TE ***Eric Dye** (c) vs. Luke Kim

Rationale: Committee nominee

Alternate

-

RE Robert Mattes vs. ***William Blake Temple**

Rationale: while I believe Mattes to be able in many things his enthusiasm for pursuing a strong agenda (not altogether wrong!) doesn't seem to be a good fit for this committee.

Overtures recommendations to follow

JK

James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2014, 11:20:05 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

All,

Don't stray too far from the ballroom. We are moving so quickly that there's an outside chance we may start before lunch.

JK



Jedidiah Slaboda

<jedidiah@secondcitychurch.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2014, 11:36:34 AM

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to James Kessler, TheNP@googlegroups.com

Overtures starting now.

--

Rev. Jedidiah Slaboda
Second City Church

GA: Overtures preview

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>
unread,
Jun 19, 2014, 11:36:37 AM

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□

to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

As you prepare to vote on the Overtures before us here is a preview with recommendations – as always these are suggestions that you are free to accept or not! Hopefully this information will aid you.

First the rules:

-No one on the Overtures committee can enter into debate on the floor – they have already spoken through committee

-Each overture typically comes with a recommendation to affirm or answer in the negative.

If the recommendation is to answer in the affirmative:

The floor can affirm the committee and the overture is passed

The floor can answer the committee in the negative and the overture is not passed

The floor can move to recommit the overture to either the current Overtures committee or next year's

If the recommendation is to answer in the negative:

The floor can affirm the committee and the overture is not passed

The floor can answer the committee in the negative and the overture is not passed, but is automatically recommitted to the overtures committee

-No one may offer an amendment to the work of the overtures committee. All perfecting of language must be done by the OC.

1. All SJC motions were answered in the negative in reference to Overture 13 (that means all were dealt with together). The vote was by a 4-1 margin. There will be considerable debate but not much that can be done. Either these motions will be completely defeated by affirming the committee or they will be recommitted probably to next year's overtures committee for further work. I am recommending against recommitting these overtures as none of them can improve our current

process and all would lead to difficulties of all sorts. There are many fine summaries out there but I am including an attachment to something I wrote regarding this – I was helped along by many others in my opinion.

2. Overture 6: the child protection overture was answered in the affirmative (unanimously) and should be affirmed by all of us. Here are some additional notes from Mike Sloan who coauthored the overture:

- 3.

"Brothers, the child protection overture received unanimous affirmation in the Overtures Committee (there was 1 abstention). **There were a few edits, but in my opinion these were all friendly, and in no way water down what was intended.** I do not anticipate much opposition on the floor, but there were some concerning comments by David Coffin in his overture chart. You never know what will happen on the floor. I cannot speak to it because as a member of the Overtures Committee I am not to allow to enter into the debate on overtures when they come to the floor. If needed I hope that you will be ready to stand up for the precious little ones that Jesus welcomes with open arms as many of you already have in your presbyteries. Thank you for all of your encouragement to me this year. I ask your indulgence for one final, personal word, my dear brothers. I am grateful for the rising awareness surrounding child protection. I am also aware this overture consists only of words. Words matter, but without action, they are empty. My prayer is that we will speak clearly on Thursday, but also take these words as a call to action in our churches.

Read quickly!

JK

SJC argument:

Men,

I hope you'll permit me to have the last word on our SJC discussion before we move on. I've asked for and received quite a bit of advice concerning the seven overtures related to the SJC and I'll put them here for the benefit of the group. Attached you'll find one document prepared by a very gifted brother in our denomination. I was thankful to receive it and also offer it to you as help. Here are my own thoughts after hearing from you and many others:

Proposed changes create unacceptable delays in process:

I thought Ray Cannata had some helpful things to say here, but I also asked advice from multiple members of the SJC who are also a part of the NP and they are universally disturbed by the idea of delay

in a case that may have already taken a few years to process through the courts. A case decided in the SJC October meeting, for instance, could not be finalized for 8 more months! In some cases it may not be of too much consequence but in cases where a minister's good name (or employment!) is on the line, this is a grievous wait for justice. In the case of a Presbytery commission (whose decisions must be finalized by the entire body) the delay would likely be no more than a month or so, from stated meeting to stated meeting.

Proposed changes expose parties to an uninformed and politicized jury

Every person I've spoken to who has served on the SJC has been humbled by the massive amounts of reading and deliberation necessary to dispose of a single case before the court. It is foolish to think that even the most conscientious commissioner will have the opportunity to read the record of any but the most notorious cases before them. And this is part of the problem. If only the most notorious cases receive this degree of review and discussion among commissioners, we have entered a world where justice is not equal from case to case, because one court is uninterested in 95% of the plaintiff cases. The issue is this: the Assembly as a whole cannot justly function as a sometimes-interested court of review. It must function uniformly despite the case presented before it, or not at all.

Further to this point, notorious cases create a climate where half-truths and uninformed theories breed. In our secular court system the process of sequestration protects defendants and plaintiffs from politicized juries. In our current SJC system the final word on a case proceeds from sequestered discovery and deliberation. The records of the case are made available to the commission and decisions rendered before they ever hit the blogosphere – the record of the case is not as easily compromised by widespread commentary. This is the proper way to decide a judicial case, extending mercy to the parties by a concern to limit the record of the case accordingly. David Coffin's ByFaith rejoinder on these overtures covers the oaths SJC members must take before deliberation and voting – it may be helpful to review these.

Proposed changes presume a mistrust of commission work

Much of the discussion over these changes revolves around the following fear: that a commission appointed by the General Assembly (i.e. To function as the assembly) will err so grievously that a slide into liberalism and disunion will follow, with no recourse. The watchword is "lack of accountability". Here are my problems with this assertion:

1. The Assembly has established the SJC with safeguards: a minority report consisting of at least 1/3 of the commission may be presented to the Assembly for vote and the Nominating Committee yearly elects 6 members of the court submitted through the Presbyteries – allowing the assembly to turn over 1/4 of the court's membership every year. A quick comparison to the Federal court system (lifetime appointments) provide a stark contrast.
2. The General Assembly is itself a commission! Commissions are Presbyterian! 700-1000 commissioners yearly vote on matters significant to thousands more who are not present. One could say that cases

decided by the Assembly, itself a small commission in comparison to the whole of Teaching Elders and eligible Ruling Elders would be functioning in the same capacity as our current commission but without the same skill and knowledge of the case, and after great delay.

3. If a Commissioner cannot trust the decision of the Presbytery, nor the decision of the commission of his own Assembly reviewing the Presbytery, nor the process for reforming the erring commission (voting new members in), the commissioner's greater problem may be his inability to fulfill his fourth ordination vow (subjection to the brethren) because he does not trust his fellow Elders to dispose of any business in which he is not directly empowered.

ADDITIONAL NOTES:

This is an emotional debate. I think it is advantageous, if you wish to oppose these overtures, to engage that emotion. Commissions are an expression of connectionalism: we trust each other to labor in the same field, out of view, for our own good. Or we don't.

While it is tempting to make this conversation about one case, we must remember that this isn't about one case. For Sean Lucas this is about the case of the future and the rogue presbytery of the future and the court whose hands are tied. The question every commissioner must ask himself is this: are we willing to lose charity and care for the parties in these cases because we are fearful of an imagined possible future? It really is that simple of a choice: the seven overtures seeking some improvement or even a middle ground seem to fail, in our opinion, to improve anything. This is evidence that we must choose one of two futures for our life together at the Assembly: will it be a dull meeting of trusting though diligent commissioners or will it be a shootout with the interested parties fighting every notorious case on the floor and uninformed commissioners seeking cover? Our preliminary principles favor the former. The latter really is a different denomination, not the PCA.

Thanks for allowing me to speak on this. I want to be careful not to coerce anyone; please forgive me if I am being too forward. We'll start discussion on other amendments Thursday.

JK

GA: Overtures advice, cont'd

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2014, 11:52:31 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

There is a minority report regarding Overture 43 (by which overtures 2 and 5 are answered in the negative). The floor has the option of, after hearing the minority opinion, to substitute the minority report for the majority report. In this case it is to answer with a statement for prayer and encouragement to those pastors engaging in Marriage and sanctity of human life issues. While I personally do not believe that a statement like this will actually equip pastors and open new avenues of Kingdom. Here is an argument from Kevin Twit regarding Overture 43

Thoughts on Minority Report for Overture 43

I am opposed to this softened version of Overture 43 and since I am unable to speak during overtures, I am willing to share my thoughts for those who are interested.

Even though the minority report softens (and certainly improves) the resolves, it does not eliminate, nor speak to, the original overture in the decisive way I believe we should. I don't think overtures that ask the PCA to pick and choose certain issues to highlight through public proclamation are helpful approaches and believe we should send a strong message that such overtures will be rejected. In this case, overtures 2 and 5 were overwhelmingly rejected, but many felt that we should say something and overture 43 was seen as a good compromise. But I want to speak clearly that overtures such as these are unwise and we need to stop sending them.

Even though the resolve is softened in the minority report approach, the where as section is still there. I know that we don't adopt the where as section, but who outside of General Assembly commissioners really understands that. If we send this out publically, people will assume we agree with the where as section. The first problem with the where as section is that it references the US Constitution – but the

PCA does not just contain people in the United States and so it fails to recognize that fact. How are our pastors and churches in Canada to explain this overture?

Furthermore, overtures which seek to have the whole church speak to an issue, end up making it more difficult for our churches to contextualize the Bible's teaching in their own contexts. Undoubtedly in the PCA there are pastors working in church contexts where they could lose credibility for not speaking a word of solidarity for those suffering for their stand on gay marriage and sanctity of life. But there are also pastors working in contexts where speaking out on these issues must be dealt with very skillfully, because most of the people in their community assume that all the church cares about is condemning things like gay marriage. Broad statements like this are a bad idea – we need to allow pastors and churches freedom to know how to speak, and when to speak, in their own context. What seems like a bold stand in one area of the country may come across as an unnecessary offense in another. I am not saying that we must weaken our stance on sanctity or life or marriage. We are confessional Presbyterians and thus it is clear where we stand on these issues. But overtures like this demand we consider the wisdom of how and when we speak to these issues publically – and I would argue such wisdom is best worked out and applied at a local level.

We must be very careful when we speak as a church about issues, particularly those that are seen as connected to the culture war in our day. Even the softened version of the resolves still carries the impression that we as a church are cherry picking certain issues to care about and remaining silent on other issues. Furthermore, as the grounds for answering this original overture in the negative say, “It is vital that the world hear the gospel from us clearly, yet overtures like this can add weight to the charge that we are more interested in condemning the culture than we are in reaching the culture with the love of Christ.”

The minority report alters this overture in such a way that it really seeks to propose a different overture – and thus we end up dealing with an overture not from a Presbytery but from a minority of the overtures committee. If those in the minority want an overture such as the minority report proposes, let them work on in with input from their presbytery (typically the way we gain the wisdom of the broader church on a proposed overture) and let them bring it in more typical way. I do not believe we need to affirm the practice of rewriting an overture in such a radical way by a minority of the overtures committee.

While I appreciate the intent of those who asked us to reconsider overture 43 in the overtures committee in order to avoid having the General Assembly deal with a minority report, this strategy was never going to work. If we had adopted the minority report as our response to overture 43 then we would have had the original answer to overture 43, with the grounds, offered as a minority report. And it is worth mentioning that this minority report was already offered up to the overtures committee as a substitute motion and it was rejected.

GA: in session

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2014, 1:43:14 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Debate resuming now on Overture 22

GA: overture actions

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 19, 2014, 2:06:31 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Overture 6 is affirmed

All SJC items are rejected.

A quick post-GA note

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Jun 21, 2014, 10:08:14 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Deep gratitude to all of you for your hard work at the General Assembly this week. For two straight assemblies I saw the majority of the PCA well-represented in committees, on the floor of the assembly, at gatherings late at night and into the early hours of the morning. As one who felt like an alien at the GA as recently as three years ago I am so thankful. You were there and you were ready to speak, ready to vote. Great men were elected to committee work and for the most part the actions of the assembly were beneficial for the growth of the Kingdom. I could not have imagined it in Louisville.

During one of the seminars Ray Cortese spoke about his presbytery being a place he would not hesitate to bring unbelievers (by the way you should get the tape from that seminar with Bruce O'Neil and Jason Dorsey; incredibly helpful). I felt there were many times this week when I would have proudly brought a non-Christian around with me; when we reflected a PCA that can actually speak in a culture where you have to earn your voice with grace, truth and love.

Thank you Joel St. Clair who kept me from making too many administrative mistakes and handled a huge burden for the Nominating Committee. Thanks to David Richter who sat in on the entire OC meeting even though he wasn't a member and helped me understand the issues we would be facing from the floor. Thanks to Bryan Chapell who did not wait the extra second to hear calls for 'division'. Thanks to Mike Sloan whose Child Protection Overture gave me one concrete thing I could bring to my church as worth the price of the Assembly. Thanks to sweaty Mike Khandjian (blame Houston) who opened my eyes to the fact that with 300 in attendance at Wednesday night's dinner I am not nearly as hip as I might have thought – this assembly is full of brilliant and holy men who can hold a pint or five. Thank you all for reminding me by your example that though I was not always at my best this week, Jesus was.

You will not hear from me for a few months, so enjoy that! Let's make it three-in-a-row in Chattanooga.

Warmly,

JK

Partnership NOTE (welcome back!)

2 views

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James Kessler

<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Oct 29, 2014, 11:08:18 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

We're back at it. We need to start thinking about nominations to permanent committees, the SJC, etc. What I mean by that is participation in the work of the PCA means that we can suggest men at the presbytery level that will be healthy additions to places of significant influence in our church. For those of you who are unaware of the process:

- Men are nominated to the permanent committees at the Presbytery level.
- Those nominations are debated and confirmed at the Nominating Committee meeting in March
- Those nominees approved by the Nominating committee come to the floor of the General Assembly for a vote
- Floor nominations are allowed preceding the votes (floor nominees are those put forward by commissioners against those approved by the Nominating Committee)

The committees for which we nominate members:

Administrative Committee (oversees denomination-wide administrative functions including GA)

Committee on Constitutional Business (gives advice regarding the constitutionality of overtures from presbyteries to the Assembly; reviews the minutes of the SJC ensuring that it follows its manual of operation)

Covenant College (reviews actions of the board)

Christian Education and Publications

Covenant Theological Seminary (reviews actions of the board)

Interchurch Relations (oversees the relationship of the PCA to other Presbyterian and Reformed denominations)

Mission to North America (oversees the work of our denomination's domestic church planting agency)

Mission to the World (oversees the work of our denomination's foreign missionary agency)

PCA Foundation (oversees our denomination's agency tasked with encouraging charitable giving, endowments, etc.)

PCA Retirement and Benefits (oversees retirement investment services)

Ridge Haven (oversees actions of the board)

Reformed University Ministries (oversees our denomination's campus ministry agency)

Standing Judicial Commission (functions as the final court of appeal in our denomination)

Theological Examining Committee (examines all first and second level administration officers in denominational committees)

1. **Additions** (157 elders in 55 presbyteries)

2. News

-There is an opening in a good church for an Associate/Executive pastor. If you are interested in talking about this confidentially please contact me: jkes...@npc-dublin.org and I'll gladly talk with you about the position. You may not share this information with anyone outside the NP

-There is also an opening at MTW for a Chief Administrative Officer:

"Mission to the World, the missions sending agency of the Presbyterian Church in America, is seeking a leader with a passion for mobilizing the Church to see Christ worshiped by every people, tribe and tongue. Specifically, we are looking for an experienced person who is gifted to serve the missionaries of our organization and help us to pursue our mission and values. Amid the complexities inherent to nonprofit organizations, international mobilization and management, we are looking for a leader who can streamline processes, achieve efficiency in administration, while remaining responsive to the missionary community.

The Chief Administrative Officer (CAO) is a Senior Team position that reports to MTW's Chief Operating Officer (COO). Through a cadre of experienced directors, the CAO oversees the Accounting, Treasury, Human Resources, Process Analysis and Training, and Information Technology departments of the home office. Specifically, this position is responsible for: oversight of cash and investment management; maintaining the financial and legal policies of the organization; and directing the process and technology resources to help carry out our strategic decisions. Key in the profile of this position will be a desire to participate in MTW's missional community, embrace and proclaim the gospel of grace, and apply the services of this division responsibly and creatively to fuel transformative church planting and renewal movements." Please contact Brian Deringer (brian.d...@mtw.org) with any questions. You may not share this information with anyone outside the NP

TE Larry Hoop added a discussion to the website discussions page. He has participated in an ad-hoc committee discussion about how to improve denominational health. As part of that discussion there is a proposed biennial conference. They would like feedback from the National Partnership : <http://thenationalpartnership.com/national-conference-to-minister-to-ministers/>

3. Action items:

None yet with the exception of commenting on the idea of a proposed biennial pastor's conference

4. Calendar:

Fall/Winter: Overtures from previous GA up for vote at the presbytery level. GA seminars are scheduled and openings filled.

March 21: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April: Overtures due requiring CCB opinion

May: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta.

June 8-12, 2015: The General Assembly meets in Chattanooga

National Partnership NOTE

1 view

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James Kessler
<JKessler@npc-dublin.org>

unread,

Dec 30, 2014, 8:51:25 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

Next up: let's get committee vacancies filled! Check the "Action Items" below.

1. **Additions** (160 elders in 58 presbyteries)

TE Irwyn Ince (Chesapeake)

TE Bryce Hales (Northern California)

2. **News**

Below is a note from David Richter, Church Planter for Christ The King in Somerville, MA (Boston). Please pray for the Richters as they plant!

Dear Brothers,

James was gracious enough to let me write a quick note to all of you regarding a particular need that my church plant will be facing in the New Year. My wife Kelly and I moved to Boston almost two years ago now with our family to plant a church in Somerville, MA (an inner ring city right in the heart of Metro-Boston), with the Christ the King Church Planting Network. Since that time, the Lord has been very gracious to us. We have seen a number of conversions. We have seen sleepy Christians in our community awoken to the transforming power of the gospel of grace. Moreover, we have seen our core group grow to the extent that we were able to launch weekly public services on September 7th.

I can't tell you how exciting and thankful we are for all of this! The need here is enormous. As many of you know, New England is currently the most un-churched region in the country, with only 2.5% of our population claiming to be evangelical Christian. Therefore, it is a great honor to be given the gift of serving the Lord in this area of the country.

Yet, as you can imagine, ministry in Boston is not cheap. We were able to initially raise a lot of money to move onto the field and sustain us for the first couple of years. But just recently we received word from MNA that unless things change with our support account, we will not have enough income after the first of the year to continue at our current rate of expenditure. Therefore, I come to you asking for your prayers, brothers. Please pray for the Lord's continued molding of our hearts, the strengthening of our faith, the increased effectiveness of our ministry, and for His abundant provision for our needs.

Moreover, if you know of anyone, or of any church, that might be interested and/or willing to support our church plant, please let me know - davidr...@ctksomerville.org.

Here is the link to our website (www.ctksomerville.org) and our MNA support page (<https://www.egsnetwork.com/gift2/?giftid=44257F0B6C6942A>).

Please don't hesitate to contact me if you have any questions or if you would like to hear more about what the Lord has been doing here in Boston.

Grace & Peace,

David Richter

3. Action items:

We've mentioned the value of participation in the Review of Presbytery Records committee and the Nominating Committee as two key ways you can do your part to preserve the health of our denomination. Participation in the NP means, at a minimum, that you will be involved in helping to fill committee spots from your presbytery. Huge thanks to Joel St. Clair for putting together the list of vaEither volunteer yourself for open slots on RPR and the Nominating Committee (The NC recommends members for the permanent committees and the SJC to the floor of the General Assembly) or find a friend in your presbytery to volunteer. Your Spring meeting is the likely point for nominations to these committees.

Here are the NP presbyteries with openings for Review of Presbytery records:

Central Indiana - RE

Chicago Metro - TE

Eastern Canada - RE

Eastern Carolina - TE

Eastern Pennsylvania - RE

Grace - RE

Houston Metro - RE

Metro New York – RE

Missouri – TE

Nashville – RE

Northern Illinois – RE

Pacific Northwest – RE

Philadelphia Metro West – TE

Platte Valley – TE

Providence – RE

Savannah River – TE

South Coast – TE

Southern New England – TE

Western Canada – TE

Western Carolina – RE

Westminster – RE

Here are the NP presbyteries with openings for Nominating Committee: (This is my last year on this committee. The votes on this committee were very close last year, and I believe that nearly every candidate we passed through committee were excellent representations of the health of the PCA. There were also many vacancies on the NC. Please consider this critical denominational work)

Central Florida – TE

Chicago Metro – RE

Eastern Canada - TE

Eastern Carolina – RE

Eastern Pennsylvania – TE

Grace – TE

Houston Metro – TE

Metro New York – TE

Missouri – RE

Northern Illinois – TE

Pacific Northwest – TE

Philadelphia Metro West – RE

Platte Valley – RE

Providence – TE

Savannah River – RE

South Coast – RE

South Florida – RE

South Texas – TE

Southern New England – RE

Sun coast - RE

Western Canada – RE

Western Carolina – TE

Westminster – TE

4. Calendar:

Fall/Winter: Overtures from previous GA up for vote at the presbytery level. GA seminars are scheduled and openings filled.

March 21: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April: Overtures due requiring CCB opinion

May: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta.

June 8-12, 2015: The General Assembly meets in Chattanooga

2015

Partnership NOTE

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Feb 6, 2015, 6:35:26 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

Time to go to work. Let's get committee vacancies filled! Check the "Action Items" below.

1. **Additions** (160 elders in 58 presbyteries)

2. **News**

There are a few ministry openings in the PCA that are geared toward a 2nd or 3rd pastor - equipper, evangelist, staff work, etc. These churches are all healthy and strategic in our denomination. Please feel free to contact me if you would like me to put you in touch.

3. **Action items:**

Denomination Work: you are needed!

PERMANENT COMMITTEES:

We've mentioned the value of participation in the Review of Presbytery Records committee and the Nominating Committee as two key ways you can do your part to preserve the health of our denomination. Participation in the NP means, at a minimum, that you will be involved in helping to fill committee spots from your presbytery. Either volunteer yourself for open slots on RPR and the Nominating Committee (The NC recommends members for the permanent committees and the SJC to the floor of the General Assembly) or find a friend in your presbytery to volunteer. Your Winter meeting is the likely point for nominations to these committees.

Here are the NP presbyteries with openings for Review of Presbytery records: **Please help me update your presbytery openings if they are no longer vacant**

Central Indiana - RE

Chicago Metro - TE
Eastern Canada - RE
Eastern Carolina - TE
Eastern Pennsylvania - RE
Grace - RE
Houston Metro - RE
Metro New York – RE
Nashville – RE
Northern Illinois – RE
Pacific Northwest – RE
Philadelphia Metro West – TE
Platte Valley – TE
Providence – RE
Savannah River – TE
South Coast – TE
Southern New England – TE
Western Canada – TE
Western Carolina – RE
Westminster – RE

Partnership men serving on this committee: Dave Schutter (Ohio), Tim LeCroy (Missouri), Todd Gwennap (Eastern Carolina) - **Let me know if you are serving on RPR**

Here are the NP presbyteries with openings for Nominating Committee: (This is my last year on this committee. The votes on this committee were very close last year, and I believe that nearly every candidate we passed through committee were excellent representations of the health of the PCA. There were also many vacancies on the NC. Please consider this critical denominational work)

Central Florida – TE
Chicago Metro – RE
Eastern Canada - TE
Eastern Carolina – RE
Eastern Pennsylvania – TE
Grace – TE
Houston Metro – TE
Metro New York – TE
Northern Illinois – TE
Pacific Northwest – TE
Philadelphia Metro West – RE
Platte Valley – RE
Providence – TE
Savannah River – RE
South Coast – RE
South Florida – RE
South Texas – TE
Southern New England – RE
Sun coast - RE
Western Canada – RE
Western Carolina – TE
Westminster – TE

Partnership men on this committee: Joel St. Clair (Potomac), James Kessler (Ohio), John Pennylegion (Missouri), Mike Khandjian (Chesapeake)

GA COMMITTEE OF COMMISSIONERS:

The CoC is the group of presbyters that meet during the first days of General Assembly to review the work of the permanent committees and, in the case of the Overtures Committee, make recommendations for the business passed to the assemblies through her presbyteries. The primary way we influence the disposition of our denomination is through work like this. If you're a part of the National Partnership we expect that you're ready to do your duty so please ask your presbyteries to place you on these committees. In the order of influence on the work of the assembly: Overtures Committee, Administrative Committee, Interchurch Relations. Overtures, in particular, acts as a sort of "Senate" for the assembly. Each presbytery sends both a RE and TE and the work of this committee cannot be amended from the floor of the assembly. We need good men to serve in these places if the majority in our denomination intends to steer the ship. If those positions are filled I would encourage you to volunteer anywhere you can.

Please let me know if you are on a CoC, Nominating Committee, or Review of Presbytery Records so we can keep our rosters current

4. Calendar:

Fall/Winter: Overtures from previous GA up for vote at the presbytery level. GA seminars are scheduled.

March 21: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April: Overtures due requiring CCB opinion

May: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. We will begin interacting on the website regarding overtures coming to the assembly.

June 8-12, 2015: The General Assembly meets in Chattanooga

Partnership NOTE

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Feb 17, 2015, 6:36:10 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

So far we are counting four NP men on the Overtures committee, which is extremely low. Please check with your presbytery clerk and try to fill those open spaces. The OC functions as a sort of Senate in our new rules, meaning that any amending/perfecting of overtures from presbyteries takes place in that meeting. The OC also functions as a sort of gateway for overtures that should not see the floor of the Assembly. This is a vital way to serve our denomination. Help us fill spots on the OC, Nom Com, RPR as first priorities.

1. Additions (162 in 58 presbyteries)

TE John Bourgeois (Piedmont Triad)

TE Rodney Barton (Westminster)

2. News

We've opened discussion on the website (<http://thenationalpartnership.com>) regarding this year's first two Overtures of substance: Overture 2, North Texas (study committee on Sabbath) and Overture 3, Gulf Coast (changes to baptism charge)

3. Action items:

Denomination Work: you are needed!

PERMANENT COMMITTEES:

We've mentioned the value of participation in the Review of Presbytery Records committee and the Nominating Committee as two key ways you can do your part to preserve the health of our denomination. Participation in the NP means, at a minimum, that you will be involved in helping to fill committee spots from your presbytery. Either volunteer yourself for open slots on RPR and the Nominating Committee (The NC recommends members for the permanent committees and the SJC to the floor of the General Assembly) or find a friend in your presbytery to volunteer. Your Winter meeting is the likely point for nominations to these committees.

Here are the NP presbyteries with openings for Review of Presbytery records: **Please help me update your presbytery openings if they are no longer vacant**

Central Indiana - RE

Eastern Canada - RE

Eastern Pennsylvania - RE

Grace - RE

Houston Metro - RE

Metro New York – RE

Nashville – RE

Northern Illinois – RE

Pacific Northwest – RE

Philadelphia Metro West – TE

Platte Valley – TE

Providence – RE

Savannah River – TE

South Coast – TE

Southern New England – TE

Western Canada – TE

Western Carolina – RE

Westminster – RE

Partnership men serving on RPR: Dave Schutter (Ohio), Tim LeCroy (Missouri), Todd Gwennap (Eastern Carolina), Bobby Griffith (North Texas), Dan Adamson (Chicago Metro)

Here are the NP presbyteries with openings for Nominating Committee: (This is my last year on this committee. The votes on this committee were very close last year, and I believe that nearly every candidate we passed through committee were excellent representations of the health of the PCA. There were also many vacancies on the NC. Please consider this critical denominational work)

Chicago Metro – RE
Eastern Canada - TE
Eastern Carolina – RE
Eastern Pennsylvania – TE
Grace – TE
Houston Metro – TE
Metro New York – TE
Northern Illinois – TE
Pacific Northwest – TE
Philadelphia Metro West – RE
Platte Valley – RE
Providence – TE
Savannah River – RE
South Coast – RE
South Florida – RE
Southern New England – RE
Sun coast - RE
Western Carolina – TE

Partnership men on Nominating committee: Joel St. Clair (Potomac), James Kessler (Ohio), John Pennylegion (Missouri), Mike Khandjian (Chesapeake), Jeff Kerr (Western Canada), Jack Howell (Tidewater), Michael Novak (South Texas), Brandon Lauranzon (Central Florida), Andy Moehn (Westminster), Brian Deringer (Piedmont Triad)

GA COMMITTEE OF COMMISSIONERS:

The CoC is the group of presbyters that meet during the first days of General Assembly to review the work of the permanent committees and, in the case of the Overtures Committee, make recommendations for the business passed to the assemblies through her presbyteries. The primary way we influence the disposition of our denomination is through work like this. If you're a part of the National Partnership we expect that you're ready to do your duty so please ask your presbyteries to place you on these committees. In the order of influence on the work of the assembly: Overtures Committee, Administrative Committee, Interchurch Relations. Overtures, in particular, acts as a sort of "Senate" for the assembly. Each presbytery sends both a RE and TE and the work of this committee cannot be amended from the floor of the assembly. We need good men to serve in these places if the majority in our denomination intends to steer the ship.

If those positions are filled I would encourage you to volunteer anywhere you can.

Partnership men on the Overtures Committee

David Richter (Southern New England), Sean Roberts (Northern New England), Geoff Ziegler (Chicago Metro), Bent Stutzman (Chicago Metro)

Please let me know if you are on a CoC, Nominating Committee, or Review of Presbytery Records so we can keep our rosters current

MNA – Doug Tharp (Rocky Mountain)

MTW – Nick Protos (Ascension)

4. Calendar:

Fall/Winter: Overtures from previous GA up for vote at the presbytery level. GA seminars are scheduled.

March 21: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta to staff denominational permanent and special committees.

April: Overtures due requiring CCB opinion

May: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. We will begin interacting on the website regarding overtures coming to the assembly.

June 8-12, 2015: The General Assembly meets in Chattanooga

National Partnership NOTE

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Apr 8, 2015, 5:38:24 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

So far we are counting 11 NP men on the Overtures committee, which is low. Please check with your presbytery clerk and try to fill those open spaces. The OC functions as a sort of Senate in our new rules, meaning that any amending/perfecting of overtures from presbyteries takes place in that meeting. The OC also functions as a sort of gateway for overtures that should not see the floor of the Assembly. This is a vital way to serve our denomination. Help us fill spots on the OC and RPR as first priorities.

1. Additions (163 in 58 presbyteries)

TE JonPaul Watson (Eastern Carolina)

2. News

-Overture 7, which requires officers to testify in church court proceedings, was rejected by Potomac Presbytery but submitted to the General Assembly from the session where it was first crafted (David Coffin's church, Hope PCA in Fairfax VA). Historically our polity has provided a protection for the accused to decline testimony in a case. While some are concerned that continuing to allow this right encourages dishonesty in matters as serious as constitutional subscription others are concerned that compelling testimony could submit some to repeated calls to clarify their positions – in effect re-examining a man repeatedly without cause. I've opened discussion on this overture on the site: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-7/> and have provided the rationale presented at Potomac's meeting to defeat the overture. The rationale in favor of the Overture is of course included in the language itself.

-We've opened discussion on the website (<http://thenationalpartnership.com>) regarding this year's first three Overtures of substance: Overture 2, North Texas (study committee on Sabbath) and Overture 3, Gulf Coast (changes to baptism charge) and Overture 7, Hope PCA Fairfax, VA (compel officer testimony)

-Willow Creek Church (Pastor Kevin Labby, NP member) is looking for a Worship/Music Director. Here's a link to the position: http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/02/DirofMusic_WillowCreekWinterSpringsFL.pdf

3. Action items:

Denomination Work: you are needed!

PERMANENT COMMITTEES:

We've mentioned the value of participation in the Review of Presbytery Records committee and the Nominating Committee as two key ways you can do your part to preserve the health of our denomination. Participation in the NP means, at a minimum, that you will be involved in helping to fill committee spots from your presbytery. Either volunteer yourself for open slots on RPR and the Nominating Committee (The NC recommends members for the permanent committees and the SJC to the floor of the General Assembly) or find a friend in your presbytery to volunteer. Your Winter meeting is the likely point for nominations to these committees.

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Eastern Pennsylvania - RE

Grace - RE

Houston Metro - RE

Metro New York – RE

Nashville – RE

Northern Illinois – RE

Pacific Northwest – RE

Philadelphia Metro West – TE

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Providence – RE

Savannah River – TE

South Coast – TE

Southern New England – TE

Western Canada – TE

Western Carolina – RE

Westminster – RE

Partnership men serving on RPR: Dave Schutter (Ohio), Tim LeCroy (Missouri), Todd Gwennap (Eastern Carolina), Bobby Griffith (North Texas), Dan Adamson (Chicago Metro), Tim Weldon (Gulfstream), Dan Herron (Central Indiana)

GA COMMITTEE OF COMMISSIONERS:

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If those positions are filled I would encourage you to volunteer anywhere you can.

Partnership men on the Overtures Committee

David Richter (Southern New England), Sean Roberts (Northern New England), Geoff Ziegler (Chicago Metro), Bent Stutzman (Chicago Metro), Ben Lyon (Tidewater), Jonathan Winfree (Southwest Florida), Andy Moehn (Westminster), Kevin Allen (Rocky Mountain), E.J. Nusbaum (Rocky Mountain), Nate Walker (Pacific Northwest), Walt Nilsson (Potomac)

Please let me know if you are on a CoC, Nominating Committee, or Review of Presbytery Records so we can keep our rosters current

MNA – Doug Tharp (Rocky Mountain)

MTW – Nick Protos (Ascension)

RUM – Walter Henegar (Metro Atlanta)

4. Calendar:

April: Overtures due requiring CCB opinion

May: RPR (Review of Presbytery Records) meets in Atlanta. We will begin interacting on the website regarding overtures coming to the assembly.

June 8-12, 2015: The General Assembly meets in Chattanooga

National Partnership NOTE

4 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

May 19, 2015, 11:34:14 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]
Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

So far we are counting 13 NP men on the Overtures committee, which is low. Please check with your presbytery clerk and try to fill those open spaces. The OC functions as a sort of Senate in our new rules, meaning that any amending/perfecting of overtures from presbyteries takes place in that meeting. The OC also functions as a sort of gateway for overtures that should not see the floor of the Assembly. This is a vital way to serve our denomination. Help us fill spots on the OC and RPR as first priorities.

1. **Additions** (163 in 58 presbyteries)
TE Robbie Schmidtberger (Heritage)

2. News

-Discussion continues on Overture 7 (compelling testimony in cases) on the website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-7/> . E.J. Nusbaum, an SJC member, has responded on the site in favor of the Overture. Please add to the discussion and resource one another. This appears to be the primary issue of discussion at this year's assembly.

-Discussion is open on Overture 9 (Study committee regarding the Sabbath Exception): <http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-9/>

-We've opened discussion on the website (<http://thenationalpartnership.com>) regarding this year's three Overtures of substance: Overture 2, North Texas (study committee on Sabbath) and Overture 3, Gulf Coast (changes to baptism charge) and Overture 7, Hope PCA Fairfax, VA (compel officer testimony) and Overture 9 (Study committee on Sabbath Exception)

-Willow Creek Church (Pastor Kevin Labby, NP member) is looking for a Worship/Music Director. Here's a link to the position: http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/02/DirofMusic_WillowCreekWinterSpringsFL.pdf

3. Action items:

Denomination Work: you are needed!

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Partnership men on the Overtures Committee

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Please let me know if you are on a CoC, Nominating Committee, or Review of Presbytery Records so we can keep our rosters current

Admin - Joel St. Clair (Potomac)

Covenant College – Erik McDaniel (Evangel)

Covenant Sem – Aaron Baker (Chicago Metro)

Discipleship min – Nate Conrad (Chicago Metro)

IRC – Dan Adamson (Chicago Metro), Larry Hoop (Ohio Valley), Jeff Kerr (Eastern Canada)

MNA – Doug Tharp (Rocky Mountain), Michael Langer (Iowa)

MTW – Nick Protos (Ascension)

RUM – Walter Henegar (Metro Atlanta)

4. Calendar:

June 8-12, 2015: The General Assembly meets in Chattanooga

Fwd: resolution

4 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

May 22, 2015, 9:21:06 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Below is a note from TE Sean Lucas about a racial reconciliation resolution that will go through the Overtures Committee this year. I see this as a step in the right direction. Glad to hear your thoughts on it as well.

I will set up a discussion page on the website ASAP. The actual resolution is attached.

JK

I've attached the resolution for you--it is a resolution on racial reconciliation that finally recognizes our covenantal and generational involvement in and complicity with racial injustice during the Civil Rights era. We started working on this a year ago, but pulled back in order to get more feedback from African American pastors and others. After circulating it through key black PCA pastors through RAAN and getting feedback, we decided we need to move forward with this.

I've been emailing Roy Taylor about this in the run-up. He intends to give this to Overtures Committee on Monday and have them work on a response presuming that the Assembly will give a 2/3 vote on Tuesday night to refer it as new business. It will also show up in the OC briefing materials that will be going out to them through Sharefile so that it can be seen in advance as well. So, this will be getting out there.

We are working on a talking point sheet for this resolution. Some of the issues that I've already encountered in sharing this with our session and presbytery (as well as input from Roy and others):

- The spirituality of the church: going back and confessing our sins and failures during this era involves us in political and not religious/theological issues
- Covenantal connection: not everyone in the PCA today was involved in these issues; only involves old PCUS churches, and not all of them; what about the Korean Presbyterians in the PCA--are we confessing for them too?
- Previous statements on this: the RPCES had a statement on this as well as the 1966 PCUS General Assembly; don't those statements cover this already?
- The historical proof: the overture doesn't contain "the historical proof"--how do we know these things are so?
- Outright disagreement: we do not believe that these charges or claims occurred; this is an assumption of "white guilt" that is unnecessary

I'm sure there are other things that will come up, but these are the things that I've encountered already in talking about this with others. Once I write responses, I'll pass it along.

I wanted you to be aware, but I thought it might be good to alert those to whom you are connected that this is coming. I'm passing the word as well to other key folks to whom I'm connected so that this doesn't take people completely by surprise. Let me know your thoughts, questions, or other issues I need to consider as we run up to GA.

Thankful for you and excited for what God is doing in the new plant already. My brother-in-law lives in Westerville; is that close at all to Hillyard?

Best,

Sean

Personal Resolution on Civil Rights Remembrance

Whereas, last year and this year mark significant anniversaries in the Civil Rights movement: 2014 was the sixtieth anniversary of the United States Supreme Court decision *Brown v. Board of Education* and the fiftieth anniversary of the Civil Rights Act and Freedom Summer, and 2015 was the fiftieth anniversary of the Voting Rights Act and the Selma-to-Montgomery March; and

Whereas, many of our conservative Presbyterian churches at the time not only failed to support the Civil Rights movement, but actively worked against racial reconciliation in both church and society; and

Whereas, the 30th General Assembly adopted a resolution on racial reconciliation that confessed its covenantal, generational, heinous sins connected with unbiblical forms of servitude, but failed to deal with the covenantal, generational, heinous sins committed during the much more recent Civil Rights era (cf. Daniel 9:4-11); and

Whereas, the 32nd General Assembly adopted a pastoral letter on “the Gospel and Race” that was produced under the oversight of our Mission to North America committee, but that also failed to acknowledge the lack of solidarity with African Americans which many of our churches displayed during the Civil Rights era; and

Whereas, our denomination’s continued unwillingness to speak truthfully about our failure to seek justice and to love mercy during the Civil Rights era significantly hinders present-day efforts for reconciliation with our African American brothers and sisters; and

Whereas, God has once more given our denomination a gracious providential opportunity to show the beauty, grace and power of the gospel of Jesus Christ by showing Christ-like love and compassion towards the greater African American community;

Be it therefore resolved, that the 43rd General Assembly of the Presbyterian Church in America does recognize and confess our church’s covenantal and generational involvement in and complicity with racial injustice inside and outside of our churches during the Civil Rights period; and

Be it further resolved, that this General Assembly recommit ourselves to the task of truth and reconciliation with our African American brothers and sisters for the glory of God and the furtherance of the Gospel; and

Be it finally resolved, that the General Assembly urges the congregations of the Presbyterian Church in America to confess their own particular sins and failures as may be appropriate and to seek to further truth and reconciliation for the Gospel's sake within their own local communities.

TE Sean M. Lucas

TE J. Ligon Duncan III

Discussion open on Civil Rights Remembrance Resolution

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

May 23, 2015, 6:26:46 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

<http://thenationalpartnership.com/resolution-racial-reconciliation/>

(password: 'rev223')

Quick note

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 4, 2015, 8:04:20 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Expect a multi-part email from me in the next couple of days on this year's General Assembly. The email will cover:

1. 43rd General Assembly issues
2. Overture advice
3. Review of Presbytery Records advice
4. Nominating Committee advice

As I have said before, I will do my best to provide resources for your preparation – including my own perspectives – but I want to emphasize once again that participation in the National Partnership does not imply your conformity to the opinions expressed. What I'm going for is unity – in truth and charity. More soon.

JK

General Assembly NOTE #1: Introduction to the 43rd Assembly

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 6, 2015, 6:51:32 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

I. 43rd Assembly Introduction – primary issues (now)

II. Overtures before the Assembly (Saturday)

III. RPR Report advice (Sunday)

III. The overtures committee review (Wednesday morning)

IV. Nominations to permanent committee (Wednesday evening)

43rd Assembly Introduction:

After a couple of years of relatively peaceful assemblies I think the 43rd assembly will follow the recent pattern: there are a couple of contentious issues but no wide-ranging divisive ones. These are moments where there will be significant debate and about which we need to pray!

Overture 7 would compel testimony in judicial cases. This will be heartily debated. Here's the link to the Partnership discussion thus far: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-7/>

Overtures 2 and 9 will create a study committee to deal with the oft-taken exception to our standards regarding the Sabbath: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/new-blog-1/>

The Review of Presbytery Records will give a majority report (where most citations are reviewed without incident) and four minority reports. Some have provided a rationale for voting in the minority on three of the reports and that summary is posted on the website here: <https://james-kessler.squarespace.com/rpr-minority-reports/>. I would appreciate the help of some who can provide more in-depth analysis, especially those who voted in the minority at the RPR meeting. Please add your understanding of the issues in the comments section. Additionally there will be a fourth minority report I and others in this group would oppose allowing Westminster Presbytery to maintain "pre-fail" standards for ordinands. Essentially that presbytery has created additional standards, like required 6-day 24-hour creation, in order to receive a man for Ordination or transfer. The majority report cited the presbytery for this and there is a minority report contending that the practice is appropriate.

These reports will be hotly debated due to the fact that the Review of Presbytery Records has become the location of surrogate battles over orthodoxy in the PCA. Paedocommunion, suspected federal vision, how confessionalism works, etc., the lines that exist in our denomination show most clearly when RPR meets.

A **Personal Resolution on Civil Rights Remembrance** will work its way through the Overtures Committee. Though I don't suspect it will be hotly contested, there will probably be rhetoric you hear from some corners about the propriety of one generation repenting for another generation's sins, why are we getting bogged down in racial stuff again, etc. More on this later but I am an enthusiastic supporter of this resolution, and any resolution, that recognizes the need for the church to speak more courageously about our past sins in order that we might speak in good faith and hope about both the present and the future. Text of the resolution can be seen here: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/resolution-racial-reconciliation/>

The **Nominating Committee** reports Thursday at 10.15am – it is a fixed item so regardless of how ahead or behind we are the report will take place at that hour. There will be a stiff contest yet again for the SJC nominations (see the RPR report above for the reason why). I will send a separate email on the issue with advice.

Times to make sure you're on the floor. (non pub-hours) You'll get an email alert from me.

Wednesday:

130pm – Review of Presbytery Records. Get yourself back from lunch!

Thursday:

10.15am – Nominating Committee Report.

3.30pm – Overtures Committee Report – there's no telling if we'll be on time for this report or not. I'll update you during the week on the time for this report.

I will email you with any urgent votes or needs for your involvement. Please be sure your email settings are not set on 'digest', which will hold any incoming Partnership emails until the end of the day. You'll miss any urgent communication. I believe the vast majority of you have your settings on 'all emails', which is what we want.

Note on communication

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 6, 2015, 6:54:04 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

I neglected to include the normal disclaimer in the last email but continue keeping these notes confidential, as we have with all communication.

Looking forward to seeing you next week!

JK

Site password

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 6, 2015, 9:43:44 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

rev223

General Assembly NOTE #2: Overtures before the assembly

1 view

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james
<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 8, 2015, 6:04:17 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

The Overtures Committee will meet Monday afternoon until their business is done. They will reconvene Tuesday morning and Wednesday if necessary. For those of you who are unfamiliar with the way the OC works: each presbytery may send 2 commissioners (one RE and one TE). The OC acts as a sort of senate to deal with overtures sent to the assembly. They may amend the overtures before them (overtures *may not* be amended from the floor of the General Assembly) and their report may contain minority opinions. When the Overtures report comes to the floor of the Assembly (**slated for Thursday at 3.30pm**) the majority and potential minority reports are presented then debated. Again, the overtures in these reports may not be amended.

My advice is provided as an additional resource for your preparation but I want to emphasize once again that participation in the National Partnership does not imply your *conformity* to the opinions expressed. I have formed my opinion through the opinions offered on the website, my conversations with polity experts in our denomination and, of course, my own biases! I hope the following is helpful for you. Since we will not be holding up our placards this year (unless there is a problem with the electronic voting) you will have a hard time just following the crowd!

Overtures of note:

#2 (Study Committee regarding Sabbath). Advice: YES. Note the Tennessee Valley Presbytery's opinion paper advocating for this study committee (attached). Further discussion on the website here: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/new-blog-1/>

#3 (Change Baptismal Vow). Advice: NO. As currently written there seems to be no compelling reason to change the wording. I leave open the possibility that the OC may amend the wording enough to make something helpful out of it, but as currently written I don't think we gain anything. <http://thenationalpartnership.com/new-blog/>

#7 (Compel testimony). Advice: NO. This will be the most hotly debated overture. I take TE Scott Seaton's view of the protection we currently enjoy. Please note that fellow partnership member RE EJ Nusbaum (also a member of the SJC) has written an able opinion in favor of the overture. A great discussion online: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/overture-7/>

#9 (Study Committee regarding Sabbath). Advice YES. See advice on #2 above.

Personal Resolution Overture. Advice: YES. This is potentially an encouraging moment of conscience for our denomination. Pray with me that the discussion will be courageously honest and compassionate. <http://thenationalpartnership.com/resolution-racial-reconciliation/>

Recreation on the Sabbath

It is common in exams in TVP for candidates to take exception to WCF chapter 21, section 8 and LC questions 117 and 119 and SC questions 60 and 61. TVP routinely approves these exceptions regarding recreation on the Sabbath without discussion. In fact, taking exception to the Standards' prohibition of recreation on the Sabbath seems to have become the default position of the PCA.

With this reality it seems to us that it is time to consider amending the Standards regarding recreation on the Sabbath. We recognize that this is not a process to be entered into without careful thought and most importantly without clear Scriptural guidance. But it is our belief that it is Scripture itself that needs to be heard. Objecting to recreation on the Sabbath cannot come from merely not liking the prohibition. We recognize that often we must do what we might naturally desire not to do because of our faithfulness to God's Word. At times we must be willing to stand against our culture because of our commitment to Scripture as God's rule of faith and life. Is the prohibition of recreation on the Sabbath to be included in this resistance to the prevailing winds that characterize our culture? We are not convinced that it is. And we base this on what we believe Scripture commands. At the same time we wish to be clear that our proposal is not intended to lessen our appreciation of the Confession and Catechisms but is rather a call for *greater confessional integrity*.

This short paper will seek to address two critical questions: Is the prohibition of recreation on the Sabbath expressly set down in Scripture? Is recreation forbidden on the Sabbath by good and necessary consequence from Scripture? One will recognize that this is the framework given by the WCF for understanding “the whole counsel of God” (WCF chapter 1, section 6: *“The whole counsel of God, concerning all things necessary for his own glory, man’s salvation, faith, and life, is either expressly set down in Scripture, or by good and necessary consequence may be deduced from Scripture: unto which nothing at any time is to added, whether by new revelations of the Spirit, or traditions of men. Nevertheless we acknowledge the inward illumination of the Spirit of God to be necessary for the saving understanding of such things as are revealed in the Word; and that there are some circumstances concerning the worship of God, and government of the Church, common to human actions and societies, which are to be ordered by the light of nature and Christian prudence, according to the general rules of the Word, which are always to be observed”*).

It is our belief that the case for or against recreation on the Sabbath must be made from Scripture. For that reason we do not enter into the historical situation that gave rise to the Assembly dealing with this specific matter. We are aware of the historical context of the Westminster Assembly and the positive influence of Nicolas Bownd’s 1595 treatise on the Sabbath and the negative influence of King James’ Book of Sports issued in 1617 and 1633. However informative this history may be in demonstrating the cultural influences on the Westminster Assembly, the final appeal must be to God’s Word which the Assembly believed they were interpreting correctly.

While considering whether Scripture forbids recreation on the Sabbath it is necessary to remember the positive nature of the fourth commandment. In Mt. 22.36-40 Christ summarized the first table of the Law with the words “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, and with all your soul, and with all your mind” (see also LC question 102). As we approach the fourth commandment we are being given instruction as to how we are to demonstrate our love to God as we keep the Sabbath.

First – is recreation on the Sabbath forbidden by divine command? The Sabbath command in Ex. 20.8-11 and Dt. 5.12-15 begins with the instruction to remember the Sabbath day, to keep it holy. This opening sentence gives the general instruction that

God's people are to celebrate and call to memory the seventh day that it may be separated and set apart to God. A major difference in the Sabbath day from the other six days is the restriction on work on the Sabbath. In the use of *'ā bad* (to labor) and *mēlā 'ka* (occupation, work), the commandment has in view what the Confession phrases as worldly employments. *'ā bad* is the term used in Gen. 2.5,15; 3.23; 4.2,12 to speak of tilling the ground and in Ex. 5.18 to do the work of making bricks. These examples are consistent with the use of *'ā bad* throughout the Old Testament, and it is plain that the word is limited to work in the sense of physical labor. The use of *mēlā 'ka* falls into the same category as can be seen from its use in passages such as Gen. 2.2; Jer. 18.3; and Jonah 1.8. Based on the terms used in the fourth commandment it is labor not activities in general, that is prohibited on the Sabbath.

But what about Isaiah 58.13 which the Standards use as a proof text to forbid recreation: "If you turn back your foot from the Sabbath, from doing your pleasure on my holy day, and call the Sabbath a delight and the holy day of the Lord honorable; if you honor it, not going your own ways, or seeking your own pleasure or talking idly" (ESV)? Does this not clearly forbid any form of recreation on the Sabbath? The context of the chapter is God's critique of formalism in Israel's worship with specific focus on fasting and Sabbath keeping. Both fasting and Sabbath are to be a "delight" or "pleasure" (the Hebrew reading, *hē peš*). It must be emphasized that *hē peš* is not referring to fun and games but to the things that we take pleasure in or are a delight to us. We see this usage in passages such as Is. 54.12 (*walls of precious stone*); Mal. 3.12 (*all the nations will call you blessed for you will be a land of delight*); Job 31.12 (*if I have withheld anything that the poor desired*); Is. 44.28 (*I am the Lord Who says of Cyrus, he is my shepherd and he shall fulfill all my purpose*); Is. 53.10 (*the will of the Lord shall prosper in his hand*); Prov. 31.13 (*she seeks wool and flax and works with willing hands*); Eccl. 3.17 (*God will judge the righteous and the wicked, for He has appointed a time for every matter and every work*); Is. 58.3 (*behold, in the day of your fast you seek your own pleasure, and oppress all your workers*). It is apparent from the wide range of usage that the meaning of *hē peš* cannot be limited to recreation and there is good reason to question whether this is the correct understanding of the term in Is. 58.13. This is particularly true in light of its use in Is. 58.3 which points to a meaning

associated with work not recreation. Given the semantic range of *ḥē peš*, its usage in passages such as Prov. 31.13, Eccl. 3.17 and its context in Is. 58, it is likely that the idea of “pursuing one’s business” would make more sense in Is. 58.13. In summary, from the words used in the Sabbath command and in Is. 58 we are not convinced that recreation is forbidden by divine command.

Second - Is recreation on the Sabbath forbidden by good and necessary consequence? Is. 58.13 states that God will bless those who turn back from doing their pleasure, their delight, their will on the Sabbath. Obviously that does not include the pleasure of worship and serving God. It does at least mean that the Sabbath is not a day to do with as we please. Does that preclude recreation? To consider this question it is helpful to think about the purpose of the Sabbath as a gift of God – a sign of His goodness. Jesus taught in Mk. 2.27 that the Sabbath is for our benefit and as such is a sign of God’s grace. The reaction of the Pharisees here is quite instructive. They “*watched Jesus, to see whether He would heal him (a man with a withered hand) on the Sabbath, so that they might accuse Him*” (Mk. 3.2). The Pharisees interpreted the Sabbath in terms of Law and had lost sight of the Sabbath as a sign of God’s grace. Jesus’ anger at them (Mk. 3.5) is understandable. This helps us understand the Sabbath command – God is interested in a proper heart attitude over against a mere external obedience. In this light Is. 58.13, while consistent with the fourth commandment, carries us further along so that it is not only a matter of refraining from our work on the Sabbath but also not viewing the day as a “free” day in which we may pursue our “pleasures” – whatever those pleasures may be. This understanding is undoubtedly behind the Standards’ prohibition of recreation. But we believe that it prohibits too much. What is condemned is recreation or any other thing occupying the focus of the day. We can and must say that the Sabbath is not to be devoted to recreation, but that is a far different statement than saying that all recreation is to be prohibited. Is. 58.13 is a control on our Sabbath observance reminding us that we are to devote the day to the worship and enjoyment of our Creator and Redeemer not our own pursuits.

How do we properly worship and enjoy God on the Sabbath? We follow the example that God set forth on the seventh day of creation as Ex. 20.11 instructs us – God rested. We know that God did not rest because He was physically tired. This directs us away from seeing the Sabbath as being intended solely for the purpose of providing a time of

physical rest, although since God knows how we are made (Ps. 103.14), this purpose certainly is included. But the significance of God's rest on the seventh day can be better understood from Ex. 31.17 – “on the seventh day He rested and was *refreshed*.” In Ex. 23.12 we read: “Six days you shall do your work, but on the seventh day you shall rest; that your ox and your donkey may have rest, and the son of your servant woman, and the alien, may be *refreshed*. The Hebrew root for *refresh* is *nā paš*, the common term for breath or to breathe. The idea of its use in the Sabbath command is that God finished His creation work and then took a breath. Surely it was not to “catch His breath.” Most likely the idea is that on the seventh day God ceased from His work of creation and was then able to look at, contemplate, and enjoy His creative activity. To follow this pattern means that on one day of the week we can rest and be refreshed in body and soul because God is the Creator. We can rest from our fear and concern for our needs because it is God, our Creator, who will sustain us and supply what we need. We see this at work in the wilderness wanderings when God commanded that no manna be collected on the Sabbath as He would supply enough on the sixth day (Ex. 16.22f). We also see this in the command that the land be given a Sabbath rest with no reaping or gathering every seventh year (Lev. 25.1-7). How could God command such a radical agricultural policy? What answer was there for those who asked “what shall we eat in the seventh year if we may not sow or gather in our crops?” (Lev. 25.20) God replies: “I will command my blessing on you in the sixth year, so that it will produce a crop sufficient for three years” (Lev. 25.21). God promises this as the Creator and Sustainer of life. Relating this to Ex. 20.10, we can rest and be refreshed on the Sabbath because God is our Creator and Sustainer. We do not need to fear for our own needs when God commands that we labor only six days of the week. Instead we can give worship to God who supplies our needs and breathe – be refreshed. Does this allow for recreation? We believe that it does as part of our refreshment on the Sabbath.

The Sabbath command is to be understood not only in light of creation but also in light of God's redemption of His people (Dt. 5.15). Here we are to observe the Sabbath with reference to God as our Redeemer. God brought His people out of bondage in Egypt into the rest of the promised land which foreshadowed the Sabbath rest (Heb. 4). As is the case in acknowledging God as Creator, keeping the Sabbath in light of God as Redeemer is an exercise of faith. The Sabbath is to be a time set aside in which God is

worshipped as Redeemer; it is to be a time of resting in His redemptive work. The cares and concerns of this world hold no terror for us. We do not have to spend seven days laboring to insure our existence and safety. We look to God's redemptive work in which He secures life for us. Since God takes this responsibility upon Himself we are called to rest in Him, delight in Him, and joyfully and freely give worship to Him. Can this include recreation? Recreation as an exercise in freedom certainly seems appropriate to the Sabbath day.

Our conclusion is that Scripture does not either expressly prohibit recreation on the Sabbath nor does it forbid it by good and necessary consequence. But we trust that in saying this we have made clear that we do not believe that the Sabbath is a time for doing as we please. Any activity on the Sabbath must be examined as to its consistency with the Sabbath as a sign of response to God as our Creator and Redeemer. Recreation is not always a good thing for it can be abused and misused as can all God's good gifts. We recognize that far too often recreation is pursued as an end in itself. Jacques Ellul's insightful quote is to the point: "Obviously the Christian does not understand the holy day if on it he prefers to head for the beach or the ski slopes. It is not just that he has been badly taught or does not need rest. But he will not take up his freedom. He is not acting like a man who is freed in Christ. Nor has he discovered that prayer and worship in fact refresh him far more effectively than eight hours of play" (*The Ethics of Freedom*, p. 130). There can also be a problem with recreation that does not lend itself to enjoyment of God or fellowship with other Christians. A Sunday "couch potato" watching sports all day would be a case in point. If a given recreational activity distorts or detracts from the significance of the day which God in His goodness has given us, then that type of recreation should be stopped. But that is far different from prohibiting all recreation on the Sabbath. From our study of Scripture we humbly believe that the Westminster fathers got this wrong and we propose that all references to the forbidding of recreation on the Sabbath in the Standards be stricken.

General Assembly

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 8, 2015, 11:22:52 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

We are live. Happy Assembly everyone.

General Assembly NOTE #3: important schedule notes and RPR advice

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 9, 2015, 10:07:43 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Tuesday Schedule notes:

1. The opening worship service: Outgoing moderator Bryan Chapell preaching.
2. Following the opening worship will be the **opening session of the General Assembly**. RE Jim Wert will be nominated. I am not sure of his opponent. I've heard good things from everyone I've asked about Jim. When you're not sure of a man's moderating skill, temperament is all you've got to go on. I plan to vote for Jim.

3. Following the election of the moderator we have what will be the most important business of the assembly: TE Sean Lucas and TE Ligon Duncan will be presenting their **resolution on racial reconciliation** (Link:). The resolution will be read and then requires a 2/3 majority to send the resolution to the Overtures Committee for them to deal with Wednesday morning. Please be sure to be present tonight and vote (even if you must be late to an after session party). There *will* be opposition, unfortunately in my opinion, to this overture. Pray and vote.

BACKGROUND AND ADVICE ON RPR REPORT

The RPR report will be given around 1.30pm on Wednesday. I cited this report as one of the primary things you want to engage on the floor of the Assembly. It will most likely follow lunch Wednesday so you'll need to hustle back. I will send an email when the time of the report is fairly certain.

RPR will present both a majority report (the report passed by their committee during their meeting in May) and FOUR minority reports. Here are the basic facts related to the minority reports:

Eastern Pennsylvania - By a vote of 26-22, the RPR committee adopted a recommendation to judge, as Unsatisfactory, Eastern PA's 2014 updated response to an exception of substance citation relating to an exam from November 2011 where Presbytery sustained an ordination exam in which the candidate stated a difference with Larger Catechism 177 on the admissibility of covenant children to the Lord's Supper. The Minority intends to recommend the GA judge Eastern PA's updated response as Satisfactory. There are 20 signers of this MR and RE Howie Donahoe will present it.

Susquehanna Valley - By a vote of 29-22, the RPR committee adopted a recommendation to cite Susquehanna with an exception of substance for sustaining a BCO 13-6 transfer exam of a PCA minister who expressed a difference with Larger Catechism 177 and his view, but not practice, on the admissibility of covenant children to the Lord's Supper (TE Sam Andreades, transferring in from Metro NY in Jan 2014). There are 18 signers of this MR and RE Howie Donahoe will present it.

Philadelphia - By a vote of 26-25, the RPR committee adopted a recommendation to cite Philadelphia with an exception of substance for sustaining a Feb 2014 ordination exam in which a candidate (Chris Currie) stated he was not 100% sure the New Testament "itself teaches a universal prohibition of women eldership." The Minority intends to recommend the GA not cite Philadelphia with an exception of substance for their judgment on this matter. There are 13 signers on this MR and TE Tim Lecroy will present it.

Westminster - will be presented by RE Flynt Jones from Central Carolina (session clerk at Christ Covenant). The RPR committee (in the majority report) adopted a recommendation to cite Westminster Presbytery with an exception of substance for adopting a policy prohibiting anyone, even a candidate, from even being examined by Westminster Presbytery, unless they hold a particular views about Adam and creation – including 6 day, 24-hour creation.

Advice:

I intend to vote to sustain the Eastern Pennsylvania and Susquehanna Valley minority reports. Eastern Pennsylvania and Susquehanna Valley are of the same type: these are citations for ministers who have a stated view in conflict with LC 177 (the admissibility of covenant children to the Lord's Supper). They have a view, *but not practice*, of Paedocommunion. While the vast majority in the PCA do not share a Paedocommunion view we have allowed, as a matter of common practice, men to have the view but not to

practice such. Additionally there is a method for dealing with an Elder who spreads heretical views – the man should be charged with an offense rather than being cited through the review process. Using RPR for this process is an error of category confusion. You can hammer a nail with a hand grenade, but I wouldn't recommend it.

I intend to vote to sustain the Philadelphia minority report. This one is a little more of a nuanced issue. I believe this issue arose out of a fiercely divided discussion both at the presbytery and committee level. It sounds terrifying: a man denies the NT teaching on the ordination of women?! But I feel confident that is not in fact what happened. Everything I've heard and read tells me that this is the case of an ordinand not speaking the language of his presbytery. For a man to talk about "100% certainty" is in some cases a matter of temperament: some people are more comfortable with generalities and others are painfully specific. Rather than a doctrinal difference I believe this was a philosophical and epistemological one (can we say 100% about any issue where further scholarship and the work of the spirit may affect our interpretive grid?). I don't think this is a high-stakes issue. While I will support the minority report I do not believe there will be significant damage either way.

I will vote against the Westminster minority report. I am concerned about any presbytery adding a "pre-fail" super-confessional view for potential ordinands. Confessionalism cuts both ways: it both maintains on our historic doctrinal standards and protects us against endless exclusionary inventions.

Voting TONIGHT

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 9, 2015, 8:15:46 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers, please be in the hall in the next few minutes as we elect a moderator but more importantly we will vote on the issue of whether or not we will refer the racial reconciliation resolution to the overtures committee so we can vote on it. This requires a 2/3 majority. Be there.

OC debating Racial Injustice Resolution

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 10, 2015, 7:07:34 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

If you're interested in watching the debate on overture you may sit in Ballroom J as a guest. It is about to begin.

JK

RPR.

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 10, 2015, 11:52:28 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Best bet is RPR will be happening at 1.30. Please cut lunches short to be there.
JK

Microphone 6

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 9, 2015, 8:19:29 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Is where I'm seated if you have questions.
JK



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 10, 2015, 12:27:16 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

If you have any questions you can find me sitting near microphone 6. I'm glad to help.

RPR

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 10, 2015, 2:36:37 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Sorry for the delay, the report is starting now.

RPR starting now!

2 views

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jon
<jon@covcommunity.org>

unread,

Jun 10, 2015, 2:40:26 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

We're doing RPR right now!

Sent from my iPhone



Deringer, Brian
<brian.deringer@mtw.org>

unread,

Jun 10, 2015, 3:22:19 PM

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to jon, TheNP@googlegroups.com

Some are stuck in overtures

Sent from my iPhone

> On Jun 10, 2015, at 3:40 PM, Jon Price <j...@covcommunity.org> wrote:

>

> We're doing RPR right now!

>

> Sent from my iPhone

>

> --

> You received this message because you are subscribed to the Google Groups "The National

Partnership" group.

> To unsubscribe from this group and stop receiving emails from it, send an email to TheNP+un...@googlegroups.com.

> To post to this group, send email to Th...@googlegroups.com.

> For more options, visit <https://groups.google.com/d/optout>.



Dan Herron

<dan@hopebtown.org>

unread,

Jun 10, 2015, 3:35:04 PM

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to brian.deringer@mtw.org, jon, TheNP@googlegroups.com

NomCom is supposed to meet at 4:30, I emailed Angela and told her that many are still in RPR

From the iPhone of...

Rev. Dan Herron

Assembly starts tomorrow morning at 9.30am

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 10, 2015, 9:09:56 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

The RPR report continues tomorrow with two more minority reports. You'll want to be there for that session. Tomorrow morning: a review of Overtures and Nominations.

JK

NOMINATIONS RECOMMENDATION

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 11, 2015, 9:04:36 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

brothers,

Please note the following recommendations as advice - if you are looking for it:

SJC:

TE Evans

TE Meyerhoff

TE Burroughs

TE Hoop (for Gunn)

RE Donahoe

RE Duncan

RE Jones

CCB:

TE Anderson

TE Sloan

Others are as the committee recommended, declining floor nominees

Come to the Assembly

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 11, 2015, 9:15:25 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

We are continuing the RPR report and are about to discuss nominations. This is critical stuff. Please join us. Small group right now.

JK

Overtures

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 11, 2015, 2:49:50 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Come to the assembly for the overtures voting please.
JK

Business tonight

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 11, 2015, 5:06:03 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Business continues with the overtures committee and a motion to recommit the civil rights overture

General Assembly: FINAL NOTE

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

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Jun 12, 2015, 9:01:33 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Work done: (we were of course not unanimous in our opinions here – I am speaking from my perspective)

1. Reaffirmed the proper role of the RPR by pushing back on alleged “exceptions of substance” in the majority report. Two of the reports we targeted were affirmed. This is a good outcome for the future peace of our denomination. We reaffirmed the bounds of good-faith subscription in the process. Thankful for men that were willing to go to microphones and push: Omar Ortiz and Joel St. Clair, Bruce O’Neil, Tim LeCroy, many others.
2. Defeated an overture that would have opened the door further to unnecessary prosecution of men for alleged doctrinal offenses. It is still my view that gross heresy does not need the testimony of the accused to be discovered. On a 3% margin the overture was defeated.
3. Confirmed some great nominees for permanent committees in the PCA
4. Lodged a protest on the last night of the GA that allowed our men to speak to the issue of racial reconciliation. I was proud of the men that stood in there and spoke boldly, for Bobby Griffith, Kevin Twit, Mike Sloan, and Jon Price for not letting us go before we had a chance to talk as one big denomination about our complicated history.

Work undone:

1. While we were attentive Monday-Wednesday, we fell apart as a group Thursday. There were 350 less voters in the room and those voters were the broad center of the denomination. We lost nearly every significant vote and all of our floor nominees we recommended were defeated. Lots of reasons for this that we’ll address next year.
2. The racial reconciliation overture will require more from the NP this year. After the NP summer sabbatical I will outline the process we will engage to get the right overture to the floor of the GA.

An exhausting week of meetings and fast-walking ended with more than a whimper last night, though to what great end we rang the bell is not yet clear. Please bear with me as I thank our Lord with all of you for the move of the Spirit last night. How do I know it was the work of the Spirit? Because men do not lay down power willingly. They do not tarry in prayer willingly, they do not vote anonymously to extend debate willingly. Jesus will never grow tired of reminding us that he is the head of His church. Thank you to those that could show up last night and did. Thank you Jesus for Jim Baird, patriarch for our beautiful and small denomination, who waved his old arms all over the place and pointed his finger for the sake of calling himself to repentance. Sins of omission burn from the inside out and thank God I had a chance to watch that holy thing happen right in front of my eyes. I thank of so many of you who labored long hours in the OC (specifically David Richter who had an impossible task of pushing for a reconciliation overture that would not frustrate a new and growing African American leadership team) for some way to answer the burden we all carried to address the continuing degradation of our African American brothers and our inability to deal with injustice in a way that honors God. Thank you for making speeches all week, and voting when it was time to vote, and reading all of the emails. There is much more work yet to do.

Thanks again for your hard work and energy on behalf of the Kingdom, and our little corner of it.
JK

2016

Partnership NOTE

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jan 13, 2016, 4:11:45 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

After a long sabbatical following last year's GA, we are ready to dig back in and prepare for Mobile. A couple of reminders as we get started:

- This group exists as a way to resource one another. We want you to feel prepared for the Assembly and engaged in its work on the Presbytery level.
- This group does not tell you *how* to vote. Even if I/we make recommendations please remember that we are grateful for diversity. We are looking for unity, not uniformity.
- Being a part of the National Partnership means that you are committing to participation in the business of our denomination. We will be about the logistics of denominational health; we aren't a visioning committee.
- The NP also creates a place to have a conversation in confidence; nothing here is reproduced and blogged or whatever. Our discussion boards are places to stretch and reason together. Please feel free to use them.

Outlook for Mobile:

I believe this assembly will be primarily concerned with addressing the Overture on Racial Reconciliation. A little history:

-TE Sean Lucas and TE Ligon Duncan co-authored a resolution perfected over several months to last year's GA

-The overtures committee voted unanimously (after very vigorous debate) to table the issue until this year's GA. The debate was, in my opinion, at times discouraging and cynical. Those seeking to pass the overture pressed the issue ably but in the end a coalition of thoughtful Overtures Committee members, in consultation with some of our African American Teaching Elders pushed to table the issue in order to use 2015-2016 as a period of refinement for the overture, discussion and repentance for the denomination.

-There were hundreds who protested the tabling of the overture due to concern that delay on the matter of addressing our culpability as a denomination was harmful to our witness. In an unprecedented period of prayer and confession the Assembly invested Thursday evening in dealing with this issue as a body – while still tabling the amendment. It was a beautiful time.

Following the Assembly a group consisting of TE Sean Lucas and some of our African American brothers worked to further perfect an amendment with concrete action steps. This new version was circulated for feedback then revised and was first passed by the Missouri Presbytery (Overture 4). There is a competing amendment from Heartland Presbytery, overture 1, that seeks more specificity in steps but softens language of the covenant/collective responsibility of today's denomination in the silence of the Presbyterian church during the Civil Rights Movement. Essentially, there is disagreement in the two versions regarding whether or not we can/should publicly repent for the sins of our fathers.

There will be quite a debate at this year's Overtures Committee. Since there will be more than one version of the amendment, discussion will center on a way to combine the two, or find a consensus document. It is my opinion that any consensus efforts will leave us with a weakened version. For those seeking to pass the revised (TE Lucas) version of the amendment can find it here: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/10/Overture-4-Missouri-Confession-Commitment.pdf>

Chesapeake has also passed this version. I think the most effective ways to move this through the Overtures Committee are:

1. Move the amendment without any alterations (avoiding a third option at the OC) if you think you can. This is the strongest move, but requires a unified presbytery.
2. Move an overture to *affirm* overture four (similar to what we did regarding 'preventing child sexual abuse in the church'). This avoids the headache of drafting and parsing language on your presbytery floor. This allows for a more divided presbytery to in effect "draft" an amendment without having to agree on all of the language.

I have opened a discussion section on the website and would love for you all to share your thinking: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/new-blog/2016/1/13/overture-4-from-missouri-presbytery-to-oc-confession-of-sin-and-commitment-to-racial-and-ethnic-diversity>

1. News

- Travel to Mobile is expensive! I would suggest travel to Pensacola then renting a car for the 1-hour drive to Mobile.
- Overture 1 through Heartland Presbytery is an attempt to deal with the Racial Reconciliation overture (Overtures 4, 6) with practical steps *without* accepting culpability for the "sins of our fathers." I think it would benefit all of us to have a robust discussion of the two versions on this website. As I say above, I prefer overture 4/6's understanding of covenantal responsibility. Here is the link to discussion about Overture 1:
- There are already 3 overtures dealing with the operation of judicial commissions, unsurprising given the tense debates over SJC decisions the past couple of years.
- Overture 2 is the latest in a series of helpful corrections to the way judicial process is outlined in our manuals. Here's a link to the page, should you wish to discuss it: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/09/Overture-2-Pacific-NW-OMSJC-18.12.pdf>
- Overture 3 seeks to allow minority reports in judicial decisions: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/11/Overture3ChesapeakeBCO15-3.pdf>
- Overture 5 aims to give the Assembly the right to instruct the SJC in particular cases: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/11/Overture-5-Pittsburgh-BCO-15-5.a-RAO-17-1.pdf>

2. Action items:

- January is probably the month for your presbytery meeting. It may be time to stand for election to committees!
- Begin to familiarize yourself with the two competing forms of the Racial Reconciliation Overture

-Move in your presbyteries to either adopt an identical form of Overture 4 (if you are in favor of this form, as I am) or *affirm* overture 4.

-Join the Overtures Committee. We have several unused seats on this committee every year. Please also note that it is not rude or inappropriate to stand for election to the committee in opposition to a sitting member. Presbyteries simply vote on the person they would like to send. This is the group that will debate the Overtures that come before the assembly, as a sort of senate. Please consider joining this important work.

-Join a permanent committee. Much important work is done on both the Nominating Committee and Review of Presbytery Records (I hope to join RPR this year and have served 3 years on the NC). Note on permanent committee participation below.

PERMANENT COMMITTEES:

We've mentioned the value of participation in the Review of Presbytery Records committee and the Nominating Committee as two key ways you can do your part to preserve the health of our denomination. Participation in the NP means, at a minimum, that you will be involved in helping to fill committee spots from your presbytery. Either volunteer yourself for open slots on RPR and the Nominating Committee (The NC recommends members for the permanent committees and the SJC to the floor of the General Assembly) or find a friend in your presbytery to volunteer. Your Winter meeting is the likely point for nominations to these committees. The Nominating Committee is a one-day meeting in Atlanta, Saturday April 2nd. Your travel and accommodation (you will likely travel Friday night for this meeting) is reimbursed by the denomination. Review of Presbytery Records meets for a few days during one week in May, your travel and accommodation is reimbursed for this meeting.

3. Calendar:

January-February: Presbytery meetings with elections to permanent and special committees

April 2: The Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta

June 20-24: The Assembly meets in Mobile

Partnership NOTE

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james

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

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Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

There will be no Donald Trump related news in this update.

As we move toward the assembly, please be in prayer for the social media discussion in the weeks leading to the meeting. The discussion on racial reconciliation has been extraordinarily positive, but the disagreements have been sharp, particularly related to “generational sins.” No one likes admitting the sins of the daddies and grandfathers. I am of the opinion that any resolution ignoring covenantal, generational responsibility will be a mistake. This is the primary difference between the overtures to the assembly and will be the subject of continued blogs, etc. So let's pray that we will have the advantage of wisdom in Mobile.

There will be quite a debate at this year's Overtures Committee. For those seeking to pass the revised (TE Lucas) version of the amendment can find it here: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/10/Overture-4-Missouri-Confession-Commitment.pdf>

Chesapeake has also passed this version. I think the most effective ways to move this through the Overtures Committee are:

1. Move the amendment without any alterations (avoiding a third option at the OC) if you think you can. This is the strongest move, but requires a unified presbytery.
2. Move an overture to *affirm* overture four (similar to what we did regarding ‘preventing child sexual abuse in the church’). This avoids the headache of drafting and parsing language on your presbytery floor. This allows for a more divided presbytery to in effect “draft” an amendment without having to agree on all of the language.

I have opened a discussion section on the website and would love for you all to share your

thinking: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/new-blog/2016/1/13/overture-4-from-missouri-presbytery-to-oc-confession-of-sin-and-commitment-to-racial-and-ethnic-diversity>

1. News

-There are 7 Overtures affirming Overture 4, “Confession of Sin and Commitment to Racial and Ethnic Diversity,” and several “near versions” of the overture.

-There are already 3 overtures dealing with the operation of judicial commissions, unsurprising given the tense debates over SJC decisions the past couple of years.

-Overture 5 aims to give the Assembly the right to instruct the SJC in particular cases. This is a reaction to the TE Leithart case in which the CCB maintained its scope to oversee the SJC only on matters of adherence to the committee manual. Basically the CCB makes sure SJC traffic obeys the speed limit and traffic lights, not where the traffic is headed. I'm in favor of keeping it that way, and from what I've heard SJC members and the chairman of the CCB are in favor of maintaining the committee's current scope as well. Here's more from this particular overture: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/11/Overture-5-Pittsburgh-BCO-15-5.a-RAO-17-1.pdf>

2. Action items:

-Please let us know if you are doing committee work at this Assembly. Particularly if you are on the Overtures committee.

-You can register for the Overtures committee up to the day it meets, the Monday of the assembly. Would you consider filling an empty spot in your presbytery? The committee debate will be sharp and particularly important this year.

-Move in your presbyteries to either adopt an identical form of Overture 4 (if you are in favor of this form, as I am) or *affirm* overture 4.

3. Calendar:

April 2: The Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta

May: RPR meets in Atlanta
June 20-24: The Assembly meets in Mobile

Partnership NOTE

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Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

Brothers,

Three weeks out from the assembly and we need to start resourcing one another. There are two ways we will do that:

1. A discussion regarding the main overtures hosted on the Partnership website
2. Regular updates during the assembly with alerts for critical votes and summaries.

There will be quite a debate at this year's Overtures Committee about the Confession of Sin and Commitment to Racial and Ethnic Diversity overture, the revised version of last year's Lucas-Duncan motion. There is a place to discuss the overture, and the alternate forms passed by other presbyteries

here: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/new-blog/2016/1/13/overture-4-from-missouri-presbytery-to-oc-confession-of-sin-and-commitment-to-racial-and-ethnic-diversity>

To further aid you in understanding the differences between these overtures TE Joel St. Clair (Potomac) has compiled the attached chart. It is a very helpful resource for you as you prepare for the floor discussion.

1. News

-There are 20 presbyteries affirming the basic form of Overture 4, "Confession of Sin and Commitment to Racial and Ethnic Diversity," either by an overture of affirmation or by submitting a very "near version" of the overture. There are also several forms that drop important elements like covenantal responsibility (the idea that all of us bear the burden of confession for the sins of churches to whom we are connected through our denomination).

-There are already multiple overtures dealing with the operation of judicial commissions, unsurprising given the tense debates over SJC decisions the past couple of years.

-One of those judicial-case-focused overtures is an attempt to again pass a BCO amendment removing the right against self-incrimination for witnesses in judicial cases; that is, **compelling the testimony of the accused.** This was defeated on the floor of the assembly last year. TE Scott Seaton has given a helpful critique of this proposed

amendment, and I will again vote against its passage this year. <http://theaquilareport.com/the-pca-and-the-right-against-self-incrimination-against-overture-14-at-the-pca-general-assembly/>

-Overture 5 aims to give the Assembly the right to instruct the SJC in particular cases. This is a reaction to the TE Leithart case in which the CCB maintained its scope to oversee the SJC only on matters of adherence to the committee manual. Basically the CCB makes sure SJC traffic obeys the speed limit and traffic lights, not where the traffic is headed. I'm in favor of keeping it that way, and from what I've heard SJC members and the chairman of the CCB are in favor of maintaining the committee's current scope as well. Here's more from this particular overture: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/11/Overture-5-Pittsburgh-BCO-15-5.a-RAO-17-1.pdf>

-In non-Overture news, this from TE Cal Boroughs:

The Administrative Committee is bringing a major recommendation to this GA, a recommendation that was developed by the Cooperative Ministries Committee. **Recommendation 3 is for a study committee on the issue of women serving in the ministry of the church.** Particular attention is to be given to the question of the meaning of ordination, the nature and function of the office of deacon, and "clarification on the ordination or commissioning of deacons/deaconesses."

This is a study that needs to be done. Some of us believe that women should be ordained as deacons. Others of us disagree and believe that the BCO gets it right. Some have developed other creative forms for women serving/assisting in diaconal functions that are more or less ambiguous about our present position.

The Administrative Committee report is docketed for 1:30 PM Thursday afternoon along with other COC and informational reports. For many this is boring and they prefer to be somewhere else. I understand but urge you to not miss this.

If you are on the Administrative Committee of Commissioners be prepared for this recommendation.

You may want to review what the RPCES worked on before Joining and Receiving: <http://www.pcahistory.org/findingsaids/rpces/docsynod/390.html#m>

The final action by a close vote was as follows:

An Affirmation Concerning Biblical "Ordination"

"Ordination" as seen in the New Testament is the solemn setting apart of an individual to represent the Church of Jesus Christ.

In accordance with Scripture the special officers of the church (teaching and ruling elders, and deacons) are set apart to their tasks by means of distinctive, formal "ordination" or "setting apart" ceremonies. Presbyterian, and we believe biblical, church polity understands that ordination ceremonies do not convey special grace nor the ability to be an officer. The Holy Spirit give gifts to believers. When both the body and the individual recognize the Spirit's gifts to and calling of that individual to a special office, that person is "set apart" or "ordained." The ceremony is an acknowledgment of the gifts and calling of the Holy Spirit.

That which essentially distinguishes the ordination of an elder from that of a deacon is neither the form nor the ceremony, but rather the specific task to which the individual is set apart.

An elder is set apart to serve the community by teaching, exhorting, and ruling. He exercises a disciplinary authority. The deacon serves the community as its representative in matters primarily of physical need. The deacon does possess delegated authority to represent the church in deeds of mercy. Such serving authority is not to be confused with the teaching and disciplinary authority of elders. The deacon serves under the direction of the session (elders) and, in the capacity of deacon, disciplines no one.

In this day of general ignorance as to the meaning of "ordination," Reformed Presbyterian elders should be especially careful to educate their congregations as to the nature and meaning of biblical ordination.

ACTION: Synod adopted the affirmation. The report was continued in the afternoon meetings (see below). Synod recessed for lunch. Rev. Robert Hamilton led in prayer.

ROLE OF WOMEN, continued

At 2:20, Dr. Hurley made the following motion on behalf of the majority:

RECOMMENDATION:

That some women, full of the Holy Spirit and with appropriate gifts from him, may be called of God to serve the body of Christ as deacons and that women so gifted and called may be set apart (ordained) to the office of deacons. After the majority position was debated, Mr. Miladin moved the following minority position:

We affirm in the absence of any compelling biblical evidence to support the ordination of women to the special office of deacon, that this office be limited to qualified men. At the same time acknowledging that the Scriptures contain many examples of serving women, and also mention "women" in 1 Timothy 3: 11, suggesting a possible third class of serving people in conjunction with elders and deacons, we affirm the right of a local church to have a separate body or board of women (which may be called deaconesses), auxiliary and subordinate to the deacons, to be compatible with Scripture.

FINAL ACTION:

After lengthy debate and several amendments, the minority position read as follows was adopted at 10:15 p.m. Negative votes were recorded by W. Zumbach and R. Freiwald.

We affirm in the absence of any compelling biblical evidence to support the ordination of women to the special office of deacon, that this office be limited to qualified men. At the same time acknowledging that the Scriptures contain many examples of women who serve, we affirm the right of a local church to have a separate body of unordained women who may be called deaconesses.

If you are interested in discussion Recommendation 3 further we have opened a discussion on the confidential partnership website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com/admin-committee-rec-3-on-women-in-the-office-of-deacon/>

2. Action items:

-Please let us know if you are doing committee work at this Assembly. Particularly if you are on the Overtures committee. Here's what I have thus far:

Overtures:

TE Jonathan Winfree

TE David Richter

TE Doug Tharp

RE E.J. Nusbaum

TE Joshua Reitano

TE Kevin Twit

TE Tim LeCroy

TE Irwyn Ince

TE Kyle Hackmann

TE Dennis Hermerding

TE Mike Sloan

TE Jon Price

TE David Juelfs

Covenant Seminary:

TE James Kessler

MNA:

TE Andy Moehn

-You can register for the Overtures committee up to the day it meets, the Monday of the assembly. Would you consider filling an empty spot in your presbytery? The committee debate will be sharp and particularly important this year.

3. Calendar:

June 20-24: The Assembly meets in Mobile

Overtures Regarding Racial Reconciliation—44th General Assembly—2016

Overview: 41 of 63 Overtures at the 44th GA focus on the subject of Racial Reconciliation. This one-page summary provides categories to compare and contrast the Overtures.

Corporate Response/ Repentance	Specifies Sins	Sin of Racism Ongoing Reality	Connects to Gospel Mission of PCA	Examination Only	Return or Reject
This component expresses corporate ownership over past actions.	Gives a historical structure and specifics in the "Whereas" clauses	Acknowledges the sin of racism continues in the PCA		Does not confess sin but recommends individual and/or organizational examination	Take no action this assembly and return overtures or reject
Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)	Overture 1 (Heartland) Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)	YES [Total 33/41: 80.4%] Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)	Overture 1 (Heartland) Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)	Overture 1 (Heartland) Overture 11 (Calvary) - Overture 34 (Westminster)	Overture 53 (NW Georgia) Overture 60 (session Auburn Rd Church) Overture 50 (N. Florida)
Overture 13 (Providence) -Overture 52 (Lowcountry) Overture 15 (Covenant) Overture 16 (Blue Ridge) Overture 18 (Heritage) Overture 23 (Nashville) Overture 29 (Pittsburgh) Overture 41 (Korean SW OC)***	Overture 13 (Providence) -Overture 52 (Lowcountry) Overture 15 (Covenant) Overture 16 (Blue Ridge) Overture 18 (Heritage) Overture 23 (Nashville) Overture 29 (Pittsburgh) Overture 41 (Korean SW OC)***	Overture 15 (Covenant) Overture 16 (Blue Ridge) Overture 18 (Heritage) Overture 23 (Nashville) Overture 41 (Korean SW OC)*** Overture 43 (Potomac) Overture 48 (Susq Valley) Overture 49 (James River) Overture 55 (MVP) -Overture 56 (Evangel)	Overture 13 (Providence) -Overture 52 (Lowcountry) Overture 15 (Covenant) Overture 16 (Blue Ridge) Overture 18 (Heritage) Overture 23 (Nashville) Overture 41 (Korean SW OC)*** Overture 43 (Potomac) Overture 48 (Susq Valley) Overture 49 (James River) Overture 55 (MVP) -Overture 56 (Evangel)	Overture 11 (Calvary) Overture 13 (Providence) -Overture 52 (Lowcountry) Overture 15 (Covenant) Overture 16 (Blue Ridge) Overture 18 (Heritage) Overture 23 (Nashville) Overture 29 (Pittsburgh) Overture 41 (Korean SW OC)*** Overture 43 (Potomac) Overture 49 (James River) Overture 55 (MVP) -Overture 56 (Evangel)	Overture 13 (Providence) -Overture 52 (Lowcountry) Overture 15 (Covenant) Overture 16 (Blue Ridge) Overture 18 (Heritage) Overture 23 (Nashville) Overture 29 (Pittsburgh) Overture 41 (Korean SW OC)*** Overture 43 (Potomac) Overture 49 (James River) Overture 55 (MVP) -Overture 56 (Evangel)
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*** Korean SW OC is the only minority-majority Presbytery confessing	MAYBE [Total 6/41: 14.6%] Overture 1 (Heartland) - Overture 34 (Westminster) Overture 29 (Pittsburgh) Overture 50 (N. Florida) Overture 59 (Gulf Coast)	YES [Total 33/41: 80.4%] Overture 1 (Heartland) Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)	YES [Total 33/41: 80.4%] Overture 1 (Heartland) Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)	YES [Total 33/41: 80.4%] Overture 1 (Heartland) Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)	YES [Total 33/41: 80.4%] Overture 1 (Heartland) Overture 4 (Missouri) -Overture 6 (Chesapeake) -Overture 8 (Eastern Carolina) -Overture 9 (Tenn Valley) -Overture 10 (Metro NY) -Overture 12 (PNW) -Overture 17 (Metro ATL) -Overture 19 (Chicago Metro) -Overture 27 (Rocky Mountain) -Overture 28 (North Texas) -Overture 30 (Suncoast FL) -Overture 31 (Southern NE) -Overture 33 (New York) -Overture 35 (New Jersey) -Overture 42 (Philadelphia) -Overture 46 (N. Cal) -Overture 47 (Savannah River) -Overture 51 (Platte Valley) -Overture 57 (C. Indiana) -Overture 58 (Piedmont Triad) -Overture 63 (Ohio Valley)
Total 34/41: 82.9%	Total 36/41: 87.8%	Total 33/41: 80.4%	Total 37/41: 90.2%	Total 4/41: 9.8%	Total 2/41: 2.8%

National Partnership: Recommendation 3 from the CMC

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Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'rev223')

With all of the discussion about the Racial Reconciliation Overture there has not been much said about recommendation 3 from the CMC regarding a study committee to investigate the role of women in church ministry, a study committee I strongly support. This morning an article opposing this study committee, was co-written by former moderator Dominic Aquila. It can be found here: <http://theaquilareport.com/pca-general-assembly-should-not-approve-cmcs-recommendation-to-form-a-study-committee-on-women-serving-in-ministry/>

Please join the conversation we've created on the Partnership Website. This issue deserves some thought as it will obviously be hotly debated.

<http://thenationalpartnership.com/admin-committee-rec-3-study-committee-women-serving-in-church-ministry/>

See you all in a couple of weeks,

JK

Partnership Note: GENERAL ASSEMBLY (1)

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Website Password: rev223

thenationalpartnership.com

We will have multiple General Assembly notes. This first note is for the purpose of giving a basic schedule and overview of the assembly with key points in the schedule.

Quick reminder:

The advice shared in this and other notes should not be seen as coercive. We are seeking unity rather than uniformity. The Partnership Website is one place for you to speak back or please feel free to email me if you feel the advice given is unhelpful, incomplete, or erroneous. The purpose of the Partnership is to resource one another. When advice is shared it is seeking to help, not coerce.

OVERVIEW

This year's assembly continues a theme from the last few years: we are still attempting to figure out how to function as a growing denomination swimming in strong cultural waters. There are four primary issues about which most debate in the assembly will be concerned:

1. The need for racial reconciliation in light of sins suffered in America's Civil Rights era, and the current effects of that sin
2. A proposed Study Committee regarding the role of women in ministry
3. Overture 14 which again seeks to compel ordained elders to provide testimony in judicial cases (removing the so-called right against self-incrimination)
4. Various overtures seeking to further define/limit the power and role of the Standing Judicial Commission of the PCA

Racial Reconciliation

Overture 4 was the basis for much of what you see in the Overtures regarding RR. While Overture 4 was the basis, it has been replaced on the first day of pre-assembly meetings through the work of the Overture Committee. There is now a modified version of the overture, Overture 43, that will come to the floor. Some key language was softened (particularly regarding the terms 'covenantal and generational sin') but the finished product I believe provides much for which to be thankful. There will undoubtedly be some who prefer both more and less from this overture; I would regard this as the first wobbly steps of recognition and repentance. More to come.

Study Committee

The Admin Committee of Commissioners we received a recommendation from the CMC through the Admin Committee establishing a study committee on the role of women, particularly as it regards women

strengthening the work of committees in both the local and broader church. This is my twelfth General Assembly and I have never seen such a stacked committee of commissioners. The composition of the committee was staunchly conservative, and the debate was not at all representative of the broader denomination. The commissioners substituted the recommendation for a study committee with a recommendation that one NOT be appointed. The vote was 31-7. I strongly support such a committee. The discussion was lively, albeit at some points bewildering. The committee found itself at once suggesting that there is nothing unsettled about the issue and decrying the diversity of uninformed opinions about the subject. So while bemoaning the need for more learning on the subject they vehemently denied the opportunity for such a study. We will have the opportunity from the floor to adopt the original motion to establish the study committee or to sustain the CoC's rejection of it.

Further notes will address in greater detail overtures and nominees.

SCHEDULE (The docket is 'proposed' until finalized tonight). Critical moments are highlighted. We will send notes as the schedule develops with updated times. CLIFF NOTES: minimize any non-assembly meetings/business on Thursday.

TUESDAY (all times estimates unless ***ORDER OF THE DAY***)

9.00pm **Election of moderator**

WEDNESDAY

1.30PM RPR (Review of Presbytery Records). Nothing much to worry about here, in contrast to years past.

9.00PM Mike Khandjian Fellowship Dinner

THURSDAY

10.15am **Nominating Committee Report.** ***ORDER OF THE DAY*** This is one of the ESSENTIAL times in which you need to participate. There will be an advisory note regarding nominations. Do not schedule meetings during this time.

1.30PM **Admin Committee Report.** This will contain the Recommendation for a study committee discussed above. An important debate.

3.30PM **Overtures Committee Report.** This is where the overtures mentioned above will be debated.

A word regarding participation, copied from a friend:

Please remind folks, probably often, and especially Thursday morning, that Committee elections will be an Order of the Day at 10:15 am Thursday (report of Nom Comm). It follows the SJC report, which is preceded by the CCB report. I'd hate to see a surprise floor nominee get on an important committee.

As an example, perhaps guys need to be reminded that in 2013 in Greenville, Grover Gunn, as a floor nominee, defeated the Nom Comm nominee Cal Boroughs from TN Valley by just 53 votes - 394-341 (+12 for D. Shuffield = 747 votes case). Since there were 1,327 registered Commissioners, that means only 56% voted. 580 did not cast votes. I expect it's likely a majority of those non-voters were probably more-broad-minded guys who had legitimate and important business in the hallways or at a coffee table. But if 54 of those 580 had been in the room and voting for Cal (9% of the non-voters), he would have been elected.

And Ray Cannata was elected rather than Dominic Aquila by only 9 votes.

I suppose, to emphasize the point, we could say that in committee elections in Greenville, 56% of the registered commissioners did not vote, and two elections were determined by very close votes, one of which was just a 9 vote difference.

National Partnership: Vote ALERT

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 22, 2016, 10:49:11 AM

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to noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

These notes may not be shared without the permission of the sender.

Though we did not initially have any crucial votes to consider I would like to add a vote for today.

The **RPR report** did not appear to have an item of significance until the following minority report was shared with me. You'll note that a perfectly reasonable exception is taken, in the best possible spirit, on the Sabbath. Yet this was seen by some on the committee as an exception. That may sound minuscule, but when the RPR report is given (1.30pm today), if this minority report is passed due in part to our absence, it will only add to the spirit of hostility fostered between candidates, their presbyteries, and the committee that reviews their minutes. If we believe we are a denomination where this sort of charitable latitude on the Sabbath is given, we must soundly reject this minority report. Sorry to pull you all in for just this one vote, but if we're trying to change the way the Assembly functions, and the committees function, we have to react to this sort of overreach when it happens. Accepting the minority report tightens the screws on Sabbath views without justification.

The report is slated for 1.30, and this is in the second half of the report, the minutes for Philadelphia Metro West. **Best estimate is 2pm**, but we will let you know if it seems to be much later or any earlier.

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The candidate's own words are quoted in full (from the November 2015 meeting of PMWP):

My exception, stated briefly, is as follows: I can in good conscience affirm that the Bible teaches that a due proportion of time on one day out of seven be set apart for the worship of God. I believe the Lord's Day is analogous to and in many ways the fulfillment of the Old Testament Sabbath. I believe that Sunday is perpetually the Lord's Day because it commemorates the resurrection of Jesus. Our Sunday worship follows the example of the New Testament church and stands with almost all of the global and historic church. However, I am not comfortable with how closely the Confession seems to tie the specific day of worship and rest with the essence and acceptability of our worship and rest. As a result, I believe that it is possible that certain circumstances may arise in which a church could consider gathering for weekly corporate worship and resting on a day other than Sunday.

This is not a "hot-button" issue for me. I have no ideas or desires regarding moving (church name omitted) services from Sunday to another day, or even of adding services on other days of the week (such as Saturday night, for example) that could be seen as "substituting for" the Sunday service. I also have no desire to stir up controversy or ignite debate on this issue. As a matter of deference to the Confession and to the Presbytery, I am happy to refrain from

27

28 Our culture is witnessing the continuing erosion of morality. The
29 philosopher Voltaire connected the destruction of Christianity with the
30 destruction of the Sabbath Day. Allowing differences on recreation is one
31 thing. Allowing a Teaching Elder to hold a position that could result in a
32 denial of the Sabbath altogether is something quite different.

Signers

TE James Codling

RE Lee Joseph

TE Lane Keister

TE Dong Woo Kim

RE Richard Leino

TE Kenneth McHeard

At

TE Benjamin Shaw

Microphone 3

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 22, 2016, 1:48:55 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Is where I'll be hanging out during RPR and all day tomorrow during critical votes for those of you who may have questions.

JK

Quick voting note

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 22, 2016, 3:13:30 PM

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□

to thenp@googlegroups.com

Well we just had a little bit of a rehearsal for tomorrow. We beat back an aggressive restriction on Sabbath exceptions by only 130 votes. If we didn't have you all joining us in the room it may have passed. I think it's plain that tomorrow is going to be difficult, with very close votes. Please prioritize these votes as we make you aware of them.

National Partnership: GENERAL ASSEMBLY (2) - Day 4 overview

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 6:49:40 AM

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to noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

Brothers,

Hope you're ready for a full day.

SCHEDULE (The docket is 'proposed' until finalized tonight). Critical moments are highlighted. We will send notes as the schedule develops with updated times. CLIFF NOTES: minimize any non-assembly meetings/business on Thursday.

***ORDER OF THE DAY*)**

THURSDAY

10.15am **Nominating Committee Report.** ***ORDER OF THE DAY*** This is one of the ESSENTIAL times in which you need to participate. There will be an advisory note regarding nominations. Do not schedule meetings during this time.

1.30PM **Admin Committee Report.** This will contain the Recommendation for a study committee discussed above. An important debate.

3.30PM **Overtures Committee Report.** This is where the overtures mentioned above will be debated.

I will be providing you with three additional emails:

1. Nominating Committee Report Advice
2. Admin Committee Report Advice
3. Overtures Committee Report Advice

Remember that crucial decisions on the floor the last few years have been decided by a dozen votes of the assembly. Please make every attempt to be present.

At Microphone 3 today

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 8:37:23 AM

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to noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

If you have any questions, please do not hesitate to find me. You may also text me at [614.302.1570](tel:614.302.1570)

JK

National Partnership: Administrative Committee Report (potential study committee) ADVICE

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 9:54:42 AM

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to noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

Brothers,

There is one item for the Administrative committee that bears full engagement: **Recommendation 3** to form a study committee to study women's roles in the church.

Today, from the Administrative Committee, we will be voting on a recommendation to form a study committee to study the issue of woman serving in the ministries of the church. Wherever you come down in your own thoughts on these issues, please keep in mind that the study committee advocated by the CMC and the Administrative Committee comes to the floor of the General Assembly as a unanimous recommendation. Some might ask: why then did the Admin CoC reject the motion overwhelmingly by a vote of 31-7? You would have to ask the majority in the committee, but many arguments formed around fear of losing our orthodoxy, much like the PCUSA. But this strikes me as an unfounded fear. More to the point, the remedy is worse than the disease: to restrain the liberty of our denomination to study an issue for the sake of orthodoxy is to protect nothing at all. When we fear the opening of God's word, and the studying of it by fully ordained men, for fear of unorthodoxy, we deprive one another of the very means of Orthodoxy. We starve at the dinner table. We would urge you to vote for further study.

I've asked TE Peter Rowan to write a quick summary of our position:

Study committees along these lines have been voted down in previous assemblies, yet this issue has continued to resurface and will continue to do so until we are willing to enter in to this conversation and consider this for our time and

for our people. . This unanimity speaks loudly to this need. Our denomination has done a great job at telling women what they are not allowed to do, what is desired most in this kind of study committee is to ask what they can and should do. You may find the nature of the committee too broad, you may find a particular issue to be one that you find completely settled, but please consider that the Spirit is with our church and will guide this committee in its work. We can - and we will - debate the particularities of what the committee is charged with, but please consider voting in favor of this committee in belief that the Spirit has been present with the study committee of the CMC, the CMC and the Administrative Committee.

Nominations Committee ADVICE

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 23, 2016, 8:35:41 AM



to noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

These notes may not be shared without the permission of the sender.

Please note our concern about SJC TE Gunn below.

This year we believe the Nominating Committee has given us a fine slate of candidates. In each case we are supportive of the committee. The following is a list of the candidate we would support along with floor nominations submitted during this GA to challenge the committee nominees. There are several reasons for recommending a candidate, as we are exhorted in the committee meeting. Special preference is given to geographical representation (some presbyteries and regions are oversampled) as well as a desire to allow for a broader representation of age and experience on our committees. Again, in each case we are supportive of the committee recommendation.

CCB // Alternate // RE

RE C. Thompson Harley, Savannah River ***

RE Rich Leino, James River

RE Fred Marcinak, Calvary

RE Chris Shoemaker, Southern New England

Slot currently vacant. The most qualified candidates are Harley and Marcinak. Presbytery representation (Calvary over-represented) makes Harley our rec.

CCB // 2020 // TE

TE Per Almquist, Northern New England ***

TE Art Sartorious, Siouxlands

Per Almquist is the NC candidate. He has served well on RPR for multiple years as chair. Younger and gives better geographical representation. Almquist demonstrated ability for balance and fairness makes him strongly preferred. TE Sartorious, for instance, headed the move to squash the recommendation for a study committee examining the issue of women in ministry. CCB is a body entrusted with upholding the constitutionality of our Assembly's actions; for a presbyter to demonstrate repeated extra-constitutional preferences is troubling. Almquist is the choice.

ICR // Alternate // RE

RE Knox (Kipper) Tab, Metro ATL ***

RE Dan Hudson, Gulfstream

RE George McCurdy, SE Alabama

Slot currently vacant. Knox (Kipper) Tab most qualified given board service, denominational background, and current work.

ICR // 2019 // TE

TE Brian Janssen, Iowa ***

TE Brian Peterson, Central Carolina

Brian Janssen is the NC candidate. Geographical representation preferred here.

MNA // Alternate // RE

RE Ed McDougall, Central Florida ***

RE Terry Murdock, South Florida

RE David Smith, SE Alabama

Slot currently vacant. Ed McDougall has been Church Planting Director for the Florida Church Planting Network.

MTW // 2021 // TE

TE Kyle Hackmann, Eastern Canada ***

TE Roland Barnes, Savannah River

Kyle Hackmann is the NC candidate. Geographical diversity (Canada vs Georgia) and age are the strongest factors here. Hackmann strongly preferred.

RUM // 2021 // TE

TE Russ Whitfield, Potomac ***

TE Martin S.C. (Mike) Biggs, North Texas Presbytery

Russ Whitfield is the NC Candidate. Ethnicity, geographical representation, age, and strategic direction of RUM (toward HBCU ministry) make Whitfield the very clear choice.

SJC // 2020 // TE

TE Paul Bankson, Central Georgia ***

TE Grover Gunn, Mississippi Valley

Paul Bankson is the NC Candidate. He is the strongly preferred candidate for many reasons. There is a need on SJC to develop new, younger committee members. Gunn is retired from pastoral ministry and additionally faces some serious questions regarding his suitability. Some have encouraged Gunn to withdraw his candidacy, or for his presbytery to withdraw its approval, even asking the NC to disqualify him – but they are not empowered to do so. We urge you to vote against Grover Gunn in this instance and to encourage others you know to do the same. He has served previously; it would be a grievous error to allow him to serve again.



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 23, 2016, 9:57:22 AM

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to noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

Some did not receive this the first time around. My apologies for the duplication.

NOMINATIONS COMMITTEE ADVICE UPDATE

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 10:03:51 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

A quick change. Our recommendation for the ICR was incorrect. My apologies. Wrong Brian. The superior option is **Brian PETERSON** not Janssen. This is the one place we are advocating a substitute for the committee nomination. Thank you for hanging with us.

Report starts on time at 10.15. Be there for the vote!

GA Schedule

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 11:38:13 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Best estimate for the **Admin report** (and debate on erecting a study committee on the role of women in ministry) is shortly after lunch. **You'll want to make plans to be present at 130pm.** Note that I also sent some advice on the subject of the study committee in an earlier email.

JK

General Assembly: OVERTURES REPORT Advice

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 1:21:50 PM

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to noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

While we wait for the Administrative Committee Report, I'm sharing our advice on Overtures compiled from men on the committee. The basic advice is below, followed by specific perspectives on overtures:

Additional thoughts on specific overtures:

Regarding Overture 14

I have been thinking of more lines of thought on 14

On 14, it seems to me as we debated in overtures that some are afraid of being able to deal adequately with heretics without this added power (and be clear this is giving an added power to the prosecutor.) But it should

be pointed out that the most controversial recent case, that involving Peter Leithart, would not have been helped by this change. Leithart did testify on his own behalf. So while it seems that some are concerned that we need this additional power in order to deal with false teachers this is just not the case. If you need an officer to testify against himself, if you have to compel him to do so, then I would argue you need to build a stronger case.

On the other hand, there are many who are afraid of the unknown, of the tool that this might give an overzealous prosecutor, who perhaps hears through the grapevine or the blogosphere about something a pastor said and wants to go after the guy. This change, this added power, could be used to go after a guy where there is insufficient other evidence, and I would submit to you that this is a very real danger.

Thus I urge you to vote down this change which will add nothing necessary for a legitimate case with ample evidence, but open the door for nuisance cases and overzealous prosecutions.

Regarding Overture 39

From the RE from Nashville who was on overtures, Bryce Sullivan. He gave me permission to share and include his name.

I thought these issues in 39 were confusing and, of course, arcane, and I didn't study this carefully before GA. But here's what I think.

First, I now disagree with replacing "complaint" with "appeal" on line 16. It seems to me that a complaint is made against an action of the court, so the term complaint seems to work. The outcome of discipline without process is an action of a court and not the result of a trial. An appeal is only used in a very specific case, and I don't think discipline without process is one of these.

This is a primary question. Is the discipline without process a trial or simply "an act of the court?" Of course, they are modifying 42-2 as well, but this change seems wrong to me. 42-2 no says: Only those who have submitted to a regular trial are entitled to an appeal.

Looking at 38-1, you see that the discipline without process is done before the court, but no mention is made of a trial. The fact that it is "without process" indicates there is no trial. So in order for this amendment to be made, 42-2 is also being amended--but is that enough?

38-1. When any person shall come forward and make his offense known to the court, a full statement of the facts shall be recorded and judgment rendered without process. In handling a confession of guilt, it is essential that the person intends to confess and permit the court to render judgment without process. Statements made by him in the presence of the court must not be taken as a basis of a judgment without process except by his consent. In the event a confession is intended, a full statement of the facts should be approved by the accused, and by the court, before the court proceeds to a judgment. The accused has the right of complaint against the judgment.

I think in the case a discipline without process, the man must submit to the court's action. The appeal would be by way of complaint against the court's action. I don't think the same protections need to be in place for discipline without process when compared to a trial.

Overtures Advice.

Note that we recommend the support of all committee work with the exception of Overture 14.

Overture	Committee Action	Recommendation	Rationale
1, 4, 6, 8-13, 15-19, 23, 27-31, 33-35, 41, 42, 46-63	Refer to committee's action on Overture 43	SUPPORT	While we hoped to pass a version of overture 4, we were not able to do so. Jay Neikirk suggested a version of 43 that included some parts of 53 and 55 and that became the basis for our answer to the racial overtures. We felt we were able to strengthen 43 significantly. But were disappointed that we could not retain the phrase "covenantal and generational, and continuing sin" in the final overture. It would not be a bad idea in our view for a few people to express disappointment that this phrase was changed to "corporate, historical, and continuing sin." The resolve about "failing to love our African American brothers and sisters was also lost in the final version but this was likely inadvertent. What should not be lost here is that the combined efforts of so many to bring Overture 4 created much more unity when an amended 43 was proposed. Presbyteries made clear that nothing less than Overture 4 would be passed; it strengthened 43 into its current product.
3	Refer back	SUPPORT	
5	NO	SUPPORT	
7	Refer to AC	SUPPORT	Though we think this overture, ultimately, is a bad idea, the proper process is to send it back. This is not unusual with these sorts of petitioning overtures
14	Approve as amended	OPPOSE	The vote (51-32) represents the divided nature of the committee on this issue. There is a minority report which we would urge you to approve. This measure removes an important protection given to witnesses and would represent a break between the PCA and its NAPARC brethren on this matter (ARP, RPCNA, OPC). We urge you to closely review the minority report for an excellent rationale.
25	NO	SUPPORT	93-0 in committee. This additional language would be redundant.
32	Refer	SUPPORT	
36-38	YES	SUPPORT	We believe these are helpful clarifications to the operation of our court. Unanimous in committee.
39	NO		
40	YES	SUPPORT	This added language is helpful, nearly unanimous vote in committee
43	YES	SUPPORT	See above rationale re: Racial Reconciliation overtures



Jedidiah Slaboda

<jedidiahslaboda@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 1:32:53 PM

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to james, noreply-spamdigest via The National Partnership

Thanks! I'm sure it's accidental but your first section reads as if we all assume Leithart is an example of a false teacher. That's not the belief of many individuals in this group but more importantly, our best reformed theologians, his former congregation, his Presbytery, and, by implication at the very least, the GA. He also has a continued voice among the wider conservative church.

GA: CONVENE AT 9PM

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2016, 7:45:20 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

We aren't done yet. Hopefully one more session will do it. We reconvene with crucial votes on Overtures at 9pm. Please join us - your votes have been critical all day.

2017

National Partnership NOTE

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Feb 7, 2017, 4:06:28 PM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

Brothers,

It's that time again. There are a number of things we need to be doing to prepare for General Assembly:

1. Participating in committee work
2. Volunteering for a General Assembly Committee of Commissioners

The primary issues related to this assembly revolve around last year's action of the Cooperative Ministries Committee (CMC), a committee composed - among others - of the heads of each permanent committee and the last five moderators of the General Assembly. Last year the CMC, in keeping with its charter to propose any changes beneficial to furthering the work of the church, proposed a study committee on the role of women in ministry. We expect the committee to bring a final report this year. Due heavy conflict surrounding the recommendation of the CMC, some believe that the committee overstepped by proposing a study committee through the Administrative committee instead of presbytery overture, we anticipate a number of overtures seeking to restrict the work of the CMC. There will also be overtures seeking to block the reception of the report from the women in ministry study committee. Expect a few overtures that seek to preemptively limit the "damage" of the report by "clarifying" BCO language (no women deacons, etc.).

1. News

-Six overtures have officially been received by the Stated Clerk. Any necessary discussions will take place a little closer to the assembly - probably in May - on the NP website.

-Overture 2 from Calvary seeks to give BCO 59 full constitutional status, the aim to make statements like, "marriage is between one man and one woman" more clearly a part of our constitution, and driven by concerns over PCA ministers eventually being compelled to officiate same-sex marriages. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-2-Calvary-BCO-59-Marriage.pdf>

-Overture 3 from Westminster seeks to dismiss, with apologies, the women in ministry study committee. The Assembly would be apologizing for their previous action. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/12/Overture-3-Westminster-Role-of-Women.pdf>

-Overture 4 from Northwest Georgia seeks to specify that the role of Elder or Deacon is not open to women. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-4-Northwest-Georgia-Add-BCO-24-11.pdf>

-**Overture 5** from Rocky Mountain seeks to further elaborate on the role of Elder. Perhaps some helpful additions to a section that is far too thin. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-5-Rocky-Mtn-BCO-8-1-8-3.pdf>

-**Overture 6** from Gulfstream is another attempt to strengthen constitutional documents against same-sex marriage views and practices. This one wants to see additional proof texts in our confession regarding marriage. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-6-Gulfstream-WCF-add-proof-texts.pdf>

2. Action items:

First: Sign up for Nominating Committee OR Review of Presbytery Records

PERMANENT COMMITTEES:

We've mentioned the value of participation in the Review of Presbytery Records committee and the Nominating Committee as two key ways you can do your part to preserve the health of our denomination. Participation in the NP means, at a minimum, that you will be involved in helping to fill committee spots from your presbytery. Either volunteer yourself for open slots on RPR and the Nominating Committee (The NC recommends members for the permanent committees and the SJC to the floor of the General Assembly) or find a friend in your presbytery to volunteer. Your Winter meeting is the likely point for nominations to these committees. The **Nominating Committee** is a one-day meeting in Atlanta, Saturday March 25th. Your travel and accommodation (you will likely travel Friday night for this meeting) is reimbursed by the denomination. Review of Presbytery Records meets for a few days during one week in May, your travel and accommodation is reimbursed for this meeting.

Review of Presbytery Records: Serving on RPR is a three-day commitment May 31-June 2 - and the PCA pays the expenses. This committee reviews the minutes presbyteries submit to the General Assembly to ensure the minutes of presbytery are in order – that is, there are no strange deviations, exceptions recorded that strike at the vitals of our system, etc. What sounds perhaps mild-mannered has become a battleground for theological axe-grinding. While there are many who seek to serve on this committee for less litigious reasons, there are others who see RPR as an opportunity to move the lines of orthodoxy in the PCA. It is always necessary to have wise and qualified men serving in this committee to ensure that our denomination is accurately represented in these discussions.

Committee of Commissioners. This is the committee work done on site at the General Assembly TE Joel St. Clair put together a helpful priority list for committee work:

TIER 1 - Playing with the New England Patriots of the polity world

- Overtures (TE)
- Overtures (RE)
- MTW
- Admin
- Interchurch Relations

TIER 2 - Rookie league (or grizzly veterans who need to rest their hurting/broken bodies) from a polity perspective

- CTS
- MNA
- CDM
- RUM

TIER 3 - These are where they hand out participation medals to everyone serving;

- Foundation
- CC
- RBI

- Ridgehaven

-Contact your presbytery's clerk and simply ask to be assigned to a committee. Your process may involve a nominating committee for your presbytery or they may appoint anyone willing. Don't be afraid to be bold; we all have a right to do the work of the broader church, even if the same people seem to serve every year. speak up.

-You can register for the Overtures committee up to the day it meets, the Monday of the assembly. Would you consider filling an empty spot in your presbytery? The committee debate will be sharp and particularly important this year.

3. Calendar:

June 12-16: The Assembly meets in Greensboro, NC (which is in the south, incredibly)

National Partnership NOTE

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

May 23, 2017, 10:24:39 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

Brothers,

It's time to prep for General Assembly. If you've wondered why you haven't received many partnership emails it is partly due to the fact that I'm trying not to wear us all out before we hit Greensboro. So let's dig in.

1. News

There are 25 overtures; I'll narrow it down to the more interesting ones:

-Overture 2 from Calvary seeks to give BCO 59 full constitutional status, the aim to make statements like, "marriage is between one man and one woman" more clearly a part of our constitution, and driven by concerns over PCA ministers eventually being compelled to officiate same-sex marriages. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-2-Calvary-BCO-59-Marriage.pdf>

-Overture 4 from Northwest Georgia seeks to specify that the role of Elder or Deacon is not open to women. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-4-Northwest-Georgia-Add-BCO-24-11.pdf>

-Overture 5 from Rocky Mountain seeks to further elaborate on the role of Elder. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-5-Rocky-Mtn-BCO-8-1-8-3.pdf>

-Overture 6 from Gulfstream is another attempt to strengthen constitutional documents against same-sex marriage views and practices. This one wants to see additional proof texts in our confession regarding marriage. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-6-Gulfstream-WCF-add-proof-texts.pdf>

-Overture 11 from Chesapeake seeks to allow minority reports in judicial commissions (this motion was previously referred back in order to correct language): <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-11-Chesapeake-Presbytery-BCO-15-3.pdf>

-Overture 17 from Pacific Northwest seeks to charge presbyteries to have a clarifying discussion with candidates seeking to opt-out of social security regarding their theological reasons for doing so: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-17-Pacific-NW-candidates-Soc-Security.pdf>

-Overture 25 presented to Suncoast by the Session of Auburn Road Presbyterian Church but REJECTED has been sent ahead by that session, the overture seeks to influence and support parents to place their children in formal christian education rather than secular schools that are "wholly opposed" to Christ. <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-25-Auburn-Rd-PC-Christian-Education.pdf>

OVERTURES SEEKING TO CHANGE THE ROLE OF THE CMC

In some of the speeches from the floor opposing the formation of the Women in Ministry Study Committee, there was doubt cast on the proper role of the Cooperative Ministries Committee and whether it should be able to present business before a committee of the Assembly (in this case, the Administrative Committee). My own view is that the CMC cannot plan without the ability to move business; I'm sure we've all experienced committees that are all rudder and no sail. These overtures have in common a desire to shrink the profile of the CMC in regards to Assembly business.

-Overture 7 from Northern New England seeks to "remove long-range planning" from the CMC charter <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-7-N.-New-England-RAO-7-3.c.pdf>

-Overture 18 from James River seeks to bind the Assembly from creating Ad Interim committees (e.g. study committees) without presbytery overture: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/10/Overture-18-James-River-RAO-IX.pdf>

CAL BOROUGH'S RESPONSE TO THE WIMSC REPORT

You can read and interact with Cal here (or on the FB page mentioned below): <http://thenationalpartnership.com/response-to-wimsc-cal-boroughs/2017/5/23/response-to-wimsc-cal-boroughs>

2017 NP GA DISCUSSION VIA CLOSED FACEBOOK GROUP

I realize this may limit some of you who are not connected via facebook. If you propose to ask specific questions seeking a discussion I will post those questions on the website then direct traffic there through this email list. Because so much discussion happens on social media I thought it may encourage further resourcing of one another if we choose a more engaging platform. The group is closed, so it can be located via search (though eventually I'll make it secret - in which case you'll need to email me to join), but here's the link: <https://www.facebook.com/groups/237759476709705/>

I'll post the overtures for discussion on that page, and any other pertinent info.

2. Action items:

-Please let us know if you are on a Committee of Commissioners for GA. I will post those group memberships so you can connect if you have a question about something going on in a particular committee.

-READ THE WIMSC REPORT. It's important to form your own conclusions about the findings of the study committee before engaging in discussion. This will be the primary topic of discussion during the week. Here's a link to the report: <http://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2017/04/Women-Serving-in-Ministry-of-Church-Ad-Interim-Report-2017.pdf>

Irwyn Ince, NP member and chairman of the committee wrote a helpful brief intro to the work of the committee and I'm sharing it here with his permission:

"Brothers, let me share some foundational (and other) thoughts with you about our committee's makeup, goals, and work. I hope that what I write here is helpful, provides clarity, and encourages you that we've taken a healthy step forward. Much of what I'm about to say I'll repeat in the seminar at GA, but there are other things that I'm only going to say here.

Our Makeup. George Robertson did an excellent job in selecting the committee members (I only question his selection of convener!). With regard to special committees appointed to investigate a question, Robert's Rules says it is important that all the different views of the membership be reflected in the committee members. This is what George did. He wrote to me earlier this week and said by far this is the most difficult and potentially incendiary task that our Church has taken up in the three decades he's served the PCA. So, although the members' views may differ, he wanted people who would put the peace and purity of the Church before themselves. Also note the point made in lines 30-38 on page 2404 of the report. He fought for the establishment of this study committee and was thankfully sustained.

Our Goals. Given the diversity of views on our committee I made a strategic decision at the outset. I can rightly be criticized on this point, so feel free to do so. I made it clear to the committee that we were going to pursue a consensus report. This meant that everyone was going to have to give on certain points. We could have easily pressed into two camps on the committee. That approach would've inevitably lead to a majority and a minority report. What would follow from this is a blood bath on the floor of GA over the issue of women in the diaconate,

and a significant potential to lose the middle over the broader issue of women in the ministry of the church. I was determined to pursue a course that would move the conversation on that issue forward without making this GA all about women deacons. That is only a PART of our non-health as a denomination when it comes to women. The report has holes for sure, but I believe it is clear throughout that we are calling our church to stop the detrimental way of talking about women in terms of what they cannot do in the church, and to joyfully pursue how women are called to use their gifts for the blessing of the church. This calling is well beyond our overly patriarchal (and often misogynistic) approach to ministry.

Our Work. Another determination that I and the committee made was that we would report in one year and not request an extension. This was a strategic decision that came with understanding that our report would not be all that it could be. We would be opening ourselves to even more criticism because there are plenty of people who have personally or corporately studied this issue and will point to things we didn't consider or left out. At the same time, I do stand by our work as a whole. When it comes to the animating (in this group and elsewhere) recommendations that come from our work, understand that the committee's view is that we are taking a step forward. They're not intended to be an end to dialogue, but a way of engaging the start of dialogue. Please note that it says "select and appoint godly women of the congregation to assist the ORDAINED leadership." This isn't just about deacons. We are calling for sessions and presbyteries to appoint women to assist the elders as well. We are saying that we need godly women to assist the session in its work, and that our churches need to be intentional in identifying and making room for women who are gifted in shepherding."

3. Calendar:

June 12-16: The Assembly meets in Greensboro, NC (which is in the south, incredibly)

More next week.

NP: important question for the group

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 1, 2017, 10:00:52 AM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Leading up to the 2006 establishment of the CMC, was anyone on this list involved in the creation of the CMC charter? I'm asking specifically because we will hear at this year's GA, again, that the CMC

wasn't designed to do this kind of strategic planning. Can anyone help me here? Please let me know.

JK

Partnership NOTE: Assembly, day 1, 2

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 13, 2017, 7:24:37 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

wanted to give you visibility on what's taken place so far at the Assembly and what to expect today. As always, please know that where I am advocating (in particular for the moderator vote), I am speaking as one man. I am both grateful and indebted for your willingness to vote your conscience; I've had my mind changed by more than one of you speaking *your* mind.

PRE GA MEETINGS

The Overtures and Administrative Committees of Commissioners meet on Monday of the assembly week. Yesterday both finished their business without much complication. Overtures will feature a couple of minority reports but the Admin committee was completely smooth (in contrast to last year when the Ad Interim committee on Women in Ministry was debated).

OVERTURES

The report of this committee happens Thursday. We will update you with voting time updates. There was not much this year to do in the OC, thankfully. But there are three items worth discussing:

-Overture 2. This overture seeks to grant BCO 59 (the solemnization of marriage) full constitutional authority. We heard a few speeches stating that we need to do more to protect our pastors and, in particular, chaplains from prosecution when they decline to perform same-sex marriages. The idea is that some might view 59-3 as immaterial because it "lacks constitutional authority." This overture, which probably was the most heavily-debated item of the day, passed 54-45. I am a signatory for the minority report, asking the assembly to reject the overture. The rationale for rejecting the overture stems from the fact that:

1. BCO 59 already clearly spells out the orthodox position on marriage. It seems to be without question that we expect ministers to follow this injunction, even without the same constitutional power as other chapters in the book.

2. There is, of course, good reason why we would not make this chapter constitutional in the first place: this is an issue more appropriate for our standards, and WCF 24 is not at all ambiguous, a document we subscribe to as ministers in the PCA. In other words, "one man, one woman" already *has* constitutional authority in the PCA

3. So the question might be asked: why not do it anyway? One man in the OC rose to say that in a storm, when the winds are blowing, it isn't redundant to place another tent stake. Fair enough. But let me add to the illustration: while it may not be redundant to add a tent stake to your tent, it *is* redundant to add one to your house. WCF 24 is more than sufficient, as is BCO 59 as-is. But this isn't a simple argument for the status quo. Making BCO 59 constitutional this way, and for this reason, without any thought to what might be unintended consequences of the other items in the chapter (for instance 59-4,5 which are clearly words of guidance for families. How do you enforce these?). The remedy is far too weak, and the problem already solved.

-Overture 7 was one attempt to limit the power of the CMC by removing strategic planning from their profile. As I said previously, I felt this overture would create a team with all rudder and no sail, wasting everyone's time. The anxiety of those proposing the overture was that this allows the CMC to function as its own presbytery, making overtures to the assembly without being forced to work through a presbytery, the natural "vetting" process for overtures that allows us to retain a "bottom-up" polity. In the committee we amended the overture by retaining the strategic planning "sail" language but ensuring that any overtures must still work through presbyteries. RE Jay Neikirk proposed this elegant solution and the room was grateful for a way out of the debate. I'm glad to support it.

-Overture 18 was another attempt to limit the CMC by insisting that all Ad-Interim (e.g. study) committees must come via overture. The debate on this motion was light, I'm not sure why, and it passed overwhelmingly. One problem with this overture is that without the ability for permanent committees to propose AICs we would not have had the Women in Ministry Study Committee and the Insider Movement Study Committee, both of which have been very beneficial to the church. While I understand the continuing worry about the CMC's scope, and preserving the traditional lines of polity in the PCA, I am concerned that in limiting the CMC we are removing the potential of permanent committees, which may be far more in touch with a particular issue, will be forced to wait until they can work through a presbytery to receive help. I'm also not crazy about the idea that we cannot trust our committees enough to allow them to simply propose an AIC themselves. I do not think this ability would threaten, at all, the character of our polity. Let's trust our committees, since we're the ones in them.

NOTE: there will be a minority report on Overture 5 which further clarifies the role of an Elder. The committee worked on the overture's language. Though the overture was defeated the minority will present what they believe to be helpful additions to BCO-8. While I'm not in favor - there's much we could and probably should revisit about the description of an Elder's ministry - I'd much rather take one swing at the whole chapter via study committee.

DAY 2

MODERATOR VOTE

Tonight, at 9pm, we will vote on the moderator for the General Assembly. The two candidates will be RE Alex Jun and RE John Bise. Lloyd Kim, MTW Coordinator will present Jun and RE Dan Carrell will present Bise. This may be the closest vote we see at the Assembly this year, and it is a fairly important one. While to some it may seem ceremonial, the moderator is critical to a well-ordered and fair assembly. Debate can bog down endlessly without the willingness of a moderator to move the process forward sometimes uncomfortably. The moderator also ensures that the majority does not bully and the minority does not exasperate the room. Additionally, the moderator has a place on the CMC for 5 years, so understanding their view of the denomination is also helpful. John Bise is a well-respected man for his work as an elder but also a churchman. He is clear-headed and wise. While I would call him solidly right-of-center in terms of our PCA polity disagreements (subscription et al), he is not belligerently so. On the other hand he was not an effective moderator when called upon in the Overtures Committee. It was a frustrating experience for many. While I like John, I am not convinced he will be an effective moderator.

While I do not know Alex Jun well, all of my interactions with those who do have been very reassuring. He is regarded as theologically astute, confident in debate, able to understand complexity with ease, and fair to all sides. I'm glad to support him for moderator this evening.

Please be present for the vote tonight. It is tempting to visit with friends or family during this time but, to speak plainly, no one else is empowered to vote your conscience. This is why you are here. If you don't show up, we will dramatically strip you of your NP pin and pocket square. I'm just kidding. Also: make sure you have a **pocket square** in those suit jacket pockets, men. We don't live in caves.

More tomorrow.

Blessed by all of you.

JK

NP Note correction and moderator vote input

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 13, 2017, 10:16:19 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Brothers,

Please forgive me, I misspoke regarding the creation of AICs: the Insider Movement Study Committee was actually in response to an overture. I am appreciative to those of you who sent me that quick correction.

I also wanted to pass along a perspective from EJ Nusbaum, former moderator of the GA, who was also present for RE Bise's service as moderator in the Overtures Committee I mentioned earlier. I want to make sure we hear from those who can help us and I found EJ's response to be useful for everyone:

James-

I really do appreciate what you do and how you lead us. I especially appreciate your openness to other opinions and input. So, I am going to take you up on that invitation. I leave it to your good judgment if you want to pass this on to the rest of the Partnership.

Your assessment of the importance of the role of Moderator is spot on. You are also correct that we have a tough decision to make tonight.

We do have a tough choice to make tonight and I have not made up my mind yet. So, I am not trying to start a campaign called "John for Moderator", but would like to take the opportunity to offer a different perspective on John Bise's leadership of the Overtures Committee a couple of years ago. That was a tough year to chair the Overtures Committee. As you will recall, the most controversial issue, racial reconciliation, came to the committee from the floor of the Assembly as a personal resolution. In the hours the committee struggled with the issue, there were numerous discussions, speakers from outside the committee, and many proposals that had to be considered. That was a frustrating Assembly for many of us, but in my humble opinion, John Bise was effective and probably did as well as anyone could have given the circumstances he was put in.

Thanks for the opportunity to give my perspective. I am confident that your thoughtful and serious approach to the Kingdom work at the Assembly serves our people well.

In Him,
E J Nusbaum

NP NOTE: Schedule update and voting alert

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 13, 2017, 2:01:34 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Tomorrow there will be a partial report of the Overtures Committee at 11.15am. You need to be there in order to vote on important changes to our RAO like Overtures 7 and 18. We have also been given a spot for the WIMSC-R, at 2.15pm. So tomorrow you will want to have very fluid plans for lunch and those two spots marked out on your calendar:

11.15am - OC report (partial)

2.15pm - WIMSC-R

This is not to mention the important moderator vote tonight at 9pm.

I'll let you know where to find me on the floor if you have any additional questions

JK

NP NOTE: Scheduling update, more on Overtures 7, 18

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 14, 2017, 6:58:42 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

This morning, before the partial OC report (11.10am) there will be an attempt at new business on the floor (that is, business not submitted before the Assembly and represented on the docket). The new business will focus on further changes to the CMC similar to the ones we've already received. If accepted (will need 2/3 vote), the OC will go back into session to deal with these. I'm not in favor of receiving the new business, not just because I'm not for cutting the profile of the CMC but also because I am not a fan of a rushed OC going back to work. This is why we have deadlines. Since the Assembly convenes at 10.45a and there is a partial OC report dealing with an RAO (rules of assembly operation) change that would prevent this kind of new business, the new business will have to be attempted between 10.45 and 11.10. So we are asking you to be there early to vote on this. Please join us at 10.45a, the start of this morning's session.

Some have asked me to explain my view on 7/18. Let me explain:

Overture 7 initially sought to remove all strategic planning from the profile of the CMC. In committee we were able to amend the overture such that the language for strategic planning remained, while requiring the CMC to work overtures through a presbytery - a task easy enough, only requiring one of its well-respected members to work with their, or another presbytery. I am for this overture because it accomplishes some helpful goals:

1. It takes some heat off the CMC, limiting the "strong centralized governance" complaint. When the CMC handles an overture it becomes radioactive. It is a distraction they don't need when the remedy is so easy.
2. Fighting this overture (it was 99-1 in committee) increases the scrutiny for the committee on, again, an issue not worth fighting. Those who are annually looking for watershed moments in our denomination will look for anything to seize upon, where there is a concerted fight against something seen as "conservative" the unity of the assembly is strained. I like to save my bullets for the things that matter, and I don't want to amp up the opposition to the CMC any further. I'm hopeful for what they can do to serve the Church.
3. Passing this overture gives the assembly a resounding affirmation of the strategic planning goals of the CMC. If we vote with those who have anxiety about the committee the vote will be overwhelming. This is useful as the committee continues its business in the years ahead.

Overture 18 is more troublesome. It requires any Ad Interim Committees to bring study committee overtures through the OC. The problem, of course, is that the OC then has the ability to change the nature of the AIC request *before* it hits the permanent committee with the expertise to shape it meaningfully. Forcing the Assembly to work even AIC requests through the OC first, in my

opinion, further inflates the operation of the Overtures Committee and weakening the deliberative power of the whole (like our permanent committee CoCs), making them the gatekeeper of even the questions the assembly seeks to ask itself (via Study committee, for example). This is, for me, overreach-territory.

Glad to hear you brothers about this. See you at 10.45!

JK

NP: Nomination Committee guidance

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 15, 2017, 8:47:59 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

These votes will occur at 10.20a this morning.

In these recommendations, there is preference given to geographical representation and age of candidates. Our goal is to see a wide representation of Presbyteries as well as younger men serve on committees. We've also told you where NP members are present on the ballot. It's important to note that this is not a primary criterion but may be helpful to you. As always I am indebted to your ability to vote your conscience.

CCB // Alternate // TE

TE Roger Collins, Mississippi Valley

TE Worth Carson, South Florida *****

Both candidates are qualified, but there is a significant difference in Presbytery representation. Carson is an experienced churchman who will bring helpful perspective. For this reason the floor nominee is strongly preferred.

CCB // Class of 2021 // RE

RE C. Thompson Harley, Savannah River *****

RE C. Fredric Marcinak, Calvary

Harley is strongly preferred. He is the NC recommendation, represents an under-represented Presbytery, and is highly qualified.

MTW // Class of 2022 // TE

TE Mark Bates, Rocky Mountain *****

TE Maranatha Chung, Philadelphia

Bates is strongly preferred. He is a Partnership member. His experience and expertise far outweigh the floor nominee.

MTW // Class of 2022 // RE

RE Hugh Potts, Mississippi Valley *****

RE Gordon Cloke, Central Florida

Potts is the NC suggestion. He has more experience than the floor nominee.

RUF // Class of 2022 // TE

TE Brad Waller, Savannah River *****

TE Martin (Mike) Biggs, North Texas

Waller is the NC nominee, is younger (which brings an under-represented view on the committee) and much of what Biggs brings is already present in other members. Waller preferred.

SJC // Class of 2021 // TE

TE Larry Hoop, Ohio Valley *****

TE Guy Prentiss Waters, Mississippi Valley

Hoop is strongly preferred. He is the NC nominee. He's a Partnership member. He's in a much less represented Presbytery and brings geographic diversity. Finally and most importantly, his balanced perspective is far preferred than what the floor nominee would bring.

SJC // Class of 2021 // RE

RE Howell (Howie) Burkhalter, Piedmont Triad *****

RE John Bise, Providence

Burkhalter is strongly preferred. He has served two terms on the SJC and has a more representative view than the floor nominee. We recognize this is one view of many regarding RE Bise.

TEC // Alternate // RE

RE Wes Reynolds, Great Lakes

RE Charles Waldron, Missouri *****

The floor nominee Waldron has served on TEC previously and has a broader perspective that better fits the committee and represents the big tent. Waldron is strongly preferred.

Joel St. Clair

Pastor

NP Update: GA Day 4

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 15, 2017, 6:08:24 AM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Today's schedule:

9.30a: reconvene. Continued debate on the WIMSC-R, recommendation 4. Please be present as margins were thin (a couple dozen votes) at some point yesterday.

10.20: Special Order*: Nominating Committee Report. We will have recommendations for those of you looking for additional input regarding committee rosters. This is one of the most important votes each year: permanent committees greatly influence our denomination.

2.30p: Report of Racial Reconciliation Study Committee

3.15p: Vote regarding the budget for RRSC recommendations (including the Unity Fund)

3.35p: Overtures committee report (Including Overture 2, which we have discussed previously)

(Non-bold times are estimates. They are listed on the docket but are dependent on how we process other business)

*A special order means that we must interrupt current business to deal with an item on the docket. This gives us a predictable time for items of special importance.

You should expect at least a couple more emails today, one dealing with recommendations for the rest of the WIMSC-R, and another providing advice on committee nominations. Busy day! See you on the floor.

I'll be at Microphone 2 by 9.15a if you have any questions

JK



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 15, 2017, 11:55:16 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Begin forwarded message:

From: Austin Pfeiffer <aus...@salempresws.org>

Date: June 15, 2017 at 9:51:22 AM EDT

To: James Kessler <ja...@newcityhilliard.org>

Subject: Re: NP Update: GA Day 4

James,

This is Austin, the bald, beardy fellow from the host committee. I wonder if you might be willing to send this to the NP. I'll leave it to your discretion. Many thanks!

The Thursday worship service is often the least attended. Tonight, we are celebrating the Lord's Supper. In my experience is a new thing, to celebrate it at the final service as well. Please join us for worship tonight. Come back from dinner early and be present for the supper. Worship is formative and it occurs to me our debates are weakened when we do not worship and commune together. John Bourgeois will be taking us to the table tonight and in his fencing he intends to ask us to examine ourselves and our conflict with each other before partaking. Please, please join us. Worship our Lord, celebrate the supper. Nothing can be a more positive formation on our denomination.

Much love,

Austin Pfeiffer

Winston-Salem, NC

Be here at 3.30 please

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 15, 2017, 2:16:31 PM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

Well,

We've had a difficult day in the assembly voting some peculiar things forward. Voting numbers have been down. Overture two remains and I believe it needs to be voted down. The docket is a mess which means without a SPECIAL ORDER forcing an Overtures report at 4.30Pm we will likely have an OC report sometime after dinner with the "middle" being more absent than we'd like (the crowd is ordinarily light in evening sessions).

So we need you here at 3.30 for the vote to amend the docket so that the OC report occurs at 430. Then we need you here at 4.30 for the report itself! Please spread the word and we will see you at 3.30



rwootton2010

<rwootton2010@gmail.com>

Jun 16, 2017, 7:15:12 AM



to james, thenp@googlegroups.com

James,

Thank you for all you work leading up to and during the Assembly. I wanted to engage this year and wouldn't have been able to as well with you and the rest of the group. I appreciate you all.

Grace and Peace,

Rob Wootton

National Partnership NOTE: Assembly Report

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 17, 2017, 6:35:56 AM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

All,

Saturday morning GA retrospective. There are several things for which to be thankful:

- Worship *has* to be an indicator of something healthy in the PCA. When we turn our eyes to Jesus good things happen in our denomination. It isn't like that everywhere. **We had three beautiful worship services.** There were moments I teared up (that's really emotional for me) at the breadth and beauty of the Gospel presented to us in the liturgy mediated by the body of Christ much broader than we often believe. Even I was there, and given my heart, that's something. We received the means of grace together and it was awesome. The word was preached skillfully with desperate joy.

-The WIMSC-R (Women in Ministry Study Committee - Report) was presented to the PCA and represented some of the best of Presbyterian thought on the issue. It was a study guaranteed to fully please almost no one. And yet most I met found something to be encouraged about. **The presentation of the committee, and specifically the competency of those who authored the report, filled me with pride.** We have been given many gifts in the PCA. If you haven't already read it I would plead with you to do so. The final report felt like it also began a dialogue not just with each other but the *women* in our denomination. My sense was that it urged us, with faithfulness to the

Scriptures, *to open the guild of theologians and leaders to the gifted women in our denomination*. I'm not going to qualify that statement. We have taken our vows and that should be enough.

-The **broadening of our understanding of the body ethnically**. While it was not the aim to elect *somebody* non-white, I was grateful to vote for someone both skillfully orthodox *and* Korean as our moderator. Any denomination must hold to the beauty of the Great Commission's fidelity and mission. When I see diversity it helps me believe the Gospel is true. If the growth of the church in this way is proof of Jesus' Ascension, then it is also proof that he will come again.

-Hearing of the progress of the **Racial Reconciliation Study Committee** - these men are going to present us with an incredible report next year - and their intent to move beyond the report to specific actions, makes me think we are on the verge of a tremendous movement of the Spirit in our churches. The people on this committee are simply at the top of their game. Do pray for them as they continue to work. When the continued funding for this committee came to the floor there was not a peep, not one objection to the continued provision of funds and time for their work. That was incredible.

-The display of **new involvement at this GA**. Many of you in the NP have joined within the last year. Our group of pastors is not large but nearly all of our 200+ were either directly involved in doing the work of the denomination this week, or were engaged at a distance. I worked with a lot of new faces. You new guys were asking good questions, crafting motions, present for every major vote, worshipping well at the evening services, and keeping up with our whiskey consumption. Well done, brothers.

We had significant disappointments too, regarding committee nominations, and a minority report for RPR concerning the images of Jesus. I am not foolish enough to think the National Partnership can insulate us completely from these disappointments, but I take responsibility for not recognizing some key moments, allowing our people to be taken by surprise on the floor of the Assembly. The ground lost is not significant, in my opinion, but the SJC took a casual step to the "right" and personally I would like us to undo, soon, a truly absurd ruling (in my opinion) and misapplied WLC109 exception. In light of what has been accomplished the last four years this is barely a stagger, much less a step backward. I have some ideas about what that means for us moving forward, to ensure that the broad middle of the denomination is represented in these moments. I'll post something in the next couple of weeks as I capture the after-action feedback from others.

My report: this week made me much more thankful for the PCA. That's a good week.

JK



sepccal@comcast.net
<sepccal@comcast.net>

Jun 17, 2017, 7:59:03 AM

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to james, TheNP@googlegroups.com

Concerning WC109 - I forget that some of you are new to this debate which has been a bone of contention since I joined the PCA in 1982. Please read the RPCES study on this matter. This is part of the historical record of the PCA the PCA has never adopted this position. You can read it here: <http://www.pcahistory.org/findingaids/rpces/docsynod/332.html>

And James - a big debt for all your labors. The prize for winning the pool of guessing the number of points of order at next year's GA will be a signed copy of one of James's sermons.

cal

NP NOTE

1 view

Skip to first unread message



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Sep 27, 2017, 4:24:04 PM

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to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Hello friends,

Hope you all enjoyed the summer off from denominational "organizing," but I wanted to give you a bit of a long look at things, including a suggested timeline for involvement in the polity world of the PCA. That is, here's what's next everyone:

My assessment of last year's General Assembly includes the belief that we continue to become healthier as a denomination, while recognizing that we, perhaps, shuffled backwards a step. I believe we made a decision on the floor, regarding the use of images in worship, that was

particularly unhealthy and some committee choices, particularly on the SJC, that will be a challenge for the cause of continued unity and growth. We had extended and highly picky debates that discouraged first-time attenders. Still, there was much to love as there always seems to be.

The health of our denomination can be most affected by the involvement of us all at the following levels:

1. **Presbytery Health** | working toward presbyteries as real courts of care for pastors (a goal that involves the heavy lifting of both pastors AND elders). When our presbyteries are healthy our denomination will be healthy. All of us actively working to resource one another on best practices for presbyteries - including modifying by-laws, planning retreats, selecting meeting schedules most conducive to brotherly love and spiritual formation, etc. Brothers, I am reminded of Ray Cortese's statement about his own presbytery attendance when he said that Central Florida presbytery is so good for him that he would have no problem inviting an unchurched person to attend. Imagine that! We can work toward this together. My goal this year is for us to have a plan in place for strengthening the care present in our presbyteries.
2. **Involvement in the work of the General Assembly** | This means making plans to engage nearly year-round in committee work, planning, reading, discussion groups, etc. We simply have to ensure that there is not a single NP presbytery without representation at the Nominating Committee and RPR. My goal this year is that, at the very least, every one of our presbyteries is engaged in denominational committee work. I hope you will all volunteer for these positions.
3. **Making General Assembly attendance a mandatory expenditure in your budget**, and ensuring that you are present. Believe it or not, if you cannot afford to make it to presbytery there are churches willing to help fund attendees. This year we need to make it our goal that none of the men in this group are prevented from attending GA due to financial constraints. If you are willing to do the committee work and you're willing to show up and vote at the Assembly, we will do our best to get you there. My goal this year is that we establish a regular process for getting underfunded pastors to the Assembly.

The question you may be asking is, "is this really worth the trouble?" I understand that. As a church planter, my time for denominational work has been minimized. But I want to tell you about why I love this denomination. I met the PCA as a know-nothing middle schooler from a broken home. Because the PCA loves church planting a church plant planted a youth group in my neighborhood. It proved to be my lifeline. Because the PCA loves and supports higher education I was able to attend Covenant College while being at a significant financial disadvantage. That's where I met my wife, where I solidified my calling to ministry, where I learned about Kuyper and Schaeffer, Keller and Novenson and Neighbors, where I first experienced cross-cultural ministry and the Trinity Hymnal. Because the PCA loves to train pastors, even broken ones (there are no other kinds), my wife and I found Covenant Seminary and were trained to meet sin with redemption, everywhere. And because the PCA loves the future of God more than golden past I have been led by many voices toward optimism about what we can accomplish in a world expecting much, much less from churches and ministers. I really do believe we have the best game in town, and we have the tools to lovingly engage and protect the vulnerable and preach with power and heal wounds. But this will not just happen. It requires highly dedicated men and women to be committed to the cause in our little corner of the Church.

Ten years ago in my little town thirty percent regularly attended church. Now it's one in eight. I bet my little town isn't much different than yours in that regard. The field is ripe for harvest and this is the field the Lord has given us and these are the tools. My argument for dedicated engagement is simple: let's do the best we can with what we have.

More next week. Start looking at your presbytery meeting schedule to figure out when you need to get your name in the hat for committees, NomCom or RPR. Thanks, all of you, for indulging me here and for joining in the work.

JK

the NP: One quick correction.

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Sep 28, 2017, 10:20:20 AM

✉



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Thankful to Cal Boroughs who, in addition to being a fine churchman, pointed out my autocorrect mistake. Randy **Nabors**, of course, not Neighbors, is a name worth getting right. And it gives me a quick chance to brag on him once again - in college my first thought that Heaven would be better than I expected was a visit to New City in Chattanooga. Is it possible to pay a higher compliment to the church of Jesus? May we all show people the Kingdom even better than we preach it.

Warmly,

JK

Quick Partnership NOTE

1 view

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Oct 12, 2017, 2:16:49 PM

≡



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Hello all,

I wanted to write this note to remind you of two things:

1. You are about to enter into fall presbytery meetings. NOW, not later, is the time to ask your stated clerk or nominating committee to add you to these particular committees: Nominating Committee (one-day meeting in Atlanta, expenses paid), Review of Presbytery Records (multi-day meeting in Atlanta in May, expenses paid), Overtures Committee at the Assembly. Those three are of critical importance and all of you have as much right as any in your presbytery to participate in this critical work. I'm interested in the broadest possible representation of the PCA in her courts; I believe we are a good reflection of the majority, so we need to participate in the work. We will keep track, here, of those who are already serving and which presbyteries have made their appointments so you can know where vacancies exist.

2. I have said many times that I do not intend for the NP to be a "visioning" organization, and I want to keep to that promise. But I would like to offer the following observation, as just one of the many here. As always I will not be putting forth any kind of public initiative, but I hope you'll indulge me.

During my time in the denomination we have assumed a Progressive-Conservative dance as a ritual we needed to fulfill in order to live as the PCA. The assumption is that conservatives need progressives and progressives need conservatives, that the PCA must keep her fringes healthy by pursuing a sort of, forgive me for the wonkish term, a dialectic - a see-saw of give and take where we expect to be pulled in both directions and so we by necessity settle somewhere in the middle. I do not agree with that. While I believe there is a majority, I am not fond of calling that majority, the "middle." Instead, I would like to see us conceive together of the greatest things we can do in fulfilling the Great Commission and go there not with a balance born of the Progressive-Conservative dance, a slow, clumsy, trot around the same old fields of harvest. Instead what if we did not worry about whether we were creating friction, or objection, and simply went for the Gospel as the best version of the PCA that we can be? What if we determined to find fields where we haven't reaped, whether in poorer communities as well as wealthier communities, rural and urban, minority as well as majority populations? What if we were free to ask questions about the way we've always done things, to amend whatever needs to be amended - to reform, continually, whatever we

need to reform? To look at ourselves and see who we really are, in 2017, as a denomination, and be willing to seek the Lord's counsel for our future together. And when we hear it, to go unreservedly.

I believe the only thing limiting this generation of pastors and elders in that task is our dedication to the dialectic, the dance, the see-saw. It takes two to see-saw; I'm recommending that we give it up.

Now I don't want you to fear that I've lost my commitment to charity and love for all our brothers (and sisters) at work in the denomination. And know also that I love and embrace our fathers and grandfathers in the PCA. I cannot begin to express all that we owe them. Part of what we owe them is a vital, courageous, beautiful denomination. In the process we will have to free ourselves from thinking that charity and love for all means that we cannot charitably run instead of walking, that we cannot continue to love our friends and co-laborers from the boundaries of other denominations, in other corners of the Kingdom of God. Please think and pray about this, that we might approach this year's denominational work asking only to see Jesus and to do what he does.

More next week. Do that committee work!

JK

NP Note

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Nov 8, 2017, 4:26:33 PM

⌵



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Just a quick reminder.

The best venues for involvement at GA: **The Overtures Committee**, Admin Committee

The best “bang for your buck” committee work:

The **Nominating Committee** (meets in March) and **Review of Presbytery Records** (meets in May)

NOW is the time to alert the clerk of your presbytery about your interest in these particular areas.

To Do:

1. Volunteer for committee work with your Clerk
2. Let me know where you're volunteering so that we can put together a vacancies list.

Can you communicate with your Clerk within the next week?

Thanks so much for helping us serve the denomination and our little corner of the Kingdom.

JK

NP NOTE

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Dec 13, 2017, 10:13:29 AM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Quick reminder, before we go into the Christmas communication vacuum, that we are asking you to make your intentions known to your presbytery clerks NOW about your desire to stand for nomination to denominational committees and General Assembly Committees of Commissioners.

We've received some of your updated committee work, **please let us know**, in particular, if you've been added to the Nominating Committee, Review of Presbytery Records, or the Overtures Committee (these three are the most critical areas of involvement for ensuring the work of the denomination is done well), and other General Assembly work.

Thanks all.

hjin29

<hjin29@gmail.com>

unread,

Dec 13, 2017, 11:41:48 AM



to james, TheNP@googlegroups.com

I'm on the Nominating Committee. Korean Capital Presbytery.

Hansoo Jin

Pastor

2018

NP NOTE: Committee Assignments, so far

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jan 3, 2018, 1:16:00 PM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Hello all,

Just a quick update on where we stand so far, though I know if missed a handful of you that notified me a while back. We need to pick up the ball on committee assignments. If you haven't notified your clerk of your intent to serve, please do. My presbytery, for instance, will be making assignments this month. And if you've notified me but I somehow missed it please let me know!

Nominating Committee

Kyle Hackmann - Eastern Canada

Andy Moehn - Westminster

Hansoo Jin - Korean Capital

Brian Deringer - Piedmont Triad

RPR

Robbie Schmidtberger - Philadelphia Metro West

Ethan Smith - Piedmont Triad

Andy Wood - Blue Ridge

Dave Lindberg - Metro Atlanta

Overtures

Bruce O'Neil - Chesapeake

Hope you had a wonderful holiday. Peace in your labors, friends.

JK

NP Note: 2018 Overtures submitted, committee membership update

1 view

Skip to first unread message



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jan 10, 2018, 1:56:06 PM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Hello all,

Just wanted to give you an update on a couple of things:

I. 2018 Overtures Way-Too-Early-Update

-There have been 8 received so far, FIVE from Calvary Presbytery. Here's a link: <http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/>. I don't want to open discussion on these yet except to observe that the Calvary overtures appear to take aim at the power of Ad Interim committees to conduct business through the Assembly, forcing all business through the Overtures Committee. There are a couple regarding making BCO 59 (solemnization of marriage) constitutional in the hopes of protecting ministers from pressure to officiate gay weddings. I did not vote for this overture when we received it last year in committee, but it was sent back to be perfected. It is back. There is also an overture from Tennessee Valley seeking to address holes in the process of restoring a deposed minister. We will talk about these, and others, in the spring as we approach the Assembly.

II. Committee participation: Here's the updated tally, NP guys on committees: [update us if you have jumped on to one of these]

Nominating Committee

Kyle Hackmann - Eastern Canada

Andy Moehn - Westminster

Hansoo Jin - Korean Capital

Brian Deringer - Piedmont Triad

Sam DeSocio - New York State

Brian Ferry - Ohio Valley

Dan Herron - Central Indiana

Ben Lyon - Tidewater

Jonathan Winfred - Southwest Florida

Sean Roberts - Northern New England

RPR

Robbie Schmidtberger - Philadelphia Metro West

Ethan Smith - Piedmont Triad

Andy Wood - Blue Ridge

Dave Lindberg - Metro Atlanta

Wayne Larson - Iowa
Kevin Rodgers - Eastern Canada

Overtures

Bruce O'Neil - Chesapeake
Jonathan Winfree Southwest Florida

Brothers, get yourself on the Overtures committee, please. Notify your clerks of your intent!

Thanks all,
JK

National Partnership Note

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Feb 28, 2018, 4:48:06 PM

主



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

Hello all,

I. 2018 Overtures Update

<http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/>. We will open discussion on these after the Easter holiday. The Calvary overtures appear to take aim at the power of Ad Interim committees to conduct business through the Assembly, forcing all business through the Overtures Committee. There are a couple regarding making BCO 59 (solemnization of marriage) constitutional in the hopes of protecting ministers from pressure to officiate gay weddings. I did not vote for this overture when we received it last year in committee, but it was sent back to be perfected. It is back. There is also an overture from Tennessee Valley seeking to address holes in the process of restoring a deposed minister. Added to the list is a request to raise the notice from one week to one month when leaving the denomination.

II. Committee participation: Here's the updated tally, NP guys on committees: [update us if you have jumped on to one of these]

Nominating Committee

Kyle Hackmann - Eastern Canada
Andy Moehn - Westminster
Hansoo Jin - Korean Capital

Brian Deringer - Piedmont Triad
Sam DeSocio - New York State
Brian Ferry Jr. - Ohio Valley
Dan Herron - Central Indiana
Ben Lyon - Tidewater
Jonathan Winfred - Southwest Florida
Sean Stessman Roberts - Northern New England
Erik Bonkovsky - James River
Jon Price - Pittsburgh Presbytery
Hace Cargo - Metro Atlanta Presbytery
James Kessler - Columbus Metro Presbytery
Tim LeCroy - Missouri
Justin Edgar - Build That Wall Presbytery
Aaron Baker - Chicago Metro
Joel St.Clair - Potomac
Peter Rowan -
EJ Nusbaum - Rocky Mtn.

RPR

Robbie Schmidtberger - Philadelphia Metro West
Ethan Smith - Piedmont Triad
Andy Wood - Blue Ridge
Dave Lindberg - Metro Atlanta
Wayne Larson - Iowa
Kevin Rogers - Eastern Canada
James Kessler - Columbus Metro Presbytery
Tim LeCroy - Missouri

Overtures

Bruce O'Neil - Chesapeake
Jonathan Winfree South West Florida
Joshua Reitano - Ohio Valley
James Kessler - Columbus Metro Presbytery
Shane Gibson - Southern Louisiana
Cal Burroughs - TVP
Austin Pfeiffer - Piedmont Triad
Geoff Ziegler - Chicago Metro
Rob Wooten - James River
David Richmon - PNW
Mark Bates - Rocky Mtn
David Lindberg - Metro Atlanta

What this means:

1. If we do not get a dramatic increase in the number of guys on Overtures, this is going to be a very difficult and discouraging assembly. My view of overtures over the last couple of years has been that those on the committee with a very strong minority viewpoint, perhaps you could call it *strongly conservative and narrow* have been over-represented while the “middle” of the denomination has been squeezed out. I think this will be the case, again, unless men are willing to step forward in their presbyteries, even where there is a “legacy” member, someone that is willing to be on the committee, so they end up serving most years. There’s nothing wrong with asking the presbytery to vote on representation to these committees, brothers. Now’s the time to speak up; notify your stated clerk of your intent.

2. I expect a hard push (in view of the overtures submitted) to push forward limits on the CMC's scope and effectiveness, and to further restrict any remaining Session discretion regarding the election and utilization of women in diagonal roles. While it is true that Overtures may be defeated on the floor, neglecting the work of the OC produces a floor agenda that discourages us all and prevents an opportunity to send *good* overtures to the floor.

TO DO:

1. Be sure you're serving somewhere.
2. Research the overtures. Set aside a window of time every week, even 20 minutes, to read through an overture and capture your thoughts. It will be a great help to you in June.
3. Jump on the NP website and check to make sure your listing, under "roster," is correct. Some of you have transitioned. If you have an update on your listing, please send to todd.g...@icloud.com

Anticipate an NP note every couple of weeks from here on out.

Brothers, get yourself on the Overtures committee, please. Notify your clerks of your intent!

Thanks all,
JK

NP: Overtures committee membership update

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Apr 4, 2018, 4:12:01 PM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Quick question

I will be sending an update soon but want to see if we are any closer or overtures membership. **Does anyone have an update to Overtures membership? In particular, which of you have jumped on the Overtures committee?**

Overtures

Bruce O'Neil - Chesapeake

Charles Anderson - Central Indiana

Jonathan Winfree Southwest Florida

Joshua Reitano - Ohio Valley

James Kessler - Columbus Metro Presbytery

Shane Gibson - Southern Louisiana
Cal Burroughs - TVP
Austin Pfeiffer - Piedmont Triad
Geoff Ziegler - Chicago Metro
Rob Wooten - James River
David Richmon - PNW
Mark Bates - Rocky Mtn
E.J. Nusbaum - Rocky Mtn
David Lindberg - Metro Atlanta
Bruce Terrell - Metro New York
Sam DeSocio - New York State
Charles Garland - Arizona
David Juelfs - South Coast
Hansoo Jin - Korean Capital

NP NOTE: Beautiful Orthodoxy, October 23-25, 2018

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Apr 10, 2018, 5:11:29 PM

主



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Dear friends,

You are the first to hear the news that a group of PCA pastors and ministry leaders have created a new conference to celebrate the potential for kingdom work in the PCA. For those of you in the NP I think this is a great expression of what it means for us to be connectional and missional as a denomination. We are particularly hopeful that ministers may bring their wives and female staff members with them. The conference is structured with four complete worship services, a number of keynote speakers, and several “beautiful orthodoxies” — testimonies of the work of God as we hold to the truth of the Gospel. Exciting stuff. Needed stuff.

Please give it a look and register soon. There are only 300 spots available and we will be sharing the news of the conference widely beginning tomorrow morning.

<http://beautifulorthodoxypca.com/>

October 23-25, 2018

More to come. Excited to see many of you in October!

NP NOTE

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Apr 18, 2018, 4:55:27 PM

≡



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[The following communication is confidential and may not be shared without the permission of the sender]

Partnership Website: <http://thenationalpartnership.com> (password: 'ps2211')

I. Joining the NP

II. Overtures committee representation update

III. New GA Schedule

IV. Beautiful Orthodoxy: October 23-25, Cincinnati, OH

In 2 weeks we'll begin more formal discussion of the overtures headed to the assembly this year, and share any tools of the trade for those who haven't been to GA before. Thanks, as always, for participating in the work of the church.

I. New NP friends:

TE Jerid Krulish

RE Todd Phillips

TE Jason Cornwell

TE Israel Ruizore

TE Adam Feichtmann

Welcome!

II. Overtures Committee (NP)

Bruce O'Neil - Chesapeake
Charles Anderson - Central Indiana
Jonathan Winfree Southwest Florida
Joshua Reitano - Ohio Valley
James Kessler - Columbus Metro Presbytery
Shane Gibson - Southern Louisiana
Cal Burroughs - TVP
Austin Pfeiffer - Piedmont Triad
Geoff Ziegler - Chicago Metro
Rob Wootton - James River
David Richmon - PNW
Mark Bates - Rocky Mtn
E.J. Nusbaum - Rocky Mtn
David Lindberg - Metro Atlanta
Bruce Terrell - Metro New York
Sam DeSocio - New York State
Charles Garland - Arizona
Adam Feichtmann - South Coast
Hansoo Jin - Korean Capital
Dave Abney - North Florida
Kevin Twit - Nashville
Travis Scott - Pittsburgh
Josh Eby - South Texas

Let me know if you should be added to this list! I'd say that so many of you willing to jump in and participate at the OC is a good sign for this year's assembly.

III. New GA Schedule

Just a quick note: if you check out this year's Assembly schedule you may be surprised to see that the **Overtures committee report is scheduled for Friday AM**, when you may be expecting to be catching a flight home. This is a big deal. Obviously if a large percentage of the Assembly is at the airport, **whatever minority is left over could have a disproportional effect on the assembly**. I'm guessing there will be an attempt to amend the docket since altering the travel plans of 1000 or so people is less likely than getting the docket amended. At any rate, if you can change your plans please do so.

IV. Beautiful Orthodoxy: October 23-25, Cincinnati, OH

Check out this new PCA pastor's conference taking place **October 23-25 in Cincinnati, Ohio**, the purpose of which is to celebrate and promote a beautiful orthodoxy in our denomination. This conference was born out of the vision for the PCA expressed in many places, including Ray Cortes' General Assembly Sermon, "A Beautiful Orthodoxy." Lots of worship, some great ministry stories, preaching, equipping. It is our hope that this will be a yearly opportunity for pastors, their spouses, and their ministry staff to be ministered *to* and rest in hope. More information here:

<http://beautifulorthodoxypca.com>

NP Note

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

May 16, 2018, 3:28:38 PM

≡



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

A quick note to let you know that as members of the NP you are free to use our discussion group on Facebook.

We are beginning discussions on overtures there.

To join follow this link:

<https://www.facebook.com/groups/237759476709705/?ref=bookmarks>

I am also glad to discuss any issues via the NP website if you are not on Facebook. My intent is to provide the platform most conducive to discussion.

The list of overtures to the Assembly can be found here:

<http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/>

More to come!

JK

This week's GA prep.

3 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 4, 2018, 8:54:19 AM

主



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

Hello all,

Just want to give you a heads up that by the middle of the week we will send along a collaborative document summarizing some of the discussion occurring on the NP Facebook page about particular overtures. We just want to make sure everyone has access to the best resources for an informed vote. This will be a draft document, and I hope to inform it further through your responses. Please feel free to dialogue with me and I will share your views on a second draft later in the week.

As in former years you will have an overtures guide (NOT a “voting” guide, but overtures advice/resources), and a schedule for the week, including key voting moments. Let me know if there is more I can do to help you navigate the GA.

Looking forward to seeing many of you in seven days!

JK

2018 NP overtures advice (first draft)

3 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 7, 2018, 9:06:10 PM

主



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

This is the first draft of the 2018 GA overtures advice book. Lots of help putting this together. Call it the Little Red Book. I'm kidding.

A few notes:

1. I anticipate this draft changing as we continue our discussion here and as the NP guys on the OC talk a bit.
2. Overture 8 may shift. I deeply respect Cal Boroughs and it was sent from his session. I'll give him every opportunity to shift the thinking.
3. Please, Please, Please remember that this is a consensus advisory document. It is particularly helpful to those who feel a little lost in the weeds at this stage. NO ONE is expected to conform. We want unity, not uniformity.
4. Last you are NOT free to share this document outside the NP, but you are free to share the advice.

Here's the link:

<https://www.dropbox.com/s/s79ekg3p727vl5/2018%20PCA%20GA%20Advice.pdf?dl=0>



ssauls

<ssauls@christpres.org>

unread,

Jun 8, 2018, 6:01:21 AM



to james, National Partnership

James, I can't tell you how much I personally appreciate the hard work you do on this. You serve us well and we are all so grateful.

Scott S.

NP: Newer version of overtures advice

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 8, 2018, 12:22:12 PM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

My apologies to you all, the version sent out earlier is not as up to date as this proper version - see esp. overture 13.

<https://www.dropbox.com/s/n8z9rbpbs43gzlw/2018%20PCA%20GA%20Advice%28V2%29.pdf?dl=0>

Advice re: overture 3

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 8, 2018, 2:18:35 PM



to NP

Received this background and thought it was a helpful counter to our advice on Overture 3

"I write to give some background to my opposition to #3 that actually came to GA from my presbytery: South Florida. Our session came through a very painful case that went to the GA. We sought wisdom and direction through the Stated Clerk of the GA's office during this time as our session had never taken any matter to the SJC. During the process, we learned that a brother was consulting for the individual who did so much damage to our staff, session, and congregation. This brother armed someone who has caused significant harm to the church and the PCA as a whole.

It was during this time that I became disabused of bringing outside counsel to church sessions and presbyteries as a whole. I could see/can see the day when cases/trials/complaints are "litigated" through the courts of the church with roving experts who relish the idea of going before a church court. These folks enjoy the very things we hope to avoid. I think the original BCO provisions were wise to protect the courts from this as much as possible. I hope we will not open the door further. As

things stand now, anyone can seek the wisdom of others as they deal with matters before the courts of the church. This should be more than enough help.”

GA SCHEDULE.

1 view

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 12, 2018, 12:45:02 PM



to NP

Most updated GA schedule with important vote times. NOTE: anything not a SPECIAL ORDER is subject to change.

<https://www.dropbox.com/s/6fm2wmvvtdcpbm/GA46%20SCHEDULE.pdf?dl=0>

GA day one review, today's schedule.

3 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 13, 2018, 7:07:03 AM



to NP

Hello all,
Wanted to give you a little of a review of what's happened so far in the GA.

1. The **Overtures Committee** results generally followed the line of our OC advice, with one exception. Overtures 13/26 were denied, allowing for unordained persons to have the ability to vote on committee. To me the ruling by our CCB that the overtures were in conflict with the constitution provided too high an obstacle to overcome. For those who are not sure they are ready to have the vote given to, for instance, women in committee meetings, the CCB recommendation was an easy way out. My guess is that we will see this type of overture again in 2019, but without the constitutional conflicts.

2. There is some rumbling that the OC “declined to make traditional marriage mandatory/constitutional,” through the declining of multiple requests to dust **BCO 59** (pious advice on Marriage) with constitutional power. This is, at best, a distortion of the work of the committee and should be corrected wherever it is heard. What the OC said by declining those overtures is that “traditional” marriage is ALREADY constitutional and mandatory via our standards (WCF et al.). The OC saw overtures which would not reinforce but simply repeat what is said elsewhere. Given that BCO 59 was not written with constitutional language, it seemed odd to grant that chapter constitutional power. We can praise God that that the OC knocked on the walls establishing Biblical marriage in the PCA and found they are, still, load-bearing.

GA SCHEDULE

This link gives you our current schedule including key votes. We will let you know when it is updated as times change:

<https://www.dropbox.com/s/6fm2wmvvvtdcpbm/GA46%20SCHEDULE.pdf?dl=0>

-The moderator election and first session of the assembly are of critical importance as we amend the docket to ensure that overtures are voted on Thursday instead of Friday. **Please be there to vote at 3pm.**

-**RPR** is scheduled for 4.30p. Last year an unfortunate action of the Assembly reversed a key finding of the committee due to very low voter participation. Do not miss this committee report, please!

Vote reminder: 10 minutes

2 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 13, 2018, 2:10:18 PM

≡



to NP

The moderator vote and amended docket vote will take place in 10 minutes. Come To the assembly floor.

NP advice regarding nominations.

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 14, 2018, 1:19:50 AM

主



to NP

[you may not share this document without the author's permission]

Tomorrow, at 11.15a, we will stop whatever's occurring at the General Assembly in order to obey a special order and hear the report of the Nominating committee. I wanted to provide you with my own conclusions and rationale in the hopes that it may help you to decide for yourselves. I believe this is an excellent slate and heartily recommend them. As always, the NP are free to vote however they believe the Lord to lead.

NOTE: The chairman will share with us a set of nominees that were approved by their presbyteries, then stood against multiple other candidates (in most cases) at the Nominating Committee meeting and prevailed in those votes in order to come to the floor as recommended. The Assembly has the right to put up "floor nominees" to oppose the recommended slate of candidates from the committee. If you are not sure your candidate will be selected by the committee but the candidate has significant name recognition, making them a floor nominee, in many cases, may be a way to avoid the process of approval by both presbytery *and* committee. While we should all agree that a provision allowing floor votes is wise and helpful, it is fair to conclude that the floor nominations come with less "weight" and approbation.

Here is my recommended slate, with rationale

ADMIN COMMITTEE

TE David Richter

TE Kevin DeYoung

Despite DeYoung's significant blogging personality, his relatively short time in the denomination (I believe this is his 2nd attended GA) and narrow experience in PCA polity pales in comparison to Richter's broad and deep experience in the PCA, experience which is useful on the permanent committee of administration.

TE Walter "Jerry" Schriver

TE Carlton Wynne

There is a mountain of evidence in Schriver's bio that he has the administrative experience and interest when compared with Wynne's primarily academic experience. For the Administrative Committee, this is of primary importance, the defining criteria.

TE Ian Hard

TE Bob Brunson

Again, this is a question of fittedness for the particular committee. Brunson has twice chaired this committee; his institutional memory is helpful and needed.

RE Jon A. Ford

RE Frank Cohee

Ford has proven, repeatedly, to be suited administratively - chairing multiple organizational boards. While Cohee has some experience in administrative matters before the church, it does not overcome Ford's advantage, and his place as the committee's candidate.

CCB

TE Joel St. Clair

TE Steve Tipton

CCB requires a breadth of knowledge regarding the operation of the Assembly and the Assembly's constitution. While Tipton has a commendable presbytery record, it is not at St. Clair's level. The CCB's work is critical to the proper function of the Assembly. I am more confident in St. Clair, the committee's nominee.

COVENANT COLLEGE

TE Leon Brown

TE Brian Cosby

While Cosby has significant author credits to his name, this is a position focused on the nurturing of a higher education mission, and both seem to have a hand in the education mission of Covenant. When the bios are this close in terms of obvious qualifications, it isn't unreasonable to consider the question of diversity. As one of our fifty-something African American ministers, it would be valuable to welcome Leon's input by adding him to the committee. His role in the Women in Ministry study committee is useful for a school whose enrollment is mostly women.

CDM

TE Chad Bailey

TE Danny Kwon

Danny's experience in Education Ministries instruction would seem to be a natural fit for CDM

COVENANT THEOLOGICAL SEMINARY

TE Doug Serven

TE Aaron Myers

I am grateful for the influence of RUF ministers at the seminary level. Beyond the value of this RUF/Covenant partnership, I would have serious questions about TE Myers for this particular post. Please forgive me for speaking here about my concerns, I know "speeches against" nominees are typically out of order! But Just a few years ago on the floor of the GA TE Myers spoke at length about the fact that the General Assembly has the "blood of our covenant children on its head" for our tolerance of paedocommunion (a charge completely without evidence, and a speech which could not be considered "temperate"). Consequently, this does not seem to be a wise post for TE Myers.

ICR

TE Kevin Rogers

TE Caleb Cangelosi

For a committee aimed at growing our proper inter-denominational relationships, It would seem that a man whose experience spans several denominations would have useful input on this committee. Additionally our strategic plan calls for increased diversity on these committees. TE Cangelosi is from Mississippi valley, a very well-represented region. Rogers, is one of the few and proud from Eastern Canada. It seems useful to grow in diverse representation. Rogers is also the committee's recommendation.

MNA

RE Charles Dumas

RE Keith Goben

RE David Marr

Goben's experience in helping to lead a church planting movement in a very difficult place makes him an ideal and superior choice for MNA

MTW

TE James Richter

Maranatha Chung

Richter has been the alternate for consecutive years. His experience in ministry to cross - cultural contexts is significant. He knows the committee well and should be an easy transition into voting member.

RUF

RE Chuck Duggan

RE Todd Phillips

Both are excellent. But Duggan's RUF-committee experience is preferred.

THEOLOGICAL EXAMINING COMMITTEE

RE Hans Madueme

RE David Talcott

Hans is far and away more qualified for this role.

Thank you all. I hope this is helpful! Please let me know if you have any further questions. You are more than welcome to share this advice, I only ask that you not *forward this document*.

TOMORROW MORNING, 11.15A IS THE NOMINATIONS COMMITTEE. PLEASE BE THERE TO VOTE, THESE MARGINS WILL BE VERY SMALL.

Prayer for Sean Roberts' dad

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 14, 2018, 5:37:55 AM



to NP

Brothers,

Woke up to find an email sent a few hours ago by Sean Roberts and he gave me permission to share. He is on his way out of Atlanta as his father has suffered a massive heart attack. This was completely unexpected and the prognosis is not good. Please pray for Sean and his family. And pray that our Lord may be pleased to save his Father's life.

VOTE ALERT

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 14, 2018, 10:10:22 AM



to NP

Nominating Committee beginning NOW.

Overture on abuse and sexual assault

2 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



jmullen79
<jmullen79@gmail.com>
unread,
Jun 15, 2018, 5:34:52 PM



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

NP squad,

I'm well on my way with an overture for a study committee on abuse and sexual assault. The goal would be to supply the church with (1) pastoral care resources, (2) policy recommendations, and (3) an exploration of changes to the Rules of Discipline that protect victims.

If you're interested in helping me refine it, please let me know!

Jeremy

--

Rev. Jeremy M. Mullen
Reformed University Fellowship, Harvard University
www.harvard.ruf.org
jeremy...@ruf.org
[978-473-1383](tel:978-473-1383)



Jerid Krulish
<pastor@solochristo.org>
unread,
Jun 15, 2018, 5:35:44 PM



to jmullen79, TheNP@googlegroups.com

Count me in.

Jerid E. Krulish
Pastor, Westminster Presbyterian Church
Vancouver, WA
www.solochristo.org

Chairman, Pacific NW Presbytery Credentials Committee/
<http://www.pacificnorthwestpresbytery.com/credentials-committee/>



james
<james@newcityhilliard.org>
unread,
Jun 15, 2018, 5:44:35 PM



to pastor@solochristo.org, jmullen79, TheNP@googlegroups.com

Excellent! Please all respond ONLY to Jeremy in order to keep from flooding the rest of the NP thanks! Glad to see this moving forward!

Final NP NOTE

2 views

Skip to first unread message



james
<james@newcityhilliard.org>
unread,
Jun 15, 2018, 9:39:31 AM



to NP

Well the 46th General Assembly is in the books.

As always, my last note is full of bullet points because it's all I've got at this point in the week!

- The **leadership** of the PCA was further clarified this week. The people leading this denomination are: Irwyn Ince, Alex Jun, Lloyd Kim, Derek Halverson, Howie Donahoe, Larry Hoop, Bruce O'Neil, Sean Lucas, Mike Khandjian. That's a good group. We are in good hands. That's an incredible change from six years ago when we started the NP.

- We put to bed the ridiculous question of whether the PCA is willing to own her constitutional statements regarding **biblical marriage**. On to the next crisis.

- We are within reach of asserting a proper view of the **ministry of women** in the PCA. Practice is still a long ways away, but I believe the change in our polity leading to women on boards and

agencies in the PCA is only one year from reality. If men are going to exercise authority in the courts of the PCA in true fruitfulness, they will require the committee work of both men *and* women in service to the Lord's Church.

- Central Indiana presbytery saved us from a fawning **Morton Smith** memorial on the floor of the Assembly. Because any MS memorial reading would require Central Indiana's more honest memorial to be read as well, the Smith contingent at the Assembly was willing to have the memorials ruled out of order. Dan Herron is owed a real debt of gratitude. Thank you, brother.

- We unequivocally spoke in favor of **abused and bullied women**. Even where we did not have a remedy available to us, there were floor speeches and prayers that allowed us to speak publicly so that those hoping and watching would know that they are not alone. The PCA continues to trend toward a real, strong, unity in the body for the sake of those who need an advocate. This kind of care is dear to the heart of Jesus. I was grateful to see it. May it result in greater vigilance and a more robust polity that maintains the church's core ministry to outsiders.

You won't hear from me for a while, but thank you.

Last night we shared a toast among NP guys and others in my room. What I expressed there I want to express here: we cannot do this without you. It is one man, one vote on the floor of the GA, in the Nominating committee and RPR, the Committee of commissioners and the SJC. You are all doing your part to help lead the Church whose head is Christ. We are blessed to know that we are not alone in our love for the PCA and commitment to her well being. Thank you, thank you.

May our God grant you delight and rest in your labors, and may you experience deep joy as you are Christs to the sheep and the lost ones and the little ones in your cities.



e.j.nusbaum.b7ci

<e.j.nusbaum.b7ci@statefarm.com>

unread,

Jun 15, 2018, 9:57:59 AM

主



to james, NP

And let us not forget that Ruling Elders are no longer required to be grave. 😊

I would be willing to gather and work with a group to figure out the path and proper sequence/steps needed to get the BCO changed so that non-ordained persons may be added to the appropriate boards and agencies.

Thanks for your good work James!

In Him!

EJ



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 15, 2018, 11:14:54 AM

主



to kevinjtwit, e.j.nusbaum.b7ci, NP, ssauls, dcassidy3817, vomarortiz, David Richter

Everyone who has asked to be a part of this effort:

Scott Sauls
David Cassidy
EJ Nusbaum
Omar Ortiz
Sean Lucas
David Richter
James Kessler

Looks like a good group to me. I would consider adding Larry Hoop as well.

servenator

<servenator@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 15, 2018, 4:49:21 PM

主



to james, kevinjtwit, e.j.nusbaum.b7ci, NP, ssauls, dcassidy3817, vomarortiz, David Richter

AMEN!!!!!!

-

Rev. Doug Serven

dcassidy3817

<David.Cassidy@christcommunity.org>

unread,

Jun 15, 2018, 5:09:45 PM

主



to james, kevinjtwit, e.j.nusbaum.b7ci, NP, ssauls, vomarortiz, David Richter

I'm all in.

David Cassidy Sent from my iPhone



Dan Herron

<dan@hopebtown.org>

unread,

Jun 15, 2018, 7:37:00 PM

主



to dcassidy3817, james, kevinjtwit, e.j.nusbaum.b7ci, NP, ssauls, vomarortiz, David Richter

So great to be laboring alongside this band of brothers

I'm praising God for his work in our midst

Custom, thumb-typed message from...

Dan Herron

Beautiful Orthodoxy

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 27, 2018, 1:05:44 PM

主



to NP

Hello all,

Sorry to ruin your post-GA radio silence, but I wanted to remind you that registration continues for Beautiful Orthodoxy, a PCA-centered conference for ministry practitioners. We are excited about the impact of this kind of gathering to inspire and equip. We hope you can make it!

So much of what we see in our denomination is polarized, truncated theology applied. I, along with Ray Cortese and Josh Reitano, wanted to put together an annual conference that was specific to the work of the Kingdom in the PCA, a conference that helped us collaborate and celebrate the orthodoxy at work in our denomination. Some of you went to the Gathering Dinner (Mike Khandjian's group) during General Assembly. Think of Beautiful Orthodoxy like Mike's dinner, but spread over three days.

We hope you can join us by registering at the link below. Can't wait to see you all.

Best,
JK

<http://beautifulorthodoxypca.com>

Why I'm taking my team to the Beautiful Orthodoxy conference

1 view



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jul 26, 2018, 7:39:53 AM



to NP

I wanted to take a moment to give you some insight into the value and importance of the upcoming Beautiful Orthodoxy conference, **October 23-25**. No doubt, there are a lot of conferences out there designed to help you think about "mission," and "gospel," not to mention "ministry." Certainly this conference does that as well. But as a church planter, with a very small budget, I thought I'd tell you why I'm paying to bring six of my leadership team members with me:

1. This is a **PCA-centered conference**. I want my people to understand why we are in this denomination, and what God can do in and through us as we lock arms with churches across the country and around the world. There are truly beautiful stories and vistas that aren't shared until we create a forum to share them.

2. While there is much *information*, **there is even more spiritual formation**. I need this - my people need this too - desperately, and it is good for us to hear the Gospel preached and ministered by someone else every once in a while. We need to be inspired and shaped for our work together! We

patterned this conference on four values we feel are intrinsic to orthodoxy: beauty, truth, love, and rest. There will be a lot of worship, and some incredible preaching, the Lord's Supper will be shared, we will pray and sing with a wonderful - truly wonderful - group from Grace DC and New City Cinci. We expect you to leave being healed and renewed.

3. I want my people to see **a broader view of the PCA** than the typical suburban context. I want them to see men and women from all walks of life teaching and challenging and sharing the story of the Gospel in ways that allow us to dream bigger for Hilliard, Ohio, where we live. Maybe you want that for *your* people too, in your context.

We would love to have you join us. If you're already planning on it, **would you consider registering soon?** We are trying to nail down some fun fellowship opportunities for the evenings that require a good sense of our group size. To that end we have created a tiered pricing for the conference. Those who have already signed up have taken advantage of the early-bird rate of \$175. That number jumps to **\$200** on August 21st, and **\$225** October 1st.

You can register at:

<http://beautifulorthodoxypca.com/registration.html>

Thanks for considering this - hope to see you there!

James Kessler

Beautiful Orthodoxy is just TWO weeks away!

1 view



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Oct 10, 2018, 3:15:55 PM



to NP

Just two weeks away, this conference will be an incredible celebration of what it looks like for people in ministry to express orthodox faith in the world. If you're a ministry practitioner in the PCA this conference is for you. Wonderful worship, preaching, teaching, community. Still time to sign up.

As I've said before, I believe this is a wonderful opportunity in the life of the PCA to gather and dream about what we can accomplish as a connectional denomination. I hope I see you there!
JK

<http://beautifulorthodoxypca.com/>

2019

National Partnership NOTE

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jan 30, 2019, 3:49:04 PM



to NP

{The content of this email may not be shared without the permission of the sender}

Friends,

It's that time again. I waited as long as possible before firing up the Partnership for 2019, but it's time.

Wanted to give you a few updates and things to keep an eye on.

I. News

II. Calendar

III. To Do

NEWS

My sense is that the next 3-5 years of assembly work will shape the next forty years of the PCA. If we are clear in advocating for greater health in the Presbyterian Church in America, we will all be part of a more beautiful, more orthodox denomination for Kingdom work around the world. But as always, it will require dedicated and sacrificial efforts.

I am not in the habit of reacting to the minority, one which seeks to drag us into a place of greater uniformity with their vision for the PCA; a vision out of line with her original charter; so let's not worry about what other organizations in the PCA are saying or doing. Let's worry about the next healthy thing we can do as a denomination, starting with this year's assembly.

This year's Assembly will focus on a couple of things in particular:

-More concern about the PCA sliding into liberalism. This will center on an overture to remove Covenant as the denominational seminary, as well as overtures asking the denomination to affirm the Nashville Statement (regarding human sexuality and marriage). I will speak strongly against any and all of these measures at a later date and look forward to hearing from you all as well.

Given the easy prejudices of our cultural commitments, it will be important for us to think soberly and sort out the ethical questions of our day biblically and confessionally. I believe we continue to be on excellent footing as a denomination. We need to save our Orthodoxy Voices for when the Gospel is truly at stake in the PCA. This is not that time.

-An opportunity to further clarify how ecclesiastical authority works and how unordained people may serve the denomination. For some this is where they have pledged to go no further - promising to leave the PCA. I can tell you that I have been greatly impressed by the scholarship and wisdom displayed by those advocating a change to our rules regarding the work of unordained people on committees. I've asked Pastor **Larry Hoop** to chime in here as he is part of a working group on this issue. You can read his reasoning at the end of this NP Note.

II. CALENDAR

Feb. 26: Deadline for nominations to permanent committees

March 23: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta

May 29-31: RPR meets in Atlanta

June 25-28: GA meets in Dallas

III. TO DO

-There's always a need to keep things running smoothly. Volunteering for NomCom, or RPR is tending the fire. If we aren't there in force, things fall apart. Please continue to participate in these committees or help your presbytery find someone to take those slots.

-Participating in a GA Committee of Commissioners is an expected part of your role in the NP. Most critical is the Overtures Committee. There will be SIGNIFICANT work in that committee this year and we need very strong participation. This is the primary deliberative body at the Assembly level. Please do all that you can to ensure your presbytery is well represented. A friend of mine recently mentioned the fact that he tried to get on the OC but found that there was an informal process that led to the same people getting on that committee year after year. I cannot stress enough that you must be willing to make this an above-board process. There is no harm insisting that your presbytery vote on their commissioners. Even if the man taking the spot is well thought-of, the goal for each presbytery is to elect someone who represents the membership. The best way to do so is to ask the presbytery to explicitly nominate.

-Given the fire that Covenant Seminary is receiving from the Aquila Report and other gossip outlets, we should also ensure that the majority in the denomination is represented on the CTS Committee of Commissioners.

-The Admin committee is always operating under high scrutiny. Participating in the Admin Committee CoC is a yearly need.

I would rank the need as follows: 1. OC, 2. CTS, 3. Admin

-Let me know if you are serving on a Committee of Commissioners so I can update our records.

A "SPEECH" IN SUPPORT OF OVERTURE W (Pastor Larry Hoop)

Someone might ask "Why should we change the Book of Order concerning membership on our Permanent Committees?" A better question to ask is "Why not?"

This is a better question because of what Scripture teaches us about stewardship. We are called to make the best possible use of our time, talents, finances, etc. This certainly applies to our Church as well as to its individual members. Good stewardship calls for us to place any of our people in the places where they can best serve our Lord in His church unless Scripture imposes some restriction on that arena of service. In other words, we should employ the gifts of all our members ordained or non-ordained, male or female on our Permanent Committees unless there is some Biblical restriction on who may serve on them. In the case of our Permanent Committees, the question is this: is there some Biblical principle that restricts their membership to elders?

The only Biblical reason for this restriction would be that our Committees exercise the *governing authority* that is restricted to elders. Is this the case? Careful consideration of the BCO and RAO reveal that it is not. BCO 15-1 provides a general statement about the function of committees as contrasted to commissions: A committee is appointed to consider, examine, and report. Commissions, however, are authorized to deliberate and conclude the business referred to it. The ordination process illustrates the difference. In most presbyteries, a Credentials *Committee* examines candidates for ordination. This *committee* has the authority to conduct the exam, asking questions within the BCO guidelines. However, it does not have the power to approve the exam. Only the presbytery can do that. Once the candidate is approved, the presbytery appoints a *commission* to carry out the ordination. The commission's action then becomes the action of the presbytery; it has *governing authority* that the Credentials Committee lacks.

BCO 14-1.7 goes beyond this general principle to address the role of General Assembly Permanent Committees specifically: "The Assembly's Committees are to serve and not direct any Church judicatories [that is, church courts]. *They are not to **establish** policy, but rather **execute** policy established by the General Assembly.*"[emphasis added] Thus Committees do not exercise governing authority. This explains why the RAO directs the work of the Permanent Committee (reflected in its Minutes) to be examined by Committees of General Assembly Commissioners annually to ensure that Committees are following the Assembly's directives. Some have argued that these General Assembly Committees of Commissioners are mere "rubber stamps" of the Committees whose records they review. While it is true that, generally speaking, these Committees find the work of the Permanent Committees to be in order, that is more reflective of the fact that there is seldom conflict as to those Committees staying within their bounds or making wise recommendations to the Assembly. However, there have been notable instances

where there has been vigorous debate within a Committee of Commissioners concerning a proposal made by a Permanent Committee, sometimes yielding an alternative proposal. For example, at the 44th General Assembly, the Committee of Commissioners for the Administrative Committee recommended, contrary to the Permanent Committee's recommendation, that a study committee on the role of women in the ministry of the church not be formed. From this it should be noted: the Permanent Committee did not have the authority to set up that committee on its own – it lacked the governing authority to do so. That authority belonged to the court alone. Conclusion: our Permanent Committees are specifically directed *not* to exercise governing authority; therefore, there is not Biblical reason to restrict their membership to elders, and every reason to employ all the appropriately gifted people in our churches in their membership.

[¹It has been argued that Permanent Committees *do* possess a form of governing authority identified as “diatactical” – a word unknown to most of us until it was brought up in connection with an overture similar to this one last year. Diatactical power refers to the authority to implement the circumstances of our polity which is a form of governing authority. However, the person making the argument last year interpreted this to include administering the directives of a court. A moments reflection should reveal that administering the directives of a court can't be a form of governing authority, for then *everyone* involved in administering the directives of our courts would have to be an elder – not just our Permanent Committees, but also all the member of their staff (think of the AC office, all those listed on the MNA brochure, all of our missionaries). A look at the history of our Book of Order and its predecessor, the PCUS Book of Order², gives a more complete idea of how diatactical power is to be understood. The 1867 draft of the PCUS BCO (chapter 5.2.2) identifies diatactical power as the power that allows the Church (through action of its courts) “to establish canons for the government, discipline, worship and extension of the church” – in other words, to *create* the *structure* enshrined in the Book of Order *through which* the directives of Church Courts are carried out. It does not extend to the *carrying out of the directives itself*. In other words, the execution of General Assembly policy, which is the work assigned to the Permanent Committees, is *not* an exercise in diatactical power.]

We strongly believe the PCA is responsible to provide the opportunity for our people to exercise their gifts in all the avenues open to them. However, we recognize that not everyone will be convinced by our arguments. Some will still maintain that Permanent Committees do exercise governing authority, or perhaps, that it is prudent for Permanent Committee membership to be restricted to elders. For this reason, we offer this overture as a compromise. While we believe there should be no restriction to any

of our members being Permanent Committee members, our overture ensures that a majority of each Committee will be ordained elders, with the chair of the committee reserved for elders. We believe this is a reasonable compromise in that it retains elder leadership of the Committees while opening the membership to gifted church members who are not ordained.

¹ I'd use this argument only if somebody brings "dialectical authority" up. That's why it's in brackets.

² This is found on the PCA Historical Center website: "The Historical Development of the PCA Book of Church Order" <http://pcahistory.org/bco/index.html>, an amazing volume of work done by the Wayne Sparkman and the PCA Historical Center

NP NOTE (Overtures/Overtures Committee Edition)

4 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Feb 20, 2019, 12:52:42 PM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

{The content of this email may not be shared without the permission of the sender}

- I. News
- II. Calendar
- III. To Do

NEWS

-A couple letters of concern are reaching Missouri Presbytery as sessions and presbyteries continue to worry about Revoice and the PCA's view of the sinfulness of homosexual desire. I'm sure Missouri will do a fine job answering those questions with clarity as they are in the thick of that conversation regularly and are finishing their own study on the question.

- There are three items, in particular, that I think could do a great amount of good in the PCA, should they be adopted. Perhaps this is a worthy goal for the year.

1. We should be encouraged by this request for a study committee regarding domestic abuse. There's much that needs to be done here to empower and equip

churches: <https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-7-Pacific-NW-Ad-Interim-on-Domestic-Abuse-etc..pdf>

2. This overture regarding the ministry of unordained persons on our committees and agencies in the PCA helps us clarify the nature of delegated authority and opens a venue for the gifts of the unordained to serve the Church. <https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-8-Ohio-Valley-Non-ordained-on-CAs.pdf>

3. We are permitted TWO concurrent Ad-Interim Study Committees (we did this with the Racial Reconciliation and Women in Ministry committees). I would recommend that a presbytery take up a Study Committee very narrowly defined on the nature of Homosexual desire and recommended steps for ministering to those struggling with same sex attraction in the Body of Christ. Below is my reasoning - I welcome your feedback as we all seek to think through this:

“After a few days of mulling over the issue, here's where I am: I think we should push for a study committee. I am not enthusiastic about linking it to the Nashville statement as a substitute, I do not want the SC to be a response to the GRN, or anyone else. So defeat that statement soundly, then approve a committee. My rationale is this:

1. I do believe there is confusion in our denomination, among people of good faith, people in the middle of the PCA, who would like to know how to deal with SSA among the people in our congregation. Revoice exists, in part, because our best strategy has been don't ask-don't tell in the PCA. The voices that speak the loudest for many of these pastors and elders, youth pastors and directors, are not our best voices.

2. The question of homosexual attraction should be answered in line with biblical anthropology and an orthodox doctrine of sin. Are we content that the lines of argument end up with, “well would you call yourself an adulterous Christian?” Well yeah, actually, I would consider myself both sinner and saint. The difference between having personal piety and being pietistic is our willingness to see that personal holiness pleads the blood of Jesus daily. We see through a glass dimly, I believe in part, because our eyes are clouded by desire in all kinds of directions. Are those who struggle with SSA not allowed in the fellowship of half-blind jackasses looking for the Glory of the Lord? To give up on this issue strikes at the heart of our beautiful orthodoxy. I'm in the PCA because we have the best answers for the toughest questions. We have the toolbox for dealing with these kinds of ethical issues. Let's not be Presbyterians in the light and Baptists in the dark.

3. Yes we run the risk of the wrong moderator selecting the wrong committee. So let's not lose the moderator vote. Win. We have to be there, we have to get our Elders in the room at GA, we have to find ways to finance our friends that can't afford it. We have to show up. The only way to avoid the wrong committee is to win the right to a good committee. You have to show up.

4. The committee should simply be our best, with some geographic diversity. I want seven voters who are theologians and practitioners on the issue, and a couple of advisory committee members who are in the trenches daily. If we're going to study the problem of people getting left in ditches I'd like some Good Samaritans on the committee. I do not want a camel committee with extremists to represent the extremes. I do not believe this is a report that serves only our cultural moment - I want us to look beyond our current battle lines to the church of the next generation. What PCA will my daughters inherit? This SC should provide a report that paves the way in Christian ethics for the next thing. Worrying about quieting the extremists is only going to give us a report that serves this assembly, alone. Not worth our time.

I believe in our guys. I know there's a risk, but I also don't believe in punting on first down. Our generation has been given this particular moment to minister the Gospel in the PCA. We are

servants of Christ's church, and this is a moment for the Church to greet suffering with beautiful orthodoxy. I believe in our guys, why should we be afraid to study something like this? There will be crazy coming to meet our commitment - there will be articles in the Aquila Report calling Mike the Pied Piper and Scott Sauls will wear the black hat. Someone will call me Jim again on Facebook and I'll want to burn it all down. That's okay.

We will face pressure to sign on to a Nashville statement that is simply the latest stick being used to whack away the unclean. Does anyone really think this statement is more than empty words? Where does it leave us? What are the next words, after the statement? Come to my house? Eat at my table? Sleep in my bed? I doubt it.

It's a "time to stand," they say, and I actually agree with that sentiment. The Bible is full of people standing, but sometimes people just stood around while beautifully orthodox people stood to serve, and stood to carry friends on stretchers who needed to be in the room with Jesus. So let's stand."

Again, please feel free to sharpen my thinking around this issue. Grateful for all of you.

II. CALENDAR

Feb. 26: Deadline for nominations to permanent committees

March 23: Nominating Committee meets in Atlanta

May 29-31: RPR meets in Atlanta

June 25-28: GA meets in Dallas

III. TO DO

-We DESPERATELY need a strong showing in the Overtures committee this year. Here is our current list. Please update:

Could I get an Overtures Committee membership update from all of you? Here are the NP members I currently have on the committee:

TE James Kessler (Columbus Metro)
TE David Ridenhour (Hills and Plains)
TE EJ Nusbaum (Rocky Mountain)
TE Walt Henegar (Metro Atlanta)
TE Rob Wootton (James River)
TE Tag Tuck (Blue Ridge)
TE Kevin Twit (Nashville)
TE Ben Lyon (Tidewater)
TE Andy Moehn (Westminster)
TE Dan Herron (Central Indiana)
TE Jeremy Fair (North Texas)
TE Joshua Reitano (Ohio Valley)

-Can you check in your presbytery and ensure that you have a nominations process for your OC rep? This means that there is a vote at some point on the floor for these nominees and consider standing for election. The OC, when populated in a healthy way, saves everyone a lot of time and frustration at the Assembly, and throughout the year. Participating in a GA Committee of Commissioners is an expected part of your role in the NP. There will be SIGNIFICANT work on OC committee this year and we need very strong participation. This is the primary deliberative body at the Assembly level. Please do all that you can to ensure your presbytery is well represented.

-Update us on the status of the OC nominees from your presbytery, if you haven't already.



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Mar 15, 2019, 7:06:01 PM



to NP

Brothers,

A chaotic assembly. A lot in the air. Articles about the fall of Orthodoxy in the PCA. Promises to stand on principles. Blogs and letters of concern, and Al Mohler helping the PCA stay confessional. It can be overwhelming.

Let me encourage you to see three objects on the horizon, three things I believe we can win in the service of creating a denomination worth having:

1. The improvement of our BCO in pastoral care for abuse cases.
2. The defeat and/or replacement of the Nashville Statement with real guidance, care and and clarity for ministry to those struggling with SSA.
3. Providing the means for the unordained, including women, to serve as voting members on committees of our boards and agencies.

Each one of these goals is worth the time, effort, and money required to get to Dallas. Each goal is worth the investment of your sweat and hope. And I believe we can win all three, for the first time in our denomination's history.

Let's keep our eyes on the prize. Get on the overtures committee, plan your week so you are ready for the assembly floor. Let's do our jobs. I'll have more this Wednesday.

JK



dcassidy3817

<dcassidy3817@gmail.com>

Mar 15, 2019, 7:08:13 PM



to james, NP

Wise and timely words my friend!! Thank you.

David Cassidy Sent from my iPhone



ssauls

<ssauls@christpres.org>

Mar 16, 2019, 8:30:34 AM

主



to james, NP

Thank you, James.

I for one will be there, fully engaged.



tag...@gmail.com

<tagtuck@gmail.com>

Mar 16, 2019, 11:23:58 AM

主



to The National Partnership

On the unordained serving - can you (or anyone) post some background material, talking points, or share some links to the what and why behind it?



mbates

<mbates@v7pc.org>

Mar 16, 2019, 12:00:02 PM

主



to james, NP

Agreed. Thank you, James.

Also, we need people on the Committee of Commissioners for all of our agencies. Some of our coordinators and presidents have faced unfair attacks. Dr. Dalby has had to defend Covenant Seminary from innuendo and false rumors. MTW has faced criticism over allowing women to be in leadership positions in ways that are consistent with the PCA's position paper. Also, there is an attempt to micromanage our agencies and permanent committees, which would be very harmful to the mission of the church. All of this means that the CoC could be more interesting and important than in years past. Thanks again for your leadership.
Mark

NP Note

4 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

May 22, 2019, 10:40:16 AM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

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I. 2019 Assembly Goals

II. Other GA news

2019 GA GOALS

Reminder that I would recommend 3 primary goals for this year's assembly:

1. **Approve the overture appointing a study committee for guidance on domestic abuse** and sexual assault cases. <https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-7-Revised-Pacific-NW-Ad-Interim-on-Domestic-Abuse.pdf>
2. **Reject Nashville Statement and approve a study committee** on the subject of pastoral care for those struggling with same sex attraction.
3. **Approve overture calling for the appointment of non-ordained persons** to serve on committees and boards: <https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-8-Ohio-Valley-BCO-14-1.10-12-revised.pdf>

All of these goals are attainable for us this year. All are vitally important to the health of our denomination. Regarding #3, this will be the most difficult to pass. There is a small process issue

that will have to be overcome in the overtures committee. The CCB (Committee on Constitutional Business) gives their recommendations on all overtures requiring constitutional amendments before the assembly each year. Typically, if the CCB rules that an overture is in conflict with another part of the constitution, it will make that overture very difficult to pass without edits. In this case there is what amounts to putting the address on an envelope, nothing wrong with the letter itself. Opponents of the overture will argue vigorously that it is enough reason to scuttle it entirely. If we can get it through the OC I feel good about its prospects.

Ohio Valley passed a study committee overture regarding same sex attraction. Chicago Metro also called for a study committee. I believe momentum is moving in this direction. Here's what that means: The moderator election will have far-reaching impact. The moderator will have the right to appoint the committee. The right committee could produce a report that blesses our churches and strengthens our orthodoxy. You *must* be present for the moderator election. In our Pre-GA rundown in a few weeks we will talk a bit more about the candidates. **3pm Wednesday is the moderator election.**

OTHER NEWS

A frustrating late overture from Heritage Presbytery seeking to limit all leadership positions at MTW to only ordained staff (<https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/Overture-41-Heritage-MTW-Statement.pdf>). This is a strange view of ordination in the extreme. It would require ordained officers in the PCA to assume that their credentials grant them special authority in non-church settings. Truly odd, and a pretty blunt attack on MTW's recent allowance of non-ordained staff in leadership areas commensurate with their skills. I'll share this from Pastor Mark Bates, a member of the MTW board, about why this needs to be defeated:

“Heritage Presbytery passed an overture last week that could have far reaching implications. The overture limits certain positions in MTW (team leaders, regional directors, and international directors) to ordained elders only. It is a reaction to CMTW's recent policy that allows women to serve in certain leadership positions in MTW.

I believe CMTW's policy is biblical, constitutional, and consistent with the PCA's paper on women in ministry. On the other hand, this reactionary overture not only limits where women can serve, but also limits where non-ordained men can serve. We currently have a good number of non-ordained people serving in these roles. They would lose their jobs if this is passed and it would prevent other people (both men and women) who have leadership gifts from using their gifts in the church in the future.

CMTW just received this overture. So, we haven't had a chance to craft a response. However, I want to get the word out about this.”

Yet another proposal for the PCA to leave the NAE. Here's the brief summary from Pastor Bruce O'Neil. A perspective with which I agree completely:

“Guys, Overture 23 from Central Carolina Presbytery calls for the PCA to leave NAE. This is similar to the effort to leave the NAE back in 2011. Obviously the NAE is a broad Christian organization made up of denominations that we would not agree with on many theological issues, but find broad agreement on many more. I am a member of the Interchurch Relations Committee and think it would be unhelpful to the PCA and the NAE if we leave. The PCA is typically looked to for biblical and theological guidance within in NAE. We have a disproportionate influence for the size of our denomination within NAE. Roy Taylor, our stated clerk, has served as the chairman of the Board for NAE for more than a decade. But I also believe the PCA would be impoverished by our leaving the NAE. The Mission of God is so much bigger than the PCA and being part of NAE demonstrates we recognize this fact and are willing to cooperate whenever we can. I hope that this will be defeated in the Committee of Commissioners, but if not surely the Assembly will not support such a narrow view of the mission. The IRC has adopted a lengthy response to this overture which will be part of our report at GA.”



Ewan Kennedy
<Ewan@redeemeratlanta.org>
Jun 6, 2019, 4:01:25 PM



to james, thenp@googlegroups.com

James,
Can you add Sam....@gmail.com (South City, STL & Revoice Board) to the NP group.

I vouch for him and understand it will fall to me to administer discipline should he ever fail us.

Ewan



Ewan Kennedy
<Ewan@redeemeratlanta.org>
Jun 6, 2019, 4:07:39 PM



to james, thenp@googlegroups.com

Whoopsie.
Sorry.

NP NOTE

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 6, 2019, 4:57:14 PM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

{The content of this email may not be shared without the permission of the sender}

Dear friends,

As we head toward this next General Assembly I want to make sure to remind you of a few things:

1. The previous NP email will give you a lay of the land for the week. Please make sure to read that update. I am suggesting three primary goals by which to measure success this year. That email is attached below this one.

2. A big part of effectiveness on the floor is making sure you are available to other commissioners with whom you have a relationship who may be new to the system or not connected to the NP. Please feel free to share - in your own words - the content of our collaboration here. Some of these votes may be very close. **Connecting personal networks** is a key to ensuring that we make healthy and informed decisions at the Assembly.

3. There will be a pre-assembly advisory document we will work through via email. I'll suggest a primary opinion taken from multiple sources and as always I will be very glad to share contrary advice. Please be willing to speak up! We all benefit from your willingness to share wisdom.

4. NON-ASSEMBLY information: You may have heard that some from within this group were also involved in starting a conference to take up the oxygen in the room with good news about ministry in the PCA. Rather than investing in little battles we want to shift the horizon and look at what God is doing through this denomination in the world. Beautiful Orthodoxy is open to any ministry practitioner in the PCA, your session, lay leaders, teachers, staff.

Let me give you some insight into the value and importance of the conference, **October 15-17, in Nashville**. No doubt, there are a lot of conferences out there designed to help you think about "mission," and "gospel," not to mention "ministry." Certainly this conference does that as well. But as a church planter, with a very small budget, I thought I'd tell you why I'm paying to bring six of my leadership team members with me:

This is a **PCA-centered conference**. I want my people to understand why we are in this denomination, and what God can do in and through us as we lock arms with churches across the country and around the world. There are truly beautiful stories and vistas that aren't shared until we create a forum to share them.

While there is much *information*, **there is even more spiritual formation**. I need this - my people need this too - desperately, and it is good for us to hear the Gospel preached and ministered by someone else every once in a while. We need to be inspired and shaped for our work together! We patterned this conference on four values we feel are intrinsic to orthodoxy: beauty, truth, love, and rest. There will be a *lot* of worship, and some incredible preaching, we will pray and sing with **Kevin Twit** leading a local team from Nashville. We expect you to leave being healed and renewed.

I want my people to see **a broader view of the PCA** than the typical suburban context. I want them to see men and women from all walks of life teaching and challenging and sharing the story of the Gospel in ways that allow us to dream bigger for our city.

If you sign up before July 15, you take advantage of the \$175 early registration price. I think this conference will be a big part of how we sustain a healthy and vibrant PCA for years to come.

Take a look at those preaching, teaching and story-telling at BJQ19
<http://beautifulorthodoxypca.com/>

Initial overtures advice

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 20, 2019, 8:41:43 AM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

This is draft advice concerning **ONLY** the overtures before the OC. Other overtures (such as the request to withdraw from the NAE) are handled by other committees. This draft is for your collaboration. Glad to hear and incorporate your substantive changes if you've got them.

There will be another document for all overtures coming to the Assembly floor. Hope to see you in Dallas!
JK

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.		Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/
Overture	Presbytery	Advice	Rationale
1 - Allow 4 RE representative per church	NW Georgia	No.	There do not appear to be many churches struggling with this limitation as it stands, in fact many churches do not sent a single elder representative. Solution does not deal with the problem. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/01/Overture-1-NW-GA-REs.pdf
2. Release Covenant Seminary from GA oversight	NW Georgia	No.	From the CTS Board: The Covenant Seminary Board of Trustees voted unanimously at its April 26, 2019, stated meeting to recommend that Overture 2 from Northwest Georgia Presbytery, be answered in the negative with the following rationale. Covenant Seminary was shocked to hear of this overture as we were in no way consulted on this overture. Covenant Seminary does not and never has desired to be released from PCA oversight but rather delights in and values deeply the oversight provided through the General Assembly Contrary to the implication of the overture, Covenant Seminary has every desire to continue to be under the exclusive oversight of ordained elders as voting members of the Board of Trustees. Covenant Seminary believes that authoritative oversight of the Seminary by ordained elders is particularly important and vital for the task of training men who will be ordained pastors in the PCA --- Overtures are not trial balloons; they obligate precious hours of the Assembly's work and deliberation. That such an overture passed a presbytery without first consulting the denomination's seminary, her leadership, her board, any of those who would be primarily affected by such a move is a gross neglect of pastoral care and wisdom. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/Overture-2-NW-GA-CTS.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared. Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/	
3. Regarding GA Worship	N. New England	No. The AC responds: RAO 10-3 relates to the corporate worship services of the entire General Assembly, not to pre-Assembly prayer meetings. Overture 3 combines public worship services of the entire Assembly with pre-Assembly prayer meetings. The primary function of the AC regarding pre-Assembly prayer meetings is to provide a room for commissioners and guests to pray for the General Assembly. Those involved in pre-Assembly prayer meetings are already expected to use godly prudence and wisdom in conducting such prayer meetings. There were several rooms made available for pre-Assembly prayer meetings in 2018. Some attendees could have taken issue with what was said at any of those gatherings. A better means of dealing with the issue of potential offenses is for leaders of prayer meetings to exercise godly wisdom in leading prayer meetings and for attendees to refrain from making corporate confessions of sin on matters for which they do not individually believe themselves to be culpable For AC staff or Committee members to attend, monitor, and report on every potential offense that could be taken by any individual at every pre-Assembly prayer meeting would be impractical https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/10/Overture-3-NNEP-GA-worship.pdf
4. Declare The Nashville Statement to be Biblically Faithful	Calvary	Answer in reference to overture 42 https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/11/Overture-4-Calvary-Nashville-Statement.pdf
5. Dissolving Pastoral Relations	Central Indiana	Unsure Is this really a problem that needs to be solved? The CCB notes issues with the overture for which some propose the following fix: BCO 21-3 ... If any church desires to be relieved of its pastor <i>or associate pastor</i>, a similar procedure shall be observed. But whether the <i>minister pastor or associate pastor</i> or the church initiates proceedings for a dissolution of the relation, there shall always be a meeting of the congregation called and conducted in the same manner as the call of the pastor. <i>In the case of an assistant pastor, the church Session may present its request for dissolution directly to the Presbytery without prior approval at a congregational meeting.</i> In any case, the minister must not physically leave the field until the Presbytery or its commission empowered to handle uncontested requests for dissolution has dissolved the relation. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/11/Overture-5-C.-Indiana-Dissolving-Pastoral-Relations.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.		Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/
6. Disallow memorials	PNW	Yes	The complicated debate surrounding a memorial for Morton Smith last year, showed us that the point of such an overture is not well-served by this particular body.
7. Establish Ad Interim Committee on Abuse and Assault	PNW	Yes Also (10, 13, 20, 26, 31, 38, 43, 47)	Yes, with the following recommended amendment. Answer all others in reference. Amendment 1 - <i>"AC shall be funded by designated contributions."</i> CCB advises original language conflict with RAO 9-3 funding provision. p. 283. CCB vote 6-1. Amendment 2 - <i>"All Presbyteries, churches and individuals are encouraged to send contributions to AC designated for this Committee, especially those Presbyteries that filed related overtures."</i> Amendment 3 (if necessary) - Item 1.c. - Strike and Replace: <i>"If the Committee deems it prudent, it may recommend to the 48th General Assembly (Birmingham 2020)—through the GA Overtures Committee—any revisions or additions to BCO Rules of Discipline that might more appropriately protect victims of these sins within a biblical process, and"</i> <i>The Committee may report its conclusion(s) regarding any revisions or additions to BCO Rules of Discipline that might help protect victims of these sins, and prosecute offenders, within a biblical process. The Assembly encourages the Committee to publish any such conclusions in sufficient time for Presbyteries to consider filing overtures proposing related BCO changes."</i> https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-7-Revised-Pacific-NW-Ad-Interim-on-Domestic-Abuse.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.		Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/
8. Allow unordained personnel to serve on denomination boards and committees	Ohio Valley	Yes. Also 14, 19, 21, 32	Recommended with the following amendment: Change the proposed ratio of the 15-person membership from 4-4-7 to 5-5-5 - that is, revising the overture-proposed 4TEs + 4REs + 7 at large, to 5TEs + 5REs + 5 at large (i.e., five classes of 1+1+1). NOTE: CCB's advice can be followed by amending the overture in the OC to account for the necessary editorial changes. More to the point, we <i>must</i> get serious about clarifying the essential nature of special ecclesiastical authority (ordination) in the church. Must all positions of influence in the church require ordination? Does a committee or board's work (which must be ratified by the higher court) require special ecclesiastical authority? If we are not careful, extending that authority to all realms of influence will not only render ordination less meaningful in the areas for which we need it most, but will injure the doctrine of the priesthood of believers. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-8-Ohio-Valley-BCO-14-1.10-12-revised.pdf [There are a number of objections we want to deal with below, quoted from advice being circulated... "The second defect is that the <u>nomination</u> and election procedure set forth in proposed BCO 14-1.12 will not produce an equal number of TEs, REs, and at-large members for CDM, MNA, MTW, and RUF. <i>(This is dealt with in the proposed amendment above - ed.)</i> The third, and most significant, defect of the Overture is that it does not properly account for the ecclesiastical authority/responsibility of the committees and agencies. These committees and agencies are arms of the Church, not para-church organizations. Our Lord has provided for the authority of the Church to be exercised by ordained elders (Eph. 4:11; 1 Pet. 5:1-2). While advice should be sought from unordained persons, they should not be the voice of authority in the Church. The committees and agencies are the authority for their directors and staff. <i>(This is telling - authority not for the church but "directors and staff" on this we agree. Which is why we should not be ruling on the ability for the unordained to exercise influence or authority here. Unless you're providing the sacraments in your board meeting. Then we have other problems - ed.)</i> Finally, this Overture is essentially the same in substance to similar overtures that were soundly defeated at the 46th Assembly (700-488 or 60/40%). <i>(The overture which failed before carried a very strong defect illustrated by the CCB which probably induced many to vote against. This is not a fair comparison - ed.)</i>

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.		Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/
9. Regarding the filing of judicial cases	Plate Valley	Yes	Creates consistency with the SJC manual. Makes sense. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-9-Platte-Valley-BCO-42-4-43-2-3.pdf
11. Commend and distribute RPCNA paper on human sexuality	Fellowship		Answer in reference to Overture 42 https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-11-Fellowship-RPCNA-Perspectives.pdf
12. Amend floor nominations process	Northern New England	No	Another solution in search of a problem. The overture cites the “worrying trend of celebrity floor nominations” which seems, at best, without proof. The vast majority of presbytery-affirmed and nominating committee-confirmed nominees succeed against floor nominations. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-12-N.-NE-RAO-8-4.i-Floor-Nominations.pdf
16. Moderator-Elect	GA Foothills	Yes	Not a critical issue, but could reduce some of the moderator politicking and drama. Does not prevent additional nominations. May allow for increased preparation for inexperienced moderators. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-16-GA-Foothills-RAO-1-4-6-8-2-1-3-Moderator-Elect.pdf
17. Allow for Video Testimony	Houston Metro	Yes	CGB advises conflict, but that conflict is easily dealt with in committee. One problem with our current rules forces victims of abuse and minors to testify in front of their alleged abusers. This overture would allow victims to testify without further trauma or intimidation. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-17-Houston-Metro-BCO-32-8.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.	Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/	
18. Overtures to multiple committees	Houston Metro	Yes (Also 15)	A fine overture to remove confusion over the process for receiving overtures. CCB advises that a change is required. One proposed fix: RAO 11-5. Upon receipt the Stated Clerk shall refer all overtures requesting amendment of the <i>Book of Church Order</i> or the <i>Rules of Assembly Operations</i> to the Committee on Constitutional Business for its advice to the Overtures Committee. Upon receipt, the Stated Clerk shall forward all overtures concerning presbytery boundaries or a new presbytery to the permanent Committee on Mission to North America. Any overture, other than an overture proposing amendment to the Constitution (which shall be referred to the Committee on Constitutional Business for its advice to the Overtures Committee), having to do with the nature or responsibilities of a permanent Committee or Agency shall be referred by the Clerk to the appropriate permanent Committee or Agency or ad interim committee. All other overtures shall be referred to the Overtures Committee. While the Stated Clerk may refer overtures to more than one Committee or Agency or ad interim committee for advice, the Moderator and Stated Clerk shall decide which single entity shall present a recommendation to the Assembly on the overture. The Overtures Committee alone will present a recommendation directly to the Assembly on any proposed BCO or RAO amendments. No overture shall be referred for consideration and recommendation to more than one Committee of Commissioners, permanent Committee or Agency or ad interim committee; an overture, however, may be referred for informational purposes only to another Committee of Commissioners, permanent Committee or Agency or ad interim committee. All overtures shall be published in the <i>Commissioner Handbook</i> with reference for consideration indicated. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-18-Houston-Metro-RAO-11-5.pdf
33. Add vow regarding the trinity to membership	Tennessee Valley	No	It seems strange to oppose this overture on its face, but the doctrine of the trinity would seem best taught through creeds and pastoral care than through the taking of vows. For most of the history of the church this has been the means for engaging this truth. Unless there is a crisis within the PCA of belief on this topic, this does not seem to be the best means of ensuring trinitarian belief. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-33-TN-Valley-Membership-Vows.pdf
34. Regarding Electronic Filing	Philadelphia	Yes	A proposed amendment - Heed SJC advice and "postpone consideration of the SJC Manual change proposed in Overture 34 until the General Assembly and the Presbyteries render a decision on the BCO provisions proposed by the Overture." https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-34-Philadelphia-Written-Filing.pdf
35. Affirm PCA's commitment to Biblical sexuality	Savannah River		Answer in reference to Overture 42

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.	Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/	
36. Clarify the meaning of "credible report"	Savannah River	Yes	Affirmative (but not the simplest way to achieve what seems to be the goal.) A simple change in one word in RAO 17-2 could remedy the problem. OC could recommend answering in the Affirmative, as amended, and simply propose the single-word change shown below (and the change could be effective at this GA.) Even though this would be a change to RAO, and the overture proposes a change to BCO, it is still germane. RAO 17-2. With respect to the Rules of Discipline, any reference (BCO 41), appeal (BCO 42), complaint (BCO 43), BCO 40-5 preceding report, or request to assume original jurisdiction (BCO 34-1) made to the General Assembly shall be assigned to the Standing Judicial Commission for adjudication. This helpful change is suggested in the second SJC dissenting opinion in the GA Handbook, on page 2012, in <i>Case 2018-02: Anna Lewis v. Mississippi Valley</i> (a Case that dealt with the interpretation of BCO 40-5). See also the report of the Review of Presbytery Records Committee on Mississippi Valley, which recommends the GA cite the Pby to appear before the SJC in October regarding the matter, per BCO 40-5. The one-word revision in RAO 17-2 would probably prevent such delays in the future. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-36-Sav-R-Credible-Report.pdf
39. Recommend RPCES report on human sexuality	Southern New England		Answer in reference to Overture 42
40. Overture to support and recognize women's roles	NW Georgia	No	This ironically titled overture offers "support" the same way the same presbytery offered support to Covenant Seminary by seeking to stop supporting it. This sub-biblical attempt to restrict the roles of women should be strongly opposed. Additionally some have advised: <i>"The Overture is a too vague resolution ("be authorized") to a vague problem ("churches wishing to acknowledge") that would create confusion around the doctrine of ordination ("with the laying on of hands")"</i> https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/Overture-40-NW-GA-Commission-Women.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared. Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/		
42. Appoint Ad Interim Committee regarding human sexuality	Chicago Metro	Yes (Also 4, 11, 22, 28, 30, 35, 37, 39, 42, 45)	My rationale is this: 1. I do believe there is confusion in our denomination, among people of good faith, people in the middle of the PCA, who would like to know how to deal with SSA among the people in our congregation. Revoice exists, in part, because our best strategy has been don't ask-don't tell in the PCA. The voices that speak the loudest for many of these pastors and elders, youth pastors and directors, are not our best voices. 2. The question of homosexual attraction should be answered in line with biblical anthropology and an orthodox doctrine of sin. To give up on this issue and answer in political statements given without pastoral care strikes at the heart of our beautiful orthodoxy. 3. We will face pressure in this committee to sign on to a Nashville statement that is simply the latest stick being used to whack away the unclear. "We must do something now." This is no less than the fifth straight year we've been told we must do something now or else, or else. Each time we have caved a bit - we have re-written the BCO, re-affirmed Biblical Marriage and re-affirmed our re-affirmation. Another statement is not going to keep us from hearing the same voices next year. There is intense distrust in our denomination, and any tool like the NS cannot be used in good faith - it will be the means of instituting discipline without process, without taking the time to understand the meaning of each other's words. It is simply a way to avoid the burden of relationship with one another. A study committee recognizes that we simply cannot come to an agreement at the moment, and need guidance.
48. Make a stronger statement on Abortion	Session CTK (Norman, OK)	No	Current statements are clear guidance for our congregants. If we want to guide the watching world it will require local witness, not denominational utterances. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/Overture-48-Session-Christ-the-King-Abortion.pdf

Scott Sauls pre-GA thoughts

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 21, 2019, 8:16:17 AM



to NP

This was a good clarification of the lines of controversy we will find in Dallas. I thought it was an encouraging look at how an orthodox faith can embrace wisdom at GA

<http://scottsauls.com/blog/2019/06/21/thoughts-on-revoice-unnecessary-division-and-the-pca/>

Day 1 GA review

1 view



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 25, 2019, 10:46:16 PM

主



to thenp@googlegroups.com

The end of the first day of GA committee meetings and we wanted you to have a bit of an update.

1. Overtures committee has two particularly difficult issues before it. Issues related to Same Sex Attraction (and Revoice) and unordained persons laboring on committees in boards and agencies. After a full day of debate we have nearly completed the first issue, but have not dealt at all with the second. This was a 50/50 day, in an earlier session we approved an overture that declared the Nashville Statement to be biblically faithful - vigorous debate by many who are connected through the NP that this was not a helpful or needed proclamation, especially in the absence of equally prominent pastoral guidance on these issues. The vote was 58% to approve. While many who are a part of the GRN and are sailing on the cultural winds whipped up by Al Mohler and others around this issue, felt this was an important victory, I believe they were shocked at the relative closeness of the vote. I personally heard from one commissioner who thought there might be only a handful vote against it. This may bode well for the Assembly as a whole - this Overtures Committee strikes me as more "conservative" on these particular issues, than the body will be later in the week. So I was not discouraged by what I consider to be a defeat. There will be a well-reasoned and compelling minority report recommending to the Assembly that we *not* adopt the Statement.

Just before 9pm we were able to pass Overture 42, the most helpful of the study committee proposals. What this meant was that the Nashville Statement, which some hoped would be the sole - and therefore most prominent - statement of the assembly, was no longer alone. We acknowledged that we need to study this issue - we are not of one mind and need help. I do not believe that others on the OC expected the proposal to pass. That outcome completed the day with some optimism. Tomorrow we will tackle the second issue and I am hopeful that we will be prepared to carry the room.

2. Interchurch relations committee voted to recommend severing from the NAE. I and others have covered why we think this is a serious mistake and you will hear more about this in the Pre-Assembly briefing coming out tomorrow morning.
3. Covenant Seminary - Dr. Dalbey again was the focus of some intensive questioning related to Revoice, but he was able to answer firmly, charitably, definitively - as he has several times over the past few months.
4. MTW: rejected "elder-only" supervisors in committee. This affirms MTW's practice of allowing unordained people to act in places of supervision, accountability, and support of missionaries and other staff. Good news.

My opinion is that the additional 450ish attendees this year will split 70/30 in a way we would probably welcome. I believe an agenda that truly represents the heart of the PCA will be reflected by decisions on the floor this week - so try not to overreact, one way or another, to the committee votes. And further, I think it's a great idea to pray for the assembly, pray that our means of work at the assembly adorns our profession with dignity. We are pastors first. Let's pray for one another and the PCA, but let's also pray for each other's churches and the people we are seeking to love and serve and protect. I feel good about our ability to help the PCA move toward health. I feel even better about the ability of King Jesus to rule his church. Grateful to be on His team, most of all.

JK

UPCOMING:

Tomorrow AM: Wednesday's Schedule, important votes, etc.

Tomorrow PM: Final overtures advice

Thursday AM: Thursday's schedule, important votes, etc.

Thursday AM: Nominations advice

GA Wednesday NOTE

5 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 26, 2019, 8:16:07 AM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

Today there are a few goals I would recommend for the group:

1. Pass the unordained persons serving on committees overture through the OC
2. Elect Howie Donahoe for moderator
3. Defeat last year's BCO 30-1 (see explanation below)
4. Defeat the Interchurch Relations CoC recommended withdrawal from the NAE. (See explanation below)
5. Maintain your charity, hope, and grit.

HOWIE DONAHOE

I want to take a moment to share why I will be voting for Howie instead of John Bise. This is not a vote *against* John Bise. He has served in many capacities in the Lord's Church and the PCA in particular. He is kind and willing to help wherever needed. This is more about the opportunity to elect someone who will serve not only as the moderator of a meeting but for the next five years as an advisor on the Cooperative Ministries Committee, a position that requires us to look beyond good sentiment in favor of John and toward the gifts we need to utilize in the PCA for the current cultural moment.

Howie has served as an elder for 32 years. In four churches across three presbyteries - sea to shining sea. He has served on every level of denominational leadership at the Assembly, Presbytery, and local church. He is currently serving multiple terms on the SJC, helping us sort through cases like those related to our SSA debates. This is not to mention his collection of whiskeys and his willingness to kindly share them. But it isn't just his service to the PCA that compels me.

Howie left a church where he was connected and beloved to go to another PCA church in his area that needed an extra elder to help them through a transition. He has been willing to personally travel across the country to encourage struggling ministers. I love that view of Eldership in the local church. The fact is that John is not what some call "political," something many of us have heard by those preferring Bise for moderator. What that means is that we don't know his views on the role of the church or a vision for the PCA in general. We know Howie's views, his help to many of us in understanding the polity of the PCA, the countless hours he spends making sure that we are thinking through the long-term impact of all those RAO and BCO amendments. We know his care for and dedication to the PCA and the ministry of the local church. And as we are trying to think more carefully and deeply about how our denomination will speak and minister in a culture of mistrust and fear, I want as many voices like Howie's in the room as possible. We are looking not only for someone whose service to the church we can celebrate, but whose leadership we can follow. Howie is that guy.

LAST YEAR'S BCO 30-1

At the beginning of Assembly business we deal with amendments that passed *last year's* assembly, and voting by presbyteries, and now must pass a second assembly. Part of the reason for that long process is that in the intervening year we may see issues with an overture that we missed initially. Last year's BCO 30-1 is an example of just this kind of overture. I reviewed Bryan Chapell's advice on this and I agree with him that we need to vote this down. I am including the text of a speech you will hear later on the issue. I would recommend you be ready to vote against this overture:

Item 3 (Amendment to BCO 30-1) attempts a commendable revision, but in doing so creates another problem that contradicts the spirit of the revision. The proposed wording would formalize a common misunderstanding of the biblical rules of discipline.

That misunderstanding is that the progressive steps of discipline are to be exercised without exception or discretion – automatically – whenever there is not *satisfactory* repentance. The key revisions proposed are not merely *permissive* (saying what actions “may” be taken, as in the original opening sentence), nor are they *procedural* (saying what steps you “should” follow *if you must* progress), but rather the revisions include a *directive* “shall” (in the 2nd and last sentences), saying that *you must* progress to indefinite suspension or excommunication, unless there is satisfactory repentance. Such a mandate removes from local sessions the discretion needed to *shepherd* with the discernment *and* conviction needed to evaluate what is best for the spiritual health of individuals and the overall church.

Let's be clear, Jesus, in Matthew 18, *does* describe the steps you *must* follow *if* you go to the end of the path of church discipline; but, the Savior does *not* teach that you must always go to the end of the path. The *procedure* is mandatory, *progression* to a predetermined end is not.

To contend that we **must** go to the end of the path for every known-, not-fully-repented sin is:

- 1) To require the excommunication of all who overeat and who do not reach proper weight;
- 2) To require the parent of every wayward teen to submit their child to church discipline; or for the church to discipline such parents for the mistakes others believe they have made.

We are not so mechanical, *not* because we are compromisers, but because we are committed to exercising proper, pastoral and sessional discretion about what is best for the overall health of church and her people in terms of the initiation, timing, advancement and degree of discipline.

We remember that love covers a multitude of sins (1 Pet. 1:8); and, that “God’s patience waited in the days of Noah” (1 Pet 3:20). He even “endured *with much patience* vessels of wrath prepared for destruction, in order to make known the riches of his glory for vessels of mercy” (Rom 9:22–23).

Calvin, who *strongly* advocated the conscientious and non-prejudicial application of church discipline so that “the contagion of sin would not invade the multitude,” nonetheless was remarkably balanced in how he advised the church to proceed with “discrimination” and without “disruptive severity.” He advised, “... Great severity is not to be used in lighter sins, but verbal chastisement is enough -- and that mild and fatherly -- which should not harden or confuse the sinner....” Calvin commended Augustine’s advice against using church trials to discipline public drunkenness because he said it would empty the churches. Some sins, he argued can be corrected by formal discipline, but others will require a generation of sound preaching. [Inst. IV.12.1-13]

By all means, we should follow biblical procedures *when* advancing through the steps of discipline, but to mandate constitutionally that every sin be moved to higher orders of discipline until there is full and satisfactory repentance will make either tyrants or compromisers of us all.

Local sessions must be allowed discretionary decisions about when to commence and how far to take church discipline in order to preserve the life and health of the church and her children. This is our shepherding responsibility that requires me to ask you to vote *against* this well-intended but improperly-worded amendment. Send it back for more biblically-balanced wording.

PROPOSED WITHDRAWAL FROM THE NAE

The permanent committee - Interchurch Relations - recommends *against* withdrawing from the NAE. But a very stacked committee with some of the farthest, hardest right voices in the PCA took over committee work yesterday and passed a resolution withdrawing from the association. We knew this would happen as it has been the stated goal by many who, curiously, are simultaneously seeking to withdraw the PCA from the NAE while threatening, for many years, to leave the PCA themselves. I want to remind us of the advice of Bruce O'Neil on this matter:

"This is similar to the effort to leave the NAE back in 2011. Obviously the NAE is a broad Christian organization made up of denominations that we would not agree with on many theological issues, but find broad agreement on many more. I am a member of the Interchurch Relations Committee and think it would be unhelpful to the PCA and the NAE if we leave. The PCA is typically looked to for biblical and theological guidance within in NAE. We have a disproportionate influence for the size of our denomination within NAE. Roy Taylor, our stated clerk, has served as the chairman of the Board for NAE for more than a decade. But I also believe the PCA would be impoverished by our leaving the NAE. The Mission of God is so much bigger than the PCA and being part of NAE demonstrates we recognize this fact and are willing to cooperate whenever we can. I hope that this will be defeated in the Committee of Commissioners, but if not surely the Assembly will not support such a narrow view of the mission. The IRC has adopted a lengthy response to this overture which will be part of our report at GA."

SCHEDULE (Bold, underlined, are the most critical moments for you to be on the floor!)

8a: Overtures committee continues

1.30p: Opening worship service (Irwyn Ince preaching!)

3p: **MODERATOR ELECTION.**

3.45p: **IRC REPORT** (this is the NAE withdrawal I recommend we defeat)

Finally I want to remind us of this: some of you may not have experienced GA week before, or at least you haven't been this involved before. We are thankful for you. There are many in the PCA who have been bearing the weight of defending it against attacks from all sides, who have championed things like Good Faith subscription, who have pushed forward racial reconciliation, who have had to run back into the assembly hall for difficult votes, who have had to refocus and re-enlist their energy after late-night debates and frustrating results. You are a breath of fresh air for them. You are a sign

that all of it is worth the work. Please do not be discouraged by early results, whatever they may be. The week is long and the story of the church is much longer.

We are all, even our beloved opposition, united in a future that will renew all things long after the last clicker malfunction prompts the last point of personal privilege. We are beloveds of the beloved together. Beloved enemies sometimes, fighting like siblings do, and there will be some unfair things said and unfair accusations. But let's be men and women of grit. Let's not be the first ones to forget that we serve the great King, who loves us so. I know you know all of this, but sometimes good news needs to be rehearsed. He loves us, and we serve him before we serve committees or churches, or nefarious and clandestine secret PCA societies. Much love to you all, it's time to get on the grind and be counted this week.



j.dorsey23
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Jun 26, 2019, 12:33:30 PM

主



to james, thenp@googlegroups.com

Howie Donahoe would be a great Moderator

NP VOTING REMINDER!

1 view



james
<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 26, 2019, 3:25:26 PM

主



to NP

Hey all,
Here's what we need to do today: BE HERE

3pm: MODERATOR ELECTION

3.30p: last year's overture 30-1 will be debated.

3.45p: IRC committee (delegates reports first THEN NAE withdrawal motion. (Approx 4.30p)

NP DAY 2 review, Day 3 schedule

1 view



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 26, 2019, 11:49:59 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Day 2 review:

I gave you a some goals for today's assembly business:

1. Pass the unordained persons serving on committees overture through the OC - This failed. But we discovered in the course of business that the Overtures Committee is far to the right of the Assembly. This gives me hope that we will be able to win this one the floor. We have a powerful minority report given by E J Nusbaum and some compelling speeches.
2. Elect Donahoe for moderator: passed 62-38%. That is quite a margin. Of course Howie was very duly and deservedly elected but it might tell us something about what the floor's composition will be. There was *heavy* electioneering for Bise, and yet his nomination failed by 22%. John is a fine man, I want to say that again. But I see this as a win for all the reasons given this morning.
3. We defeated the 30-1 amendment from last year (and another related to legal representation in presbyteries) that I felt were not helpful. That's a victory.
4. Defeat recommended withdrawal from NAE. The assembly did not complete that business. It will be the first thing taken up at 9.30a.

So in general a good day.

THURSDAY SCHEDULE

9.30a: Debate over withdrawing from NAE

10.30a?: Review of Presbytery Records

11.15a: Nominating Committee Report

4.15p: (Estimated time) Overtures Report

We will give you updates on the timing of the Overtures report. Obviously tomorrow will be a marathon and it will be critical for you to be in the room at 9.30, 11.15, and whenever overtures reports. RPR is a moment where we dropped the ball in the past and a small crowd in the room

changed a report in a way that was very unfortunate. We need to make sure we are in the room for these four things tomorrow. As I said before we will keep you updated.

Overtures advice will come in a separate email tomorrow morning.

NP Nominating Committee recommended slate

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 27, 2019, 9:49:14 AM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

{Confidential, but you are certainly to share this in your own words}

At **11.15am** (precisely), we will work through the list of nominations for our denomination's permanent committees. One thing we have continued to do in the NP is to help one another come to agreement on candidates we may not know as well as others. The following list is our best attempt at a recommended slate of candidates. In some cases we will not have much to say, just working on the recommendations of committees and other leaders in the PCA who know the men in question. In others we offer some brief thoughts. As always you are free to disagree! And if you have some data point we all need to know, please share it!

{In these recommendations, there is preference given to geographical representation and age of candidates. Our goal is to see a wide representation of Presbyteries as well as younger men serve on committees.}

ADMINISTRATIVE COMMITTEE // TE // Class of 2023

Bob Brunson, Metro Atlanta***

Randy Lovelace, Chesapeake

(Both of these candidates are great options, but Bob has labored on this committee before and in the process of finding

ADMINISTRATIVE COMMITTEE // TE // Alt

Todd Baucum, Southeast Alabama

Rod Mays, Calvary ***

COMMITTEE ON CONSTITUTIONAL BUSINESS (CCB) // RE // Class of 2023

Fredric Marcinak, Calvary

Bryce Sullivan, Nashville ***

COMMITTEE ON CONSTITUTIONAL BUSINESS (CCB) //TE // Alt

Robert Cathcart, Calvary

Robert Browning, Covenant ***

(Part of this is browning's experience, part of it is Calvary's very frustrating animosity expressed through their polity at the GA level. Their overtures, for one, have been a disaster. Hard to endorse a Calvary presbytery candidate for the CCB)

COMMITTEE ON DISCIPLESHIP MINISTRIES (CDM) // RE // Alt

Dan Barber, Central Indiana

Taylor Clement, Missouri

Jason Walker, Houston Metro

BOARD OF CTS // Class of 2023

C.R. Wiley, Southern New England

Frank Wicks, Missouri ***

(This is important. Frank wicks is the board recommendation. Wiley is a harsh antagonist of the seminary. Why would we want him on the permanent board. Let's defeat this)

STANDING JUDICIAL COMMISSION // TE // Class of 2023

Steve Meyerhoff, Chesapeake

Sean Lucas, Covenant ***

(Prefer Lucas' balance and teamwork, not just his clarity and skill, and understanding of the PCA's origins and culture)

Michael Ross, Columbus Metro ***

Brad Evans, Southern New England

(Former moderator. Columbus Metro needs representation!)

STANDING JUDICIAL COMMISSION // RE // Class of 2023

Melton Duncan, Calvary

Terry Jones, Missouri ***

(Mel Duncan is the primary GRN organizer and agitator, the prime organizing voice against CTS and mover of the Nashville statement. He would be, i cannot stress enough, a disaster for the court)

THEOLOGICAL EXAMINING COMMITTEE // TE // Alt

Benjamin Shaw, Calvary

Wayne Larson, Iowa ***

(Shaw is a GPTS professor whose views on subscription, confessionalism, are far out of touch with the broader vision of the PCA)

2019 Overtures ADVICE, Thursday preview

4 views



james

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Jun 27, 2019, 10:49:39 AM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

Friends,

I would like to recommend some particular goals for our work today:

1. Defeat the overture to withdraw from the NAE: DONE
2. Defeat some particularly unhelpful nominations to permanent committees
3. Approve Overture 42 and answer all other SSA-related overtures to it
4. Approve Overture 8 regarding unordained persons on committees

Regarding nominations - I know it is difficult to vote *against* fellow brothers in Christ, so we should think about it this way. Not every minister is gifted for every ministry. Our polity requires us to make those judgments. Elder Mel Duncan's lack of fit for the SJC and Wiley's lack of fit for CTS seem beyond question - though I am glad to hear your perspective on this - and as always please vote your conscience! The recommendations for the Nominating committee report were covered in an earlier email this morning.

Regarding Overture 42: There will be a procedural motion offered that would allow us to save 2/3 of our time on the docket while also presenting an opportunity to avoid speaking primarily through unhelpful and non-pastoral overtures concerning SSA. Overture 42 also *incorporates* every other paper and study (including the Nashville Statement and Missouri Presbytery study committee). Be aware this will be at the beginning of the Overtures committee report. Be ready to vote.

Today's the day. One day for all the business; one day that affects the work of our denomination for years to come. Thankful for all of you, for speaking and for keeping your friends up to date, and for correcting me when I'm off track. Much love to you, friends. Let's get on the grind.

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly This document is not to be reproduced or shared. Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/			
Overture	Presbytery	Advice	Rationale
1 - Allow 4 RE representative per church	NW Georgia	No.	There do not appear to be many churches struggling with this limitation as it stands, in fact many churches do not sent a single elder representative. Solution does not deal with the problem. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/01/Overture-1-NW-GA-REs.pdf
2. Release Covenant Seminary from GA oversight	NW Georgia	No.	From the CTS Board: The Covenant Seminary Board of Trustees voted unanimously at its April 26, 2019, stated meeting to recommend that Overture 2 from Northwest Georgia Presbytery, be answered in the negative with the following rationale. Covenant Seminary was shocked to hear of this overture as we were in no way consulted on this overture. Covenant Seminary does not and never has desired to be released from PCA oversight but rather delights in and values deeply the oversight provided through the General Assembly Contrary to the implication of the overture, Covenant Seminary has every desire to continue to be under the exclusive oversight of ordained elders as voting members of the Board of Trustees. Covenant Seminary believes that authoritative oversight of the Seminary by ordained elders is particularly important and vital for the task of training men who will be ordained pastors in the PCA -- Overtures are not trial balloons; they obligate precious hours of the Assembly's work and deliberation. That such an overture passed a presbytery without first consulting the denomination's seminary, her leadership, her board, any of those who would be primarily affected by such a move is a gross neglect of pastoral care and wisdom. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/03/Overture-2-NW-GA-CTS.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.	Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/	
3. Regarding GA Worship	N. New England	No.	The AC responds: RAO 10-3 relates to the corporate worship services of the entire General Assembly, not to pre-Assembly prayer meetings. Overture 3 combines public worship services of the entire Assembly with pre-Assembly prayer meetings. The primary function of the AC regarding pre-Assembly prayer meetings is to provide a room for commissioners and guests to pray for the General Assembly. Those involved in pre-Assembly prayer meetings are already expected to use godly prudence and wisdom in conducting such prayer meetings. There were several rooms made available for pre-Assembly prayer meetings in 2018. Some attendees could have taken issue with what was said at any of those gatherings. A better means of dealing with the issue of potential offenses is for leaders of prayer meetings to exercise godly wisdom in leading prayer meetings and for attendees to refrain from making corporate confessions of sin on matters for which they do not individually believe themselves to be culpable For AC staff or Committee members to attend, monitor, and report on every potential offense that could be taken by any individual at every pre-Assembly prayer meeting would be impractical https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/10/Overture-3-NNEP-GA-worship.pdf
4. Declare The Nashville Statement to be Biblically Faithful	Calvary		Answer in reference to overture 42. Otherwise NO. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/11/Overture-4-Calvary-Nashville-Statement.pdf
6. Disallow memorials	PNW	Yes	The complicated debate surrounding a memorial for Morton Smith last year, showed us that the point of such an overture is not well-served by this particular body.
7. Establish Ad Interim Committee on Abuse and Assault	PNW	Yes Also (10, 13, 20, 26, 31, 38, 43, 47)	https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-7-Revised-Pacific-NW-Ad-Interim-on-Domestic-Abuse.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.		Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/
8. Allow unordained personnel to serve on denomination boards and committees	Ohio Valley	Yes. Also 14, 19, 21, 32	E J Nusbaum is giving the minority report which represents many of us. There is much to say, but let me just put it this way: If we want to hold ordination high - we want to defend it - then we will have no problem with unordained persons serving on committees by the ordained sending of an assenting Session, we will insist on it. The problem with the debate is that one side doesn't take ordination seriously enough. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-8-Ohio-Valley-BCO-14-1.10-12-revised.pdf
9. Regarding the filing of judicial cases	Plate Valley	Yes	Creates consistency with the SJC manual. Makes sense. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-9-Platte-Valley-BCO-42-4-43-2-3.pdf
11. Commend and distribute RPCNA paper on human sexuality	Fellowship		Answer in reference to Overture 42. Otherwise NO . https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-11-Fellowship-RPCNA-Perspectives.pdf
12. Amend floor nominations process	Northern New England	No	Another solution in search of a problem. The overture cites the "worrying trend of celebrity floor nominations" which seems, at best, without proof. The vast majority of presbytery-affirmed and nominating committee-confirmed nominees succeed against floor nominations. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-12-N.-NE-RAO-8-4.i-Floor-Nominations.pdf
16. Moderator-Elect	GA Foothills	No	A change here. Initially advised YES but after feedback believe this may only subject a moderator elect to increased scrutiny for a year leading to the assembly, and will not avoid campaigning by hopeful moderators, rather it will now be the moderator-elect <i>and</i> moderator (the assembly may still vote against the last assembly's elect moderator) which must be settled every year. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-16-GA-Foothills-RAO-1-4-6-8-2-1-3-Moderator-Elect.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.		Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/
17. Allow for Video Testimony	Houston Metro	Yes	CCB advises conflict, but that conflict is easily dealt with in committee. One problem with our current rules forces victims of abuse and minors to testify in front of their alleged abusers. This overture would allow victims to testify without further trauma or intimidation. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-17-Houston-Metro-BCO-32-8.pdf
18. Overtures to multiple committees	Houston Metro	Yes (Also 15)	A fine overture to remove confusion over the process for receiving overtures. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Overture-18-Houston-Metro-RAO-11-5.pdf
33. Add vow regarding the trinity to membership	Tennessee Valley	No	It seems strange to oppose this overture on its face, but the doctrine of the trinity would seem best taught through creeds and pastoral care than through the taking of vows. For most of the history of the church this has been the means for engaging this truth. Unless there is a crisis within the PCA of belief on this topic, this does not seem to be the best means of ensuring trinitarian belief. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-33-TN-Valley-Membership-Vows.pdf
34. Regarding Electronic Filing	Philadelphia	Yes	A proposed amendment - Heed SJC advice and "postpone consideration of the SJC Manual change proposed in Overture 34 until the General Assembly and the Presbyteries render a decision on the BCO provisions proposed by the Overture." https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-34-Philadelphia-Written-Filing.pdf
35. Affirm PCA's commitment to Biblical sexuality	Savannah River		Answer in reference to Overture 42. OTHERWISE NO
36. Clarify the meaning of "credible report"	Savannah River	Yes	https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/04/Overture-36-Sav-R-Credible-Report.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.	Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/	
40. Overture to support and recognize women's roles	NW Georgia	No	This ironically titled overture offers "support" the same way the same presbytery offered support to Covenant Seminary by seeking to stop supporting it. This sub-biblical attempt to restrict the roles of women should be strongly opposed. Additionally some have advised: <i>"The Overture is a too vague resolution ("be authorized") to a vague problem ("churches wishing to acknowledge") that would create confusion around the doctrine of ordination ("with the laying on of hands")"</i> https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/Overture-40-NW-GA-Commission-Women.pdf

NP Overtures Advice for 2019 PCA General Assembly	This document is not to be reproduced or shared.		Click here to read the overtures: http://www.pcaac.org/general-assembly/overtures/
42. Appoint Ad Interim Committee regarding human sexuality	Chicago Metro	Yes (Also 4, 11, 22, 28, 30, 35, 37, 39, 42, 45)	My rationale is this: 1. I do believe there is confusion in our denomination, among people of good faith, people in the middle of the PCA, who would like to know how to deal with SSA among the people in our congregation. Revoice exists, in part, because our best strategy has been don't ask-don't tell in the PCA. The voices that speak the loudest for many of these pastors and elders, youth pastors and directors, are not our best voices. 2. The question of homosexual attraction should be answered in line with biblical anthropology and an orthodox doctrine of sin. To give up on this issue and answer in political statements given without pastoral care strikes at the heart of our beautiful orthodoxy. 3. We will face pressure in this committee to sign on to a Nashville statement that is simply the latest stick being used to whack away the unclean. "We must do something now." This is no less than the fifth straight year we've been told we must do something now or else, or else. Each time we have caved a bit - we have re-written the BCO, re-affirmed Biblical Marriage and re-affirmed our re-affirmation. Another statement is not going to keep us from hearing the same voices next year. There is intense distrust in our denomination, and any tool like the NS cannot be used in good faith - <u>it will be the means of instituting discipline without process</u>, without taking the time to understand the meaning of each other's words. It is simply a way to avoid the burden of relationship with one another. A study committee recognizes that we simply cannot come to an agreement at the moment, and need guidance.
48. Make a stronger statement on Abortion	Session CTK (Norman, OK)	No	Current statements are clear guidance for our congregants. If we want to guide the watching world it will require local witness, not denominational utterances. https://www.pcaac.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/05/Overture-48-Session-Christ-the-King-Abortion.pdf

Voting alert: nominating committee

2 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 27, 2019, 11:25:18 AM



to NP

Please join us in the assembly hall. We are losing votes at the moment.

NP Voting awareness

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 27, 2019, 1:47:41 PM



to NP

Time to return to the assembly hall for votes. We will be here until 5.30p and need to be ready to work.

Potential Nashville Statement Talking Points

11 views



tag...@gmail.com

<tagtuck@gmail.com>

Jun 27, 2019, 5:04:44 PM

主



to The National Partnership

I'd try to say some of these things myself but I was on Overtures. If you're looking to speak up tonight and you have the opportunity maybe this can help get you started:

POINT 1

Two sides of debate on all these Overtures regarding human sexuality.

The two sides focus on one of two audiences.

First Audience: the faithful Christian who does not struggle with non-straight sexual desire (my grandma)

Second Audience: the believer or skeptic trying to understand their own non-straight sexual desire

Most of our debate basically argues: ignore one audience and minister to the other.

Both sides have said things that sound like this to the other side.

We are talking past each other!

So think about who you are picturing in your mind – which audience are you ministering to?

How would you change your words if you wanted the other side of the debate to be able to hear you?

Please answer Overture 4 in the negative.

POINT 2

How can we declare the Nashville Statement as a “biblically faithful” statement, which although it has biblical language in parts, it does not have one single Bible reference?

Who are we seeking to talk to? To whom are we declaring things?

Without Biblical references, we must be seeking to talk to people who already know the Bible.

However, the rhetoric around this statement indicates we are trying to stand up to the culture.

This statement does not communicate clearly to the culture. It actually alienates and confuses the culture.

Please answer Overture 4 in the negative.



sseaton

<sseaton@emmanuelarlington.org>

Jun 27, 2019, 6:20:06 PM

主



to tag...@gmail.com, The National Partnership

And also point to the study committee. We want to speak, just in our own words and not a retweet.

Scott Seaton



jason.cornwell77

<jason.cornwell77@gmail.com>

Jun 27, 2019, 6:48:57 PM

主



to sseaton, tag...@gmail.com, The National Partnership

In addition to those great ones...

1. Theological Confusion: Council for Biblical Manhood & Womanhood (CBMW) put out the NS. 2 of their big names, CJ Maheny & Paige Patterson are currently Part of a large abuse scandal. Furthermore CBMW is neck deep in the Christological error of Eternal Subordination of the Son (ESS).

"Well, that's a genetic fallacy!" Not if the argument for supporting the NS is clarity. Our people have the internet. What will we say when they ask us why we got something from the likes of CBMW?

2. Closely related, take off the CBMW name. There's no way someone exercising intellectual honesty would support something from that kinda organization when other options are available.

3. Theological laziness - Not doing a study committee looks intellectually lazy & we miss a huge opportunity to make something official. And while we do a study committee pastors can refer their people back to the WLC on the 6th commandment.

4. Pastoral tone deafness - Supporting this Statement will place unnecessary roadblocks for many ministers in our denomination. It's the equivalent of using a sledgehammer to remove wisdom teeth.

Jason Cornwell



travis

<travis@graceandpeacepgh.org>

Jun 27, 2019, 7:10:55 PM

主



to jason.cornwell77, sseaton, tag...@gmail.com, The National Partnership

Also, also, if people try to use the NAE decision to justify the Nashville Statement (i.e. connection to the broader church) we need to judo flip it. Staying in the NAE allows the PCA to influence the NAE, endorsing the NS is allowing a particular segment of evangelicalism to uncritically influence us.

By endorsing the NS we'd actually be doing what those who were against the NAE feared that connection would do.



ssauls

<ssauls@christpres.org>

Jun 27, 2019, 7:24:42 PM

✉



to travis, The National Partnership, tag...@gmail.com, jason.cornwell77, sseaton

Another common argument i'm hearing this week is, "people with SSA should not be treated as unique or special in terms of their struggle with sin. We all struggle with sin, therefore we should all be treated equally."

In my estimation, this is the PCA equivalent of saying "all lives matter." It is a significant case and missing the point.

But a counter argument can be offered as well. If their sin doesn't set them apart as different in any unique sort of way, then why are we talking so much about their sin and not other sins more hetero in nature, or for that matter gossip, slander, gluttony, drinking too much, and loveless marriages, all of which are much more ubiquitous in our tribe than same sex kind of stuff?

Scott

GA Situational Awareness

3 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 27, 2019, 9:32:31 PM



to NP

The Overtures will be voted on in the assembly NOW. If by chance you are picking up SWAG in the assembly hall, smack yourselves and join us!

47th GA Reflection

11 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 28, 2019, 11:39:13 AM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

Dear friends,

The 47th GA is in the books. If you remember I listed three of my personal goals for this assembly:

1. Reject Nashville statement and approve SSA study committee
2. Approve the Abuse study committee
3. Approve Overture 8 regarding the service of unordained people on committees

1.5/3. Not what I was hoping for, by any means. Please allow me to share my personal thoughts; this is not what I think *you* ought to think, but what I think about all of this.

1. The **Nashville statement** felt like a bigger blow than I prepared for. After spending time talking to people and hearing their stories of struggle, watching the debate on the floor, the importance of rejecting the statement grew in my estimation. It wasn't important because the statement will have a long life in the PCA - I don't think it will - but because it was such a painful reminder of the chasm that exists between two sides in our denomination regarding what some call cultural engagement but others, me included, would call beautiful orthodoxy. The debate on this overture happened right after an incredible vision of the Kingdom in worship. That's the way it is, of course, rejoicing and grieving in stunning proximity until Jesus returns and all we've lost in grief comes washing back in, like the tide.

2. I am optimistic about the work of a **study committee** that can live in the PCA for at least the next generation as an expression of the very best of the thinking our God has given us at this time and in this place. I'm confident we will hear from people that will challenge us to drink deeply from truth, not truth like grape juice, but long-suffering, complex, aged wine - a nice port!, as it is embodied in our suffering savior. That's something to look forward to, and something for our prayers. The study committee would have been a stiff fight, I'm convinced, if we had not so fiercely signaled our commitment on the floor of the committee and the assembly. It was clear to the opposition that this was going to happen. That was a well-fought outcome and a critical "win."

3. I asked someone who actually knows something about RPR to speak to what was another positive outcome this week:

Review of Presbytery Records

RPR continues to be a source of health for our denomination. This is largely due to the face-to-face interaction that many of the commissioners have on the porch after hours at the hotel. Beverages are shared. Cigars and pipes are smoked. Men share about their families and ministries. It is not uncommon to see two men who have had passionate debate earlier in the day praying for each other later that night. RPR Chairman Ken McHeard was not lying about the RPR being the best committee in the PCA. It is hard, detailed work. But men have grown to trust each other over the years. Men who may disagree on some significant issues. But nonetheless they know each other and trust that the person looking from across the aisle is a good man, a man who loves Jesus and his church.

*This year men came together from across the aisle to call a presbytery to account for mishandling a case involving spousal abuse. This is the third year in a row that the RPR has held firm in holding presbyteries to account on this issue. This is one of the reasons we are having a study committee on domestic abuse this year - **because** the RPR kept the issue on the front burner.*

Another issue that has been kept on the front burner by the RPR is the issue of holding fast to good faith subscription. This year, for the second year in a row, the General Assembly has agreed with RPR's recommendation on Calvary Presbytery that they may not forbid a man to teach his views on a stated difference. This year, two other instances were joined from NW Georgia and Ohio Valley and the GA likewise concurred. For two years in a row, the GA has spoken to the issue of upholding

good faith subscription.

The reason why we kept pushing the issue at RPR is the same reason why we kept the abuse issue on the front burner: a larger change is needed. Several men came to the mics on the floor of GA and expressed that the way to handle this issue was to make a change to the Book of Church Order. Such a change is currently in the works. This is why we keep issues on the front burner at RPR, and the end game is lasting change through amendment of our constitution

4. The overture to allow the unordained to serve on boards and committees continues to work its way forward. It may not seem that way in a year it was defeated by a large margin, but consider: a. We learned more about the barriers we must overcome to see unordained men and women laboring fully in the denomination, b. we gained valuable allies, men and women, through the process of debate who I believe will give us critical tools for success, and c. An unassailable minority report - authored by EJ Nusbaum and Bruce Terrell, is now a strong line of argument to which the other side will have to answer. Wonderful work was done this year - I am only more emboldened and assured that this is the trajectory of the PCA, a more orthodox view of ordained authority and the priesthood of all believers. Next year we will knock again, at the door, and see what our Lord does.

5. We were able to defeat what I think were not helpful attempts to carve a cultural rather than kingdom-minded mission for both MTW and Covenant Seminary. Attempts to drive back MTW's endorsement of non-ordained persons operating in non-ecclesiastical areas of expertise - were met with very clear denial. And shots aimed at potentially severing our relationship with Covenant Seminary were answered, in my opinion, with prejudice. This is a sign of health that has not always existed in the PCA. Often some odd thing would be approved that would unduly embarrass a committee chairman or institution and we would have to come back the next year and undo it. This year that was stopped, immediately. Evidence of your influence in safeguarding the assembly, and a real encouragement to both Dr. Dalbey and Lloyd Kim, who have led with humble and skilled dedication to their charges.

6. Worship. Wow. What an incredible job done by the committee, guys like David Ridenhour and Joshua Anderson. I was greatly moved by the beauty of the Word given to us through music and prayer, incredible preaching, the sacrament, a blind woman who sang us all to sight, David Cassidy goin' y'aaaaaaaalll on us, Dr. Ince using his hanky because of all the fire. My goodness. A feast. How about that?

7. The Gathering, was another reminder of what's next. Lance LEWIS. Wonderful reminder that the Gospel compels generosity without exception. The venue was great, the connections we could see from agencies and parachurch and friend networks, showed us how big even this tiny church can be. Also those bacon skewers were 100%.

8. Some things I found myself saying during the week:

- No one can stop us from becoming this kind of denomination. The denomination we were at the end of worship last night. No one. We are the majority, and if we gather around the Gospel there will be nothing to stop it. If we keep preaching to the dry bones.

- There's work to be done, and it is clear that we are going to do it. You all were so invested in the courts, trying to understand everything we were doing, proposing speeches, answering the bell with *passion*. People still honestly think the NP is led by the hand but I no more lead than the bull rider leads the bull. Hang on for dear life. You guys were a joy to watch in action.

Look, there's much to be done, and it will be done. Thank God we get to go home to our churches, where the real treasure is kept. Take a break from thinking about GA polity. We'll connect again in the beginning of the fall and talk about next steps. For now I am grateful to have seen how our Lord is using you all for his glory. May he lead us to be good stewards in the PCA of the Gospel God has given to the world.

For the King,

JK



dcassidy3817
<dcassidy3817@gmail.com>

Jun 28, 2019, 12:14:46 PM

✉



to james, thenp@googlegroups.com

Incredibly helpful James. I always need your faithful, generous, hopeful perspective. I was downcast. You've lifted my heart for what I know will be hard conversations at home. I gotta have some more hang time with you so I keep my heart on track. Thank you.

David Cassidy Sent from my iPhone



sseaton

<sseaton@emmanuelarlington.org>

Jun 28, 2019, 5:32:17 PM

主



to dcassidy3817, james, thenp@googlegroups.com

David—

You may feel a bit downcast, but I gotta say, you lifted my soul the other night. We were blessed to hear from you, as you got us looking ahead with hope for our dry bones. Yes, not everything went as we'd hope, but from the perspective of someone who has been in the PCA for over 35 years, we are trending well. Very well. I am so excited for the trajectory of this part of Christ's Church—most especially because of the voices and hearts of the next generation. So good to labor with you all. It's worth it.

-Still in Dallas, poolside. (Wow, it's hot here).

Scott Seaton

2020

NP NOTE: 2020.

4 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jan 9, 2020, 3:19:06 PM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

{This communication is confidential and may not be shared without the author's permission}

Friends,

As the first presbytery meetings of the year are upon us I wanted to give a bit of an **overview for the next six months** of work and to share one big concern.

The big concern is this: while the last years of GA have provided some encouraging signs, a particular tactical response from the unhealthy wing of the denomination has led to the **packing of committees** by the minority for one reason: the majority has not been willing to speak up. In many presbyteries, administrative committees have begun nominating candidates then bringing them to the floor without a contested vote. Typically I hear surprise that a certain presbytery nominated one of their most conservative members for the OC, for instance. For the past few years presbyteries have moved nominations to Admin committees staffed with the more polity-minded and conservative members. Those committees pass along a nominee that is less representative of the presbytery as a whole and those of us who do not want to appear to be negative about a particular candidate, allow that candidate to represent them, no contest.

We cannot continue to do this. While it may appear to be gracious to not contest a nominee serving as your presbytery's representative, it is not *ungracious* to ensure that the will of the presbytery is clear. After all, we vote every year on the moderator for the assembly, for instance, without being ungracious. It is not contentious to make sure that your presbytery sends representatives that reflect the will of your presbytery, rather than a rep that is less broad-minded. The subtle inches we lose by failing to pay attention when we are electing representatives can cost us yards later. So my recommendation would be that you:

1. **Find out *how your presbytery elects*** nominees for GA committees.
2. If they're not nominated by committee, but first-come-first-served, **get your name in there - even now** in January (big areas of need are always the Overtures Committee and the Administrative committee - particularly this year)
3. IF they're nominated by committees, **ensure that those committee choices receive a vote on the floor.**
4. **Make sure that you and others are present** when those votes happen.
5. If there are no suitable nominees on the slate, **nominate someone else.**
6. **Be willing to speak from the floor of your presbytery.** It is possible to speak *for* a different candidate while not speaking *against* anyone.

One other thing: **We have to show up at the assembly.**

Most votes are 60/40, but that 60/40 can shift dramatically. When the majority isn't particularly eager to be on the floor for a vote, we leave the results in doubt. A majority committed to showing up at the assembly can do great things. We will never work our connectionalism into something beautiful until we show up regularly, together, to do the work of the assembly. **We will have to be willing to bring our Elders with us and participate.**

At this year's Assembly we will have a chance to elect a **new Stated Clerk**. We will be presented with a candidate from the Administrative Permanent Committee. There may also be one or more floor nominations presented by various factions. My read is that this could be an opportunity to move our denomination toward clarifying our mission in the world and leveraging the incredible gifts we've been given in the PCA to advance the work of the Kingdom. Roy Taylor has been a real blessing, and his steady stewardship will be a significant challenge for the next one to hold his office. But the right Stated Clerk could do more than keep the car on the road; he could help us move toward a much healthier destination. The wrong clerk may or may not be a critical error, but the right one could help us build a uniquely effective and generous and fruitful denomination. It's worth the time and expense to help make that happen this year. I hope you'll join us.

If you're new to the NP, expect another note as overtures begin to be received by the clerk's office. That's when we will begin to know what the big issues will be, and how we can participate in the process this year. Anticipate some rumblings in the usual places about human sexuality overtures, Side-B/Revoice, etc. The study committee on human sexuality is expected to report at this GA.

In February and March we will focus on Nominating Committee, then the committees of the Assembly itself. As always, we intend for the NP to serve as a forum for resourcing and encouragement. While I and others will share opinions we want to be shaped by the wise dissent, if you've got it. **Unity, not uniformity.**

Grateful to serve alongside all of you.

James Kessler

NP NOTE ADDENDUM

4 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jan 9, 2020, 3:22:49 PM

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to thenp@googlegroups.com

One other quick note:

Last year's experiment with a condensed W-F schedule was discontinued and we moved back to the previous T-F schedule. Wanted you to be aware that things will start a bit sooner, in case you missed it.

NP Note: Reviewing the AIC report, and moving forward.

13 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Aug 20, 2020, 8:18:09 AM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

[Please do not share without the permission of the author]

Dear friends,

August has always felt like the beginning of preparation for the next year's GA. With the postponement of this last assembly, the need to refocus and prepare is even more timely. Over the next few weeks I'd like to propose some areas of focus for the health of our little corner of the church. Today, though, let's reflect on the work of the Ad-Interim Committee as it examined SSA and human sexuality. Understanding this report will help us navigate the next year's overtures that will seek to act contrary to its wisdom. My apologies for the length of this note - I tried to be concise where I could.

Reviewing the AIC report:

After the General Assembly's affirmation of the Nashville Statement as "Biblically faithful," an action many of us did not support, there was some hope that the PCA's own scholars, given the directive to study the issue of a Biblical approach to same-sex attraction and human sexuality, might be able to produce a document that could serve the denomination and the broader church to a far greater degree. In certain corners of our denomination there was a significant skepticism about the usefulness of the committee and some openly denigrated the work as hopelessly compromised by liberal voices even before it began. The stakes for the PCA's reputation outside the denomination were significant, but to a degree the stakes inside the body were even higher. Would it be possible, given the cultural moment and the disintegration of civil and charitable discourse, for our denomination, through a study committee, to *do theology* faithfully, confessionally, publicly?

My view is that they met that high standard. The report is not only comprehensive, but strikingly circumspect, respectfully and charitably so. It takes hard work and patience to examine all the sides of an issue and to render judgments with love - I think they accomplished just that. In the 60+ pages of the report I found not one attribution of sinful motive. (Think of how hard it is for us to get through Twitter's 240 characters in a discussion about human sexuality without impugning motives). From that perspective the AIC's report is not only a work of substance about its subject, it's also instructive for how we might conduct ourselves as a connectional church.

Since my reflections are full of strengths, I'll begin with the only significant **weakness** I noted (there will always be smaller disagreements about terminology et al.): it relates to the discussion on the "Three Challenges for Christians Today" #1 (pp.35-36). Addressing the modern identity narrative - this was not a strong understanding of the roots of identity ideology (the report roots it in a freedom/power dialectic it calls Marxist and Nietzschean, which I think was a complete miss). Engaging in our culture from this perspective will miss the heart of our hearers.

In terms of **strengths** I found many.

1. **The apologetics content was accessible and compelling.** I found pages 34-44, an apologetic approach to human sexuality, to be critical reading. If there's one section you should closely follow and notate, it's that one. The annotated bibliography gives a great list of authors and readings with which to interact. I could imagine those sections (apologetics and bibliography) would be immediately helpful in pastoral care, not only of those struggling with SSA, but those in our churches who are anxious and fearful culture warriors on either side of this discussion. Reading this section of the report dissolved some of my apprehensions about pastoring my own church toward a Christian sexual ethic. Challenges two and three from the "Three Challenges" (pp.37-40), included this paragraph, relating to the way a Christian sexual ethic blessed antiquity, and was particularly strong:

"There was an immediate concrete result that all could see. By breaking the connection of sex with the social order, Christianity guarded the vulnerable from exploitation. No man could demand sex of a woman without giving up his independence and committing his whole life to her. No man could demand sex from his servants. The vulnerable—women, slaves, and children—were protected by the insistence that sex occur only within the safety of the covenantal union of marriage. But beyond these practical results, the "underlying logic" of Christianity regarding sex went much further and higher. It re-imagined sex as no longer a mere appetite that we could barely control but rather as a joyous, even sacred, expression that reflects the way God is saving the world." (p.38)

2. **The report engages the reader with pastoral intent.** Even the brief statements of orthodoxy were framed as wholly Biblical and Confessional ethics rather than propositions. This was not a set of affirmations and denials, thankfully. The committee showed obvious concern for the human and kingdom impact of their truthfulness. This is how we must speak prophetically, with love. The AIC report was also not willing to provide statements of orthodoxy without a framework for human flourishing. In a number of places the authors share a concern for bald truth-telling, throwing propositional grenades. Including statements #11 (friendship) and 12 (repentance and hope) in the report's Twelve Statements were clear signs of Pastoral Theology at work. I was thankful for their thoroughness in helping pastors to pastor.

Regarding shepherding of the faithful, but weary, repenter: *"We would never say to a new believer who has a history of destructive anger, 'Now that you are a Christian, you will never again feel a rush of anger rise up within you at the wrong time, for a selfish reason, out of proportion to the situation, or in any other way that contradicts God's law.'" Neither should we communicate to a believer with a history of homosexual attraction the expectation that this will simply disappear."* (II.B.2 "Continued Corruption," p.22)

There was even *confessional* hope for our imperfect obedience to Christ: *"It is crucially important that our churches communicate to same-sex attracted believers experiencing same-sex attraction that faithfulness to God's call to discipleship upon their lives is possible. An unclear understanding of the Reformed position that sinful temptations themselves, as well as sins of the will, are to be repented of might reasonably lead some to believe that faithfulness is impossible and pursuing holiness is an exercise in futility. We should be clear that while every Christian's obedience remains imperfect and tainted by sin in this life, there is still a very real and important sense in which*

through Christ all Christians have been equipped for real and progressive obedience to God that brings him honor and is worthy of rejoicing in (WCF 16.6). This remains true even if their attraction to the same sex does not go away.” (p.24)

On the Church's responsibility to function as the invitational, welcoming, feasting community of the King: *“We ought to grieve any time a person who experiences attraction toward the same sex finds a greater welcome and belonging in the secular LGBT community instead of the church.” (p.31)*

3. **The report was willing to draw healthy lines regarding current controversies.** The first third of the report deals comprehensively with questions of desire and temptation as well as what it means to “mortify the flesh.” All helpful. Of course this is the statement that will generate the most conflict from some corners of our denomination and broader evangelicalism: *“For those repentant believers who know the struggle of same-sex attraction, our churches may welcome them not merely as broken people to be ministered to, but also as active and important participants and contributors in our communities. Like all yet-to-be- glorified Christians, those who struggle with same-sex attraction are commanded to walk with the Lord in faith and repentance. Insofar as such persons display the requisite Christian maturity, we do not consider this sin struggle automatically to disqualify someone for leadership in the church (1 Cor. 6:9-11, 1 Tim. 3:1-7, Titus 1:6-9; 2 Pet. 1:3-11).” (p.31)*

The report provided wisdom, pastoral care, and clear guidance. Praise God for His care for us through His word.

A word about our present and future. I think this report gives us a glimpse into the present and future of the PCA. I'm aware, as I'm sure many of you are, of the various micro-groups whose vision is wrapped around existential threats to the survival of Biblical fidelity in our denomination. Some of those groups once sought to win votes, but having failed to do so, are attempting to cultivate division within individual churches by urging congregants to confront their pastors in a posture of distrust. I understand it is troubling to have a kind-hearted congregant ask you if you are now or ever have been a member of the National Partnership, as if it is some dishonor to your office. It is disturbing to have congregants bring up particular pastors in other corners of the denomination, friends of yours who you know to be exemplary leaders and shepherds, and to have their name mentioned as proof of theological liberalism, because they saw it on social media, or on some website. It is indeed hard to hold to a beautiful vision for our calling when it isn't the sheep who cause you the most distress but the shepherds of the sheep. When pastors defame pastors it cuts us all off at the knees. It would be tempting to buy into either a hyper localism (I'll just keep my eyes fixed on my local church) or hyper denominationalism (our hope is in eliminating the influence of bad actors). I want to encourage you, as I encourage myself, to adopt the method of cultural engagement, care for the sheep, and the gentle answer of our critics, embodied in the AIC's report. If a congregant wants to know about the National Partnership, feel free to tell them what it is. If they trust their pastor, it will be a good opportunity to share the burden you feel for what we can accomplish as a connectional church, and why you must do the hard work of being a churchman. If they don't trust you, the issues are far deeper than being a part of an email list for the good of the Church. What I tell my own people is simple: I'm better when I reason together with others. I don't know everything. I need help to fulfill my duty as a presbyter.

There are a few implications for the NP:

1. I continue to see the need for our little collective to exist - navigating controversies and micro-divisions while leveraging the gifts of so many of you for the greater good of the denomination (e.g. have you read Todd Gwennap's article about 2019's protest? Really good - <https://www.toddgwennap.com/blog/2020/8/7/why-i-signed-the-pca-protest>) will

require **clear-headed collaboration**. It's only going to get harder to lead with wisdom. We need each other's help.

2. Rather than focus on NP growth, it is my hope that we serve as **instigators of good in the PCA**. The Beautiful Orthodoxy conference is an example of this, not a Partnership conference, but created from the relationships and common cause we've built together. There are several NP friends who are now podcasting for the common good (Doug Serven and Justin Edgar's I {heart} PCA is a great initiative), these aren't Partnership things, but my hope is that continuing to do the work of polity for the good of our little denomination cultivates the ground for Kingdom work. The more we are willing to press forward toward health at the Presbytery and denominational level, the greater the harvest in the things we all love about laboring in the Church. I'm convinced that it is a trap to rely *solely* on gerrymandering away our conflicts in the PCA through polity. Instead we can be instigators for good and take up all the oxygen in the room with a beautiful orthodoxy. That's our aim. If you have friends you want to connect, by all means send me their contact info, but we will not be pursuing a GRN-type footprint in the PCA. What we *will* be looking to do is to continue maintaining a healthy path for others to walk.
3. We will continue to see micro-expressions of anxiety like the Firm Foundation Partnership and others. While I'm not concerned about their clout I *am* concerned that they reveal a need to **address our online ethics**, possibly through a change in our ministerial vows, almost certainly through discipline. I'm concerned about ministers in difficult revitalization projects or struggling presbyteries who will be forced to defend themselves against hurtful and baseless accusations of liberalism from the congregant who saw something online. The kingdom time and energy wasted refuting false statements, and the damage done not only to the reputations of the slandered but to the slanderers themselves only strengthens the need for work on the subject. Other denominations have found a way to work at this, the PCA ought to do the same.

I'm far more interested in where we may be headed as a denomination. The AIC report is a great example of why I'm in the PCA. We have tools at our disposal, and all the necessary resources, to provide the best answers to the questions our world is asking. I was proud to learn from those on the committee, and it doesn't end there. The PCA, I've learned through the first two years of the Beautiful Orthodoxy conference, is full of men and women laboring for the Kingdom in ways that inspire a sacred imagination. The PCA gets plenty of things wrong, but I'm increasingly convinced that if there's a group most capable of getting it right, it's this group. We have tremendous potential to serve a global, diverse, orthodox, beautiful church. Campus ministry and foreign mission, church planting and revitalization, the training up of men and women to serve in ministries that confront the full range of human needs. One of my favorite authors is fond of saying "it's our generation's turn to be alive." This generation of ministers, of men and women at work, has been given the responsibility not only to live but to lead. The fathers and mothers, grandfathers and grandmothers of our denomination are giving us permission to carry this little corner of the church forward. No manner of distraction or divisiveness is worth looking aside from our task. We should follow the example set by our AIC: continue to speak with wisdom, pastoral care, and clear guidance, and lead.

Next week: a typical NP note with polity updates, calendar items, etc.

NP Note

12 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Aug 27, 2020, 1:50:34 PM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

{Please do not share this communication without the permission of the author}

Dear friends,

Just one item today:

As we begin to plan for next Summer's General Assembly there is one easy way to begin working together: we need to understand how committee representatives are populated by our presbyteries. This isn't a complicated polity issue but it makes a big difference in the health of our denomination. If our GA committees (not just the Overtures committee but places like the Nominating Committee) are not representative of their presbyteries or the denomination as a whole, extreme shifts happen at the assembly. Some presbyteries have an open nominations process, taking recommendations from the floor then voting as a body of the whole. Others have a closed system where an administrative committee votes on a slate and sends them to the floor. In still other presbyteries nominating commissions will make appointments and report back without the full body voting. In some cases this has led to some of you wanting to participate on a committee but finding that these appointments have already been decided far in advance. In my opinion an open nominating process is best and it may be helpful for us to understand which presbyteries operate according to which tradition.

To help one another understand how to pursue a nomination for committee work through their presbytery, **I would appreciate you taking just a moment to indicate on this NP spreadsheet (not shared outside our group) about how your presbytery makes these nominations**. Thanks so much for your help on this!

Link:

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1QdghA3NVIPM1enWWAo2tPlyu0QpssbmwwdhCySBoEf8/edit?usp=sharing>

Next week: discussion of opportunities to serve in the denomination through committee work.

Thanks all!

JK

Follow-up on NP Presbytery information resource sheet

14 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Aug 27, 2020, 1:54:33 PM

主



to TheNP@googlegroups.com

[James Kessler](#) sent you a note about this spreadsheet with the [activity dashboard](#):

[NP Presbytery information resource sheet](#)

In case you have trouble, the link to the presbytery resource sheet is below.

||

Google Sheets: Create and edit spreadsheets online.

Google LLC, 1600 Amphitheatre Parkway, Mountain View, CA 94043, USA

You have received this email because ja...@newcityhilliard.org shared a spreadsheet with you from

Google Sheets.

2021

NP Note

23 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Feb 3, 2021, 9:09:48 PM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

[We ask that you not distribute this email without the permission of the author]

Dear friends,

As we turn toward the business of General Assembly and, hopefully, out of the business of surviving a pandemic, I wanted to reset our map of things a bit.

First, it will be wise to keep you schedule clear in September as I do believe there's a strong chance we'll be moving the Assembly back a few months this year. We should know within a month what the Admin Committee has decided, but given the state of things nationally I am pessimistic that we will be able to hold GA in June as scheduled. The alternate timeline seems to be September. Just a heads up for your long-range planning.

Second, since this is technically the 2020 GA postponed a year, the slate of nominations and committee memberships is carried forward an additional year. Here's how the postponed assembly affects things for 2021, via advice from our former Stated Clerk, Roy Taylor:

1. *All current members of General Assembly level Committees, Agency Boards, Special Committees, and the Standing Judicial Commission will have their terms continue until the next General Assembly. The parliamentary principle we are following is that leaders remain in office until the end of the Assembly that elects their successors. This practically means that all General Assembly terms are extended by one year. Those who were in the class of 2020 are now in the class of 2021 (still serving until the end of the 2021 General Assembly).*
2. *So that there would not be a disruption of the normal class structure of General Assembly committees and boards, the orderly consequence of extending the term of those initially scheduled for 2020 election is that those in subsequent General Assembly classes will also have their terms extended for one year (e.g. those who were in the class of 2023 are now in the class of 2024, and so on).*

*There will **not** be any new nominations taken for **General Assembly positions** from your presbytery this year. The slate put forth by the Nominating Committee from their March 2020 meeting for the postponed General Assembly is still the current slate to be considered for the upcoming General Assembly. If vacancies arise from that current slate, the Nominating Committee will fill them with those men already nominated by their presbytery. If other vacancies arise from resignation or death, they will be handled by floor nomination at General Assembly, as would occur in our regular General Assembly processes.*

Previous presbytery representatives on the **Nominating Committee (NC)** and **Review of Presbytery Records Committee (RPR)** will continue in service – their class years have also been extended by one year. If your presbytery's representative was to roll off in 2020, he will now roll off in 2021. Your presbytery does not need to send in new appointments to these committees this year unless your current member has moved from your presbytery or no longer wishes to serve.

For Committees of Commissioners – You need take no further action. If you wish to have the men you previously appointed for the postponed General Assembly represent your presbytery, then there is no further action for you to take.

Here's what this means for us as we engage in the assembly work this year:

1. Following the confirmation of the GA meeting dates, you should double-check with your presbytery to ensure that your representative to the Overtures Committee wishes to continue that appointment. If not, perhaps you or someone else with a healthy view of the denomination's mission could take that spot. Just like past years, this Assembly requires the work of all of us ensuring that the healthiest vision of the PCA is reflected by her committees.
2. Once you confirm your presbytery's representative to the OC, would you update our list here?

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1QdghA3NVIPM1enWWAo2tPlyu0QpssbmwwdhCySBoEf8/edit?usp=sharing>

Finally I want to reflect on where we are, and where we're going.

You all know I've never wanted the NP to see itself in opposition to the GRN, as one political party against another. The formula for a two-party system's fruitlessness is something we all experience in the world of national politics. There's a reason for this: not only does this two-party framework encourage conflict (you must constantly *respond* to the actions and rhetoric of the other) but it also constrains creativity and generosity; if the NP sees itself as an opponent of the GRN then it will waste necessary kingdom energy addressing ideas it does not advocate, instead of moving toward a greater vision of the Kingdom and marshaling its energies to realize that vision.

At the same time, I *am* concerned not by the GRN but by the effectiveness of the cultural wedge issues they continue to utilize as *calls to action* and *times to stand*. The past four years the assembly has been embroiled by rhetoric. We hastily, in my opinion, affirmed the Nashville Statement even as a far better expression of our orthodoxy was within our grasp. We have normalized an annual exercise of distrust; sending pugnacious overtures to the OC, punching for the express purpose of making the "unorthodox" howl. Riding the wave of culture-war, fear has created a strong voting block that has not only stilted our voice as an Assembly but helped to repopulate some of our committees, like the SJC, with less healthy expressions of our denominational body. While many have been focused on how to make our denominational home more hospitable to a Biblically-Orthodox and beautiful Church that welcomes every tribe, others have barred the door. I'm not sure we realize how effectively they've done so.

Maybe you have already read Greg Thompson's letter concurring with his presbytery's action to divest him without censure, but his explanation of why he does not think it would be fruitful to continue in the PCA is instructive to us. Of course it arises out of a distinct situation, and without commentary on the rest of his letter and his commendable work, I'll quote him here: "while there are many, many wonderful individual men and women laboring in our denomination (and you are surely among them), the culture of our denomination—a culture that is at once instinctively *suspicious*, *chronically self-righteous*, and *promiscuously litigious*—nurtures an ecclesial climate in which our

chief concern can never truly be the needs of the most vulnerable members of our society, but must always be the anxieties of the most vocal members of our denomination." [emphasis mine]

The last four years the GRN has worked, in my opinion, to amplify the volume not of the most vulnerable in our society but the most vocal anxieties in our denomination. Our work, not in opposition, but in contrast, is important. This is not *the most important GA of our lifetime*, because they're all important - we leave the crisis management to God, but this next assembly has the potential to be particularly fruitful if we heed warnings like Greg's and pursue a beautiful orthodoxy together.

The PCA continues to grow in a time of church recession. The PCA is where the head of the NAE (Walter Kim), the president of the Gospel Coalition (Julius Kim), and the Global Executive Director at Lausanne (Michael Oh) have their membership. The denomination where we are working to promote equity for minority ministry candidates, where we continue to create the kind of enthusiasm for the great commission that we send out scores of church planters, campus ministers and leaders, foreign missionaries into the field. There are great things, precious things, we ought to treasure about what we've helped to create. If we're going to redirect our concern as pastors and elders toward those who are longing for the Kingdom of God instead of the most entrenched critics of our collective work, Greg Thompson is right -- we will need to aim higher than fighting. We will need to tend to some basic fields of faithfulness to the work of the PCA. I'm optimistic because I believe all of these are within our reach:

1. We will have to forge relationships with other pastors and elders in the denomination beyond the boundaries of the NP. While I'm not actively recruiting more people into the NP, I do think it is possible for the NP to grow in its good influence across the denomination. An example of this kind of initiative is David Richter and Walt Nilsson's efforts to forge broader connections in the PCA among the various tribes. They're ensuring that a broad coalition of health in the PCA will have the ability to act in concert. Not just for crucial votes but to inform our practices as gospel witnesses in the world and to build the kind of common cause (call it connectionalism if you like) that will help us to pursue good initiatives *together* rather than as confederate presbyteries.
2. We have to more energetically gather our like-minded friends around the work we do. Do you have a group of people who may not be connected to the NP but are connected to you? There's no reason you shouldn't share your thoughts with them. I don't mind if you reproduce the work we do here. And I certainly don't mind if your ten non-NP PCA friends at GA want to work with you to vote in unity on the floor. There's no reason why all of us shouldn't have a group of friends we're resourcing during the work of the assembly. Reproducing the NP model of honest collaboration among friends at presbytery and the GA is a wise way to look out for your fellow pastors and elders who do not have a group like ours. So put together your group now and plan ahead for June/September. I'm encouraged that when we arrive at the GA we will have a more unified and informed group of voters on the floor, a group that knows it not only has a common interest in the various votes but a common *cause*.
3. Devote a small portion of each week to denominational work. I'll share my own personal practice here, bear with me. My Wednesday afternoons are for non-local church ministry. That includes NP issues and the Beautiful Orthodoxy conference and a global church planting collaborative, but more broadly it involves studying denominational health. Some

weeks I run out of time, that's okay. Others I have the space to read overtures and study committee reports; I can read ByFaith and pray for the PCA, or participate in calls with denominational leaders. I try to create space for this work not because I want to fight but because I believe that God has given the PCA a unique opportunity to leverage its unique giftedness for the sake of a time where it is desperately needed. And I don't want to look back at the end of my career and feel that I did not make use of the moments the Lord gave me to bear greater kingdom fruit. Our work in this denomination is one of those opportunities. While the vast majority of our heart and tears and hours in the week are dedicated to the work of our local church - and it truly delights us - I don't think it's wrong to delight in this work, too. I make no apologies for it. When I sit and listen to the stories of the gospel at the Beautiful Orthodoxy conference or The Fellowship's yearly gathering, or read about what's happening in a corner of our denomination I never knew existed, I thank God that he gives me an opportunity to help increase its righteous reach into the world.

One writer talks about her shock when she realized it was her generation's time to live, that the world was in their care. But it also meant that it was their opportunity to create the beauty, the craft, the artistry and agony of what it means to be human in that place and in that time. I'm 41. Many of you are in my age-range. This, frankly, is our generation's time to live as leaders and laborers. What our little corner of the church accomplishes, our local church and the broader church to which we belong by God's own hand, is ours to cultivate or ours to curse. I made a deal eight years ago that I would never whine about my denomination, because I believed I had the opportunity to help lead it. That's what we've done together. It's not time to fight or time to stand or time to sound the alarm; it's just time to lead. I want you to know where I stand, and how optimistic I am that the future will be a sight to see. Whenever the Assembly happens this year, I look forward to seeing you there and pulling on the same rope.

A statement about the PCA worth having

12 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Apr 12, 2021, 10:14:44 AM



to thenp@googlegroups.com

Dear Partnership friends,

With the continued public concerns raised about the PCA from news-blogs, upcoming conferences, etc., I wanted to give a view of the PCA that might speak broadly of a denomination we can enthusiastically support and build together, including all but the most strident contrary voices. This is my first attempt at vocalizing that denomination, and I've just posted it. Thankful as always for those

of you who have participated in the work of the PCA. I look forward to the assembly this June and seeing many of you in person!

<https://morsekarl.com/writing/the-pca-worth-having>

NP Note

13 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 11, 2021, 6:33:46 AM

主



to NP

{The contents of this email may not be shared without the sender's permission}

I. News

II. Overture Prep

III. Calendar

News

Dear friends,

Many of you have heard about the letter drafted by Mike Khandjian and several other contributors. I was not one of the principal authors, but I am grateful to see it out in the world. I'd commend it to you as one way that we can help guide a healthier denomination. Like you, I've encountered a lot of exhaustion and raw nerves from the last 15 months of pandemic life piled upon a particularly divisive cultural moment. My view is that much of the anxiety we're seeing has no small part to do with the fact that we have very little margin for charity. Someone has to lead the way in re-asserting our values and extending charity. This letter moves in that direction. I would encourage you to consider signing it, as I have, and to share it with your elders/pastors as well. There are some names on that list who have been real inspirations for me and you, I'm sure. I'd be proud to see our signatures on it, too.

One of the guys from our group has shared his particular rationale for signing, and encouraging others to sign.

- 1.) It's a plea for charity in our discourse
- 2.) It presents a different narrative about the state of the PCA than some others have offered. There are whole conferences promoting the idea that the PCA is about to go over a cliff, and we just don't think that's true at all.
- 3.) It supports a GFS course for the future of the PCA, as it has served us well so far.

I'd say that about covers it.

One note: I'm sure that some of you may have very good reasons for *not* signing this letter. As you know, the NP has always tried to achieve unity rather than uniformity. I want you to know that there is no lack of respect or grace for those of you who for one reason or another feel you cannot sign it. Glad to be doing the work together. Here's the link to the letter:

<https://www.afaithfulpca.net>

****If you haven't already signed up for the Fellowship Dinner (Not an NP event but lots of you guys will be there), here's the signup:** https://chapelgate.ccbchurch.com/goto/forms/873/responses/new?fbclid=IwAR281HinEvc215eczDhU6IG6tCxUz4vZfzkT1kS8sZ0_iKrVA4GMFNBTtes

Among others, like Scott Sauls and our new CTS President Tom Gibbs, I'll get a chance to promote the 2022 Beautiful Orthodoxy conference in February (we'll open registration for the first time at GA). The Fellowship Dinner is a blast every year and a needed encouragement in a work-heavy week. Hope you'll be there.

Overture Prep

Beginning Wednesday, I'll send out some preliminary thoughts on the overtures before the assembly this year. We'll have a chance to discuss via email with the group as in years past. That'll give us ten days of prep to discuss any issues and resource one another. My overall view is that while this is a record-breaking year for assembly attendance, the Overtures Committee will be as evenly divided as in years past. I'll share a post-OC updated recommendation as well.

Calendar

6.16: Overtures Prep

6.23: Assembly Overview [where you should be and when, important committee actions, votes, etc.]

6.28: Nominations Discussion

Looking forward to laboring with all of you this year. I so appreciate your wisdom and guidance through the process. More next Wednesday.

JK

NP NOTE

15 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 23, 2021, 5:27:44 PM

主



to NP

Dear friends,

I wanted to provide an overview of the General Assembly including key meetings, reports, voting times, etc. Some of this will be subject to change as the assembly begins.

*A quick note: If you're going to be at the Assembly, you really ought to be sure to be present and voting when necessary. If by some chance you need to schedule something during the business of the Assembly, do not miss any of the items in **red**. These are when critical votes and committee reports happen. Plan accordingly! Every year I hear from commissioners who miss out by not carefully planning their trips to the coffee station. As we've always said in the NP, this is a work trip and we should be ready to do the work of churchmen. Looking forward to seeing many of you next week! Next update should happen early in the week of the Assembly, updated overtures advice.*

CALENDAR

Monday (6/28)

10a: Overtures briefing and meeting (Rooms 101/102)

11a: CoC briefing (Rm 103)

1p: CoC meetings

Tuesday (6/29)

6.30p: Opening Worship Service

8.10p: Assembly reconvenes (MODERATOR ELECTION)

Wednesday (6/30)

11a: Review of Presbytery Records Report. (The issue of allowing pastors to teach their exceptions to the standards will come to the floor here)

1.45p: Scheduled report of the Ad Interim Committee on Human Sexuality

3p: Scheduled report of the Ad Interim Committee on Domestic Violence

5p: Worship service

7p: The Fellowship Gathering at Covenant College (Mike Khandjian's Fellowship group has a yearly dinner open to all)

Thursday (7/1)

11a: ORDER OF THE DAY (which means the report *must* happen at the appointed time): Nominating Committee Report, Election of Stated Clerk.

1.30p: ORDER OF THE DAY, SJC report.

3.00p: Scheduled Overtures Committee Report

5.30p: Dinner

7.30p: Worship service

9.10p: Assembly reconvenes for business (Overtures Report)

Midnight: Adjournment of the 48th General Assembly (scheduled)

GA Seminars of particular interest:

Seeking Unity in the PCA: a Conversation on Subscription With David Strain and David Cassidy

Tuesday June 29 - 3:35-4:20pm in room 274

The PCA is a Good-Faith Subscription denomination that sometimes experiences difficulty with how we apply that conviction in ways that avoid conflict between various Presbyteries and Elders. The historical debate between Good-Faith Subscription and Strict Subscription still influences many people and practices, and occasionally resurfaces with some degree of intensity, as it has again recently. In this gathering, two Pastors who love the PCA and our Confessional Standards engage in a conversation about where differences exist on this important issue and look to model how we can walk together in both fidelity to our Standards and unity of heart and purpose. Please join David Strain, Pastor of First Presbyterian Church in Jackson, Mississippi and David Cassidy, Pastor of Spanish River Church in Boca Raton, Florida for their conversation, hosted by their mutual friend Nate Shurden, Pastor of Cornerstone Church in Franklin, Tennessee.

Above reproach, self-controlled, and holy, or the moral and spiritual qualifications for ordinands: Exegetical and ethical notes.

Wednesday June 30, 8.00am

Dan Doriani

The Future Glory of the Church: The PCA We Envision for Christ's Purposes.

Wednesday June 30, 9.15am

Dr. Bryan Chapell will moderate the six-member panel of teaching elders coming from a range of callings from the pastorate to college presidency, from work in distinctly PCA settings to ecumenical settings: Michael Allen, academic dean at Reformed Theological Seminary Orlando; Chuck Garriott, executive director of Ministry to State; Brian Habig, pastor of Downtown Presbyterian Church in Greenville, South Carolina; Julius Kim, associate pastor of New Life Presbyterian Church and president of The Gospel Coalition; Philip Ryken, president of Wheaton College; and Thurman Williams, urban church planter and member of the Mission to North America permanent committee.

Tim LeCroy's essay today re: homosexuality in the PCA

4 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2021, 5:29:45 PM

主



to NP

Thought this was very well done, FYI:

https://pastortimlecroy.com/2021/06/23/misconceptions-about-homosexuality-in-the-pca/?fbclid=IwAR0jpUA-8uMw5GSc4bEwVluMOZuM1-qInU_fGvuJvSmZf5w-WhvssCUbJOc

Correction.

6 views

Skip to first unread message



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2021, 5:48:27 PM

主



to NP

Of course the Wednesday night gathering, Mike Khandjian's Fellowship Dinner group, is happening at Covenant SEMINARY. Not 454 miles away at Covenant COLLEGE.



sseaton

<sseaton@emmanuelarlington.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2021, 6:28:03 PM



to james, NP

Thanks for the correction. You saved me a ton of money on gas.

Scott Seaton

NP Discussion re: Overtures

42 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jun 17, 2021, 9:01:05 AM



to NP

{The content of this email is not to be shared without the consent of its author}

Dear friends,

Attached is the initial advice concerning overtures to the 48th GA.

Before you review it, a couple of notes:

1. The NP is not a voting bloc, we do not require you to vote one particular way, though we are united in purpose as a result of being in this thing together: we want a healthy denomination and we

have a view as to how that looks. Feel free to offer your contrary advice. In fact, our thinking often benefits from the brilliant dissent, the minority opinion we haven't considered. If you have it, bring it.

2. The advice contains a column with Dr. David Coffin's advice. He is not giving that advice as a member of the NP, of course, but he distributes his opinion widely and because I find him to be regularly helpful (though we disagree on some points), I thought it would be helpful to include his thoughts.

3. This is only *initial* advice, the first of around three versions. The next version will be distributed to NP representatives to the Overtures committee and will reflect any suggested changes coming from this list. A third copy will reflect the actions of the OC and will aid you as a resource when the overtures come to the assembly floor. So don't fret if something seems half-baked. We're just beginning.

NP Discussion Regarding Overtures to the 48th GA, with Dr. David Coffin's Advice

			42 Overtures to 48th GA 35 referred to Overtures Committee: 1, 5, 6, 9, 10, 12, 15-23, 26-38, 40, 41, 43, 45-48	Advice from Dr. David Coffin (He provides this often helpful reflection on the annual overtures)	Proposed action
1	Potomac	OC CCB	BCO 8-7 Chaplains - Add: <u>Δ Teaching Elder requiring ecclesiastical endorsement to serve as a chaplain must be approved through the endorsing agency authorized by the General Assembly for such purpose. Teaching Elders ministering as paid or volunteer chaplains in settings that do not require ecclesiastical endorsement should consider seeking the same endorsement.</u>	NEGATIVE The "whereas" paragraphs do not provide any reason for <i>requiring as a matter of church law</i> endorsement only through the GA endorsing agency. Further, the second sentence of the proposed amendment should be eliminated. A rule that says something "should" be done is fatally ambiguous, as "should" can indicate obligation, or only the advisable. And in this case, if it is taken only as advisable, it is trivial, for the advice is only to "consider" endorsement. Finally, if there is to be such a paragraph added, the whole section should be renumbered, as the paragraphs treat distinct subjects. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>Commissioner Handbook (hereinafter CH)</i>, 281, A (unless otherwise noted, the CCB vote was unanimous).	Negative. The whereas clauses do not clearly support the conclusion, and a change like this -- with potential unintended consequences for credentialing bodies, needs a compelling case.
2	Central Georgia	SJC	"Assume original jurisdiction of the case of the investigation by Missouri Presbytery of Greg Johnson and the session of Memorial Presbyterian Church with regard to theological error and involvement in the 2018 Revoice Conference."	NO COMMENT As I am a member of the SJC which is currently working on a response to the BCO 34-1 request it is inappropriate for me to express an opinion at this time.	Even though this issue will not be before us at the Assembly, I asked Rev. Dr. Tim LeCroy to give a rationale for opposition, for future reference: "These two overtures will not be up for discussion or vote at this General Assembly. The reason is that the Rules of Assembly Operation 17-2 dictate that any BCO 34-1 request for original jurisdiction "shall be assigned to the Standing Judicial Commission for adjudication."

			Already under consideration in the SJC.		The SJC manual covers the procedures for such a case in chapter 16. In this particular case, there is a complaint arising from the court of original jurisdiction, Missouri Presbytery, that is challenging the result of a BCO 31-2 investigation by Missouri Presbytery that found "no strong presumption of guilt" in TE Johnson. The SJC has decided to first adjudicate that complaint before taking up the BCO 34-1 requests because BCO 34-1 cites a "failure to act" by the court of original jurisdiction, and that alleged failure to act cannot be determined until the complaint is resolved. At any rate, there will not be any discussion or votes on overtures 2 or 25 at this General Assembly, and perhaps even at any future assembly."
3	Heritage	MTW	Add the following to the MTW Manual: <u>MTW leaders in line authority over church planting or church development ministry should be ordained elders. In extraordinary cases where this policy is not followed, the appointment of an unordained man who exhibits the qualities of an elder is permissible, but must be approved annually by a three-quarters vote of CMTW, and there shall be a record of the reasons for such an appointment included in CMTW's minutes that are submitted to the General Assembly.</u>	ANSWER BY REFERENCE TO ACTION ON OV. 14 Overture 14 has the advantage of <i>brevitas et claritas</i>. NOTE: CMNA recommends AFFIRMATIVE, but to a much attenuated version of the Presbytery's proposed language. <i>CH</i>, 713-715, item 11.	Answer in the Affirmative, as amended below with the wording proposed by MTW in its Recommendation 11 on CH p. 713, as follows. MTW leaders in line authority over church planting or church development ministry should will ordinarily be ordained elders. In extraordinary cases where this policy is not followed, the appointment of an unordained man who exhibits the qualities of an elder another MTW-qualified leader is permissible, but must be approved annually by a three-quarters vote of CMTW, and there shall be a record of the reasons for such an appointment there shall be a record of the reasons for such an appointment included in CMTW's minutes that are submitted to the General Assembly." <i>[Note from JK: I don't love this move. Personally I'd like to answer the overture in the negative. It's degrading and a dangerous mis-application of special ecclesiastical</i>

					<i>authority, but it seems MTW wants to move on from this particular fight.]</i>
4	Savannah River	SJC	"Concurs with Overture 2 from Central Georgia Presbytery, adopted on January 11, 2020, and in accord with BCO 34-1 requests the General Assembly to assume original jurisdiction of the case of the investigation by Missouri Presbytery of TE Greg Johnson and the Session of Memorial Presbyterian Church with regard to the theological error and involvement in the 2018 Revoice Conference."	NO COMMENT As I am a member of the SJC which is currently working on a response to the BCO 34-1 request it is inappropriate for me to express an opinion at this time.	Even though this issue will not be before us at the Assembly, I asked Rev. Dr. Tim LeCroy to give a rationale for opposition, for future reference: "These two overtures will not be up for discussion or vote at this General Assembly. The reason is that the Rules of Assembly Operation 17-2 dictate that any BCO 34-1 request for original jurisdiction "shall be assigned to the Standing Judicial Commission for adjudication." The SJC manual covers the procedures for such a case in chapter 16. In this particular case, there is a complaint arising from the court of original jurisdiction, Missouri Presbytery, that is challenging the result of a BCO 31-2 investigation by Missouri Presbytery that found "no strong presumption of guilt" in TE Johnson. The SJC has decided to first adjudicate that complaint before taking up the BCO 34-1 requests because BCO 34-1 cites a "failure to act" by the court of original jurisdiction, and that alleged failure to act cannot be determined until the complaint is resolved. At any rate, there will not be any discussion or votes on overtures 2 or 25 at this General Assembly, and perhaps even at any future assembly."
5	Calvary	OC CCB	Amend BCO 20-4, 24-3, 24-4 Regarding Election of Pastor, Associate Pastor, & Officers (i.e., replace "voters present" with "votes cast") BCO 20-4: "Method of Voting: The voters being convened, and prayer for divine guidance having been offered, the moderator shall put the question: Are you ready to	AFFIRMATIVE A well-framed, well-argued proposal. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. CH, 282, B.	Affirmative. Clears up ambiguous wording.

			proceed to the election of a pastor? If they declare themselves ready, the moderator shall call for nominations, or the election may proceed by ballot without nominations. In every case a majority of all the voters <u>present votes cast</u> shall be required to elect.” <i>[Same changes to BCO 24-3 and 24-4]</i>		
6	Covenant	OC CCB	BCO 24-1 timing of officer exams (add “qualified” twice, and strike “then”) BCO 24-1 Every church shall elect persons to the offices of ruling elder and deacon in the following manner: At such times as determined by the Session, communicant members of the congregation may submit names to the Session, keeping in mind that each prospective officer should be an active male member who meets the qualifications set forth in 1 Tim 3 and Titus 1. After the close of the nomination period, <u>qualified</u> nominees for the office of ruling elder and/or deacon shall receive instruction in the qualifications and work of the office. Each <u>qualified</u> nominee shall then be examined in: ...” <i>CCB advises is “constitutionally vague because it does not identify a means by which a</i>	NEGATIVE CCB’s judgment is sound, but its objection does not go far enough. Not only is there no <i>means for determination</i> set forth, there is also no <i>standard</i> as to what constitutes “qualified”. Absent means and standards there can be no accountability. This is a recipe for abuse of power. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment “is constitutionally vague because it does not identify a means by which a nominee is deemed qualified or unqualified”. <i>CH</i>, 282, C.	Negative. This is a dangerous addition to the BCO’s language, adding “qualified” without adding a particular constituting standard. Coffin’s (and CCB’s) advice is conclusive. If Covenant Presbytery would like to step up the threshold for qualification of officers there are far better ways of doing so. One path proposed by others is to answer this way: Return the Overture to the Presbytery, without prejudice. Grounds for Alternative: The manner in which potential officers are nominated, trained, and examined is vitally important for the Church. This Overture could benefit from further perfection.

			<i>nominee is deemed "qualified or unqualified." CCB vote 8-0. Handbook p. 282</i>		
7	Lowcountry		Withdrawn		
8	Catawba Valley	MNA	Revise boundaries	SEE Overture 11.	
9	Ascension	OC CCB	RAO 15-6 - Increase requirement for OC Minority Report from 3+3 to 10% of OC (at least 1/3 of which are TEs and 1/3 REs)	AFFIRMATIVE A reasonable solution to an otherwise worsening problem. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 282, letter E.	Affirmative. As the OC continues to grow, we need higher thresholds for qualifying minority reports or we will struggle to be a deliberative body, giving the Assembly yes and no on every question.
10	Ascension	OC CCB	RAO 15-6.s-4 and -5 re: content of OC Minority Reports <u>Add RAO 15-6.s.(4) No proposed action or proposed change in the wording of a recommendation from the Overtures Committee may be included in a minority report unless that proposal had been presented to the Overtures Committee and was defeated or tabled.</u> <u>Add (5) Ordinarily a minority report should employ arguments that were offered in the course of the Overtures Committee's</u>	AFFIRMATIVE However, proposed RAO 15-6.s 4) needs some adjustment. Since failed motions are not recorded, how will it be known that a motion had been proposed and defeated? Further, why "Tabled," a rarely used motion limited to peculiar circumstance? What of all the other ways of disposing with a motion? Perhaps better to put a period after "Committee" on p. 55, line 40 and strike the rest. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 282, letter F.	Affirmative. Helpful addition to the RAO. The following amendment has been suggested and, I think, will clear up any other difficulties with the overture: RAO 15-6.s.(4) No proposed action or proposed change in the wording of a recommendation from the Overtures Committee may be included in a minority report unless that proposal had been presented to the Overtures Committee and was defeated or tabled. RAO 15-6.s.(5) no revision of the Overture Possible grounds:

			<u>deliberations on the matter in question.</u>		Since failed motions are not recorded, GA would not know that a motion had been proposed and defeated. In addition, there are other ways of disposing with a motion other than defeating or tabling. If someone sought to present a Minority Report that did not comply with the new RAO 15-6.s.(4), a point of order could be raised.
11	Central Carolina	MNA	boundaries	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. CMNA recommends AFFIRMATIVE. CH, 605, item 6.	
12	Philly Metro West	OC CCB	Amend BCO 31-2 & 32-2 to Clarify that Investigation Shall Precede [all] Judicial Process BCO 31-2. It is the duty of all church Sessions and Presbyteries to exercise care over those subject to their authority. They shall <u>initiate an investigation and</u> with due diligence and great discretion demand from such persons satisfactory explanations concerning reports affecting their Christian character. This duty is more imperative when those who deem themselves aggrieved by injurious reports shall ask an investigation. If such investigation, however originating, should result in raising a strong presumption of the guilt of the party involved, the court shall institute process, and shall appoint a prosecutor to prepare the indictment and to	NEGATIVE The language proposed for BCO 31-2, "initiate an investigation" is vague. It is not at all clear what is required by the new language that was not obligatory under the unamended text. The language proposed for BCO 32-2 puts the cart before the horse. There is no good reason to amend a provision of long standing that has been ably construed by our courts. Overall, the Overture does not appear to grasp the point of the concurring opinion that it claims to rely upon. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. CH, 282, G.	Negative I received this advice from some on the SJC. I think it's helpful in addressing the defects in this overture: <i>It's not clear what the new language requires that isn't already obligatory under the unamended text of BCO 31-2. And the proposed addition to BCO 32-2 seems to put the cart before the horse. There is no good reason to amend provisions of long standing that have been ably construed by our courts. And finally, we note the Overture does not appear to grasp the point of the concurring opinion that it claims to rely on. In addition, the proposed change seems to disallow a court from ordering an indictment and appointing a prosecutor immediately upon finding sufficient reason to do so. But that right should be retained for the courts, even it is not ordinarily used.</i>

			conduct the case. This prosecutor shall be a member of the court, except that in a case before the Session, he may be any communing member of the same congregation with the accused. BCO 32-2: Process against an offender shall not be commenced unless, <u>after a careful investigation (BCO 31-2) by the court and its finding of a strong presumption of guilt</u>, some person or persons undertake to make out the charge; or unless the court finds it necessary, for the honor of religion, itself to take the step provided for in BCO 31-2.		
13	Mississippi Valley	MNA	Be it therefore resolved that the MNA Permanent Committee explore the advisability of endorsing Lifeline Children's Services as a possible resource for PCA churches.	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. CMNA recommends AFFIRMATIVE. CH, 605, item 7.	
14	Evangel	MTW	Direct CMTW to amend the MTW Policy Manual to include the following statement: <u>"All MTW leaders in line authority over church planting or church development ministry shall be ordained elders."</u>	AFFIRMATIVE Presbytery's rationale is compelling and its proposal is well-crafted, particularly in its evident commitment to BCO 14-1.7, "The Assembly's committees are to serve and not to direct any Church judicatories. They are not to establish policy, but rather execute policy established by the General Assembly."	Answer in reference to answer on Overture 3

				NOTE: CMNA recommends answer by reference to action on Overture 3. <i>CH</i> , 716, item 13.	
<u>15</u>	New Covenant (Session)	OC CCB	Insert as the second sentence of RAO 11-2: <u>Nor should digital communication for vote coordination be transmitted or received by any person or portion of the General Assembly while in session.</u>	NEGATIVE Appropriately, RAO 11-12 is a rule governing what the Assembly may or may not do. The proposed amendment illicitly makes the rule govern what others may or may not do as well. Further, the placement of the amendment in the text separates the conditional of the following sentence from its object in what was the previous sentence, thereby making it incoherent. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution, "but [is] not germane to the RAO chapter for which it is proposed". <i>CH</i>, 283, H. 7-1-0	Negative (note: this overture was rejected by its presbytery and was an attempt to limit advice/help on the floor during GA deliberations. The bringers of the motion addressed the NP specifically). RAO 11-12 is a rule governing what the GA may or may not do. The proposed amendment makes the rule govern what others may or may not do as well. CCB also finds the overture is "not germane to the RAO chapter for which it is proposed". <i>CH</i>, 283, H. 7-1-0
<u>16</u>	Westminster	OC CCB	Add new BCO 7-4: <u>Men who identify as homosexual, even those who identify as homosexual and claim to practice celibacy in that self-identification, are disqualified from holding office in the Presbyterian Church in America.</u> <i>CCB advises this "is in conflict with BCO 12-5.b, 13.9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the</i>	NEGATIVE The insertion of the paragraph in a chapter entitled "Church Officers-General Classification" seems oddly out of place. This appears to be a rule desperately looking for a home. However, it is not clear to me that the proposal is in <i>conflict</i> with the <i>BCO</i>, as its provisions regularly specify what qualifications must be met by all candidates without undermining the rights and responsibilities of the lower courts. Beyond that, I cannot comment, as the substance of the matter is being adjudicated before the SJC.	Negative The current standard, in BCO 21-4, "his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9)" and the similar language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will continue to be, sufficient to set forth concisely the examining court's responsibility. Additionally, the citing of homosexual desires, though they be unwanted and mortified through a celibate and holy life, <i>as</i>

			<i>candidate is qualified...</i> ” CCB vote was 6-2. <i>CH</i> p. 283	NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS in conflict “with <i>BCO</i> 12-5.b, 13-9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the candidate is qualified. The Committee notes that the 48th General Assembly cannot amend the <i>Book of Church Order</i> but begins the process laid out in <i>BCO</i> 26-2. <i>CH</i> , 283, I. 6-2-0	<i>a special case</i> , has the effect of marginalizing the remainder of the Bible’s classification of notorious or heinous sins. Note: Rom 5.18-19 under the third whereas has absolutely nothing to do with sexual sin. Perhaps a mis-copy from another source? Certainly it does not strengthen the case. The rationale here is even less-helpful than 30/37, introducing the terms identify/self-identification into the BCO with no hope of clarity. These terms aren’t even broadly understood in our churches, how can they be utilized justly in the candidates and credentials committees?
17	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Reword RAO 9-3. <u>The General Assembly may appoint or continue any number of ad interim committees. However, no committee may be funded with undesignated AC funding after its third year, and only two committees may be funded with undesignated AC funding in any given year.</u>	AFFIRMATIVE Clearly, the current language is needlessly complicated, and has caused confusion. However, the proposed change could be made even more clear by striking the text on p. 71, lines 18-19, from “The General Assembly” through “However,” capitalizing the word “No” and adding “such” thereafter, so that the new opening sentence would read “No such committee may be funded. . . .” The matter of the first sentence in the proposal is adequately addressed in RAO 9-1 and -2. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 283, J.	Affirmative This doesn’t change the current policy, but it provides needed clarification. Overtures may continue to propose how an ad interim committee is to be funded, and AC and OC may continue giving their recommendations regarding funding. No RAO rule would need to be suspended for GA to decide how such an ad interim is funded (which is the current situation, but probably unclear in the current wording.)
18	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	BCO 24-1 Elder/Deacon Nominee exams (strike “then” and add a sentence)	NEGATIVE	Move to refer back to presbytery. The overture seeks to address a significant

			Strike one word in BCO 24-1 "Each nominee shall then be examined in: ..." And add: <u>The Session may render a decision on Christian experience at any point in the process, and based on that decision, may judge him ineligible for that election.</u>	The proposed language does not appear to solve the alleged problem, so long as the sentence "After the close of the nomination period, nominees for the office or ruling elder and/or deacon shall receive instruction. . . ." (p. 75, lines 13-15) remains in the text. The proposal is in need of revision if it is to clarify and make more flexible the procedure. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i>, 283, K.	problem but suffers from major defects (as is evident in Coffin's rationale). Could benefit from further perfection.
19	Pacific Northwest (revised)	OC CCB	Amend BCO 38-1 and 42-2 to allow an appeal, instead of a complaint, after censure in confessions. BCO 38-1: When any person shall come forward and make his offense known to the court, a full statement of the facts shall be recorded and judgment rendered without process. In handling a confession of guilt, it is essential that the person intends to confess and permit the court to render judgment without process. Statements made by him in the presence of the court must not be taken as a basis of a judgment without process except by his consent. The accused <u>A censured person has the right of complaint against the judgment to appeal the censure (BCO 42).</u>	AFFIRMATIVE The current language of the provision denies the subject of the proceeding due process in that the remedies available with respect to a successful complaint are considerable narrower than those for a successful appeal. The proposed amendment wisely corrects this significant defect. The language for <i>BCO</i> 38-1 would be better put "A person so censured has the right to appeal (<i>BCO</i> 42)," thereby narrowing the focus. The remedy for CCB's concern about conflict is to answer Overture 34 in the negative! NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that if the amendments proposed by Overture 19 and Overture 34 are both adopted, they would be in conflict regarding the right of appeal or the right of complaint." <i>CH</i>, 283, L.	Affirmative. Coffin's rationale is persuasive.

			BCO 42-2. Only <u>The only parties entitled to an appeal are those who have submitted to a regular trial are entitled to an appeal, those appealing a censure in a BCO 38-1 case without process, and those appealing a BCO 34-10 divestiture without censure</u> <i>CCB advises there might be a conflict between PNW 19 & PNW 34. CCB vote 8-0 CH 283. Note: This will be remedied by considering PNW 19 after the other 3 Overtures on 38-1.</i>		
20	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Increase Vote for Pretrial Suspensions (by adding a clause) BCO 31-10. When a member of a church court is under process, all his official functions may be suspended at the court's discretion; but this shall never be done in the way of censure, <u>and this requires a three-fourths (3/4) majority</u>. BCO 33-4. When it is impracticable immediately to commence process against an accused church member, the Session may, if it thinks the edification of the Church requires it, prevent the accused from approaching the Lord's	AFFIRMATIVE The case for the change is well made by Rationale. A more felicitous phrasing for BCO 31-10 would be: "When a member of a church court is under process, by a three-fourths (3/4) majority all his official functions may be suspended at the court's discretion; but this shall never be done in the way of censure." A more felicitous phrasing for BCO 33-4 would be: "When it is impracticable immediately to commence process against an accused church member, the Session may, if it thinks the edification of the Church requires it, by a three-fourths (3/4) majority prevent the accused from approaching the Lord's Table until the charges against him can be examined."	Affirmative Some have recommended a grammatical amendment: BCO 31-10. When a member of a church court is under process, <u>the court may, by a three-fourths (3/4) majority, suspend</u> all his official functions <u>may be suspended at the court's discretion</u>; but this shall never be done in the way of censure. BCO 33-4. When it is impracticable immediately to commence process against an accused church member, the Session may, if it thinks the edification of the Church requires it, <u>and by a three-fourths (3/4) majority</u>, prevent the accused from approaching the Lord's Table until the charges against him can be examined.

			Table until the charges against him can be examined, <u>but this requires a three-fourths (3/4) majority</u> .	NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 284, M.	
<u>21</u>	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Increase Vote for maintaining suspensions during appeals (by adding clause). BCO 42-6. Notice of appeal shall have the effect of suspending the judgment of the lower court until the case has been finally decided in the higher court. However, the court of original jurisdiction may, for sufficient reasons duly recorded, prevent the appellant from approaching the Lord's Table, and if an officer, prevent him from exercising some or all his official functions, until the case is finally decided (cf. BCO 31-10; 33-4). This shall never be done in the way of censure, <u>and shall require a two-thirds (2/3) majority</u>.	AFFIRMATIVE The case for the change is well made by Rationale. A more felicitous phrasing for <i>BCO</i> 42-6-10 would be: "Notice of appeal shall have the effect of suspending the judgment of the lower court until the case has been finally decided in the higher court. However, the court of original jurisdiction may, for sufficient reasons duly recorded, by a two-thirds (2/3) majority prevent the appellant from approaching the Lord's Table, and if an officer, prevent him from exercising some or all his official functions, until the case is finally decided (cf. BCO 31-10; 33-4). This shall never be done in the way of censure." NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i>, 284, N.	Affirmative Again, with this proposed grammatical amendment: BCO 42-6. Notice of appeal shall have the effect of suspending the judgment of the lower court until the case has been finally decided in the higher court. However, the court of original jurisdiction may, for sufficient reasons duly recorded <u>and by a two-thirds (2/3) majority</u>, prevent the appellant from approaching the Lord's Table, and if an officer, prevent him from exercising some or all his official functions, until the case is finally decided (cf. BCO 31-10; 33-4). This shall never be done in the way of censure.
<u>22</u>	Pacific Northwest (revised)	OC CCB	Amend BCO 32-20 re Statute of Limitations (strike and replace) BCO 32-20. Process, in case a matter of scandal, shall commence within the space of one year after the offense was committed, unless it has recently become flagrant. When, however, a church member shall commit an offense, after	REFER TO SJC FOR ADVICE The Overture addresses a very important defect in our Rules of Discipline, but the language proposed is not fully adapted as a remedy. The concept of a statute of limitations is a matter of considerable complexity, fraught with possibilities for doing more harm than good. A full and careful consideration of the matter by the SJC over the coming year would greatly enhance our likelihood of success. Note that the rationale	Refer to SJC Dr. Coffin's rationale is persuasive.

			removing to a place far distant from his former residence, and where his connection with the church is unknown, in consequence of which process cannot be instituted within the time above specified, the recent discovery of the church membership of the individual shall be considered as equivalent to the offense itself having recently become flagrant. The same principle, in like circumstances, shall also apply to ministers. BCO 32-20. <u>There is no statute of limitations, per se, for prosecuting offenses. However, the accused or a member of the court may object to the consideration of a charge, for example, if he thinks the passage of time since the alleged offense makes fair adjudication unachievable. The court should consider factors such as the gravity of the alleged offense as well as what degradations of evidence and memory may have occurred in the intervening period.</u>	for the overture grants the possible profit of this course, item 10, p. 87, lines 40 and following. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i>, 284, O.	
23	Gulf Coast	OC CCB	Add new BCO 17-4: <u>Men who self-identify as a "gay Christian," "same-sex attracted Christian," "homosexual Christian," or like term shall be</u>	NEGATIVE The insertion of the paragraph in a chapter entitled	Negative The current standard, in BCO 21-4, "his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family

			<u>deemed not qualified for ordination in the Presbyterian Church in America.</u> <i>CCB advises this "is in conflict with BCO 12-5.b, 13.9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the candidate is qualified..." CCB vote was 6-2. CH p. 284</i>	"Doctrine of Ordination" seems oddly out of place. This appears to be a rule desperately looking for a home. However, it is not clear to me that the proposal is <i>in conflict</i> with the <i>BCO</i>, as its provisions regularly specify what qualifications must be met by all candidates without undermining the rights and responsibilities of the lower courts. Beyond that, I cannot comment, as the substance of the matter is being adjudicated before the SJC. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS in conflict "with BCO 12-5.b, 13-9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the candidate is qualified. The Committee notes that the 48th General Assembly cannot amend the <i>Book of Church Order</i> but begins the process laid out in BCO 26-2." CH, 284, P. 6-2-0	management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9)" and the similar language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will continue to be, sufficient to set forth concisely the examining court's responsibility. Additionally, the citing of homosexual desires, though they be unwanted and mortified through a celibate and holy life, <i>as a special case</i>, has the effect of marginalizing the remainder of the Bible's classification of notorious or heinous sins. The rationale here is even less-helpful than 30/37, introducing the terms identify/self-identification into the BCO with no hope of clarity. These terms aren't even broadly understood in our churches, how can they be utilized justly in the candidates and credentials committees?
24	Tennessee Valley	AC	Set the GA commissioner registration fees as follows: \$250 for Ruling Elders; \$500 for Teaching Elders; Honorably retired or emeritus elders would continue to pay \$150; Teaching Elders from churches with annual incomes below \$100,000, as per their 2020 statistics, may register for \$300.	NEGATIVE Any decrease in funding would be ill-considered given that the budgetary needs of AC are not now being properly meet. Here is a text from the <i>BCO</i> worthy our meditations with respect to this subject: 10-6, "The expenses of ministers and ruling elders in their attendance on the courts shall be defrayed by the bodies which they respectively represent." I have served in two congregations that began as mission works. Both budgeted, from their beginning, to send a TE and a RE commissioner to the GA.	Negative Refer to Dr. Coffin's rationale.

				NOTE: AC recommends answer in the negative offering lengthy reasons to that end. <i>CH</i> , 308, item 4.	
<u>25</u>	Southeast Alabama	SJC	“SE Alabama Presbytery joins with Savannah River Presbytery and Central Georgia Presbytery in requesting that the General Assembly assume original jurisdiction in the case of the doctrinal error of Teaching Elder Greg Johnson per BCO 34-1.”	NO COMMENT As I am a member of the SJC which is currently working on a response to the <i>BCO</i> 34-1 request it is inappropriate for me to express an opinion at this time.	See overture 2
<u>26</u>	Philadelphia Metro West	OC CCB	Add new BCO 10-7 re Electronic Meetings (All language below is a new addition.) 10-7. The General Assembly, presbyteries, and churches, in their discretion, may conduct meetings using telecommunications arrangements, such as telephone arrangements, internet-based audio and audio-visual communications arrangements, closed circuit audio and audio-visual communications arrangements, and combinations of such arrangements. The General Assembly, presbyteries, and churches, in their discretion, also may authorize their subordinate committees, commissions, and agencies, to conduct meetings using	AFFIRMATIVE A well argued proposal the need for which has been amply evidenced by a year gone viral! The words “Some examples of” should be replaced with the more felicitous “Among the” (p. 112, line 15). NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment “creates a conflict with RAO 1-1 that requires General Assembly to open with a virtual celebration of the Lord’s Supper.” <i>CH</i> , 284, Q. 5-3-0	Affirmative With an additional proposed change to RAO 1-1, as shown below, to address CCB’s concerns: (CCB vote was 5-3.) RAO 1-1. The General Assembly shall be called to order at the designated time by the Moderator, and shall begin with a worship service, including a season of prayer, a sermon or exhortation by the retiring Moderator, and, <u>for those physically present</u> , the celebration of the Lord’s Supper.

		telecommunications arrangements. Some examples of meetings permitted by this Section 10-7 are a meeting in which all of the persons attending the meeting attend using telecommunications arrangements, and a meeting in which some of the persons attending the meeting attend in-person at the appointed meeting place and some of the persons attending the meeting attend using telecommunications arrangements. The General Assembly, presbyteries, and churches, in their discretion, may for themselves and their subordinate committees, commissions, and agencies, adopt rules determining when telecommunications arrangements may be used for meetings and regulating how meetings using telecommunications arrangements shall be conducted. A meeting using telecommunications arrangements shall be conducted as closely as reasonably feasible in the same manner as an in-person meeting and so as to permit: a. each person who is eligible to attend the meeting, to attend the meeting; b. each person who attends the meeting, to hear what is said by		
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			the other persons attending the meeting while they are speaking; c. each person who attends the meeting and is eligible to speak to the meeting, to speak to the meeting; d. each person who attends the meeting and is eligible to make a motion at the meeting, to make the motion; and, e. each person who attends the meeting and is eligible to vote on a matter that is being voted on at the meeting, to vote on the matter. <i>CCB advises this "creates a conflict with RAO 1-1 that requires GA to open with a ... celebration of the Lord's Supper." (Note: With an electronic GA, this would be a virtual Lord's Supper.). CCB vote 5-3. CH 284.</i>		
<u>27</u>	Platte Valley	OC CCB	Add to BCO 36-2 re public excommunication 36-2. Church censures and the modes of administering them should be suited to the nature of the offenses. For private offenses, censure should be administered in the presence of the court alone, or in private by one or more members of the court. In the case of public offenses, the degree of censure	AFFIRMATIVE Another case ably made in the arguments offered. However, I'm not entirely clear on what the phrase "peculiar and special reasons" (p. 117, line 34) signifies. Presumably "peculiar" reasons alone would not suffice, and "special" reasons alone would not suffice? Work at perfecting the language of the proposal would be welcome. Further, OC should attend to the observation of CCB.	Affirmative As amended below, by striking "and mode of administering it," in order to address CCB's concerns. BCO 36-2 Church censures and the modes of administering them should be suited to the nature of the offenses. For private offenses, censure should be administered in the presence of the court alone, or in private by one or more members of the court. In the

			and mode of administering it shall be within the discretion of the court, acting in accordance with paragraphs below which deal with particular censures. <u>When there are peculiar and special reasons, the court may visit public offenses, not very gross in their character, with private admonition, or with definite suspension in private; but the censures of excommunication and deposition should be either administered before the church, or else announced to it, at the discretion of the court.</u> <i>CCB advises "if adopted would create a conflict, in that the amended BCO 36-2 allows for the censure to be performed before the church or announced to the church, while the proposed amendment to BCO 36-6 allows only that the censure be performed before the church." CCB vote 8-0. CH 284</i>	NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment "would create a conflict, in that the amended BCO 36-2 allows for the censure to be performed before the church or announced to the church while the proposed amendment to BCO 36-6 allows only that the censure be performed before the church." CH, 284, R.	case of public offenses, the degree of censure and mode of administering it shall be within the discretion of the court, acting in accordance with paragraphs below which deal with particular censures. <u>When there are peculiar and special reasons, the court may visit public offenses, not very gross in their character, with private admonition, or with definite suspension in private; but the censures of excommunication and deposition should be either administered before the church, or else announced to it, at the discretion of the court.</u>
28	Philadelphia Metro West	OC CCB	Add to BCO 31-2 a lengthy, four-step sequence for investigations <i>CCB advises this "is in conflict at multiple points with the Constitution. These include but are not limited to removal of the "great discretion" provided to courts in BCO 31-2; conflict</i>	NEGATIVE The lovely chaste language of the 19th Century overcome by a barrage of sections and subsections. So large a feast is indigestible! NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment "is in conflict at multiple points with the Constitution. These include but are not limited to	Negative See Dr. Coffin's hilarious critique. Case closed.

			<i>with representation at the discretion of the accused (BCO 32-19); conflict with obtaining response from the accused that is not required; and conflation of later elements of the Rules of Discipline." CCB vote 8-0. CH 285</i>	a removal of the "great discretion" provided to courts in BCO 31-2; conflict with representation at the discretion of the accused (BCO 32-19); conflict with obtaining response from the accused that is not required; and conflation of later elements of the Rules of Discipline." CH, 285, S.	
29	Philadelphia Metro West	OC CCB	Add 7-page Appendix K on Investigations (lengthy) <i>CCB advises this "is in conflict and responds to it in reference to [CCB advice] on Overture 28."</i>	NEGATIVE Appendices are the bane of constitutional documents. Are they a part of the document? Do they set forth regulations or suggestions? Lately it became necessary to head the "Appendices" portion of the BCO with this "Editorial Note: None of these Appendices has constitutional authority. They are provided for information." Will that not apply to this proposal, retroactively? Further, given our regular itch to amend the BCO, this lengthy document would need to be amended as well, at the cost of time and money. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment "is in conflict and responds to it in reference to Overture 28." CH, 285, T.	Negative. Agree with CCB assessment.
30	Lowcountry	OC CCB	Add new BCO 21-4.e & 24-1 paragraphs on moral requirement for office <u>21-4.e. In the examination of the candidate's personal character, the presbytery should give specific attention to potentially notorious concerns, such as but not limited to relational sins.</u>	NEGATIVE The current standard, in BCO 21-4, "his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9). . . ." and the like language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will	Negative. The current standard, in BCO 21-4, "his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9)" and the similar language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will continue to be, sufficient to

		<u>sexual immorality (including homosexuality, fornication, and pornography), addictions, abusive behavior, and financial mismanagement. Careful reflection should be given to his practical struggle against sinful actions, as well as persistent sinful desires. The candidate shall give clear testimony of his reliance upon his union with Christ and the benefits thereof by the Holy Spirit, depending on this work of grace to make progress over sin (Psalm 103: 2-5, Romans 8:29) and to bear fruit (Psalm 1:3; Gal. 5: 22-23). While imperfection will remain, he should not be known by reputation or self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness, but rather by the work of the Holy Spirit in Christ Jesus (1 Cor 6: 9-11). In order to maintain discretion and protect the honor of the pastoral office, the presbytery may empower a committee to conduct detailed examination into these matters and to give prayerful support to candidates.</u> The addition to 24-1 is same as above, except substitute "nominee" for "candidate" and "Session" for "presbytery." <i>"CCB notes that if Overture 30 is adopted, it would require amendment to BCO 13-6 to</i>	continue to be, sufficient to set forth concisely the examining court's responsibility. The placement of the proposed provision in <i>BCO</i> 21-4 is problematic. For example, does item d., which naturally refers to the matters above (i.e., c. (1)-(4) apply to the new item e.? If the new text is to be included at all, surely it should be a subdivision of 21-4. c. (1) (a). NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that if Overture 30 is adopted, it would require amendment to <i>BCO</i> 13-6 to update the re-lettering of <i>BCO</i> 21-4." <i>CH</i>, 285, U. 6-2-0	set forth concisely the examining court's responsibility. The phrase "self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness" inserts a hard-to-define standard into the examination of a man's character. What <i>is</i> self-profession? Additionally, the citing of homosexual desires, though they be unwanted and mortified through a celibate and holy life, <i>as a special case</i>, has the effect of marginalizing the remainder of the Bible's classification of notorious or heinous sins.
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			update the re-lettering of BCO 21-4." CH 285		
<u>31</u>	Northwest Georgia	OC CCB	Amend BCO 22 Process for Assistant to Associate Pastor - Add sentence. The pastor and associate pastor are elected by the congregation using the form of call in BCO 20-6. <u>An existing assistant pastor, who has provided satisfactory service for one-year in this congregation, may be elected by the congregation as an associate pastor at the recommendation of the Session without the election of a pulpit committee.</u> Being elected by the congregation they become members of the Session. <i>CCB advises this "is not in conflict with the other parts of the Constitution, but the committee notes that the proposed amendment would implicitly require the use of a pulpit committee for a congregation to elect an associate pastor who has not served as an assistant pastor for at least one year, which is not currently required by BCO 20-2 and 22-1." CCB vote 8-0. CH. 285</i>	AFFIRMATIVE A plausible solution to a problem that is, happily, more frequent in its occurrence. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. [B]ut the committee notes that the proposed amendment would implicitly require the use of a pulpit committee for a congregation to elect an associate pastor who has not served as an assistant pastor for at least one year, which is not currently required by BCO 20-2 and 22-1." CH, 285, V.	Affirmative, as amended below: The pastor and associate pastor are elected by the congregation using the form of call in BCO 20-6. <u>An existing assistant pastor, who has provided satisfactory service for one-year in this congregation, A minister may be elected by the congregation as an associate pastor at the recommendation of the Session without the election of a pulpit committee.</u> Being elected by the congregation they become members of the Session. Grounds: The amended version addresses concerns noted by the CCB and would allow what the Overture seeks. In addition, however, a congregation should have the right to call <i>any</i> minister as an associate pastor, upon Session recommendation, without needing to elect a pulpit committee. This would apply to all prospective associate pastors, regardless of whether they're serving as an assistant pastor in that church.
<u>32</u>	Central Indiana	AC OC	Form Study Committee for Biblical Ethics in Digital Media to study and report on:	NEGATIVE	Affirmative.

		1) How the ninth commandment applies to digital forms of communication (such as blogs, social media, public and private online groups, and other developing technologies). 2) Biblical and confessional teaching regarding godly speech, charitable debate, and wisdom in discerning truth from falsehood. 3) Pastoral guidance on how to address questions of public concern without unintentionally spreading false or misleading information, or disparaging the good name of others. 4) Distinctions between private and public offenses (BCO 29-2, 29-4, 34-3), when private online groups with substantial membership are increasingly common. 5) Practical steps for accountability and discipline; that our members might be edified, and our officers remain “above reproach” (1 Timothy 3:2). 6) Should the findings of the study committee warrant BCO changes, the study committee will propose such changes for the General Assembly to consider.	In general, to paraphrase a US President, study committees are not the solution, they are the problem. The matters that occasion their appointment seem to be lagging just slightly behind the latest hot topics in the news cycle, and tend to reduce the Assembly to a mere interest group clamoring among a crowd of competing voices, rather than uphold its stately position as “the bond of union, peace and correspondence among all its congregations and courts,” a grand agent of the Great Commission. Folks have a tendency to use study committee reports to the neglect of (or to undermine) the Constitution of the PCA. Historically study committees have been proposed as a stealth way to give minority views a greater hearing than they deserve. So too, they are sometimes a means to avoid the difficult labor required to pursue debate and resolution with people, we suppose to be opponents, face to face. Such committees are quite expensive, their work-product is widely varied in value, and if committee members cannot agree, the effect of the conflict between a committee report and a minority report can be divisive. It has not been uncommon in Presbyterian history that the fruit of such labors is either a sentimentalizing collection of platitudes that compromise Scripture teaching, or a hammer-and-tongs majority vs. minority report that divides the Assembly. There are a few legitimate, and Constitutionally safe, grounds for appointing study committees, e.g., when the Assembly has determined that a change in the Constitution is desirable, and seeks an able and broadly representative committee to study the best means to that end, to prepare a recommendation, and to prepare a rationale for the church. Such was the case, for example, with the Ad Interim Committee on Judicial Procedures. Rarely such committees may be needed to bring Scripture light to some novel and complex matter that is a threat to the whole body,	Dr Coffin, and others, counsel against the formation of a study committee whose work may or may not be beneficial to the church, but I do not find in Coffin’s argument anything to distinguish this cause from other righteous causes (human sexuality, divorce and remarriage, etc.). These same objections (raised regularly by, for instance, Dr. Coffin) have been used in the debate over committee work we have later received as helpful to the Church. The explosion of access to digital media rivals the invention of the printing press, and its effect on the function of the church courts has been just as pervasive. There is significant difference of opinion on what constitutes the proper use of digital communication vs. personal communication, especially as it concerns theological controversies and interpersonal conflicts. Funding can be addressed, this shouldn’t be cause for scuttling the work of a study committee.
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				for example, the Ad Interim Committee on Human Sexuality. In the main, however, the best resources for our folk are not Assembly study committees, but the intellectual and spiritual wealth we have in our ministers, teachers, and scholars through academic institutions, conferences, publications, broadcasts, recordings, journals and magazines.	
<u>33</u>	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	BCO 38-1 re the Confession Document in Case Without Process 38-1 ... In the event a confession is intended, a full statement of the facts should <u>a written Confession (i.e., a sufficient summary of the facts, the person's specific confession, and any expression or evidence of repentance) must</u> be approved by the accused and by the court before the court proceeds to a judgment, <u>and the co-signed document shall be appended to the minutes (regular or executive session). No other information may be presented without written consent from the accused and the court, and this prohibition includes individuals, prosecutors, committees, and commissions.</u>	AFFIRMATIVE A needed solution to significant defect in our Rules of Discipline. Note, however, that the closing sentence would need to be brought into conformity with Overture 19 should it pass. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i>, 285, W.	Affirmative
<u>34</u>	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Add paragraph to BCO 38-1 re the timing of confessions <u>A person may proffer a confession, and request the matter be handled as a case</u>	NEGATIVE The proposal evidences a failure to understand the	Refer to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49 th GA Overtures Committee that will meeting in 2022 in Birmingham.

			<u>without process, prior to an investigation, during an investigation, or after process has commenced. If a confession is proffered after the court has instituted process (BCO 31-2, second paragraph), the prosecutor shall ascertain whether the accused is pleading guilty to the charge (BCO 32-3) or is seeking to proceed via BCO 38-1. If the latter, and if the prosecutor accepts the Confession, he shall suspend process and recommend the court approve the Confession. He may also recommend a censure. However, if no agreement is reached on the Confession, and the matter proceeds as a case of process, confession discussions between the prosecutor and the accused are not admissible as evidence.</u>	historical rationale of a case without process, thus making it the virtual equivalent of a guilty plea. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that if the amendments proposed by Overture 19 and Overture 34 are both adopted, they would be in conflict as to the right of appeal or the right of complaint." CH, 286, X.	The Overture addresses a very important defect in our Rules of Discipline. The concept of a statute of limitations is a matter of considerable complexity, fraught with possibilities for doing more harm than good. A full and careful consideration of the matter by the SJC over the coming year would greatly enhance our likelihood of success. Note that the rationale for the overture grants the possible profit of referencing to the SJC for advice.
35	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Add sentence to BCO 38-1 re right to counsel during cases without process <u>... The person has the right to be represented by counsel at any point, in accord with the stipulations of BCO 32-19.</u> Refer this Overture to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49th GA Overtures Committee that will meet in 2022 in Birmingham.	NEGATIVE This allowance is inconsistent with the idea of a case without process. To allow formal representation introduces process. The error of a presbytery alleged to have occasioned the proposal was self-evident. The BCO does not need to be amended whenever one acts foolishly. See the "General Note" on pages 142-43 for a collation of all the BCO 38-1 proposals.	Refer Refer this Overture to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49th GA Overtures Committee that will meet in 2022 in Birmingham. This is the best venue for working through process recommendations. Dr. Coffin's motion to answer in the negative is also reasonable.

			Grounds: Same as Pacific NW Overture 22	NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 286, Y.	
<u>36</u>	Chesapeake	AC OC	Proposes: ... the 48th GA authorize the Moderator to appoint a study committee, comprised of teaching and ruling elders, that would consider the relevant biblical and theological materials and consult with knowledgeable persons such as historians and social scientists, in order to: - Provide biblical and theological exposition relevant to the topic of White Supremacy; - Consider the historical background and impact regarding this topic; - Report to 49th GA the conclusion of their work and present any relevant recommendations for the understanding and use of sessions and presbyteries; - Set the budget for the study committee at \$15,000/year and that funds be derived from gifts to the AC designated for that purpose, of which Columbia Presbyterian Church will contribute \$1,000 toward that proposed budget.	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 32.	Negative. With two other study committees in process, adding a third would be difficult; if I were to pick the most urgent it would be the study committee recommended by overture 32, which affects much of the discussion surrounding these issues.

37	Eastern PA	OC CCB	Amend BCO 21-4 and 24-1 Clarifying Moral Requirements for Church Office Same as Lowcountry 30, but with the addition of the parenthetical "(e.g. homosexual desires, etc.)" in the third sentence. Add to 21-4 and 24-1: <u>"In the examination of the candidate's personal character, the presbytery should give specific attention to potentially notorious concerns, such as but not limited to relational sins, sexual immorality (including homosexuality, fornication, and pornography), addictions, abusive behavior, and financial mismanagement. Careful reflection should be given to his practical struggle against sinful actions, as well as persistent sinful desires. The candidate shall give clear testimony of his reliance upon his union with Christ and the benefits thereof by the Holy Spirit, depending on this work of grace to make progress over sin (Psalm 103:2-5, Romans 8:29) and to bear fruit (Psalm 1:3; Gal. 5:22-23). While imperfection will remain, he should not be known by reputation or self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness (e.g., homosexual desires, etc.), but</u>	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 30. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that if Overture 37 is adopted, it would require amendment to BCO 13-6 to update the re-lettering of BCO 21-4." CH, 286, Z. 6-2-0	Negative. The current standard, in BCO 21-4, "his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9)" and the similar language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will continue to be, sufficient to set forth concisely the examining court's responsibility. The phrase "self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness" inserts a hard-to-define standard into the examination of a man's character. What <i>is</i> self-profession? Additionally, the citing of homosexual desires, though they be unwanted and mortified through a celibate and holy life, as <i>a special case</i>, has the effect of marginalizing the remainder of the Bible's classification of notorious or heinous sins.
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			<u>rather by the work of the Holy Spirit in Christ Jesus (1 Cor. 6:9-11). In order to maintain discretion and protect the honor of the pastoral office, the presbytery may empower a committee to conduct detailed examination into these matters and to give prayerful support to candidates."</u> <i>"CCB notes that if Overture 30 is adopted, it would require amendment to BCO 13-6 to update the re-lettering of BCO 21-4." CH 285</i>		
38	Calvary	OC CDM	Commend Human Sexuality Report Asks GA to "declare the Report of the Ad Interim Committee on Human Sexuality as a biblically faithful declaration and refer it to the Committee on Discipleship Ministries for inclusion and promotion among its denominational teaching materials." Answer in the Affirmative, as amended below to include a clarifying addition: <u>"That the GA declare the 60-page Report of the Ad Interim Committee as a</u>	AFFIRMATIVE In my estimation, this is an outstanding piece of work, perhaps the most cogent and useful GA study I have ever read. And, I have no doubt that it would be profitable for every member of the PCA to read it, as we face increasing cultural chaos on these subjects. As I wrote to the Committee Chairman, "I am grateful for our Lord's providential care for you men in your labors, and for our denomination in the outcome. I must admit, in my weak faith, I absolutely feared the worst. I thought the outcome was but a roll of the dice. But I forgot that "The lot is cast into the lap, but its every decision is from the Lord."	

			biblically faithful declaration"		
39	Fellowship	AC	Reduce Registration Fees for REs - "... that the 49th GA set the commissioner registration fees as follows: \$250 for REs; \$500 for TEs; Honorably retired or emeritus elders would continue to pay \$150; TEs from churches with annual incomes below \$100,000, as per their 2020 statistics, may register for \$300."	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 24.	Answer by Reference to the answer on TN Valley 24.
40	TN Valley	OC CCB	Amend BCO 32-13, 35-1, and 35-5 to Allow Victim Protection Provisions Add this paragraph to each of the three BCO sections: " <u>However, throughout the trial in cases involving alleged child abuse, domestic abuse, sexual abuse, or sexual assault, a court may make reasonable accommodations to shield accusers from face-to-face contact with the accused. This can be done upon request by the accuser or when the court determines that such accommodation is necessary. Such accommodations might include procedures such as written testimony or videoconferencing testimony, in which a reasonable path for cross examination is provided.</u> "	RETURN TO THE PRESBYTERY, WITHOUT PREJUDICE An extraordinarily well prepared overture. In the main, it seeks adjustments to our procedures that are deeply informed by compassion, and a desire for justice. That being said, it is impossible to imagine a procedure, such as written testimony, that allows a reasonable path for cross-examination, since an essential element of cross-examination is for the judges to be able judge, firsthand, the credibility of the witness. This overture should be returned to presbytery, for further refinement. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 286, AA.	Dr. Coffin's advice to refer back to Presbytery also seems well-advised. Referring to SJC could also be a helpful course, as in O22.

			<u>The court shall include in the record its reasons for any accommodations and any objection from the accused to such accommodation, and the objection and the court's response shall be included in the record."</u> Refer this Overture to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49th GA Overtures Committee that will meet in 2022 in Birmingham. Grounds: Same as Pacific NW Overture 22		
41	TN Valley	OC CCB	Amend BCO 35-1 to Expand Potential Witness Availability. Strike the first sentence of BCO 35-1, to read as follows: "All persons of proper age and intelligence are competent witnesses, except such as do not believe in the existence of God; or in a future state of rewards and punishments: The accused party may be allowed, but shall not be compelled to testify; but the accuser shall be required to testify, on the demand of the accused. Either party has the right to challenge a witness who he believes to be incompetent, and the court shall decide upon his competency. It belongs to the court to judge the credibility to be attached to all evidence."	NEGATIVE The case imagined could have been true in the 18th Century. Yet our Forefathers were persuaded that, since we cannot read the heart, credible witnesses, before our courts, must at least believe that God can do so, and will judge them accordingly. I see nothing that has changed since then, and thus there is no reason to adjust our standards. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that adopting Overture 41 would create the possibility of a witness being qualified, but refusing to take the vow outlined in BCO 35-6." CH, 286, BB.	Refer this Overture to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49th GA Overtures Committee that will meeting in 2022 in Birmingham. This is the best venue for working through process recommendations. Dr. Coffin's motion to answer in the negative is also reasonable.

<u>42</u>	Susquehanna Valley	MNA	Susquehanna Valley petitions GA to change its boundary description to add those five unassigned counties, remove Berks County, and remove the erroneous comma so that the boundary description for SVP should read...	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. There is no recommendation, as yet, from CMNA in CH.	
<u>43</u>	Hills & Plains	OC AC	Form Study Committee for Biblical Ethics in Digital Media (same as #32 C. Indiana)	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 32.	Answer affirmative, in reference to overture 32
<u>44</u>	Philadelphia Metro West	MNA	Transfer Berks County to Phil. Metro W	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. There is no recommendation, as yet, from CMNA in CH.	
<u>45</u>	Metro Atlanta	OC CDM AC	Seek Asian American Flourishing - Provides sample letter - Asks GA to "recognize that the flourishing of our Asian American brothers and sisters now and in the future, will contribute to the flourishing of us all as the body of Christ, because if one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together, for the glory of God." - Asks GA to "appoint five Asian Americans from 2 diverse generations and	NEGATIVE This is, in principle, a request for a study committee. See comments on Overture 32.	No recommendation yet. As an opportunity to stand in solidarity, the overture has obvious value. The question is how to truly honor the intent of the request. There are defects that will make it very unlikely to pass the OC, one of which is mentioned by Dr. Coffin and others, that it is the creation of a study committee without the necessary parameters. There isn't really a vehicle for accomplishing what the overture is asking. There needs to be more work done on this overture for it to pass committee.

			cultural backgrounds to serve the PCA over the next three years in three tasks.		
<u>46</u>	Metro NY	OC CDM AC	Same as Metro Atlanta 45	NEGATIVE This is, in principle, a request for a study committee. See comments on Overture 32.	See 45
<u>47</u>	Chesapeake	OC AC	Study Committee on Critical Race Theory	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 32.	Negative. Aside from concerns about the probability that a study committee can accurately study and make recommendations about an academic theory like CRT, with two other study committees in process, adding a third would be difficult; if I were to pick the most urgent it would be the study committee recommended by overture 32.
<u>48</u>	Korean Capital	OC	Repudiate Anti-American Racism (with seven Be It Resolved paragraphs)	NEGATIVE In everything that the overture legitimately seeks from a church court, the PCA is already, boldly, plainly, and Constitutionally committed to. With respect to the rest, it is beyond the scope of the Assembly's jurisdiction to address such matters.	No recommendation yet. These types of overtures fail at the committee and assembly level due to two camps of opposition: (1) those who have a narrow understanding of the assembly's scope (strictly church issues), and (2) those who are uncomfortable making any statement which speaks to the role of the civil government (2nd-to-last whereas). It is a powerful statement, but one I don't think will pass. How can this receive further attention? Certainly if it fails and enough OC members support a minority report, it will receive debate from the floor of the assembly. Glad to hear other recommendations.



Cal Boroughs

<sepccal@comcast.net>

Jun 17, 2021, 9:54:59 AM

主



to james, NP

James, et al.

Re: O. 40. I read David's response and wondered what kind of overture he would support. As he said, it is an extraordinarily well prepared overture. It comes from the Study Committee on Abuse. If the objection is to the "might include procedures such as written testimony..." then a motion to delete the written testimony part could be made. But as one who worked on this with

the abuse study committee, I don't know what else we can propose. This is what the abuse study committee wants and sees as necessary.

I am open to any suggestions.

As for O. 41, this also comes from the abuse study committee. Here is an example of the concern driving this overture: Suppose a congregation has a member who is married to a non-believer. The non-believing spouse is abused in the marriage. The present 35-1 would open the door to the non-believing spouse being prohibited from being a witness. We are seeking a simple remedy by this overture.

Cal Boroughs



larry.c.hoop
<larry.c.hoop@gmail.com>

Jun 17, 2021, 2:57:59 PM

✉



to james, NP

James and all,

Re: overture 17 - the AC is offering an amended form of this proposal that I beleive does a better job of clarifying this matter. While the proposed language does simplify the provision, it does not, IMO, remove one of the most objectionable provisions - it has Ad-interim Committees funded out of *undesigned* AC funds, which is contrary to

our actual practice and if actually followed, would create an unfunded mandate. I am particularly concerned about this as one of my jobs is to raise money for the AC ☐ ☐ Seriously, funding the AC is tough enough without adding unfunded mandates.

Larry



hjin29
<hjin29@gmail.com>

Jun 22, 2021, 1:46:27 PM

主



to larry.c.hoop, james, NP

As the principal author of Overture 48, I wanted to give some insight into our presbytery's rationale for writing it.

1) It was written in response to Anti-Asian Racism, especially to the exponential increase in racist incidents and hate crimes over the past 1 1/2 years. We felt that the PCA has not addressed this reality adequately. This silence and perceived indifference has not fallen on deaf ears among Asian-Americans in the PCA.

2) We collaborated with the authors of the Metro Atlanta Overture, #45. Both our presbyteries wanted to address anti-asian racism but from distinct perspectives that reflected our presbytery's cultural differences: MAT's majority white culture and KCP's Korean-American culture. In the process of collaborating, we saw this overture as an extension or application of the Racial Reconciliation Study Committee Report.

3) I disagree with Coffin's assessment that "In everything that the overture legitimately seeks from a church court, the PCA is already, boldly, plainly, and Constitutionally committed to." I think every Asian-American commissioner could tell stories about micro and macro aggressions they've experienced at GA. Personally, I've been to 7 GA's and have experienced something offensive/hurtful/cringe-worthy every year that makes me feel like a perpetual outsider in the PCA. Additionally, the rhetoric that some PCA folks were expressing after the Atlanta shootings and in response to increased anti-asian racism (use of the phrase Kung Flu, down playing the role of race in the ATL shootings, whitesplaining Asian-American pain and trauma) shows that more anti-racism work needs to be done in the PCA, specifically as it applies to anti-Asian racism, which often times looks very different than anti-black racism.

Many Asian-Americans in the PCA would love for us to pass one of these overtures (45, 46, aor 48). However, we also know that it's an uphill climb for many reasons, legitimate and also not. Procedurally, is there a way to amend the overture and/or combine it with overtures 45/46 to make it more passable without neutering it?

Hansoo Jin

Pastor



brad

<brad@gracewoodlands.org>

Jun 22, 2021, 2:05:28 PM

✉



to hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, NP

Thanks for writing this out. Very helpful and so disappointing/shameful you had to experience that.

Peace,

Brad Wright



dennis

<dennis@kingscrosscypress.org>

Jun 22, 2021, 2:07:43 PM

主



to larry.c.hoop, hjin29, james, NP

Hansoo,

First, this makes me sad and angry to read of your experiences at GA. It also makes me pause and wonder have I been complicit or actually committed this offense to you or others.

Second, thank you for giving some background to this. I truly hope guys on the OC will be able to champion this and maybe get it into one cogent form from the different overtures to bring to the assembly.

Praying.

Dennis



pastor.tim.lecroy

<pastor.tim.lecroy@gmail.com>

Jun 22, 2021, 2:13:33 PM

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to brad, hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, NP

Hansoo,

Thanks so much for writing out that explanation. We all mourn as we learn more about the uptick in anti-Asian racism in our country.

To your question, individual overtures may be amended in the Overtures Committee. But the resulting amended overture must pass the test of germaneness. In other words, you can't change it to a completely different overture. Once one overture passes, the Assembly can answer the other one in reference to the first one.

I'm not sure exactly what we can do to the overture to give it a better chance at passing. Maybe we could put together a small working group of folks to hone this?

If you recall, the first time an overture of repentance for our failures during the Civil Rights era was attempted it did not pass. But the fact that we were able to bring it to the floor for discussion allowed many to speak to the issue and resulted in Jim Baird's moving speech. It was not until the next year, after the overture was perfected, that it passed with a 90% vote.

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Rev. Dr. Timothy R. LeCroy



kevinjtwit
<kevinjtwit@gmail.com>

Jun 22, 2021, 2:51:55 PM

主



to pastor.tim.lecroy, brad, hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, NP

Main problem with overture as written is that it kind of calls for a study committee instead of just making a declaration and calling for a season for prayer for example. I'm not on overtures but I like the idea of a group trying to perfect it while staying germane and am happy to help if I can.

Sent from my iPhone



sseaton

<sseaton@emmanuelarlington.org>

Jun 22, 2021, 3:02:33 PM

主



to kevinjtwit, pastor.tim.lecroy, brad, hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, NP

How timely: our staff had lunch together today, where we ran into Owen Lee and their staff. We were talking about the overture, and I asked him about the study committee aspect. He said the intent was really more to make a declaration rather than form a study committee, and so they hope to change the language in Overtures (which Owen is on).

grace,
Scott Seaton



rwootton2010

<rwootton2010@gmail.com>

Jun 22, 2021, 3:40:32 PM

主



to hjin29, james, NP, larry.c.hoop

Brother,

My first interaction with you the evening Alex was elected moderator was cringe worthy. I was exited about his election and didn't know how to express that well. I wanted you to know that I was married to a Korean American and the whole thing was awkward. Will you forgive me to adding to your difficult and painful experiences at GA?

This past year in particular and our whole marriage experiencing with Robin racial slurs, micro aggressions, and well meaning Christians ignorance, much of it willful, and obliviousness to Asian racism has made it clear that these overtures are necessary. Robin was so encouraged, even to

tears, when she read to overtures, I was as well. I've already planned to speak to these on the floor and look forward to hearing more from you all on how to do this well.

Rob



servenator
<servenator@gmail.com>

Jun 22, 2021, 3:47:55 PM

主



to rwootton2010, hjin29, james, NP, larry.c.hoop

My experience is that I was in the PCA for 15 years before I think I had meaningful interactions with my PCA brothers and sisters. Perhaps I have forgotten, but I cannot remember.

When I started the HUE project, I very much expanded my world - praise the Lord, but also the flip side is WTF was I doing all this time.

We had a HUE author fb group and that helped me so much. When we met in Mobile, I was able to hang out with Alex who had become a friend (not in person but online), and he introduced me to a whole swath of new friends. That was so awesome.

And it's expanded. And I have so many blind spots still. And I want things like to get passed and talked about. I don't think we can do enough of them.

And I'm so sorry for my contribution. And I am so thankful for you.



geoff.ziegler
<geoff.ziegler@gmail.com>

Jun 22, 2021, 9:05:54 PM

主



to sseaton, kevinjtwit, pastor.tim.lecroy, brad, hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, NP

What do we think might be a way to perfect this? If the concern is with the third resolution in the Metro Atlanta Overture for implicitly forming a study committee, would it make sense to amend by removing that specific resolution and perhaps instead adding a resolution that incorporates some of the language from the Korean Capital Presbytery Overture? Perhaps something like:

"Be it further resolved that that the 48th General Assembly of the Presbyterian Church in America strongly repudiates the sin of anti-Asian racism in all of its forms, including racist jokes, the sexual objectification of women, the use of rhetoric discriminatory against Asians, and all other actions that are inconsistent with a Biblical ethic of loving one's neighbor."

I'm on overtures, and would love to receive advice from those of you more knowledgeable than I!

Geoff



Jack

<jack@churchplantingnetwork.org>

Jun 22, 2021, 9:05:54 PM

主



to servenator, kevinjtwit, pastor.tim.lecroy, brad, hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, James Kessler

My very dear brothers in the Lord... I'm so glad we are having this conversations as a mixed Walsh/Cuban Dad who has adopted 5 family members which includes twin Chinese daughters now in there 50's with children and live in the USA as citizens. Also I have brought into the PCA a local Korean Church plus the Lord allowed me to serve on MNA GA for over 20+ years. Been a mentor to many Church Planting and support ministries. Enough about me... it all about you and empowering you as to how God will use you to make a good (PCA) stand for as a group.

So my words of wisdom to you is make it God honoring, humble and strong in your faith as to how God told us to act in the Scriptures, so that the world will see we have His truth. I'm proud to read and understand your feelings and what I love about the PCA is it is a process of ideas, tested against the Scriptures so God gets His will done through us sinful men.

Keep it up my dear brothers. Love you guys in Christ.

Jack



refandrev
<refandrev@gmail.com>

Jun 22, 2021, 9:05:54 PM

主



to hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, NP

Hansoo, thank you for informing us of your perspective. I too mourn that you have experienced any of these things, especially among PCA Elders at the General Assembly. Thank you for your graciousness. May the Lord guide all of us as to what will best serve to change our church culture for the better, the good of Christ's Church, and our gospel witness before a watching world. -- Walt



sseaton
<sseaton@emmanuelarlington.org>

Jun 24, 2021, 12:40:12 PM

主



to hjin29, larry.c.hoop, james, NP, refandrev

Hansoon and friends:

About a third of our church, staff and leadership is Asian American, and from them, I've heard several stories that confirm the need and value of these overtures. On top of that, I've also heard

many accounts of treating Asian American pastors being treated as second class, at GA and elsewhere. So if there's anything I can do to help, please let me know.

Have you considered picking one of the overtures to rally support behind, addressing that one first in Overtures, and the other two being answered in reference to that one? That approach was essentially what happened with the racial reconciliation overtures.

FWIW, I really like Overture 48 from Korean Capital Presbytery (so well done, Hansoo!). The fact that it's from a Korean presbytery, and is in both English and Korean, is powerful. Further, it's more pointed than the others, and doesn't raise the implication of erecting a study committee. So personally, I'd love to see support galvanized around this one.

grace,
Scott Seaton

A note on NP confidentiality

22 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 23, 2021, 6:27:17 PM



to NP

Dear friends,

I feel a responsibility to let our group know that I no longer have a reasonable expectation of confidentiality in this group. You'll notice I haven't included the confidentiality notice atop the email. The reason is that our last overtures advice email was shared by one of us with TE Todd Pruitt and

TE Chuck Williams. Both of whom decided to share that email within a FB group of PCA pastors which numbers more than 500. I can only assume the email was shared even more broadly.

Now, I have said it before and I'll say it again: the intent of confidentiality was always to protect those of you who felt you could not be as forthcoming in larger groups. I've always wanted the NP to be a place where you can seek advice with confidence that your questions weren't being used to fuel blog posts. The lack of confidentiality makes no difference in what I share with you. Emails will say pretty much what they would have said. But for those of you nervous about emails to the group, please know that you are welcome to reply only to me and I'll do my best to respond as I'm able. Looking forward to seeing you all next week. Praying for a God-glorifying five days in STL.

Grateful for all of you,
JK



pastor.tim.lecroy
<pastor.tim.lecroy@gmail.com>

unread,

Jun 25, 2021, 11:00:18 PM

✉



to james, NP

I was going to hold my tongue on this, but I just can't. I think this is terrible. Just terrible. I just can't fathom anyone with such a complete lack of honor as to betray confidence. I don't care if it's friend or foe, I was raised to keep faith.

James has always made it clear that this wasn't a voting bloc. That everyone was free to disagree and vote our conscience. That the purpose of this group was to resource one another and encourage one another to be involved in the courts of the church.

We've always been about privacy here. Not secrecy, privacy. And why should we have privacy? Let me tell you why. Just today slander from a white supremacist website was spread about me in a PCA Facebook group because I dared to set the record straight about some of the untruths being said about the PCA and homosexuality. And it's not the first time it's happened to me.

So yeah, I think it's completely dishonorable whoever did it, and you ought to write to James and ask to be taken off this list. I'm sure he will do it without spreading your name because he is a man of honor.

Tim

NP NOTE: Wednesday GA preview

3 views

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james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 30, 2021, 9:39:46 AM (9 days ago)

主



to NP

{This communication is not to be shared without permission from the sender}

Hello friends, some preview material for today's assembly.

RPR report advice. We have a report for TODAY at 11a. Advice regarding that report is below.

Things to expect today:

1. **RPR report advice.** There is an important item regarding Calvary Presbytery's response to the committee citing the presbytery for forbidding a man to teach exceptions to the standards that are judged not hostile to the system of doctrine. This report is slated for 11am. Be there and ready to vote.
2. **Overtures committee revised advice.** This is following the work of the OC and can be a help when the OC report comes Thursday.

3. **Nominating Committee advice.** Following the NC close of nominations we will send out a guide for those of you not always familiar with the candidates. In some cases we may not have a recommendation, but in others there may be a candidate whose experience and views would align more clearly with a healthy PCA. Thankfully in all those cases both men will be brothers in Christ and worthy of honor.

Today's calendar:

Wednesday (6/30)

11a: Review of Presbytery Records Report. (The issue of allowing pastors to teach their exceptions to the standards will come to the floor here)

1.45p: Scheduled report of the Ad Interim Committee on Human Sexuality

3p: Scheduled report of the Ad Interim Committee on Domestic Violence

5p: Worship service

7p: The Fellowship Gathering at Covenant Seminary (Mike Khandjian's Fellowship group has a yearly dinner open to all)

See you at 11am. RPR email coming after this one.

NP NOTE: RPR report advice.

6 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jun 30, 2021, 9:54:34 AM (9 days ago)

⌵



to NP

{This email is not to be shared without permission from the sender}

Friends,

I asked an RPR expert, Tim Lecroy, to give an overview of the action on the RPR report slated for **11a** today. My own view is in line with the RPR. While we must take care to not spread teaching hostile to our system of doctrine as ruled by our presbyteries, the PCA is not a denomination that forbids the teaching of all differences with the standards.

There is one minority report for Calvary and I suspect that NW Georgia will be pulled out of the omnibus for the same issue.

RPR Report

There will be at least one and possibly two recommendations of the RPR report that will receive debate this morning. The first one will be the recommendation for Calvary Presbytery. The underlying issue is that the Presbytery put a total ban on a man teaching his views on his stated difference to the Westminster Standards even though they ruled that the difference was not out of accord with our system of doctrine. This violates BCO Preliminary Principle 7, which states that "no church judiciary may make laws to bind the conscience." The 46th GA in 2018 ruled that this action by Calvary Presbytery was an exception of substance, meaning that their action was contrary to the constitution of the PCA.

Calvary came back to the GA in 2019 with a response that basically said, "no, the GA is wrong about that." In 2019 the 27th GA ruled again that Calvary Presbytery had interpreted the constitution of the church wrongly and their response was unacceptable. In 2020, Calvary presbytery sent back the same exact response as 2019, saying again that the GA was wrong. This year the RPR is recommending that the matter be referred to the SJC for final disposition per RAO 16-10.c. The basic reason behind this is because, while the GA has authority to interpret the constitution in General Review and Control, it does not currently have the ability to bring the matter to final disposition. The SJC does have that authority, as delegated to it by the GA. Thus instead of continuing this back and forth between the GA and Calvary Presbytery, the RPR is recommending the matter be referred to the SJC. **The vote on RPR was 36-9-0.** There will be a minority report.

The issue for NW Georgia is almost identical, if that one gets pulled out of the omnibus.

--

Rev. Dr. Timothy R. LeCroy

Revised Overture advice

4 views

Skip to first unread message



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jul 1, 2021, 9:43:27 AM (8 days ago)



to NP

This does not include advice on Overture 23. I will send that separately.

NP Discussion Regarding Overtures to the 48th GA, with Dr. David Coffin's Advice

			42 Overtures to 48th GA 35 referred to Overtures Committee: 1, 5, 6, 9, 10, 12, 15-23, 26-38, 40, 41, 43, 45-48	Advice from Dr. David Coffin (He provides this often helpful reflection on the annual overtures)	Proposed action
1	Potomac	OC CCB	BCO 8-7 Chaplains - Add: <u>Δ Teaching Elder requiring ecclesiastical endorsement to serve as a chaplain must be approved through the endorsing agency authorized by the General Assembly for such purpose. Teaching Elders ministering as paid or volunteer chaplains in settings that do not require ecclesiastical endorsement should consider seeking the same endorsement.</u>	NEGATIVE The "whereas" paragraphs do not provide any reason for <i>requiring as a matter of church law</i> endorsement only through the GA endorsing agency. Further, the second sentence of the proposed amendment should be eliminated. A rule that says something "should" be done is fatally ambiguous, as "should" can indicate obligation, or only the advisable. And in this case, if it is taken only as advisable, it is trivial, for the advice is only to "consider" endorsement. Finally, if there is to be such a paragraph added, the whole section should be renumbered, as the paragraphs treat distinct subjects. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>Commissioner Handbook (hereinafter CH)</i>, 281, A (unless otherwise noted, the CCB vote was unanimous).	Negative. The whereas clauses do not clearly support the conclusion, and a change like this -- with potential unintended consequences for credentialing bodies, needs a compelling case. <i>Committee: Negative 114-9-2</i>
2	Central Georgia	SJC	"Assume original jurisdiction of the case of the investigation by Missouri Presbytery of Greg Johnson and the session of Memorial Presbyterian Church with regard to theological error and involvement in the 2018 Revoice Conference."	NO COMMENT As I am a member of the SJC which is currently working on a response to the BCO 34-1 request it is inappropriate for me to express an opinion at this time.	Even though this issue will not be before us at the Assembly, I asked Rev. Dr. Tim LeCroy to give a rationale for opposition, for future reference: "These two overtures will not be up for discussion or vote at this General Assembly. The reason is that the Rules of Assembly Operation 17-2 dictate that any BCO 34-1 request for original jurisdiction "shall be assigned to the Standing Judicial Commission for adjudication."

			Already under consideration in the SJC.		The SJC manual covers the procedures for such a case in chapter 16. In this particular case, there is a complaint arising from the court of original jurisdiction, Missouri Presbytery, that is challenging the result of a BCO 31-2 investigation by Missouri Presbytery that found "no strong presumption of guilt" in TE Johnson. The SJC has decided to first adjudicate that complaint before taking up the BCO 34-1 requests because BCO 34-1 cites a "failure to act" by the court of original jurisdiction, and that alleged failure to act cannot be determined until the complaint is resolved. At any rate, there will not be any discussion or votes on overtures 2 or 25 at this General Assembly, and perhaps even at any future assembly."
3	Heritage	MTW	Add the following to the MTW Manual: <u>MTW leaders in line authority over church planting or church development ministry should be ordained elders. In extraordinary cases where this policy is not followed, the appointment of an unordained man who exhibits the qualities of an elder is permissible, but must be approved annually by a three-quarters vote of CMTW, and there shall be a record of the reasons for such an appointment included in CMTW's minutes that are submitted to the General Assembly.</u>	ANSWER BY REFERENCE TO ACTION ON OV. 14 Overture 14 has the advantage of <i>brevitas et claritas</i>. NOTE: CMNA recommends AFFIRMATIVE, but to a much attenuated version of the Presbytery's proposed language. <i>CH</i>, 713-715, item 11.	Negative. Would not affirm the MTW CoC answer. The CoC adopted the strictest language and cannot be sustained. The effects of affirming this would be far reaching and harmful.
4	Savannah River	SJC	"Concurs with Overture 2 from Central Georgia Presbytery, adopted on January 11, 2020,	NO COMMENT	Even though this issue will not be before us at the Assembly, I asked Rev. Dr. Tim

			without nominations. In every case a majority of all the voters present votes cast shall be required to elect." [Same changes to BCO 24-3 and 24-4]		
6	Covenant	OC CCB	BCO 24-1 timing of officer exams (add "qualified" twice, and strike "then") BCO 24-1 Every church shall elect persons to the offices of ruling elder and deacon in the following manner: At such times as determined by the Session, communicant members of the congregation may submit names to the Session, keeping in mind that each prospective officer should be an active male member who meets the qualifications set forth in 1 Tim 3 and Titus 1. After the close of the nomination period, <u>qualified</u> nominees for the office of ruling elder and/or deacon shall receive instruction in the qualifications and work of the office. Each <u>qualified</u> nominee shall then be examined in: ..." <i>CCB advises is "constitutionally vague because it does not identify a means by which a nominee is deemed "qualified or unqualified." CCB vote 8-0. Handbook p. 282</i>	NEGATIVE CCB's judgment is sound, but its objection does not go far enough. Not only is there no <i>means for determination</i> set forth, there is also no <i>standard</i> as to what constitutes "qualified". Absent means and standards there can be no accountability. This is a recipe for abuse of power. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment "is constitutionally vague because it does not identify a means by which a nominee is deemed qualified or unqualified". CH, 282, C.	Affirm OC to answer in reference to O18. This is a dangerous addition to the BCO's language, adding "qualified" without adding a particular constituting standard. Coffin's (and CCB's) advice is conclusive. If Covenant Presbytery would like to step up the threshold for qualification of officers there are far better ways of doing so. One path proposed by others is to answer this way: Return the Overture to the Presbytery, without prejudice. Grounds for Alternative: The manner in which potential officers are nominated, trained, and examined is vitally important for the Church. This Overture could benefit from further perfection. <i>OC: Ref. to O-18 109-0-0</i>
7	Lowcountry		Withdrawn		

8	Catawba Valley	MNA	Revise boundaries	SEE Overture 11.	
9	Ascension	OC CCB	RAO 15-6 - Increase requirement for OC Minority Report from 3+3 to 10% of OC (at least 1/3 of which are TEs and 1/3 REs)	AFFIRMATIVE A reasonable solution to an otherwise worsening problem. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 282, letter E.	Affirm OC answer as amended. As the OC continues to grow, we need higher thresholds for qualifying minority reports or we will struggle to be a deliberative body, giving the Assembly yes and no on every question. <i>OC: Affirmative/Amended 88-19-0</i>
10	Ascension	OC CCB	RAO 15-6.s-4 and -5 re: content of OC Minority Reports <u>Add RAO 15-6.s.(4) No proposed action or proposed change in the wording of a recommendation from the Overtures Committee may be included in a minority report unless that proposal had been presented to the Overtures Committee and was defeated or tabled.</u> <u>Add (5) Ordinarily a minority report should employ arguments that were offered in the course of the Overtures Committee's deliberations on the matter in question.</u>	AFFIRMATIVE However, proposed RAO 15-6.s 4) needs some adjustment. Since failed motions are not recorded, how will it be known that a motion had been proposed and defeated? Further, why "Tabled," a rarely used motion limited to peculiar circumstance? What of all the other ways of disposing with a motion? Perhaps better to put a period after "Committee" on p. 55, line 40 and strike the rest. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 282, letter F.	Affirm OC answer as amended.. Helpful addition to the RAO. The following amendment has been suggested and, I think, will clear up any other difficulties with the overture: RAO 15-6.s.(4) No proposed action or proposed change in the wording of a recommendation from the Overtures Committee may be included in a minority report unless that proposal had been presented to the Overtures Committee and was defeated or tabled. RAO 15-6.s.(5) no revision of the Overture Possible grounds: Since failed motions are not recorded, GA would not know that a motion had been proposed and defeated. In addition, there

					are other ways of disposing with a motion other than defeating or tabling. If someone sought to present a Minority Report that did not comply with the new RAO 15-6.s.(4), a point of order could be raised. <i>OC: Affirmative/Amended 74-51-3</i>
<u>11</u>	Central Carolina	MNA	boundaries	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. CMNA recommends AFFIRMATIVE. <i>CH</i> , 605, item 6.	
<u>12</u>	Philly Metro West	OC CCB	Amend BCO 31-2 & 32-2 to Clarify that Investigation Shall Precede [all] Judicial Process BCO 31-2. It is the duty of all church Sessions and Presbyteries to exercise care over those subject to their authority. They shall <u>initiate an investigation and</u> with due diligence and great discretion demand from such persons satisfactory explanations concerning reports affecting their Christian character. This duty is more imperative when those who deem themselves aggrieved by injurious reports shall ask an investigation. If such investigation, however originating, should result in raising a strong presumption of the guilt of the party involved, the court shall institute process, and shall appoint a prosecutor to prepare the indictment and to conduct the case. This	NEGATIVE The language proposed for <i>BCO</i> 31-2, "initiate an investigation" is vague. It is not at all clear what is required by the new language that was not obligatory under the unamended text. The language proposed for <i>BCO</i> 32-2 puts the cart before the horse. There is no good reason to amend a provision of long standing that has been ably construed by our courts. Overall, the Overture does not appear to grasp the point of the concurring opinion that it claims to rely upon. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 282, G.	Affirm OC answer to refer back. I received this advice from some on the SJC. I think it's helpful in addressing the defects in this overture: <i>It's not clear what the new language requires that isn't already obligatory under the unamended text of BCO 31-2. And the proposed addition to BCO 32-2 seems to put the cart before the horse. There is no good reason to amend provisions of long standing that have been ably construed by our courts. And finally, we note the Overture does not appear to grasp the point of the concurring opinion that it claims to rely on. In addition, the proposed change seems to disallow a court from ordering an indictment and appointing a prosecutor immediately upon finding sufficient reason to do so. But that right should be retained for the courts, even it is not ordinarily used.</i> <i>OC: Refer back 112-2-0</i>

			prosecutor shall be a member of the court, except that in a case before the Session, he may be any communing member of the same congregation with the accused. BCO 32-2: Process against an offender shall not be commenced unless, <u>after a careful investigation (BCO 31-2) by the court and its finding of a strong presumption of guilt</u>, some person or persons undertake to make out the charge; or unless the court finds it necessary, for the honor of religion, itself to take the step provided for in BCO 31-2.		
<u>13</u>	Mississippi Valley	MNA	Be it therefore resolved that the MNA Permanent Committee explore the advisability of endorsing Lifeline Children's Services as a possible resource for PCA churches.	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. CMNA recommends AFFIRMATIVE. <i>CH</i>, 605, item 7.	
<u>14</u>	Evangel	MTW	Direct CMTW to amend the MTW Policy Manual to include the following statement: <u>"All MTW leaders in line authority over church planting or church development ministry shall be ordained elders."</u>	AFFIRMATIVE Presbytery's rationale is compelling and its proposal is well-crafted, particularly in its evident commitment to <i>BCO</i> 14-1.7, "The Assembly's committees are to serve and not to direct any Church judicatories. They are not to establish policy, but rather execute policy established by the General Assembly."	Answer in reference to answer on Overture 3

				NOTE: CMNA recommends answer by reference to action on Overture 3. <i>CH</i> , 716, item 13.	
15	New Covenant (Session)	OC CCB	Insert as the second sentence of RAO 11-2: <u>Nor should digital communication for vote coordination be transmitted or received by any person or portion of the General Assembly while in session.</u>	NEGATIVE Appropriately, RAO 11-12 is a rule governing what the Assembly may or may not do. The proposed amendment illicitly makes the rule govern what others may or may not do as well. Further, the placement of the amendment in the text separates the conditional of the following sentence from its object in what was the previous sentence, thereby making it incoherent. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution, “but [is] not germane to the RAO chapter for which it is proposed”. <i>CH</i>, 283, H. 7-1-0	Affirm OC answer in the Negative (note: this overture was rejected by its presbytery and was an attempt to limit advice/help on the floor during GA deliberations. The bringers of the motion addressed the NP specifically). RAO 11-12 is a rule governing what the GA may or may not do. The proposed amendment makes the rule govern what others may or may not do as well. CCB also finds the overture is “not germane to the RAO chapter for which it is proposed”. <i>CH</i>, 283, H. 7-1-0 <i>OC: Negative 102-12-2</i>
16	Westminster	OC CCB	Add new BCO 7-4: <u>Men who identify as homosexual, even those who identify as homosexual and claim to practice celibacy in that self-identification, are disqualified from holding office in the Presbyterian Church in America.</u> <i>CCB advises this “is in conflict with BCO 12-5.b, 13.9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the</i>	NEGATIVE The insertion of the paragraph in a chapter entitled “Church Officers-General Classification” seems oddly out of place. This appears to be a rule desperately looking for a home. However, it is not clear to me that the proposal is in <i>conflict</i> with the <i>BCO</i>, as its provisions regularly specify what qualifications must be met by all candidates without undermining the rights and responsibilities of the lower courts. Beyond that, I cannot comment, as the substance of the matter is being adjudicated before the <i>SJC</i>.	Negative The current standard, in BCO 21-4, “his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9)” and the similar language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will continue to be, sufficient to set forth concisely the examining court’s responsibility. Additionally, the citing of homosexual desires, though they be unwanted and mortified through a celibate and holy life, <i>as</i>

			<i>candidate is qualified..." CCB vote was 6-2. CH p. 283</i>	NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS in conflict "with BCO 12-5.b, 13-9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the candidate is qualified. The Committee notes that the 48th General Assembly cannot amend the <i>Book of Church Order</i> but begins the process laid out in BCO 26-2. CH, 283, I. 6-2-0	<i>a special case</i>, has the effect of marginalizing the remainder of the Bible's classification of notorious or heinous sins. Note: Rom 5.18-19 under the third whereas has absolutely nothing to do with sexual sin. Perhaps a mis-copy from another source? Certainly it does not strengthen the case. The rationale here is even less-helpful than 30/37, introducing the terms identify/self-identification into the BCO with no hope of clarity. These terms aren't even broadly understood in our churches, how can they be utilized justly in the candidates and credentials committees? <i>OC: Ref. to O-37 and O-38 74-51-2</i>
17	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Reword RAO 9-3. <u>The General Assembly may appoint or continue any number of ad interim committees. However, no committee may be funded with undesignated AC funding after its third year, and only two committees may be funded with undesignated AC funding in any given year.</u>	AFFIRMATIVE Clearly, the current language is needlessly complicated, and has caused confusion. However, the proposed change could be made even more clear by striking the text on p. 71, lines 18-19, from "The General Assembly" through "However," capitalizing the word "No" and adding "such" thereafter, so that the new opening sentence would read "No such committee may be funded. . . ." The matter of the first sentence in the proposal is adequately addressed in RAO 9-1 and -2. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. CH, 283, J.	Affirm OC Answer in the affirmative as amended. This doesn't change the current policy, but it provides needed clarification. Overtures may continue to propose how an ad interim committee is to be funded, and AC and OC may continue giving their recommendations regarding funding. No RAO rule would need to be suspended for GA to decide how such an ad interim is funded (which is the current situation, but probably unclear in the current wording.) <i>OC: Affirmative/Amended 111-7-1</i>

18	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	BCO 24-1 Elder/Deacon Nominee exams (strike “then” and add a sentence) Strike one word in BCO 24-1 “Each nominee shall then be examined in: ...” And add: <u>The Session may render a decision on Christian experience at any point in the process, and based on that decision, may judge him ineligible for that election.</u>	NEGATIVE The proposed language does not appear to solve the alleged problem, so long as the sentence “After the close of the nomination period, nominees for the office or ruling elder and/or deacon shall receive instruction. . . .” (p. 75, lines 13-15) remains in the text. The proposal is in need of revision if it is to clarify and make more flexible the procedure. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i>, 283, K.	Affirm OC answer in the affirmative as amended. <i>OC: Affirmative/Amended 118-0-1</i>
19	Pacific Northwest (revised)	OC CCB	Amend BCO 38-1 and 42-2 to allow an appeal, instead of a complaint, after censure in confessions. BCO 38-1: When any person shall come forward and make his offense known to the court, a full statement of the facts shall be recorded and judgment rendered without process. In handling a confession of guilt, it is essential that the person intends to confess and permit the court to render judgment without process. Statements made by him in the presence of the court must not be taken as a basis of a judgment without process except by his consent. The accused <u>A censured person</u> has the right of complaint	AFFIRMATIVE The current language of the provision denies the subject of the proceeding due process in that the remedies available with respect to a successful complaint are considerable narrower than those for a successful appeal. The proposed amendment wisely corrects this significant defect. The language for <i>BCO</i> 38-1 would be better put “A person so censured has the right to appeal (<i>BCO</i> 42),” thereby narrowing the focus. The remedy for CCB’s concern about conflict is to answer Overture 34 in the negative! NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. “CCB notes that if the amendments proposed by Overture 19 and Overture 34 are both adopted, they would be in conflict regarding	Affirm OC answer to refer to 49th GA <i>OC: Refer to 49th GA 120-1-1</i>

			against the judgment to appeal the censure (BCO 42). BCO 42-2. Only <u>The only parties entitled to an appeal are those who have submitted to a regular trial-are entitled to an appeal, those appealing a censure in a BCO 38-1 case without process, and those appealing a BCO 34-10 divestiture without censure</u> <i>CCB advises there might be a conflict between PNW 19 & PNW 34. CCB vote 8-0 CH 283. Note: This will be remedied by considering PNW 19 after the other 3 Overtures on 38-1.</i>	the right of appeal or the right of complaint." CH, 283, L.	
20	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Increase Vote for Pretrial Suspensions (by adding a clause) BCO 31-10. When a member of a church court is under process, all his official functions may be suspended at the court's discretion; but this shall never be done in the way of censure, <u>and this requires a three-fourths (3/4) majority.</u> BCO 33-4. When it is impracticable immediately to commence process against an accused church member, the Session may, if it thinks the	AFFIRMATIVE The case for the change is well made by Rationale. A more felicitous phrasing for BCO 31-10 would be: "When a member of a church court is under process, by a three-fourths (3/4) majority all his official functions may be suspended at the court's discretion; but this shall never be done in the way of censure." A more felicitous phrasing for BCO 33-4 would be: "When it is impracticable immediately to commence process against an accused church member, the Session may, if it thinks the edification of the Church requires it, by a three-fourths (3/4) majority prevent the accused	Affirm OC answer to refer to 49th GA OC: Refer to 49th GA 120-1-1

			edification of the Church requires it, prevent the accused from approaching the Lord's Table until the charges against him can be examined, <u>but this requires a three-fourths (3/4) majority</u> .	from approaching the Lord's Table until the charges against him can be examined." NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 284, M.	
21	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Increase Vote for maintaining suspensions during appeals (by adding clause). BCO 42-6. Notice of appeal shall have the effect of suspending the judgment of the lower court until the case has been finally decided in the higher court. However, the court of original jurisdiction may, for sufficient reasons duly recorded, prevent the appellant from approaching the Lord's Table, and if an officer, prevent him from exercising some or all his official functions, until the case is finally decided (cf. BCO 31-10; 33-4). This shall never be done in the way of censure, <u>and shall require a two-thirds (2/3) majority</u> .	AFFIRMATIVE The case for the change is well made by Rationale. A more felicitous phrasing for <i>BCO</i> 42-6-10 would be: "Notice of appeal shall have the effect of suspending the judgment of the lower court until the case has been finally decided in the higher court. However, the court of original jurisdiction may, for sufficient reasons duly recorded, by a two-thirds (2/3) majority prevent the appellant from approaching the Lord's Table, and if an officer, prevent him from exercising some or all his official functions, until the case is finally decided (cf. BCO 31-10; 33-4). This shall never be done in the way of censure." NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 284, N.	Affirm OC answer to refer to 49th GA <i>OC: Refer to 49th GA 120-1-1</i>
22	Pacific Northwest (revised)	OC CCB	Amend BCO 32-20 re Statute of Limitations (strike and replace) BCO 32-20. Process, in case a matter of scandal, shall commence within the space of one year after the offense was committed, unless it has	REFER TO SJC FOR ADVICE The Overture addresses a very important defect in our Rules of Discipline, but the language proposed is not fully adapted as a remedy. The concept of a statute of limitations is a matter of considerable complexity, fraught with possibilities for doing more harm than good. A	Affirm OC answer to affirm as amended <i>OC: Affirmative/Amended 95-22-3</i>

			recently become flagrant. When, however, a church member shall commit an offense, after removing to a place far distant from his former residence, and where his connection with the church is unknown, in consequence of which process cannot be instituted within the time above specified, the recent discovery of the church membership of the individual shall be considered as equivalent to the offense itself having recently become flagrant. The same principle, in like circumstances, shall also apply to ministers. BCO 32-20. <u>There is no statute of limitations, per se, for prosecuting offenses. However, the accused or a member of the court may object to the consideration of a charge, for example if he thinks the passage of time since the alleged offense makes fair adjudication unachievable. The court should consider factors such as the gravity of the alleged offense as well as what degradations of evidence and memory may have occurred in the intervening period.</u>	full and careful consideration of the matter by the SJC over the coming year would greatly enhance our likelihood of success. Note that the rationale for the overture grants the possible profit of this course, item 10, p. 87, lines 40 and following. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. CH, 284, O.	
23	Gulf Coast	OC CCB	Add new BCO 17-4:	NEGATIVE	Affirm OC answer to affirm as amended

			<u>Men who self-identify as a "gay Christian," "same-sex attracted Christian," "homosexual Christian," or like term shall be deemed not qualified for ordination in the Presbyterian Church in America.</u> CCB advises this "is in conflict with BCO 12-5.b, 13.9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the candidate is qualified..." CCB vote was 6-2. CH p. 284	The insertion of the paragraph in a chapter entitled "Doctrine of Ordination" seems oddly out of place. This appears to be a rule desperately looking for a home. However, it is not clear to me that the proposal is <i>in conflict</i> with the BCO, as its provisions regularly specify what qualifications must be met by all candidates without undermining the rights and responsibilities of the lower courts. Beyond that, I cannot comment, as the substance of the matter is being adjudicated before the SJC. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS in conflict "with BCO 12-5.b, 13-9.a, 21-4, and 24-1, which state it is the right and responsibility of the lower courts to determine if the candidate is qualified. The Committee notes that the 48th General Assembly cannot amend the <i>Book of Church Order</i> but begins the process laid out in BCO 26-2." CH, 284, P. 6-2-0	OC: Affirmative/Amended 106-12-0
24	Tennessee Valley	AC	Set the GA commissioner registration fees as follows: \$250 for Ruling Elders; \$500 for Teaching Elders; Honorably retired or emeritus elders would continue to pay \$150; Teaching Elders from churches with annual incomes below \$100,000, as per their 2020 statistics, may register for \$300.	NEGATIVE Any decrease in funding would be ill-considered given that the budgetary needs of AC are not now being properly meet. Here is a text from the BCO worthy our meditations with respect to this subject: 10-6, "The expenses of ministers and ruling elders in their attendance on the courts shall be defrayed by the bodies which they respectively represent." I have served in two congregations that began as mission works. Both budgeted, from their beginning, to send a TE and	

				NOTE: AC recommends answer in the negative offering lengthy reasons to that end. <i>CH</i> , 308, item 4.	
<u>25</u>	Southeast Alabama	SJC	“SE Alabama Presbytery joins with Savannah River Presbytery and Central Georgia Presbytery in requesting that the General Assembly assume original jurisdiction in the case of the doctrinal error of Teaching Elder Greg Johnson per BCO 34-1.”	NO COMMENT As I am a member of the SJC which is currently working on a response to the <i>BCO</i> 34-1 request it is inappropriate for me to express an opinion at this time.	See overture 2
<u>26</u>	Philadelphia Metro West	OC CCB	Add new BCO 10-7 re Electronic Meetings (All language below is a new addition.) 10-7. The General Assembly, presbyteries, and churches, in their discretion, may conduct meetings using telecommunications arrangements, such as telephone arrangements, internet-based audio and audio-visual communications arrangements, closed circuit audio and audio-visual communications arrangements, and combinations of such arrangements. The General Assembly, presbyteries, and churches, in their discretion, also may authorize their subordinate committees, commissions, and agencies, to conduct meetings using	AFFIRMATIVE A well argued proposal the need for which has been amply evidenced by a year gone viral! The words “Some examples of” should be replaced with the more felicitous “Among the” (p. 112, line 15). NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment “creates a conflict with RAO 1-1 that requires General Assembly to open with a virtual celebration of the Lord’s Supper.” <i>CH</i> , 284, Q. 5-3-0	Affirm OC answer in the affirmative. <i>OC: Affirmative/Amended 115-7-1</i>

		telecommunications arrangements. Some examples of meetings permitted by this Section 10-7 are a meeting in which all of the persons attending the meeting attend using telecommunications arrangements, and a meeting in which some of the persons attending the meeting attend in-person at the appointed meeting place and some of the persons attending the meeting attend using telecommunications arrangements. The General Assembly, presbyteries, and churches, in their discretion, may for themselves and their subordinate committees, commissions, and agencies, adopt rules determining when telecommunications arrangements may be used for meetings and regulating how meetings using telecommunications arrangements shall be conducted. A meeting using telecommunications arrangements shall be conducted as closely as reasonably feasible in the same manner as an in-person meeting and so as to permit: a. each person who is eligible to attend the meeting, to attend the meeting; b. each person who attends the meeting, to hear what is said by		
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			the other persons attending the meeting while they are speaking; c. each person who attends the meeting and is eligible to speak to the meeting, to speak to the meeting; d. each person who attends the meeting and is eligible to make a motion at the meeting, to make the motion; and, e. each person who attends the meeting and is eligible to vote on a matter that is being voted on at the meeting, to vote on the matter. <i>CCB advises this "creates a conflict with RAO 1-1 that requires GA to open with a ... celebration of the Lord's Supper." (Note: With an electronic GA, this would be a virtual Lord's Supper.). CCB vote 5-3. CH 284.</i>		
<u>27</u>	Platte Valley	OC CCB	Add to BCO 36-2 re public excommunication 36-2. Church censures and the modes of administering them should be suited to the nature of the offenses. For private offenses, censure should be administered in the presence of the court alone, or in private by one or more members of the court. In the case of public offenses, the degree of censure	AFFIRMATIVE Another case ably made in the arguments offered. However, I'm not entirely clear on what the phrase "peculiar and special reasons" (p. 117, line 34) signifies. Presumably "peculiar" reasons alone would not suffice, and "special" reasons alone would not suffice? Work at perfecting the language of the proposal would be welcome. Further, OC should attend to the observation of CCB.	Affirmative As amended below, by striking "and mode of administering it," in order to address CCB's concerns. BCO 36-2 Church censures and the modes of administering them should be suited to the nature of the offenses. For private offenses, censure should be administered in the presence of the court alone, or in private by one or more members of the court. In the

			and mode of administering it shall be within the discretion of the court, acting in accordance with paragraphs below which deal with particular censures. <u>When there are peculiar and special reasons, the court may visit public offenses, not very gross in their character, with private admonition, or with definite suspension in private; but the censures of excommunication and deposition should be either administered before the church, or else announced to it, at the discretion of the court.</u> <i>CCB advises "if adopted would create a conflict, in that the amended BCO 36-2 allows for the censure to be performed before the church or announced to the church, while the proposed amendment to BCO 36-6 allows only that the censure be performed before the church." CCB vote 8-0. CH 284</i>	NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment "would create a conflict, in that the amended BCO 36-2 allows for the censure to be performed before the church or announced to the church while the proposed amendment to BCO 36-6 allows only that the censure be performed before the church." CH, 284, R.	case of public offenses, the degree of censure and mode of administering it shall be within the discretion of the court, acting in accordance with paragraphs below which deal with particular censures. <u>When there are peculiar and special reasons, the court may visit public offenses, not very gross in their character, with private admonition, or with definite suspension in private; but the censures of excommunication and deposition should be either administered before the church, or else announced to it, at the discretion of the court.</u> <i>OC: Negative 70-49-1</i>
28	Philadelphia Metro West	OC CCB	Add to BCO 31-2 a lengthy, four-step sequence for investigations <i>CCB advises this "is in conflict at multiple points with the Constitution. These include but are not limited to removal of the "great discretion" provided to courts in BCO 31-2; conflict</i>	NEGATIVE The lovely chaste language of the 19th Century overcome by a barrage of sections and subsections. So large a feast is indigestible! NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment "is in conflict at multiple points with the Constitution. These include but are not limited to	Negative See Dr. Coffin's hilarious critique. Case closed. <i>OC: Refer back 112-2-0</i>

			with representation at the discretion of the accused (BCO 32-19); conflict with obtaining response from the accused that is not required; and conflation of later elements of the Rules of Discipline." CCB vote 8-0. CH 285	a removal of the "great discretion" provided to courts in BCO 31-2; conflict with representation at the discretion of the accused (BCO 32-19); conflict with obtaining response from the accused that is not required; and conflation of later elements of the Rules of Discipline." CH, 285, S.	
29	Philadelphia Metro West	OC CCB	Add 7-page Appendix K on Investigations (lengthy) CCB advises this "is in conflict and responds to it in reference to [CCB advice] on Overture 28."	NEGATIVE Appendices are the bane of constitutional documents. Are they a part of the document? Do they set forth regulations or suggestions? Lately it became necessary to head the "Appendices" portion of the BCO with this "Editorial Note: None of these Appendices has constitutional authority. They are provided for information." Will that not apply to this proposal, retroactively? Further, given our regular itch to amend the BCO, this lengthy document would need to be amended as well, at the cost of time and money. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment "is in conflict and responds to it in reference to Overture 28." CH, 285, T.	Negative. Agree with CCB assessment. OC: Refer back 112-2-0
30	Lowcountry	OC CCB	Add new BCO 21-4.e & 24-1 paragraphs on moral requirement for office <u>21-4.e. In the examination of the candidate's personal character, the presbytery should give specific attention to potentially notorious concerns, such as but not limited to relational sins.</u>	NEGATIVE The current standard, in BCO 21-4, "his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9). . . ." and the like language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will	Negative. The current standard, in BCO 21-4, "his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9)" and the similar language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will continue to be, sufficient to

		<u>sexual immorality (including homosexuality, fornication, and pornography), addictions, abusive behavior, and financial mismanagement. Careful reflection should be given to his practical struggle against sinful actions, as well as persistent sinful desires. The candidate shall give clear testimony of his reliance upon his union with Christ and the benefits thereof by the Holy Spirit, depending on this work of grace to make progress over sin (Psalm 103: 2-5, Romans 8:29) and to bear fruit (Psalm 1:3; Gal. 5: 22-23). While imperfection will remain, he should not be known by reputation or self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness, but rather by the work of the Holy Spirit in Christ Jesus (1 Cor 6: 9-11). In order to maintain discretion and protect the honor of the pastoral office, the presbytery may empower a committee to conduct detailed examination into these matters and to give prayerful support to candidates.</u> The addition to 24-1 is same as above, except substitute "nominee" for "candidate" and "Session" for "presbytery." <i>"CCB notes that if Overture 30 is adopted, it would require amendment to BCO 13-6 to</i>	continue to be, sufficient to set forth concisely the examining court's responsibility. The placement of the proposed provision in <i>BCO</i> 21-4 is problematic. For example, does item d., which naturally refers to the matters above (i.e., c. (1)-(4) apply to the new item e.? If the new text is to be included at all, surely it should be a subdivision of 21-4. c. (1) (a). NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that if Overture 30 is adopted, it would require amendment to <i>BCO</i> 13-6 to update the re-lettering of <i>BCO</i> 21-4." <i>CH</i>, 285, U. 6-2-0	set forth concisely the examining court's responsibility. The phrase "self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness" inserts a hard-to-define standard into the examination of a man's character. What <i>is</i> self-profession? Additionally, the citing of homosexual desires, though they be unwanted and mortified through a celibate and holy life, as a <i>special case</i>, has the effect of marginalizing the remainder of the Bible's classification of notorious or heinous sins. <i>OC: Ref. to O-37 112-6-1</i>
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			update the re-lettering of BCO 21-4." CH 285		
<u>31</u>	Northwest Georgia	OC CCB	Amend BCO 22 Process for Assistant to Associate Pastor - Add sentence. The pastor and associate pastor are elected by the congregation using the form of call in BCO 20-6. <u>An existing assistant pastor, who has provided satisfactory service for one-year in this congregation, may be elected by the congregation as an associate pastor at the recommendation of the Session without the election of a pulpit committee.</u> Being elected by the congregation they become members of the Session. <i>CCB advises this "is not in conflict with the other parts of the Constitution, but the committee notes that the proposed amendment would implicitly require the use of a pulpit committee for a congregation to elect an associate pastor who has not served as an assistant pastor for at least one year, which is not currently required by BCO 20-2 and 22-1." CCB vote 8-0. CH. 285</i>	AFFIRMATIVE A plausible solution to a problem that is, happily, more frequent in its occurrence. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. [B]ut the committee notes that the proposed amendment would implicitly require the use of a pulpit committee for a congregation to elect an associate pastor who has not served as an assistant pastor for at least one year, which is not currently required by BCO 20-2 and 22-1." CH, 285, V.	Affirm OC answer to affirm as amended <i>OC: Affirmative/Amended 113-11-3</i>
<u>32</u>	Central Indiana	AC OC	Form Study Committee for Biblical Ethics in Digital Media to study and report on:	NEGATIVE	Affirmative.

			1) How the ninth commandment applies to digital forms of communication (such as blogs, social media, public and private online groups, and other developing technologies). 2) Biblical and confessional teaching regarding godly speech, charitable debate, and wisdom in discerning truth from falsehood. 3) Pastoral guidance on how to address questions of public concern without unintentionally spreading false or misleading information, or disparaging the good name of others. 4) Distinctions between private and public offenses (BCO 29-2, 29-4, 34-3), when private online groups with substantial membership are increasingly common. 5) Practical steps for accountability and discipline; that our members might be edified, and our officers remain “above reproach” (1 Timothy 3:2). 6) Should the findings of the study committee warrant BCO changes, the study committee will propose such changes for the General Assembly to consider.	In general, to paraphrase a US President, study committees are not the solution, they are the problem. The matters that occasion their appointment seem to be lagging just slightly behind the latest hot topics in the news cycle, and tend to reduce the Assembly to a mere interest group clamoring among a crowd of competing voices, rather than uphold its stately position as “the bond of union, peace and correspondence among all its congregations and courts,” a grand agent of the Great Commission. Folks have a tendency to use study committee reports to the neglect of (or to undermine) the Constitution of the PCA. Historically study committees have been proposed as a stealth way to give minority views a greater hearing than they deserve. So too, they are sometimes a means to avoid the difficult labor required to pursue debate and resolution with people, we suppose to be opponents, face to face. Such committees are quite expensive, their work-product is widely varied in value, and if committee members cannot agree, the effect of the conflict between a committee report and a minority report can be divisive. It has not been uncommon in Presbyterian history that the fruit of such labors is either a sentimentalizing collection of platitudes that compromise Scripture teaching, or a hammer-and-tongs majority vs. minority report that divides the Assembly. There are a few legitimate, and Constitutionally safe, grounds for appointing study committees, e.g., when the Assembly has determined that a change in the Constitution is desirable, and seeks an able and broadly representative committee to study the best means to that end, to prepare a recommendation, and to prepare a rationale for the church. Such was the case, for example, with the Ad Interim Committee on Judicial Procedures. Rarely such committees may be needed to bring Scripture light to some novel and complex matter that is a threat to the whole body,	Dr Coffin, and others, counsel against the formation of a study committee whose work may or may not be beneficial to the church, but I do not find in Coffin’s argument anything to distinguish this cause from other righteous causes (human sexuality, divorce and remarriage, etc.). These same objections (raised regularly by, for instance, Dr. Coffin) have been used in the debate over committee work we have later received as helpful to the Church. The explosion of access to digital media rivals the invention of the printing press, and its effect on the function of the church courts has been just as pervasive. There is significant difference of opinion on what constitutes the proper use of digital communication vs. personal communication, especially as it concerns theological controversies and interpersonal conflicts. Funding can be addressed, this shouldn’t be cause for scuttling the work of a study committee. <i>OC: Negative 98-26-1</i>
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				for example, the Ad Interim Committee on Human Sexuality. In the main, however, the best resources for our folk are not Assembly study committees, but the intellectual and spiritual wealth we have in our ministers, teachers, and scholars through academic institutions, conferences, publications, broadcasts, recordings, journals and magazines.	
<u>33</u>	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	BCO 38-1 re the Confession Document in Case Without Process 38-1 ... In the event a confession is intended, a full statement of the facts should be a written Confession (i.e., a sufficient summary of the facts, the person's specific confession, and any expression or evidence of repentance) must be approved by the accused and by the court before the court proceeds to a judgment, and the co-signed document shall be appended to the minutes (regular or executive session). No other information may be presented without written consent from the accused and the court, and this prohibition includes individuals, prosecutors, committees, and commissions.	AFFIRMATIVE A needed solution to significant defect in our Rules of Discipline. Note, however, that the closing sentence would need to be brought into conformity with Overture 19 should it pass. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i>, 285, W.	Affirm OC answer in the affirmative <i>OC: Affirmative 113-4-2</i>
<u>34</u>	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Add paragraph to BCO 38-1 re the timing of confessions <u>A person may proffer a confession, and request the matter be handled as a case</u>	NEGATIVE The proposal evidences a failure to understand the	Refer to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49th GA Overtures Committee that will meeting in 2022 in Birmingham.

			<u>without process, prior to an investigation, during an investigation, or after process has commenced. If a confession is proffered after the court has instituted process (BCO 31-2, second paragraph), the prosecutor shall ascertain whether the accused is pleading guilty to the charge (BCO 32-3) or is seeking to proceed via BCO 38-1. If the latter, and if the prosecutor accepts the Confession, he shall suspend process and recommend the court approve the Confession. He may also recommend a censure. However, if no agreement is reached on the Confession, and the matter proceeds as a case of process, confession discussions between the prosecutor and the accused are not admissible as evidence.</u>	historical rationale of a case without process, thus making it the virtual equivalent of a guilty plea. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that if the amendments proposed by Overture 19 and Overture 34 are both adopted, they would be in conflict as to the right of appeal or the right of complaint." CH, 286, X.	The Overture addresses a very important defect in our Rules of Discipline. The concept of a statute of limitations is a matter of considerable complexity, fraught with possibilities for doing more harm than good. A full and careful consideration of the matter by the SJC over the coming year would greatly enhance our likelihood of success. Note that the rationale for the overture grants the possible profit of referencing to the SJC for advice. OC: Refer to 49th GA 120-1-1
35	Pacific Northwest	OC CCB	Add sentence to BCO 38-1 re right to counsel during cases without process <u>.... The person has the right to be represented by counsel at any point, in accord with the stipulations of BCO 32-19.</u> Refer this Overture to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49th GA Overtures Committee that will meeting in 2022 in Birmingham.	NEGATIVE This allowance is inconsistent with the idea of a case without process. To allow formal representation introduces process. The error of a presbytery alleged to have occasioned the proposal was self-evident. The BCO does not need to be amended whenever one acts foolishly. See the "General Note" on pages 142-43 for a collation of all the BCO 38-1 proposals.	Affirm the OC answer to refer. OC: Refer to 49th GA 120-1-1

			Grounds: Same as Pacific NW Overture 22	NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 286, Y.	
<u>36</u>	Chesapeake	AC OC	Proposes: ... the 48th GA authorize the Moderator to appoint a study committee, comprised of teaching and ruling elders, that would consider the relevant biblical and theological materials and consult with knowledgeable persons such as historians and social scientists, in order to: - Provide biblical and theological exposition relevant to the topic of White Supremacy; - Consider the historical background and impact regarding this topic; - Report to 49th GA the conclusion of their work and present any relevant recommendations for the understanding and use of sessions and presbyteries; - Set the budget for the study committee at \$15,000/year and that funds be derived from gifts to the AC designated for that purpose, of which Columbia Presbyterian Church will contribute \$1,000 toward that proposed budget.	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 32.	Affirm OC answer in the Negative. With two other study committees in process, adding a third would be difficult; if I were to pick the most urgent it would be the study committee recommended by overture 32, which affects much of the discussion surrounding these issues. <i>OC: Negative 107-20-0</i>

37	Eastern PA	OC CCB	Amend BCO 21-4 and 24-1 Clarifying Moral Requirements for Church Office Same as Lowcountry 30, but with the addition of the parenthetical “(e.g. homosexual desires, etc.)” in the third sentence. Add to 21-4 and 24-1: <u>“In the examination of the candidate’s personal character, the presbytery should give specific attention to potentially notorious concerns, such as but not limited to relational sins, sexual immorality (including homosexuality, fornication, and pornography), addictions, abusive behavior, and financial mismanagement. Careful reflection should be given to his practical struggle against sinful actions, as well as persistent sinful desires. The candidate shall give clear testimony of his reliance upon his union with Christ and the benefits thereof by the Holy Spirit, depending on this work of grace to make progress over sin (Psalm 103:2-5, Romans 8:29) and to bear fruit (Psalm 1:3; Gal. 5:22-23). While imperfection will remain, he should not be known by reputation or self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness (e.g., homosexual desires, etc.), but</u>	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 30. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. “CCB notes that if Overture 37 is adopted, it would require amendment to BCO 13-6 to update the re-lettering of BCO 21-4.” CH, 286, Z. 6-2-0	Negative. I will not affirm this and plan to speak against it. The current standard, in BCO 21-4, “his acquaintance with experiential religion, especially his personal character and family management (based on the qualifications set out in 1 Timothy 3:1-7, and Titus 1:6-9)” and the similar language in BCO 24-1, has been, and will continue to be, sufficient to set forth concisely the examining court’s responsibility. The phrase “self-profession according to his remaining sinfulness” inserts a hard-to-define standard into the examination of a man’s character. What <i>is</i> self-profession? Additionally, the citing of homosexual desires, though they be unwanted and mortified through a celibate and holy life, <i>as a special case</i>, has the effect of marginalizing the remainder of the Bible’s classification of notorious or heinous sins. OC: Affirmative/Amended 82-43-1
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			<u>rather by the work of the Holy Spirit in Christ Jesus (1 Cor. 6:9-11). In order to maintain discretion and protect the honor of the pastoral office, the presbytery may empower a committee to conduct detailed examination into these matters and to give prayerful support to candidates."</u> <i>"CCB notes that if Overture 30 is adopted, it would require amendment to BCO 13-6 to update the re-lettering of BCO 21-4." CH 285</i>		
38	Calvary	OC CDM	Commend Human Sexuality Report Asks GA to "declare the Report of the Ad Interim Committee on Human Sexuality as a biblically faithful declaration and refer it to the Committee on Discipleship Ministries for inclusion and promotion among its denominational teaching materials." Answer in the Affirmative, as amended below to include a clarifying addition: "That the GA declare the <u>60-page</u> Report of the Ad Interim Committee as a	AFFIRMATIVE In my estimation, this is an outstanding piece of work, perhaps the most cogent and useful GA study I have ever read. And, I have no doubt that it would be profitable for every member of the PCA to read it, as we face increasing cultural chaos on these subjects. As I wrote to the Committee Chairman, "I am grateful for our Lord's providential care for you men in your labors, and for our denomination in the outcome. I must admit, in my weak faith, I absolutely feared the worst. I thought the outcome was but a roll of the dice. But I forgot that "The lot is cast into the lap, but its every decision is from the Lord."	<i>OC: Affirmative</i> <i>124-3-0</i>

			biblically faithful declaration"		
39	Fellowship	AC	Reduce Registration Fees for REs - "... that the 49th GA set the commissioner registration fees as follows: \$250 for REs; \$500 for TEs; Honorably retired or emeritus elders would continue to pay \$150; TEs from churches with annual incomes below \$100,000, as per their 2020 statistics, may register for \$300."	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 24.	Answer by Reference to the answer on TN Valley 24.
40	TN Valley	OC CCB	Amend BCO 32-13, 35-1, and 35-5 to Allow Victim Protection Provisions Add this paragraph to each of the three BCO sections: " <u>However, throughout the trial in cases involving alleged child abuse, domestic abuse, sexual abuse, or sexual assault, a court may make reasonable accommodations to shield accusers from face-to-face contact with the accused. This can be done upon request by the accuser or when the court determines that such accommodation is necessary. Such accommodations might include procedures such as written testimony or videoconferencing testimony, in which a reasonable path for cross examination is provided.</u> "	RETURN TO THE PRESBYTERY, WITHOUT PREJUDICE An extraordinarily well prepared overture. In the main, it seeks adjustments to our procedures that are deeply informed by compassion, and a desire for justice. That being said, it is impossible to imagine a procedure, such as written testimony, that allows a reasonable path for cross-examination, since an essential element of cross-examination is for the judges to be able judge, firsthand, the credibility of the witness. This overture should be returned to presbytery, for further refinement. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. <i>CH</i> , 286, AA.	Affirm the OC answer to refer <i>OC: Refer to 49th GA 110-7-2</i>

			<u>The court shall include in the record its reasons for any accommodations and any objection from the accused to such accommodation, and the objection and the court's response shall be included in the record."</u> Refer this Overture to the SJC for it to report its recommendations to the 49th GA Overtures Committee that will meet in 2022 in Birmingham. Grounds: Same as Pacific NW Overture 22		
41	TN Valley	OC CCB	Amend BCO 35-1 to Expand Potential Witness Availability. Strike the first sentence of BCO 35-1, to read as follows: "All persons of proper age and intelligence are competent witnesses, except such as do not believe in the existence of God, or in a future state of rewards and punishments. The accused party may be allowed, but shall not be compelled to testify; but the accuser shall be required to testify, on the demand of the accused. Either party has the right to challenge a witness who he believes to be incompetent, and the court shall decide upon his competency. It belongs to the court to judge the credibility to be attached to all evidence."	NEGATIVE The case imagined could have been true in the 18th Century. Yet our Forefathers were persuaded that, since we cannot read the heart, credible witnesses, before our courts, must at least believe that God can do so, and will judge them accordingly. I see nothing that has changed since then, and thus there is no reason to adjust our standards. NOTE: CCB finds that the proposed amendment IS NOT in conflict with other parts of the Constitution. "CCB notes that adopting Overture 41 would create the possibility of a witness being qualified, but refusing to take the vow outlined in BCO 35-6." CH, 286, BB.	Affirm the OC answer to refer OC: Refer to 49th GA 105-11-2

<u>42</u>	Susquehanna Valley	MNA	Susquehanna Valley petitions GA to change its boundary description to add those five unassigned counties, remove Berks County, and remove the erroneous comma so that the boundary description for SVP should read ...	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. There is no recommendation, as yet, from CMNA in CH.	
<u>43</u>	Hills & Plains	OC AC	Form Study Committee for Biblical Ethics in Digital Media (same as #32 C. Indiana)	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 32.	Answer affirmative <i>OC: Negative 103-20-2</i>
<u>44</u>	Philadelphia Metro West	MNA	Transfer Berks County to Phil. Metro W	AFFIRMATIVE, if approved by Committee of Commissioners. There is no recommendation, as yet, from CMNA in CH.	
<u>45</u>	Metro Atlanta	OC CDM AC	Seek Asian American Flourishing - Provides sample letter - Asks GA to “recognize that the flourishing of our Asian American brothers and sisters now and in the future, will contribute to the flourishing of us all as the body of Christ, because if one member suffers, all suffer together; if one member is honored, all rejoice together, for the glory of God.” - Asks GA to “appoint five Asian Americans from 2 diverse generations and	NEGATIVE This is, in principle, a request for a study committee. See comments on Overture 32.	No recommendation yet. As an opportunity to stand in solidarity, the overture has obvious value. The question is how to truly honor the intent of the request. There are defects that will make it very unlikely to pass the OC, one of which is mentioned by Dr. Coffin and others, that it is the creation of a study committee without the necessary parameters. There isn’t really a vehicle for accomplishing what the overture is asking. There needs to be more work done on this overture for it to pass committee. <i>OC: Refer to O-48 108-8-4</i>

			cultural backgrounds to serve the PCA over the next three years in three tasks.		
46	Metro NY	OC CDM AC	Same as Metro Atlanta 45	NEGATIVE This is, in principle, a request for a study committee. See comments on Overture 32.	OC: Refer to O-45 112-2-3
47	Chesapeake	OC AC	Study Committee on Critical Race Theory	NEGATIVE See comments on Overture 32.	Negative. Aside from concerns about the probability that a study committee can accurately study and make recommendations about an academic theory like CRT, with two other study committees in process, adding a third would be difficult; if I were to pick the most urgent it would be the study committee recommended by overture 32. OC: Negative 95-26-1
48	Korean Capital	OC	Repudiate Anti-American Racism (with seven Be It Resolved paragraphs)	NEGATIVE In everything that the overture legitimately seeks from a church court, the PCA is already, boldly, plainly, and Constitutionally committed to. With respect to the rest, it is beyond the scope of the Assembly's jurisdiction to address such matters.	No recommendation yet. These types of overtures fail at the committee and assembly level due to two camps of opposition: (1) those who have a narrow understanding of the assembly's scope (strictly church issues), and (2) those who are uncomfortable making any statement which speaks to the role of the civil government (2nd-to-last whereas). It is a powerful statement, but one I don't think will pass. How can this receive further attention? Certainly if it fails and enough OC members
					support a minority report, it will receive debate from the floor of the assembly. Glad to hear other recommendations. I plan to speak to this overture as well.

NP: nominating committee advice.

4 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jul 1, 2021, 10:50:11 AM (8 days ago)

三



to NP

{This information is intended to remain private and should not be shared without permission from the sender}

A quick note: the NP does not whip or coerce votes. We know we may disagree on these recommendations, but for those who may be unaware of the different candidates, I hope this is helpful.

In these recommendations, there is preference given to geographical representation and age of candidates. Our goal is to see a wide representation of Presbyteries as well as younger men serve on committees.

AC // Class of 2025 // TE

Roger Collins, Mississippi Valley
Rod Mays, Calvary *****

Given his extensive experience in the PCA with RUF as well as service on the Admin Committee – Rod Mays is the preferred candidate.

AC // Class of 2025 // TE

Steve Jeantet, Suncoast
Randy Lovelace, Chesapeake

Both men have served and would serve the committee well. No recommendation.

CCB // Class of 2025 // TE

Scott Phillips, Mississippi Valley
Robert Browning, Covenant *****

Robert Browning has more experience with CCB, has previously served well, and is from a Presbytery with less representation.

Covenant College // Class of 2025

TE Alexander Brown, Savannah River
RE Don Mellott, Pacific Northwest
TE Caleb Nelson, Rocky Mountain
TE Scott Seaton, Potomac *****

Scott Seaton has worked in the PCA across a wide range of ministries and settings. He understands how to work as part of a board and to labor for institutional health.

Covenant Seminary // Class of 2025

TE Brian Cosby, Tennessee
TE David Richter, Nashville *****

David Richter is the preferred choice here for his strategic leadership ability as well as his organizational labor.

Covenant Seminary // Class of 2025

TE Will Hesterberg, Illiana
TE Clay Holland, Houston Metro *****
RE Scott Shidemantle, Ascension

Clay Holland is currently a member of the advisory board; has labored to support and shape the institution and would be a valuable addition.

Interchurch Relations // Class of 2023 // RE

James Isbell, Tennessee Valley
Randy Stair, Metro Atlanta *****

Randy Stair is the far more experienced churchman and would provide helpful leadership to the ICR committee.

Interchurch Relations // Class of 2024 // TE

Richard Phillips, Calvary
Roy Taylor, Georgia Foothills *****

Roy Taylor. No further explanation required.

Interchurch Relations // Alternate // RE

Dennis Watts, Mississippi Valley
Bevan Houston, Hills and Plains

MNA // Alternate // TE

Matthew Bradley, Nashville
Hunter Brewer, Covenant
Ronnie Garcia, Rocky Mountain
Hansoo Jin, Korean Capital
Scott Levy, Hills and Plains (disqualified – he is a ruling elder)
Hung Truong, Metro Atlanta

A number of great candidates here. Personally, knowing both Garcia and Jin makes me very excited about either of them participating in the mission of MNA

RUF // Alternate // TE

Wallace Tinsley, Fellowship
Jack Howell, Tidewater *****

Jack Howell served RUF previously and did a fantastic job.

SJC // Class of 2025 // RE

James Eggert, Southwest Florida
Steve Dowling, SE Alabama
Clark Hammond, Evangel
Alexander Jun, Korean SW Orange Co *****
Robert Mattes, Potomac (likely disqualified with David Coffin running unopposed)
David Walters, Low Country

Alex Jun would bring both experience and perspective to the SJC in the face of complex issues this year and in the years ahead.

TEC // Class of 2024 // RE

Walter Leveille, Evangel
Joshua Torrey, South Texas

Vote awareness

5 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jul 1, 2021, 9:34:03 AM (8 days ago)

主



to NP

Hey friends,

Please do your best to be on the floor for the 9.30a session right now. There will be a vote to extend funding to the AIC on abuse that is desperately needed. I'd encourage you to vote yes on this but they need 2/3 to make it happen. Please step in and join if you are able.

JK



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jul 1, 2021, 11:02:09 AM (8 days ago)

主



to NP

Hey friends,

The Nominating Committee is now. An important time to vote.

My thoughts on O23

22 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jul 1, 2021, 1:21:27 PM (8 days ago)

主



to NP

{This communication is private and is not to be shared without the permission of the sender}

Friends,

As we enter into the latter parts of Thursday's assembly we will begin debating the human sexuality overtures. I wanted to give my rationale for my support of Overture 23 as things currently stand. I have watched many of you cautioning against the adoption of the overture, and have had several conversations along these lines. I've tried to pay close attention to your arguments to see if there are places the Lord might be persuading me differently. So far, this is where I come out on the issue:

The language:

Officers in the Presbyterian Church in America must be above reproach in their walk and Christlike in their character. Those who profess an identity (such as, but not limited to, "gay Christian," "homosexual Christian," same sex attracted Christian," or like term) that undermines or contradicts their identity as new creations in Christ, or deny the sinfulness of fallen desires (such as, but not limited to, same sex attraction), or deny the reality and hope of progressive sanctification, or fail to pursue Spirit-empowered victory over their sinful temptations, inclinations, and actions are not qualified for ordained office.

(1) My greatest concern at the moment is that there is no specific language to which a SSA minister can point in our BCO that protects them from non-ordination or dismissal based on sharing their story of SSA. This overture provides for a qualified *support* of identification language, by defining the identification language that is *not appropriate*. It would be the now-enumerated right of someone with SSA to ordination in the PCA if their self-identification does not prevent them from assenting to the orthodox views of sanctification.

(2) The troubling "reputation" language of the original overture, combined with the vagueness of "identity" language, are the horns on which we currently hang our SSA brothers in the ordination process. It's what we are doing now. This overture allows us to bypass that conversation entirely. Reputation is not listed here, and self-profession is defined not by some kind of clumsy biblicism but by our confessional standards on the doctrine of sanctification.

(3) The overture provides process for the ordinand who is unlawfully prevented from ordination due to self-identification or other terminology. They have a specific provision to cite and a means to appeal.

Many of you have talked about how this all reads to our friends who struggle with this sort of sexual brokenness, that it elevates *their* sexual brokenness above our own, breaking our fidelity to the doctrines of grace. I can certainly understand that. Furthermore I find myself nodding vigorously every time our friends tell us that these discussions are never to or for them. It's incredibly uncaring, the process we've undertaken. I agree. I intend to make that clear in my floor speech.

It is my recognition of the kind of suffering some of you, and your friends, have encountered in the courts of the denomination that compel me to try and *begin* to put a stop to it. Simply voting them all down I do not believe will accomplish much of note. We will all go home and many of us will be distracted again with ministry and everyday life, while those of you struggling through witch-hunts due to your self-profession will have to fight with a much smaller posse, the fight you've been fighting all along. I can't stand to leave things there, if I can help it.

I'm open to counter-arguments, and I know acutely that my current position on this is a disappointment to quite a few of you. Forgive me if I haven't listened well, or if you feel I've dismissed you in any way. If I'm wrong, extend to me the grace of being wrong too, from time to time. Hopefully God will grant us wisdom beyond Solomon for the discussion to come.



travis

<travis@graceandpeacepgh.org>

Jul 1, 2021, 2:05:23 PM (8 days ago)



to james, NP

James,

I appreciate your thoughts and actually agree with the heart of what you've written. However, I offer the following counter-arguments:

The language:

Officers in the Presbyterian Church in America must be above reproach in their walk and Christlike in their character. Those who profess an identity (such as, but not limited to, "gay Christian," "homosexual Christian," same sex attracted Christian," or like term) that undermines or contradicts their identity as new creations in Christ, or deny the sinfulness of fallen desires (such as, but not limited to, same sex attraction), or deny the reality and hope of progressive sanctification, or fail to pursue Spirit-empowered victory over their sinful temptations, inclinations, and actions are not qualified for ordained office.

(1) My greatest concern at the moment is that there is no specific language to which a SSA minister can point in our BCO that protects them from non-ordination or dismissal based on sharing their story of SSA. This overture provides for a qualified *support* of identification language, by defining the identification language that is *not appropriate*. It would be the now-enumerated right of someone with SSA to ordination in the PCA if their self-identification does not prevent them from assenting to the orthodox views of sanctification.

While I understand this is the hope of those supporting the current version of 23, I do not believe it is reality. The language of this version isn't significantly different or clear from what we have now in our system. The language of this amended version could be used to describe current ordained ministers; and yet this same language is also used by the opponents and slanderers of

those men to deny their ordainability. The fundamentalists will say that anyone suggesting that their homosexual attractions will likely persist throughout their life are denying the power of the Holy Spirit to progress them in sanctification or victory. They have a rigid, narrow, and inflexible understanding of what they believe would qualify a man to say he isn't undermining or contradicting his identity in Christ or his progressive sanctification. This overture does nothing to push back against that interpretation but will in fact allow them to use the amended language to disqualify men.

(2) The troubling "reputation" language of the original overture, combined with the vagueness of "identity" language, are the horns on which we currently hang our SSA brothers in the ordination process. It's what we are doing now. This overture allows us to bypass that conversation entirely. Reputation is not listed here, and self-profession is defined not by some kind of clumsy biblicism but by our confessional standards on the doctrine of sanctification.

Agree that the removal of the reputation language is something to celebrate.

(3) The overture provides process for the ordinand who is unlawfully prevented from ordination due to self-identification or other terminology. They have a specific provision to cite and a means to appeal.

That is something of a hollow concession since an ordinand already had that process. The reality on the ground is that this overture will be interpreted as reason for those potential ordindands not to pursue ordination in the PCA.

It is my recognition of the kind of suffering some of you, and your friends, have encountered in the courts of the denomination that compel me to try and *begin* to put a stop to it. Simply voting them all down I do not believe will accomplish much of note. We will all go home and many of us will be distracted again with ministry and everyday life, while those of you struggling through witch-hunts due to your self-profession will have to fight with a much smaller posse, the fight you've been fighting all along. I can't stand to leave things there, if I can help it.

Really appreciate your heart and sentiment here James. However, this attempt to "begin" seems to me to be another half-measure seeking to compromise and find common ground with men who have no true desire to compromise or find common ground. They will take every inch we give them and then keep coming at us and trying to push us out. Our good will has been used against us for years. This will not stop now. They have hammered us three years in a row, all while we try to play nice and meet in the middle. I wish we had let the clear and ugly original overture to go through so we could have at least said - Here we are. Do you want this fundamentalism or do you want a gracious orthodoxy? This amended language will calm the middle down and allow them to allow more attacks by the fundamentalists.

Appreciate all of you who served on OC. I know you had an uphill, and in many ways unwinnable battle. I respect those of you who disagree with me on this issue.

--

Travis Scott



sseaton

<sseaton@emmanuelarlington.org>

Jul 1, 2021, 2:19:02 PM (8 days ago)

主



to james, NP

Question: If I read it correctly, the “known by reputation” language is in Overture 37 (not Overture 23), and remains there in what OC recommends.

Is the hope to approve OC23 and vote down O37?

Either way, given the current voting trends, I'm not hopeful any of these overtures will be defeated.

grace,
Scott Seaton



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jul 1, 2021, 2:19:54 PM (8 days ago)

主



to sseaton, NP

Yes Scott, correct.



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jul 1, 2021, 2:20:09 PM (8 days ago)

主



to travis, NP

Appreciate your thoughts Travis.



binion.robort.e

<binion.robort.e@gmail.com>

Jul 1, 2021, 2:23:18 PM (8 days ago)

主



to james, travis, NP

Having sat on OC, I concur with Travis about how the fundamentalists types will attempt to use the language in the current version of 23. I understand that could be rejected at the SJC level but do we really want men to have to go through that?

I plan to vote no on 23.



dcassidy3817

<dcassidy3817@gmail.com>

Jul 1, 2021, 2:34:05 PM (8 days ago)

主



to james, travis, NP

37 is the monster that has to be defeated. Support that minority report.

David Cassidy Sent from my iPhone

Final Note

8 views

[Skip to first unread message](#)



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

unread,

Jul 2, 2021, 8:34:46 AM (7 days ago)

⋮



to NP

{This communication is private, it is not to be shared without permission from the sender}

Dear friends,

Not the assembly I'd hoped for! But I find myself grateful for how many of you shared my disappointment; not that I was grateful for your discouragement, but that I wasn't alone in it. Years ago, when I was attending my first assemblies as a commissioner, I remember that some of the same arguments with which I disagreed tonight, were made at the microphones. But the difference between then and now was the fact that now there are far more replies to those speeches.

The denomination is sharply divided, and at this assembly the side representing our views was significantly outnumbered. We will have to take that to heart and consider what it means for the next years. There will be conversations in the weeks and months ahead about how we best steward our place in this denomination. But for now I just wanted to thank you all for working together, and for stepping into the gap when it was needed on committee reports, microphones, bottles of bourbon and cigars. I'm tired, you're tired, but no one's defeated. Perhaps the next way you'll move things forward is on the floor of your presbyteries as you lead debate on overtures we passed. Or maybe it's time for your presbytery to bring something to the Birmingham assembly that moves us in a

healthier direction. It may be the ideal moment to not only react to the year's polity for three days in June, but to lead it. I'll gladly be your second.

I'll see you in June, if not in February at Beautiful Orthodoxy.

NP Fwd: Encouragement

5 views



james

<james@newcityhilliard.org>

Jul 3, 2021, 8:25:22 AM (6 days ago)



to NP

Thought this was great and wanted you all to see it in case you aren't on Mike's email list. He gave me permission to share it.

Begin forwarded message:

From: Mike Khandjian <mi...@chapelgate.org>

Date: July 3, 2021 at 8:35:20 AM EDT

To: ja...@newcityhilliard.org

Subject: Encouragement

Reply-To: Mike Khandjian <mi...@chapelgate.org>

2. Good reasons for **not** being a part of the NP:

(a) You like being in the know, but you don't really agree with what you have seen of the NP's agenda.

(b) Your conscience is telling you that you don't need to be involved at this level. You're too tribal/political as it is and struggle with loving those with whom you disagree in denominational matters.

3. Good reasons to **stay** in the NP:

(a) You want to participate in the effort to shape a denomination worth having (My explanation of this: <https://morsekarl.com/writing/the-pca-worth-having>)

(b) You've realized that the only way to have that denomination is to join in doing the work with others.

4. Choosing to stay connected means

(a) Participating in denominational and presbytery work.

(b) You're promising to maintain confidentiality. You will not share emails without permission. You're free to talk about your involvement but respect the rights of others to keep theirs confidential.

This next year will involve a lot more of you making the NP more effective and helpful in our work. I'm looking forward to it. Hope you'll be with us!



drew

<drew@redeemerwinterhaven.org>

unread,

Jul 8, 2021, 3:22:23 PM (yesterday)



to james, NP

James, I would like to continue to be a part of the National Partnership. I am committed to working towards a PCA worth having. I serve on a CoC at each GA. I also serve as the chairmen of the RUF

committee of the Southwest Florida Presbytery and I am the Director of the Florida Church Planting Network (FCPN). I introduced myself to you at GA briefly. I recruited Heath to join us here in Florida. ... This work matters to me greatly.

Thanks for your effort

Drew Bennett

